

A HEDLIN FAMILY JOURNAL

*This journal is for our boys (Peter 1978, Matthew
1982, Erik 1986).*

*Time is easier to understand once all its pieces are
set out to be looked at and talked about.*

*Here an account of who we were, what we thought,
what we talked about,*

*what we ate and read and played at, and who were
our friends and family.*

Generated July 26, 2026

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Saturday, July 23, 1983

In order to make future recordings more meaningful, today's entry will lay out some of the more important events since our marriage on August 16, 1975.

Peter David Skarsgard was born June 21 1978 at City Hospital, Matthew Paul Skarsgard on September 23 1982 at St. Paul's, (*and Erik Mitchell Skarsgard on August 27 1986). These are our big-bang events. They unleashed everything else that comprise our life.

Peter is now 5 years 1 month. He wears glasses to correct a slight stigma to his left eye. He takes swimming lessons at George Ward pool, cello lessons through the Suzuki program. He plays baseball with a clean toss and carefully arranged batter's stance. He plays with Kelsey Millar, Sara Peltier, Megan Holt, Erin Bingham, Katherine Akre, Erika and Ingrid Pederson and Crystal Torgenrud (babysitter). His interests include gnomes, knights, space, cacti, prisons, mosquitoes, bees, ending of life, religion, the Bible, the farm at Canwood, Papa and Mama, medicine, eating out, music, 2-way radios, tornadoes, floods, guns, hunting, and many others things either associated with those already mentioned or spun off them by the endless questions he asks. He listens to records and tapes (favourites are Winnie-the-Pooh read by Carol Channing, Door in the Wall, Hans Christian Anderson, Raffi, Maurice Sendak's Where the Wild Things Are, Curious George, Mary Poppins, The Fantastic Mr. Fox by Roald Dahl, Radar ("Randolph") the Reindeer, Peter and the Wolf, Free to be You and Me. His favourite books include Charlotte's Web, all of Steig, The Hobbit, Shel Silverstein's Where the Sidewalk Ends, A.A. Milne, Frog and Toad, all of Roald Dahl, Grimm Fairy Tales, Wonderful

Flight to the Mushroom Planet by Eleanor Cameron, Pippi Longstocking, Wizard of Oz.

Matthew is 10 months old tomorrow. He is very active and gives the impression of being even more so. He started sitting at 5 months and crawling at 7 months. He took his first steps at 9 months. He spoke his first words (ones he repeated) at 8 months: bye-bye, hi, no-no, yes, mama, dada, ba (bath). He moves things around to help him climb (dump trucks, chairs). He waves and claps his hands or whatever is in his hands. He turns knobs, flips switches, talks on his toy telephone, puts on shoes and hats, ruffles the pages of books and magazines. We can't keep him off the musical instruments. He leans against the guitar and picks at the strings and listens, one at a time. He sits directly in front Peter when he practises and lifts the cello by its end pin. He thumps the foot-pedals of the piano and tries to move the piano bench to sit on. He drinks out of an open cup. He refuses soothers and blankets. He empties cupboards, the hamper, clears the table, tears wire from walls, shakes table lamps to the floor, breaks knobs off TVs. He is impetuous and therefore dangerous to himself. He shakes his head as if to clear his ears of water. Not once has he slept through the night; allergies and teeth wakened him as often as five or six times a night until Cheryl discovered the cause and he woke up no more than two times. Even if not for allergies and teeth, he fights sleep off, sometimes with the look of desperation, as if avoiding being drowned. If he wakes up at night he jumps to his feet and cries until either Cheryl or I lay him down and sing "Hey dum diddley dum". During the evening, if he seems to be tiring and we mention it, he climbs directly to the floor and shakes his head, though shortly, in the middle of doing something, he will topple over, sound asleep.

Cheryl runs everywhere: she takes Peter swimming or to the library; she shops for groceries or attends a stroke-improvement class at the Lathey pool (the class began with everyone hopping on one foot, dipping first the nose in the water then the ears, until she finally managed to convince the instructor that she herself has no great fears to overcome and wouldn't they get down to real laps). She is knitting an Icelandic sweater for Dawn Kasdorf. She is reading John Updike, cookbooks, the historical fiction of Stone and Mary Stewart (especially her medieval fiction), and magazines like *Woman's Day*, *Canadian Living*, *Saturday Night*, *Macleans*, *Games*. Cheryl sews her own clothes. She organizes for everyone. She spends time on the piano. She attends a cake-decorating class. Her first masterpiece was the Cookie Monster.

I am swimming every noon hour at the Phys. Ed. pool. I practise classical guitar. I am working on a Futures Problem Solving writing project for the Saskatoon Board of Education. Recently I have rough-wired and insulated the basement. I am about to install the vapour barrier and perimeter-wall gyproc. I've been reading mostly D. H. Lawrence. I oversee the lawn and garden.

Cheryl and I enjoy our family and make no apologies about being absorbed by them. When we're not doing scheduled activities we improvise. We eat out, go for drives or visit either of our families, visit the farm, go on picnics to the Forestry Farm, bicycle and walk. When alone we watch TV programs like *Lifelines* (a series on medical biography), *Cheers* (Peter calls it the 'crazy show'; 'everyone argues'), *Fawlty Towers*, *Newhart*, *Three's Company*, and *Masterpiece Theatre* on Sunday evening. We have recently seen *Bambi*, *Reds* and *E.T* at the theatre. Two birthdays

are coming up, and we have planned for a pizza-movie night on Wednesday.

Today has been relaxed. We visited Cheryl's grandparents to return a timer and thank them for the \$10 they sent to me for my birthday. Cheryl bought two dresses and I took Peter and Matthew to the river by the Remail building at Spadina and 20th. Afterwards we ate lunch at the Sheraton Cavalier (the decision to keep a journal was made at this time). Peter ordered grilled cheese, Cheryl and I shared a BLT, Matthew had a beef and macaroni mash half of which he sent back on the tray. Total cost: \$11.70.

We bought groceries at SuperValu. I bumped into a fellow university student, Pauline Melis. Cheryl met Cheryl Wright and talked about Marg Mack.

The afternoon was hot and sunny. We went to the George Ward pool, very noisy and crowded, very enjoyable. Peter badly wants to swim. He jumps off the blocks (he landed one directly onto a girl, and thinking she had been hurt, he cried awhile) and splashes on his own for a few feet. Cheryl and Matthew waded in the paddling end. Matthew also loves the water.

Cheryl baked a cake for my surprise birthday celebration tomorrow. Mom and Dad are coming. She cleaned the house.

Peter rode his bike and played with Megan and Devin Paterson. I cut and watered the lawns. Both boys are very tired. They slept very little today. Peter drifted off with Gnomes sitting open on his stomach. Cheryl took two pictures of Peter sitting against his headboard, one arm resting on it, legs crossed, eating a snack, talking about the dangers of diving. Just then Matthew crawled in. Peter said, "Oh oh, here comes that little shark." Cheryl is lying on

the floor in a silk kimono, drying her hair with a high-speed fan. I wonder how many times Matthew will be up tonight.

Sunday, July 24

Matthew slept from 8:30 to 6 am. The family was actively awake by 8 am. We made relaxed preparations for church: breakfast, bathing, dressing. Peter cares almost completely for himself. He watches for tufts of hair. Twice today he disappeared for several minutes and returned with a wet head. "I sprayed it," he explained. "I don't like my hair sticking up. I don't want to look like a girl."

Dinner was finished by 12. The boys went to sleep. Cheryl and I worked indoors and outdoors, cleaning for the 3 arrival of my parents and grandmother. This is an early birthday party, a secret. Peter has reminded me every 30 minutes how secret this "something" is, unaware that I had been involved in the arrangements days ago. They arrived at 3:10 with a card, ice-cream, a loaf of bread and jujubes for Peter. Cheryl suggested I invite Matthew and Cheryl. They arrived shortly after 4. The visit was lighthearted. Peter went in and out, visiting for short intervals and then riding his bike. Matthew played all his baby tricks: tongue out, laughing and smiling, posing for pictures, rolling in the carpet. Dad asked about Peter's interests. Mom, Cheryl and Grandma talked about gardens. Dad and I watched a quarter of the Sask-B.C. game at B.C. Place. Sask. goes 1 – 2. Matthew and Cheryl stayed after the others had gone. They showed us pictures and proofs of their wedding. Matthew is not happy with them. They stayed for supper. We discussed Winnipeg (where Matthew went to school), computerized drafting tables, having children. Peter went gone out again. Matthew has fallen asleep.

Peter bathed with measuring cups and frying pans from a plastic corning-ware set given as a birthday present from Mama and Papa. He stuffed plastic Muppets in a tea-pot full of water ("a

well”) and lined containers filled with water along the tub wall. The room steams. He has that broiled look.

We watched Fawlty Towers (the dead man in a closet episode). Matthew woke up. The boys are put to bed for the last time. Cheryl’s mother phoned to tell about the farming weekend. The time is 10.

Monday, July 25

Sunny and warm. The basement got another start – rough wiring completed and first sheets of gyproc are set onto north wall. Peter enjoys the project far more than I do. Matthew has been in a great mood all day. Happy and eager, he follows someone from room to room hoping for attention. He has spent much of the time sitting with Cheryl, Peter and me. Lots of affection between the boys. Matthew sits on the chesterfield. Peter kisses him tenderly. Cheryl and I are swimming a lot. I swam 1250 meters today. Cheryl swam 50 - 60 widths of the Lathey. Peter went with Papa to check the summer-fallow on Harvey’s land. Harvey is waiting in Banff to hear about the weeds. Banff will not hold him for more than the hour it takes to gas up if he hears that the weeds are about to seed. Peter says that the field is “very green, but not serious”. Matthew falls asleep at 8:30. Peter is rocked to sleep by Cheryl. He wishes to hear about his life as a young child. I can hear them laughing together. Cheryl and I watch Newhart.

Tuesday, July 26

Matthew seems to have rescheduled his nights. Now they run from 8:30 pm – 6:30 am. He was up several times last night after 4. One final effort was made at 6. He cried on my shoulder awhile. I laid him in his bed. He raised himself up. I lowered him down. He cried. I said, “Lay down.” Then he did. “Just maybe,” I hoped. He was silent, so I left. From our bedroom I could hear him flap the blinds and laugh. The night was done.

We took the Toyota for a 78,000 km check-up to the new 42nd street facilities. The Mazda was taken out of dry-dock. I don't like using it because the door bangs and jams when someone pulls it open. Cheryl was appalled by the dust in it. A cobweb had formed on the passenger window. She called me a pig. Peter and I laughed. Peter has been excitable today, talkative, affectionate towards Matthew, active with us. His mood was further improved at swimming lessons. He earned his Orange badge. He starts in Red tomorrow. More gyrocing was done in the basement. It seems to go slowly, although I'm pleased with the job so far. I'm surprised there haven't been more complications. I'm teaching myself: read and hammer, then read and hammer some more.

On the drive to Toyota this afternoon the boys entertained each other. Matthew looked around the side of his seat for Peter. Peter did silly stunts for him. We go to Burger King for supper before Cheryl returned to Lathey for her swim. She drove the Toyota. I took the boys in the Mazda. Peter imagines me committing crimes with the car. To drive without seatbelts, he thinks, is as serious as anything. The police have a mandate to argue with citizens, throw “mufflers” all over their bodies and take them to jail. He would like to see it done to me.

Peter was invited to stay the night with Cheryl's parents. We watched Lifelines, a Channel 2 documentary about notable doctors in the United States. Meagen, Peter's friend, came over to play. Peter preferred to watch the show, this one about a car accident and two Jehovah Witness women with multiple "stub" wounds. Peter and Cheryl left when the show was done. I bathed Matthew and put him to bed. He has been entirely happy and affectionate today. He seems fearless, innocent. He slept with his head in my lap, an open-mouth smile. When Cheryl arrived at her parents she visited awhile. Peter was impatient to begin his night "for real". When she made the slightest motion to get up he said, "Bye mom."

Crystal Torgenrud phoned to say she would sit for us tomorrow night and Thursday – a birthday, you know. Cheryl is asleep, "stealing time" from Matthew.

Wednesday, July 27

Cheryl will pick Peter up on the way to his swimming lessons. With Matthew alone, the schedule more than relaxes. He woke at 7, we ate breakfast by 7:40. Cheryl cleaned and sewed. I worked in the basement. Things were uninterrupted until Cheryl left for Peter. The bank phoned. The woman seemed quite angry. "The supervisor has been getting irritated by your deficit account - 500 dollars to date. Would you please be in this afternoon." Our tax money has run out. Fortunately I deposit my July cheque tomorrow. Hopefully the bank will finger Cheryl and continue to see me as the straight man with the best intentions to keep the trust of powerful corporate entities.

Cheryl was in the living room as Peter and Matthew played. Matthew cried suddenly.

Cheryl asked, "What happened Peter?"

"I hurt Matthew."

Cheryl said nothing.

Peter continued. "Do you know why I hurt Matthew?"

"No."

"I love him so much."

"I don't see the sense in that."

"But on Mama's record it says that we often hurt those we love the most."

Later, Peter told Cheryl that her hair 'looked very good today'. We're not quite sure what he meant. When I came home from

swimming Peter was at the door with a wrapped box and two white envelopes. I opened his card. This card, signed by him, had been bought some time ago by Cheryl. His choice, made sometime later, was a card with a dog urinating on a fire hydrant. He thought it was a perfectly natural expression of his feeling for me, as something that might happen on one's birthday, or at any other time.

Crystal came to sit for us. Cheryl and I left the house at 7:30 for supper and a movie. Things didn't stick to the plan however. Cheryl needed eyedrops to stop the tears of chlorine-burned eyes. She insisted we return to Lathey to find a gold hoop earring she lost while swimming that day. Then we went to supper and a movie. Supper was pizza at Ryden's Deli in Bedford Square. This is a casual place with a long serving counter in front that displays meats, health drinks and menus. At the back are two rows of small round tables and chairs. Pizza cartons are stacked against the wall beside an orange bathtub/sofa with a side cut out for sitting pleasure. There is little efficiency and less service. Asking for anything, and it seems to be a first-time-ever experience for the waiter. Two fellows talk the request over with each other, think a little, then come up with a solution. However, in most restaurants, the longer you sit the less service-minded they become. Here, as the dinner lengthens the friendliness increases. The pizza and coffee were good. We ate Nanaimo bars in the car. The movie, *Survivors*, was playing in Towne Cinema next to a 3-D movie called *The Swedish Butler*. I suppose neither show will be recalled very long from now. Robin Williams, Walter Mathau and Jerry Reed, each victims of New York City's crushing sadism, struggled through a satirical expression of the individual's ego and insularity. We laughed, Cheryl harder than I expected, especially

at the scene of the bandaged Williams looking as if a plate of spaghetti had been dumped on him.

Thursday, July 28

The morning was spent shopping for goggles for Cheryl and Peter. It's not easy to find the model that Cheryl says she thinks she's sure she saw someone wearing. Peter bathed twice with his. Cheryl stayed home while I took the boys to George Ward. We swam together at noon for an hour. We're tired, and had trouble pushing ourselves. Cheryl's goggles worked fine.

Peter tried to nap. Once which I passed by his door to look in he closed his eyes. I asked why he wasn't sleeping. He pretended to sleep. I waited. I his eyelids flutter. This is quite the game he plays. Cheryl and I tried to sleep. Matthew wasn't feeling well and slept only a short time. We tried the tough approach, which means trying not to encourage him. Trying one thing usually becomes doing something else. With someone as stubborn as Matthew, this meant getting up and hoping everyone would want to go to bed a bit earlier this evening.

Cheryl arranged with her mother to have a perm after swimming. On the way over we stopped at Consumer Distributors to buy an earring set to replace the one she lost. Matthew walked on top of a retaining rail in front of the counter. He seemed to be feeling better. Peter was inciting him to scream. Another boy several months older than Matthew became interested in him. They touched hands and faces and explored each other with their 78 rpm voices. Cheryl's parents were not at home. We put the boys to bed, read and put ourselves to bed by 10. We have decided to leave for Calgary to attend a Suzuki workshop on Saturday. That leaves tomorrow to get the house ready and the car packed. Erin Bingham was over. She had a bag of perishable food that Maureen wanted to get rid of before they left for the week. Cheryl told Erin

we couldn't take it because we also were going away. Erin didn't understand and pressed the food on Peter, faithfully repeating her mother's instructions, "Take it, we're going on holidays." Erin finally left with the food.

Friday, July 29

The day was spent getting ready for Calgary. Matthew had us up as early as usual. I trimmed, watered and weeded the lawn and beds by 9:00. Cheryl has organized the operation with three lists. Peter walks around the house with his swimming goggles on his neck. Peter and I made a couple of trips about town to buy a hacksaw for locks with no keys on the car top carrier, a timer for our living room light, two gifts from Cheryl's parents for Peter and Matthew, traveler's cheques, Peter's swimming card, my rugby pants from the Squire Shop, to put a stop on our mail, pick up a nut, bolt and lock for the carrier. When we finally got home Cheryl was all packed according to her magnificent lists. Peter was talkative. Death has taken up as much of his thinking time as wondering what people are doing on the other side of the world. Peter asked me if we will live forever. I said no. Peter rolled his hands palm upwards and said, "Well I guess that is what life is made of." We were invited to the Hospitality Inn by Cheryl's parents for half-price suppers. We arrived at 5:30 and got our tables. The waiter was young, blown-dry and bare-chested, well suited to giving orders at a singles bar. He took our orders while looking over the room for better options. There was a small foul-up with the food.

Cheryl's mother said, "He's too busy looking for pretty girls."

Peter jumped to his feet and said, "Where? Where are the pretty girls?"

No one showed him so he repeated, "Where are the pretty girls?"

Cheryl's dad talked about the MVA director's committee problems with a Saskatchewan Crescent developer of condominiums.

After the restaurant we visited with Jed and Helen Dyck. Peter played with Merlin, an electronic reflex and memory game. Matthew performed for Jed's niece, a nursing student looking for a summer job. We sat in the room off the kitchen with the southern view and talked about school, cruise missile protests, Jed's carpentry projects, the football game between Saskatchewan and Toronto, the Cosmopolitan magazine for women, and the difference between having and not having children as one makes life decisions. Cheryl and I were interested in a book of theirs that imagined a conversation between Aldous Huxley, C.S. Lewis and J.F. Kennedy. We had dessert and coffee, talked some more and drove our already packed car home and left.

Saturday July 30

We had an early breakfast at Saskatoon Inn with Cheryl's parents. The restaurant was very busy handling a Charismatic Catholic's conference. Peter and I shared pancakes and sausage. Cheryl had poached eggs and toast. After the breakfast I took the bill from the waitress. As we went to the cash register, Cheryl's dad tried reaching around me for it. Quietly he said, "Come on Dave, this is embarrassing."

We wished each other well and left for Calgary. The day was sunny. Peter soon complained about being too hot. Cheryl, on the other hand, was cold and held a pillow on her lap. They switched places for the rest of the trip. Peter was sucking on a large piece of ice and got it stuck in his mouth. He yelled for help. His eyes were full of tears. I managed to pull it free, like removing a stick from a trap. He cried awhile. We stopped in Drumheller for an hour. We had shakes and ice-cream at the Waldorf Hotel. Matthew ate dry toast. We went to a nearby IGA and bought some baby food and fruit. The store management had a list set under glass at the checkout counter of those who had not reimbursed the store for NSF cheques. Three weddings passed by the store. As we were getting in the car a tall fellow stopped to fawn over the children. He talked with a drunkard's sincerity (though I don't know if he was drunk).

"He (Matthew) reminds me of my own boy. Better looking maybe. Yeah, better looking. Families are good. Keep it. I don't see my boys much anymore. I don't see my wife."

The drive from Drumheller, especially both sides of Beiseker, is surprisingly beautiful. One looks at the farms, the crops, the

fallowed fields, the ditches, and imagines a large neighbourhood kept trim, shaded, clean. We made Calgary by 4:25 and reached Michael's condominium with no trouble. Michael was waiting. He was at the balcony and squirted water on us as we passed underneath with our bags. After bringing in the luggage we walked to a nearby Safeway and bought groceries. Michael phoned Cathy from there and made plans to meet her at his place a little later. We walked back. The groceries were awfully heavy for \$51.

We went for supper at Sam's Deli on 4th St. SW. It was in a renovated building, but made to look as it might have been, with mortar squeezed and broken, vertical wall boards stained red-brown with thick varnished, and windows decorated for the effect of shadows falling over everything. It wasn't so much a place for families, but the waitresses enjoyed the boys, stalking to them, making faces. Cheryl and I split a BBQ beef sandwich. Peter had a hamburger. Michael had ham and dill. Cathy had a Caesar's salad. Cheesecake all around. The bill was \$33.

We walked a few blocks to Cathy's apartment. Her balcony looks onto the Elbow River. Peter and I watched a family of ducks swim here and there. The mother was confused. A band was playing at the Exhibition across the river. We looked at Cathy's family album, at individual pictures and her Quebec pictures. When we returned to Michael's the boys were bathed and put to bed. Peter slept on the floor and Matthew went down on the king-size waterbed. It has a mirror in the headboard. The four of us talked in the living room. Michael asked about guitars and guitar music. We discussed Leona Boyd, Nietzsche, Calvinism and the Lutheran Reformation and the sexual freedom/bondage within certain social groups. At midnight we went to bed.

Sunday, July 31

We were out of bed by 7:00. After some talk we walked on Mount Royal, just up from Michael's. The road was steep and by the time we got to the top on Hillcrest road Peter was tired. Since I was carrying Matthew on a backpack (listening to his "Hi dada"), Peter was hoisted by Michael. We noted the fastidious gardening, the low-lying willow-swept white bungalows, and the silence. Is life like that? Michael is looking at another apartment nearby, according to him the oldest in Western Canada. Cheryl and I played Risk with Michael as Peter slept. Matthew thumped around to get attention. Cheryl eventually had a nap with Matthew. Peter woke and we played in the park.

We drove to the University after buying huge cones from "My Favourite Ice-cream Place" and sharing opinions about the four 'Valley girls' and their boys. We listened to a folk singer out front for a while, then went to the Chevron building where Michael works. He got visitor passes for the electronic gates. We took the elevator to the 20th floor where both Michael's and Cathy have offices. Cathy's view is the red brick of a building six feet away. Michael is in a corner office with a view of the south and the mountains. Exploration maps are pinned on a wall, a helmet covered with stickers hangs on a hat rack. Matthew gets in his files, and Peter sits at his chair. What more could one ask for in an office in the 1980s. We spent a few minutes in the 24th floor fitness room checking out the training equipment and taking in the view. The boys romped. Back at Michael's, Peter, Matthew and I sat on the swings and hanging horses in the park. Matthew must swing hard. If it slows, he pulls at the chain. Once down, he follows on Peter's heels. After spaghetti and meat-sauce and some

conversation, Michael and Cathy go swimming, and Peter and Matthew bathe and go to bed.

Monday, August 1

Peter registers for the Suzuki Institute. Up at 7:10, with an arrival time of 8, Peter is not happy. He doesn't want a day with the cello. When registering at the University Theatre we learned that there was nothing more until 3. We went home and arranged with Michael and Cathy to go to the Zoo. Michael and I played frisbee. Peter watched Sesame Street.

Peter was so excited by the Zoo that he jumped around, ran from one exhibit to another, and asked questions about the slightest thing. Matthew slept. We had lunch downtown at the Express Cafe. The tramcars shook the street outside. The Greek proprietors babbled at the flaring hamburgers. We got home in time for Peter to sleep an hour. Matthew tried walking. He pushes everything aside between him and Michael's Sansui stereo. His knees have picked up a dull gray from the carpet. Cathy read, and Michael and I resumed with the Frisbee in the park.

We were on time for the 3 pm welcome address. At 3:30, Cheryl went with Peter to the basement for his Rep class. At 4:30, a Play-In. The activities go by different names, but we can't see much difference in them. The group is a large 27, and Peter seems to be the youngest. The pieces are played at a quick pace, and Peter gets frustrated. The teacher from New York talks more to the 10-year-olds. Peter managed by watching those nearest him. He survived the one and three quarter hours.

We were at home by 5:30 for sandwiches, then rushed to be back at the theatre by 7 for a performance by Helen and Michael Kim. Helen is an exceptional 9-year-old. She played Mozart's Violin Concerto No. 3 and Bartok's Five Hungarian Dances. Peter

marveled: "I think she's learned the violin." Then he put his feet against the back of a little boy's chair and ignored the boy's steady look.

We were home by 9:00, and Peter bathed. Matthew was carried asleep from the car. He had been bathed in the sink of a ladies' washroom during the evening concert. Peter had had enough after a while, and during the last piece slid straws down the banister of a stairway into a boy's mouth. Twice he was asked by an usherette to quiet down. Cheryl and I decided he had had enough pressure for the day, and forsook the discipline.

Tuesday, August 2

Today went smoothly. Everyone has adjusted to the new schedule. Matthew woke at 6:45 and slept with me in the living room the next half-hour. Peter spent one hour in a large group learning new techniques, and one hour in a master class. The only hint of his not being overjoyed came during the last hour.

He leaned to Cheryl and asked, “Mom, are my holidays over?”

“Not really Peter.”

“Then why am I playing my cello?” He spent the rest of the evening humming his pieces. He passed on this bit of confidence: “Mom I got confused and I’d try. I’d get confused again and I’d try.”

Cheryl joined the other parents at a special session from 4 – 5. Matthew and I strolled around the campus, and watched the security ticketing all the cars, no matter if they were out of province. Matthew beat his arms to the time of a water sprinkler. He pushed his stroller in the hallways. He briefly sleeps now and then, but is more interested in watching children throwing paper planes from the 2nd floor, studying the wall and floor patterns, turning radiator knobs, following a dragonfly as it beat itself against the inside of a window, and listening to the music. We returned to the apartment at noon hoping that Peter might sleep. He lay awake for an hour on the waterbed, but the apartment is hot, and everyone sweats.

Michael had a game at 6:30. We ate pancakes before he went. We drove to the Chinook Mall on McLeod Trail, then to the waterslides on McLeod and Heritage Drive. It’s a relief to feel

moving air. The waterslides are \$8 for the day. We'll go maybe tomorrow. Peter used \$10 given to him from Papa in two toy stores. He liked a gun with ricochet sound effects, but looked around. He thought that nothing else seemed as good, but would wait to buy it tomorrow. Michael and Cathy were home when we returned. They had won their game 28 – 7. Michael is the captain. We talked, then read some old letters. Cheryl learned family things by reading mom's letters to Michael. We talked about family members. Michael feels separated from the rest of his brothers and sisters, removed from the heat of things, the controversy that set the tone of our youth. The plan for tomorrow after supper is for Peter to see "Snow White" with Michael and Cathy.

Wednesday, August 3

Peter is finding more to enjoy. He listens, follows the instructions, relaxes when given the chance, has the confidence to participate in his own right. Once Matthew does wake, he wants to ride the elevator. He rocks his chair to get near the door for when it opens. He also wants Cheryl. Whenever we walk by the room she is in he tries to crawl to her over my shoulder.

We ate lunch at Joe's Diner where plate trays and sandwiches are taken from a '57 Chevy. Cheryl and I shared a hamburger and fries. Peter ate a hot-fudge sundae. When we saw a toy store Peter remembered yesterday's gun, but every passion has its tombstone. He rode off into the sunset with a nerf spring-loaded race car. Once at home, Peter and Cheryl napped. Matthew and I kept each other company on Michael's loveseat. He bounced, and when one leg slipped behind the springs he pulled at my shirt to free himself. Then he kneeled at the spot, pushed his hand as deep as it could go, and looked up at me. He puffed. At that age, suddenly losing a leg is an adventure. He slept shortly after. We left by 2:30.

During Peter's theory lesson, Matthew and I strolled around the campus. The sun was hot, so we alternated the outside with the cool hallways. Then Cheryl and Peter joined us outside where Peter practised. He is tired. At 4 Cheryl and I went to a parent's session and listened to explanations of the objects of the program's many games. Peter sat with us, fiddling with the lift-top of a desk. Matthew stayed with a babysitter. We picked him up at 5. He was in his stroller at the corner with children screaming all around him. He was tired and wet from a leaky bottle of milk.

We met Michael for supper at Humpty's Egg Place on McLeod Trail. Cheryl and I split a cheddar-cheese omelet (the thinnest three eggs I can remember), and Peter had a hamburger. We picked up Cathy and went to Market Mall. The plan for the movie went through, and Cheryl, Matthew and I shopped (a keystone, Peter's name stamp, a dot-to-dot, groceries). Going home we detoured through the vices of the 14th Ave and 7th St neighbourhood and found a tired Michael and Cathy who had been through the Peter-wringer of Snow White questions.

They leave tomorrow for a Chevron flight over the Rockies. Lunch in Jasper. Peter told us his dream.

"Cathy was crying. We were in the bedroom when she came. Michael asked, "Why are you crying? We're just doing something in the bedroom.' But she still cried. She was still in tears."

Thursday August 4

Two classes in the morning, two in the afternoon. Peter listens more carefully to his teachers than to us. Hmm. At noon we drive home. Several driving errors were committed that have probably found their way into a parallel journal: passing the 6th street turnoff and turning into a one-way street on 2nd, driving further than necessary.... More groceries. Peter is wild. He bounces around, races at Matthew, talks loud all the time. After lunch I took Peter to the Bonzai Water Slides. We paid the \$8, undressed in public, and slid until 1. The bobsledding position worked best. With Peter lying flat on me we flew high around the tight curves with someone always close behind. Only when a down-syndrome teenage boy followed even more closely than the others did we risk a violent outcome. Just as we reached the bottom I threw Peter clear. He came up sputtering, surprised, and asked if we could that again. Back at the condo there was an emotional cello practise, then a return to the university. Michael met us there after returning from his trip over the mountains. He was sleepy with nausea.

We had a barbeque on Michael's new Hibachi. Cathy brought wine which we drank from sugar bowls. Matthew clapped to the rhythm of Simon and Garfunkel. When the music stopped he kept on, periodically, for the rest of the day. Michael and I went to a music store, Cheryl put the tired boys to bed, Cathy went home. We were back by 9. Michael biked with Cathy. The boys had been sleeping for an hour. Cheryl and I talked about the day and went to bed at 10. I thought of Matthew earlier that day, sitting in the strong breeze, with hair flying, his arms raised, and a call deep

from within that sounded maybe like Elijah the prophet when he was a boy.

Friday August 5

Peter's final day. Good. Cheryl and I are rather tired of pushing him, and Peter has come to the end of being pushed. The days have been long, and Peter is dying to be free. Tomorrow we will drive to Banff.

We were late getting to the university. Peter talked the whole way about getting fired from jobs. I wheeled Matthew all over campus, first to the main foyer under the stairs, then to the Food-For-Thought cafeteria to add to the journal and drink coffee, then to the theatre hallway, and finally to a bench under the trees in the middle of the campus with Pluto wrapping his rubber legs around Matthew's arm. We had lunch downtown at the Express Cafe. We went along Stanley Street to the 'Catch the Wind' toy and game shop. We spent \$149 on presents, which included physics and chemistry sets for Peter. Cheryl left with the boys while I paid to listen to a rag band on the sidewalk. An old woman in pink shorts and sunglasses danced alone in the clearing and sucked on a long string of beads. The afternoon was abbreviated, we had a large supper of Japanese noodles and ground meat, then returned to the university by 7 for Peter's concert.

Peter was excited. The room was full. The program began with three baroque orchestra pieces, then a younger reading orchestra, then the cellos. It looks as if Peter has learned a lot. Matthew thinks so. He clapped with every piece. The violins played two short concertos by Bach and Vivaldi. The pieces became easier as more violinists came on stage. We left before the finish to get Michael's key before going out with Cathy. Following the Rider-Eskimo game, we went for ice-cream at My Favourite Ice-Cream

Shoppe. We meant to go next to the large reservoir on 20th St. SW, but the boys were asleep, and we were home by 11.

Saturday August 6

We left with Michael and Cathy for Banff by 10. Peter sat in the back and led a conversation about births. He talks and questions even when the answers he gets have no particular focus or meaning. He's a Pandora's Box of inquiry. The day was warm and clear. We were there by 11:20, and parked on Banff Avenue. We shopped for food for Matthew, were greeted at Samo's Broiler by a Grecian statue with a cardboard "Please Wait to be Seated" sign around its neck. A good meal but Matthew posed his usual challenges. Michael and Cathy went off to hike on Rundle's lower slopes, and we drove by the Douglas Fir Chalets on Tunnel Mountain where we honeymooned to discover that the quaint cabins with flower boxes, varnished interior and fireplace had been replaced by A-frames. We found a viewing spot over the Bow River valley. Peter and I sat on a stone. Cheryl tried for a photo of Peter with his arm around my neck, but no more film. We visited the Luxton Indian Museum, and for \$4 we spent 90 minutes with Peter asking how animals were killed, what the sun dance was about, and the Buffalo hunt, etc, and pulled Matthew off the fragile displays. Then it was a drive up Sulphur Mountain, back into Banff for ice-cream, and up Spray Avenue to the Bow Falls. Cheryl waited at the car with a sleeping Matthew, and Peter and I threw stones into the river. When Michael and Cathy returned, we went to the Golf Chalet, studied the dress regulations, and crossed the wooden bridge to the Banff Springs Hotel. Peter had punched a button on a Coke machine and got a free drink. We bypassed the outdoor and indoor pools, toured the lobby and mezzanine floors, viewed \$1,000 rings, and watched people go by. Matthew was in a pack on my back. Peter ran about. We took an elevator to the top,

peeked into open rooms on the 6th and 7th, listened to a tour-guide give information about the mushroom staircase and its handrails polished twice daily, and circled inside a medieval banquet room on a dimly lighted balcony floor. We left Banff by 5 in time for Cathy to see her parents after their visit with her brother in Traill. We ate the rest of yesterday's Japanese noodles and then packed. The boys were dressed for bed when Cathy phoned inviting us over. We visited with her parents and drank tea for a half hour. Michael came home with us. The boys went to bed, Cheryl read, and Michael and I talked more about guitars.

Sunday August 7

It's home today. We packed up our things that were scattered across Michael's condominium and left by 9. On the way to Kindersley Peter played dot-to-dot and yo-yo, and Matthew ate, clowned with wrinkled nose, and slept. We ate in Kindersley at the Gulf Station restaurant, listened to the locals talk, bought revels, gassed up, were off by 2:30 and home by 4:30. The air was hot.

Cheryl phoned her parents, but Peter spent most of the time with them. We unpacked, washed the car and drove to their place. We went to the Sheraton Cavalier for supper, exchanged news, then walked in Kiwanis Park until the mosquitoes chased us back to the car. Peter shot Papa's finger with a toy rifle and colored in a book with magic effects (the colour isn't apparent because it is dried on the page and activates when the special pen is used). Matthew walked across the floor between a pitcher and whoever would catch him. He attempted to clap, walk, snort and laugh at the same time, two steps ahead, one back, one ahead, two sideways, freeze, fall.

We returned home by 9, watched Fawlty Towers (the rat and the Health Inspector), put Peter to bed with a Suzuki tape. All Matthew needs yet is our patience.

Cheryl and I were in bed by 10:30.

Monday, August 8

The house was a bit of a merry-go-round this morning. Matthew slept well and woke at 7. I got up with him. He played with toys in the living room until 8:20. I read until I noticed how quiet it had become. Matthew was on his back behind the rocker. One foot lifted and fell, lifted and fell. He sighed nearly asleep. I put him back to bed and rejoined Cheryl. Minutes later Peter asked to go to the bathroom and then joined us in bed. I read the Journal to him. We heard Matthew cry. By then it was 9:15. After Honey-Nut Cheerios, Corn Bran and toast I shaved, showered and went into the basement to put more gyproc on the south and west walls. Cheryl washed, flipped a mattress and changed the bedding. She practised with Peter to review things learned in Calgary. After lunch Matthew went to bed. Peter left with Cheryl for his pedal-pusher's class at the Field House. Over at 3, I picked him up. The police will be there tomorrow.

As we drove through the Boychuck parking lot Peter said, "The police will probably show us his things."

"Are you guessing," I asked.

"No I'm not guessing. I'm thinking."

Matthew was climbing today. He slipped a leg over Peter's moon van and tried to get it to roll. Peter played his drums by the sofa. Kelsey and D.J. Millar came to play. Deena phoned at 1 to see if it would be all right.

She said, "You were away last week. Kelsey and I drove by your house every day hoping to play. When we saw your car in the driveway yesterday she was ecstatic."

I could hear the wildness come through the floor into the basement.

Everyone seemed tired after supper. Cheryl sewed. Matthew bathed and fell asleep in my arms as I watched a baseball game. Peter listened to a tape of Grimm's Fairy Tales. He came out at one point for a small snack and then went to bed.

I read D.H. Lawrence's *The Rainbow* until our turn came to sleep.

Tuesday, August 9

Matthew was awake by 7:15. Cheryl and I sat together with him and talked about family, parents and childraising. Peter woke at 8:30. We ate breakfast. Peter practised cello from 9:10 - 9:40. After, Cheryl sewed and I put on the last three boards of gyproc. Things are finally ready to be organized down there.

Dinner finished by 12:30. We left the house with the dishes soaking in the sink. Cheryl went to her mother's for a perm. Peter went to his pedal-pusher's class. Matthew and I went to Grandma Hedlin's. She received news from her doctor that she was physically as young as someone approaching 70. She is very alert and talked about all the news: Uncle Al and Aunt Isabel may stay in Thailand another three months, Uncle Ed needs bifocals, Katherine and Graham's daughter Meagan is as dark as he, much to Graham's pleasure, Karen spends two days a week in her daughter's day care, the rest of the time in Summer School and Uncle Alan is back in the hospital with severe hemorrhaging from his recent surgery. We left at 2:45 for Peter. Matthew walked enough to impress her and played hide and seek and peek-a-boo while she laughed.

Peter enjoys the biking lessons. The policeman had been there.

As I put Peter's bike in the back seat he said, "Dad, I want to tell you some very important rules. The police says I need a bell and a license."

He emphasized bell and license as if we have chosen to disregard the only two things in his life of any importance.

Cheryl's hair was curly. She seemed happy with it. We sat in the living room long enough to watch Matthew walk with no help. Help us. When we got home nearing 4 Matthew and Peter lay down for short rests. Cheryl and I went to the basement and cleaned. By 4:30 Matthew was awake. Cheryl went up to get him. He straddled her sewing machine cover like a horse and bounced on it.

We ate scrambled eggs for supper. Peter had hoped for spaghetti. We arranged to take him to the dump.

After supper we went downstairs and moved some of my things - desk and books. The boys were wild in Matthew's playpen. We cleaned up at 7 and loaded the gyproc scraps in the trunk. On the freeway we passed Cheryl's parents, stopped, rerouted ourselves to Archie Campbell's corn fields. The gyproc went into Cheryl's parents garbage. We stopped at the DQ on 8th. Peter ordered a Butterscotch "Barfait", Cheryl and her mom Busterbars, Cheryl's dad a cone, me a cone and Matthew a spoon. We stopped by the Skarsgard grandparents, chatted from the car, went by Cheryl's parents to get the boys and went home. They were tired. They bathed. Peter listened to his tape. We decided to put Matthew down with no ceremony, no bum-patting. Difficult. Didn't work. Cheryl bathed and I stood by the crib. Each time he got up I told him to lie down. He cried, gripped the dowels, collapsed slowly but would raise himself again, put his hands on my chest, lean his head against my stomach, then collapse slowly like before. Finally he lay still, sighed, reversed himself then slept.

Wednesday, August 10

Now that Matthew is up early each day Cheryl and I get a quick start. All the preliminaries, washing, eating, cleaning up, are finished by 9. Peter had a good cello practise. He is putting all four fingers on one string as he plays. He does this with all his songs.

Cheryl worked up a sweat this morning to get the house ready for the arrival of Danny and Joan from Duncan. Peter and I cleaned space for my study in the basement. We bought some screws for shelving and took all my books from their boxes. When we got back from Canadian Tire Peter watched Mr. Dressup and Sesame Street.

I went to Roland Michener School at 11:15 to get Problem Solving material for a writing project and a Science curriculum guide for Cheryl. She is trying to make up her mind about subject areas for this fall. Cheryl made a fruit salad and toast for dinner. I took Peter to his 'Pedal Pusher' class. He didn't like the hot sun. He flushes bright red when he's outdoors for any time. He went to the University with the others. His back carried bits of mud.

We went downtown after the Field House. Cheryl has money from Christmas to buy a winter coat. They went on sale today. She prefers a certain close-cut navy coat with a wrapping scarf and belt from Eaton's. We put it on hold. We looked for snowsuits. Peter is almost out of his. I bumped into Kathy Haugrud and her two children seconds before Colleen Muth called to me. I didn't get a chance to see either of them. Peter was wearing his red duckbill baseball cap. Cheryl took it off while trying on coats. His damp hair was curling. Peter tried to get it down. He couldn't do it so he put the cap on again.

The boys slept when we got home. Supper was corn on the cob and hamburgers. Peter was too tired to eat more than one cob. Matthew didn't eat well either. His teeth have been bothering him.

After cleaning up we joined the Skarsgards at a new restaurant named "Lydia's", just above "Onion Books" on 11th and Broadway. Only the Great Grandparents were there with Cheryl's parents. The atmosphere is relaxed. Music is soft. We ate German chocolate cake, cheesecake, ice-cream and drank coffee, orange juice and iced tea. The children were held all around. Harvey and Anne were expected. Some photos of the farm were passed around. Large windows offered the view of the dark street where children ran and couples sat outside their houses.

We were home by 9:30. Cheryl's parents came downstairs. The study is nearly finished; most books are shelved, maps and prints are tacked to the wall. Cheryl's dad helped me shift two large rugs into place. We discussed the upcoming trip to Vancouver and down the coast. Peter looked through a catalogue, his eye on guns for Santa to bring. Matthew walked across the room several times. He applauded each arrival. Matthew looked for Peter and found him in his bedroom on his back listening to tapes. They don't often play with the same toy, but today Peter sat against the chest and Matthew right beside him leaning over a game.

Frequently we hear Peter say, "Good boy Matthew. Mom, Dad, Matthew is walking."

Matthew flatters Peter too. He pays close attention to everything he does, eyes making subtle adjustments to follow each move as Peter works at something. After a few moments of this

Matthew will look up and laugh until Peter says something more to him.

Later Peter said, "I've been twice times over the bridge to the Universtity (sic)."

I asked, "What do things look like from there?"

"Small. It would be dangerous to jump on the cars, wouldn't it."

"Perhaps. Maybe not so bad if you went through a sunroof or landed in a convertible."

"But we couldn't do that with our car, right? Our car roof is very fragile."

Cheryl just received a phone call. Danny and Joan have had enough of the heat, mosquitoes and blackflies. They have not been sleeping. They will drive straight home from up north.

Thursday, August 11

Peter began his day with cello practise. Cheryl took the boys to “Humpty Dumpty” for Kindergarten clothes. Peter got four shirts. I finished cleaning the basement and tended the yard.

Cheryl made another fruit salad. Before we ate, Maureen Bingham came over to get a blood sample from one of us for some control group in an arthritis experiment being run at the University Hospital. Cheryl gave it, poor girl. Maureen called me a wimp. I told her that the only reason a woman would do what Cheryl is doing is to become more like a man. Matthew showed Maureen his walk. She said, “That kid. He’s not walking. He’s not supposed to do that at ten months.” When she left the house was quiet.

The only thing Peter didn’t like about the salad was the zucchini. When Cheryl told him it was kiwi he said he didn’t like that either. I said there are apricots in there as well. He said he doesn’t like apricots. I said he didn’t know what an apricot tasted like. He held up a nectarine and asked if that was an apricot.

He won’t sit still on his chair. He pushes it back until only an edge is close enough to sit on. He slides back and away from the table; then he loses interest in the meal. He stands on the chair and talks, always talks, nibbles at a crust, runs around to Matthew’s chair to give him a hug and then excuses himself to the bathroom. Every meal this thin little boy burns more calories than he takes in.

The afternoon became a small disaster. Cheryl took Peter to his bike class on the way downtown. At 2:30 she phoned to see if I could pick Peter up since she was going to be a minute late looking

over Matthew's birthday gift with her mother (and Matthew). I said I would. At 2:40, five minutes before Peter's class was finished, the Mazda wouldn't start. Five minutes later it still wouldn't start. I took my bike out of the basement and raced to the Field House. Peter was unconcerned by my late arrival. I thought we would wait a few minutes until Cheryl got home and then phone for a ride. By 4 we were still unable to contact her. Even though the wind blew strong from the Southeast, precisely the direction we had to travel, Peter and I headed to Weir Crescent. No-one was home. We climbed the apple tree, ate some carrots and peas, chatted while standing on top of the doghouse (a Peter Rabbit adventure) and finally biked on to Preston and 8th. We phoned from a public booth. Cheryl was at home very worried and feeling to blame for the mix-up. I told her we had enjoyed ourselves.

We ate supper at Burger King and were home by 6. Peter and Erin played for a short time in the basement while I practised guitar. Cheryl was alone with Matthew in the kitchen, holding off him with one arm, mopping the floor with the other and saying,

“Back, back Matthew.”

He answered, “Back, back,” and tried to get past her hand into the film of water.

An active boy has become much more so now that he can walk. If a hand drifts by he will grab it and walk along. He turns corners then stands still, always a laugh to follow.

Both boys bathed at 7. We watched Cheers at 7:30 (Coach loses 8000 dollars to a hustler). The boys were in bed by 8. I lay with Peter. He asked about death and about all the people I knew who

had died. For each story he would shake his head and say, "That's really horrible." He admitted to crying one night because he was afraid of dying.

Peter is doing mental arithmetic. While driving, Cheryl asked him addition questions, 3 plus 2, 4 plus 4. He provided the correct answer within an instant. Cheryl asked a few more. We told him that we were surprised.

He responded, "I have to think you know."

When she gave him 4 plus 3 plus 2, he said, "That makes me think too hard. I want to make you think. What's 200 and 100 and 300?"

Cheryl knitted Dawn's sweater. I read *The Rainbow* until 9:30. We watched *Three's Company*. At 10 Cheryl talked with her mother on the phone and then went to bed.

Friday, August 12

A day passed but little happened. The morning was busy but nondescript. In the afternoon Cheryl and I dropped Peter off at the Field House for his final 'Pedal Pusher' class. He took his lunch for a picnic. Because of driving rain the class was held indoors. I had a doctor's appointment at 1:30. I left Cheryl and Matthew at Market Mall. Dr. Lappi told me I need an operation and arrangements were made with a general surgeon for a check-up. We bought groceries at Safeway. We picked up Peter at 3 and went for an ice-cream at the Ice-Cream Scoop in College Park. We took a short drive into Brownlee to see Carol and Les' house. It has plywood siding at this point.

After supper Michael phoned. He bought a Yamaha 260S for \$414 and plans to take lessons from someone named Jacob Solomon. Cathy's in Vancouver looking for an apartment. Michael moves from his at the end of the month. His roommate got mono in Toronto.

We visited with Mom and Dad. Jim Hamilton, now in Calgary, returned lab keys to dad with his youngest son Kent and told Dad about his recent trip to California and Alaska. We talked awhile about Joel's job, the presents he received from the U of S Huskies (football, cleats, t-shirt) and about Notre Dame. Peter caught his finger in a mousetrap. Matthew walked the entire evening. We were home by 9. Matthew wouldn't go to sleep until 11.

Saturday, August 13

Matthew was up by 7, Peter by 7:30. Peter watched cartoons with Erin for a half hour and then lay on the floor until 11:45. Matthew nudged him occasionally to see if he might move. I watched part of an Expo-Pirates game. Cheryl went downtown to buy the winter coat she had put on hold a few days ago. Cheryl returned home by 12:30, shortly after the rest of us finished lunch. She bought a different coat from Eaton's, black, along with a sweater and black pants, a shirt for Peter, a new sleeper for Matthew. After Cheryl finished eating we went into the back yard to pull some Johnny Jump-ups, Cheryl's idea of a flower that threatens to take over the grass. Peter played with Erin in the basement. Matthew was in the playpen, talking to us or stepping on the toy van in order to climb over the rail. He mimics Cheryl. "Get down," he'll say as soon as Cheryl's said it. We worked until 4. Matthew went to sleep. Peter and I watched some track and field from Helsinki. Erin came by and they went to Devon's. I practised the guitar. Cheryl cleaned vegetables. For supper we had corn on the cob.

We were tired but found something funny about Peter's questions: "What is energy?" "It's something in constant shortage which your parents try to conserve."

After supper Cheryl tried to rest. Peter, Matthew and I went into the basement. Peter played space invaders with a camp stove, Matthew chewed a dice eraser and I played guitar. Peter went to the bathroom. He came back down and told us that the noise keeping us downstairs was keeping Cheryl up. Peter had a long bath and a snack before going to bed at 8. Matthew was wide awake and walked for a while, but after a bath and 1½ bottles in Cheryl's lap he went to bed. I could hear them giggle in his room.

Cheryl was still laughing when she came out. He had been reaching through the bars and pulling her mouth close to kiss her, then he would roll onto his back and flop his arms. Soon he turned onto his side, clapped his hands together, patted his head, scrubbed his hair and slept.

Sunday, August 14

We went to church today. We rushed and left the house by 9:20. The church was crowded. The service was handled by a new intern David Lefsrud and a onetime seminarian, currently an engineer, Prankev. Roesler is on holidays. Peter tried to lay on the floor. Matthew climbed up the back of the pew. Our section was noisy with children. Prankev tried something new. After the sermon, Lefsrud disappeared behind the alter wall and played a recording of To Dream An Impossible Dream over the speaker system. The Pedersen's youngest, Jens, was baptized. Their family filled the front two pews.

The A&W was closed. Matthew fell asleep in the car. After dinner Peter had a sleep. Cheryl and I read, then Cheryl knitted a sleeve for Dawn's sweater. We watched the World Track and Field Championships. We watched one Czech woman in particular; she had a swaggering masculinity and was unbeatable on the track.

An Oliver Twist musical was on. Peter got up in time to see most of it. He was captivated by the smoky blue lights of London's nighttime squalor. The "kind robber" and the "cruel robber" images did nothing to change Peter's view of criminals. He edged closer to Cheryl for comfort. As he told Cheryl's dad later, "I giggled when Bill got shot." He happy that Bill won't bother him tonight.

We went to Burger King at 5. Ken and Caroline Dick were there with their two children. Prof. Yakaluk and Brenda Larson were there as well. Back at home we decided to call over Bill and Maureen. Peter ran next door with the invitation. Erin came over first with instructions.

“Mom drinks homogenized milk and Dad only beer.”

We spent 1½ hours with them. The children screamed in Peter’s room and tried the milk in Matthew’s bottle. Bill talked about the neonatal unit, medical arrogance, and the new Med School dean.

After they left Cheryl bathed Matthew in the sink. Peter went to bed. Cheryl’s parents arrived with farm produce. They stayed until 10. Judy and Ronny gave Matthew a pewter plate and a bib and utensil they had found in different European shops. Cheryl’s parents got a lot done this weekend. Adolph plans to build an equipment shed at Henry’s. Plans have been made to move the buildings next Monday and Tuesday. Peter told Cheryl’s dad about the messiest parts in Oliver.

Monday, August 15

Matthew was up by 7. I sat with him and read Lawrence's St. Mawr, and Matthew played with a Fisher-Price cash register. He turned the crank to open the drawer, took out a yellow coin, compared it with the coloured keys and the coloured fruit and then set it into the correct hole at the top. He pushed the yellow key to drop the coin into a channel and selected the "change" key to set it rolling into a side dish.

We talked more about Bill Sykes at breakfast. After, Peter practised cello. They are working on polishing pieces that Peter knows so that he will be ready to play with the older group.

I rode bike to the University. Cheryl took Matthew to Peter's swimming lesson. Peter thinks the lessons have become shorter. He gives a little flip of his hand and says: "The lesson was short today. All we did was do back floats with a kickboard, then we put on our life jackets, and that was all."

Matthew slept from 11 to 1. Cheryl sat with Peter, first writing out words with sh, ck and th and then working with word and picture cards - Cheryl would compete with Peter to read the word - whoever said the word that matched the picture got the card. In the end Peter lifted each card just enough to glimpse the picture; perhaps a different game. At 1 Peter rested and Cheryl went outside with Matthew. He climbed onto Peter's red tractor with pedals and heaved about on it without moving much. When Cheryl took him inside he gripped the steering wheel and cried.

After supper I mowed the lawns. Peter got a phone-call from Mama and Papa. He was invited to stay the night. We rode our bikes over. On Taylor, Peter slipped against the curb edge and

skinned his knees and toes. After some tears and sitting on the sidewalk holding his leg he got back onto his bike and struck out in the lead. He showed his signals all the way. After a short visit Cheryl's parents headed to our place with Matthew and we returned on our bikes. We went to Ryden's Deli in Bedford Square. Peter, Matthew and I sat in a cutaway tub with faucets for Matthew to turn and Peter to pull off. Matthew dropped an empty glass fruit jar on the floor. Cheryl's dad spilled Tab onto his clothes. We talked about Thursday's trip to Waskesiu, the Monday and Tuesday workdays at the farm, heart operations and hernias. Finally Peter said: "Mom, you have Mama to talk to, Dad is talking to Papa. I have no-one." By then it was 9. We were dropped off at home and we heard Peter call bye to us out the window, halfway down the dark street. Cheryl and I sat in living room and Matthew fell asleep on Cheryl's chest. We were in bed by 10:40.

Tuesday, August 16

Today is our 8th Anniversary. Money is tight so we will wait for another year to celebrate. We do plan to get a subscription to Omni magazine as a small gift.

Peter slept at Mama's and Papa's. The house was quiet. We woke at the usual time, had breakfast and began to work, I on the writing project, Cheryl readying herself to take Peter swimming.

After lunch Cheryl and Matthew went to the grocery store for weekend supplies. Peter played outside with Erin until 2, ran some through the sprinkler in the back yard and then rested. When Cheryl got home I went to the University for some books.

The family went to Cheryl's parents for an anniversary supper, BBQ roast, coleslaw, potatoes, lefsa. Adolph Peters and Grandma and Grandpa Skarsgard were there. The Skarsgards have planned a trip to Vancouver with Andrew on Friday. Peter and I went to the park to play "pretend football." This was a game Peter and I had played this spring. Peter's aim was to pretend he is a soccer ball and run past me into the goal. The mosquitoes were heavy, and men were playing in the field. Instead, we watched a fastball game. Peter sat on my shoulders for most of the last inning and I stood. He asked to sit on a post. I asked if he was uncomfortable. He said, "No, I thought you might like to." He was most interested in the batters. A rusty cat played in the dirt by the umpire. When we returned Cheryl had taken her grandparents home. We left by 8:45.

At home Peter prepared for bed and I got him a bowl of Bran cereal. I read the part of The Hobbit where Bilbo rescues the dwarves from the elves by shipping them in empty barrels and

sending them in the tunnel. At this point Peter was climbing his feet up the wall and nearly standing on his head.

I said, "Peter, turn around and lie properly. You're not listening and to know what's happening in this book you must listen. Tell me what is happening."

"Well," he said, "the dwarves are stuffed in barrels and Bilbo is with them in the dark tunnel, floating in icy water."

In the meantime Cheryl put Matthew to sleep. Peter had requested a kiss from her. I read in the living room. I heard some faint voices and then a long silence. Finally Cheryl came out. Peter had wanted her to spend the night. The time was 10:40. After a short guitar practise Cheryl went to bed and I phoned David Dick. He was asleep and sounded confused for a few minutes. We planned to get families together a week from this Sunday. I was in bed by 11:15.

Wednesday, August 17

This day was spent preparing for Waskesiu. Cheryl did much running around with the boys: Peter to swimming and home again for an early lunch. The afternoon was much the same. Cheryl washed clothes, gathered food and prepared the boys' clothing. I worked on the writing project and weeded the yards. After a supper of spaghetti and waxed beans Peter and I read more Hobbit. Cheryl bathed Matthew, then ran to her parents to see some shirts from Sears for Peter. With the boys asleep by 8:30 Cheryl and I read until bed at 10:40.

Tuesday, August 18

Matthew was up at 6. I didn't think that he was quite ready so I held him by the crib. His head rested on my shoulder and his arms were relaxed but his legs kicked back and forth. I took him into the living room. I read and Matthew pushed the brass tri-light around the floor. Eventually it tipped over and he did something else.

Once everyone was up we ate breakfast, washed and then packed everything into the cartop carrier. I mowed the lawns. We left. We gassed up at Esso. Cheryl asked Peter to read the pump numbers. He stood with his nose six inches from the pump and counted as the numbers turned over.

The drive to P.A. seemed short. We drove into heavy cloud. Matthew slept the whole way. Peter checked the distance every few miles. Cheryl and I talked. At P.A. we wandered around Eaton's looking for a clown handing out the balloons that Matthew was pointing at. No luck. We went for dinner in the mall and left by 1.

Rain was steady from P.A. to Waskesiu. The girl at the park gates said that sunshine was forecast for tomorrow. We got into our cabin #216 of Bakers', set out the clothes and food in the two bedrooms and kitchen area. We drove to the Nature Centre at 2:30, looked at the stuffed animals, got word of a Grey Owl film at 4:00 and left.

Cheryl fed Matthew fruit at a cook site on the beach. Peter and I walked to the end of the breakwater and back. Cheryl met us and we walked to the stores. Cheryl bought bread and peanut butter, we talked with Ernie Krahn by the movie theatre and returned to the Nature Centre to see Grey Owl. Peter sat on a stump in front of my chair and questioned everything he saw. Matthew woke up and

since I had seen this before I took him into the observation wing. We looked at the animals. Matthew touched one lightly. It wobbled a bit as if alive and he pulled back. I could see a wall of mist rising from the lake some distance away as a storm approached. When it hit, a line of water dripped from the ceiling. I talked briefly with a naturalist.

Peter and Cheryl were out by 5. Peter was touched by the trapping scenes. A bear film is showing tomorrow. He is eager to see it. We were home shortly. Supper was sandwiches. Matthew was starved. Cheryl drove to the townsite for a cookie pan. She came back with chocolate-fudge cookies.

I read *The Hobbit* to Peter. Bilbo is in the mountain. Matthew pushed his crib around the floor. Both boys were tired. Peter went to bed at 7:30. Matthew ate a banana and finally went to bed. Cheryl read *Chatelaine* and crunched crab apples.

Friday, August 19

Today was full. Matthew was up early even though Cheryl had stuffed him with fruit and kept him up till late. We breakfasted on Variety-Pak cereal and eggs. After we dressed, Peter and I played frisbee outside the cabin and tossed bread to squirrels. Even though the sky cleared overnight a cold breeze blew off the lake. All of us dressed with our heaviest clothes and walked down Waskesiu Drive to the townsite. We searched for formula for Matthew with no luck. We went to the Park Centre Cafe, waited behind two RCMP, and ordered 2 coffees, an ice-cream cone and toast. Peter sat with us until his cone was finished, then sat alone in the far corner to watch the computer characters flow across a video game screen. A waitress watched him sitting with his hands on the machine. She put money in it and instructed him on how to play Pac Man. Pinky ate him twice in 27 seconds to end the game. As we sat with our coffee, talking and watching others stroll in, we decided to drive to P.A. that morning for the formula. We walked back to the cabin. Matthew fell asleep on my back. I could see by our shadow that Matthew's head had fallen straight back.

We were in the car by 10:30. After dropping by the Nature Centre to find the time for the Bears and Man film we set out for P.A. The sun was warm.

We arrived at the Eaton's Mall by 11:30. Both boys slept so Cheryl went down first. When they woke three minutes later we went down and met her at Zellars. After a few buys we ate at Smitty's and left. Peter bought a chocolate bar at "Boots".

The time was 1:20 when I gassed up north of P.A. The show was at 2:00. We couldn't make it by then but drove 70 anyway. Peter dripped chocolate on himself.

We were in Waskesiu by 2:10, enough time for Peter and Cheryl to see most of it. Matthew and I walked on the lake shore path outside the Nature Centre. After the film we rushed to the cabin and were changed and ready for the beach by 2:40. We followed Matthew everywhere, kept stones out of his mouth and helped him dig holes and build the "Lonely Mountain" in the sand. We visited with Carl Krause, walked along the beach until Peter squashed a rotten fish head with his bare foot, skipped stones, pulled Matthew off of the seat of someone else's tricycle, pushed the boys on the swing, read little bits, played frisbee, got Peter away from the oscillating merry-go-round, walked Matthew along the water edge, and so on. The sun was tepid. At one point Peter ran up from the lake.

"Dad, can we dig a hole as deep as that man is digging?"

Cheryl looked for that man and said to me: "That man is actually a very very very big boy."

He was sitting in a hole like layers of whipped cream in a bowl. Beside him was a pulsing dome of hairy fleshy father-hood.

We carried out our supper plans to eat at Paignton beach. After we got the food together we drove out. We roasted wieners and marshmallows, made hot dogs and "smores", kept Matthew off the ground by feeding him buns, and listened to Peter, "Boy, this lake is so beautiful. I love it here." The sun was brilliant, the lake was golden, the breeze was clean. Cheryl and I squatted by the fire with

sticks and the boys giggled with mouths full of bread. So simple and to the point, so much time just to “be” there.

We drove on to the Narrows. Around the corner a wolf squatted on the road then loped easily past us without looking a second time. We spent only a moment watching a girl cast from shore then returned, driving slowly, hoping to see wildlife.

Suddenly Peter said: “I see something.”

“A tree?” I asked.

“No, something much lovelier.”

“What?”

“A bear.”

We were home by 8:30. Matthew bathed in a hand basin. Peter changed, had his face washed and got into bed. We read *The Hobbit*. Cheryl walked with Matthew down to the lake and the swings.

Peter lay in his room, silent for a moment, then he belched. “Excuse me.”

“Ok Peter.”

“Did you hear that?”

“Yes I did Peter.”

“It sounded like a skid.”

Cheryl finally came in. She put Matthew down. We read.

Saturday, August 20

After breakfast we went for a walk into town. It was 8:45. The weather was much warmer than yesterday. Peter used 25 cents of his allowance to buy fire hydrant candies. After our coffee and fruit at the Park Centre Cafe we started home. Peter dropped his candies on the sidewalk. He bought a second fire-hydrant. We were at the cabin by 9:45. Matthew fell asleep. Cheryl took Peter to a film at the Nature Centre called Predators. I read St. Mawr. Matthew woke at 11.

After dinner Peter rested. Cheryl went out with Matthew. I read the Star Phoenix. Rider coach Faragelli has been fired and Trudeau is facing more pressure to resign. At 2 Peter and I saw Bears, with Peter leading me through it event by event: Baby cub falls in disposal container; hiker is mauled by bear. We returned to get Cheryl and Matthew, went for an ice-cream cone at the Ice Cream Scoop, walked on the beach and parted company. Cheryl and Matthew home to get beach clothing, Peter and I went to the 3 pm Death of a Legend. As we walked to the Nature Centre Peter imitated distant boat horns, then a wolf howl. We met Cheryl and Matthew and found a place to relax. Peter ran back and forth and Matthew put pinches of sand into a pot. A group of teenagers with sunglasses and tan lotion lay with pouty expressions as they watched the sun go to work on their bodies.

We ate supper at the cabin, cleaned up and drove to the Hanging Heart Lakes to feed the ducks. Peter managed to get the ducks to eat out of his hand. I quacked and they couldn't come near. After fifteen minutes, Matthew sleeping, we drove back to the cabin. Cheryl and Peter went to the swings on Lake Shore. Matthew woke up once inside the cabin and wouldn't go back to

sleep. A girl fell off the teeter-totter. Cheryl jumped off the swing and slung her injured (broken?) arm with Peter's sweat shirt. Once they had helped her home we went for a walk and a drive. The sun was setting in full view from the beach. It's a ceremony one never tires of. Many were on the beach watching it. By 9 we were back in the cabin. Cheryl made popcorn, Peter spilt his milk, I read *The Hobbit* and Matthew stood at the door and teased him. This is our last night at the cabin. Cheryl and I feel that we haven't been here long enough. We could use another week. We are both tired. We read till bedtime.

Sunday, August 21

This is the last day at Waskesiu. Cheryl, Peter and I are spending our time feeling badly about it. After an early rise and shower (Peter insisted on having his second in two days) we ate breakfast and packed the car. I was with him in bed for fifteen minutes before he got up. He was full of questions about the courtship of wolves in *Death of a Legend*. We wanted to know about the things he had seen, driving at the point when he sensed evasiveness until he was satisfied his questions had been answered. He grinned, hunched his head into his shoulders and yucked several times. These questions continued in the shower and during breakfast, never being repeated, always plucking at some new facts. This is not an easy topic to talk about.

We were packed by 10. We paid the bill and drove to the lake. The sun was bright but the wind chopped up the lake and cooled the air. Our plan to sit on the beach until 5 would never be carried out. We had coffee and toast at the Park Centre Cafe, drove around Prospect Avenue and Orchid Street, stopped at the community ballpark when Matthew fell asleep and played baseball or read. We drove to the beachhouse for hamburgers, and finally decided to leave. The weather was not good enough for sunning. On the way out of the Park Peter and I went up the observation tower at the height of land where a German couple puzzled over a plaque, and then by the Buffalo Paddocks where cars had pulled over on both sides to see the 30-odd bison by the fence. We had been telling Peter the trip would take an hour. He was impatient with driving. He asked Cheryl to tell him when an hour was up.

Cheryl said, "Okay, we'll tell you when we get to the farm."

In a fairly sarcastic tone Peter replied, "I guess I know when we get to the farm. I want to know when an hour is up."

We arrived at the farm by 2, found Cheryl's parents at the Isaachsen's with the long trailer. After coffee I changed into work clothes and helped load the Inland granary on the trailer. Cheryl and her mother dug potatoes. By five-thirty we were on the road; we had the granary off in no time once we got there.

We ate supper (spaghetti, meatballs and farmer's sausage), changed and drove to Louise's where Judy, Dawn-Marie, Erling, Barb, Debbie, Erland, Ernest, Maggie and Tabatha were visiting. We left at 10. Peter was tired but talked. Matthew slept. We were in bed by 10:40.

Monday, August 22

Adolph was at the door at 7:15. He had driven in from the lake. None of us were up when he arrived, but breakfast was on the table by 7:50. After the meal was eaten and the equipment prepared Adolph and I drove ahead, Peter and Papa came behind. Within 1 1/2 hours the storage shed was loaded. We were invited in for coffee although Cheryl's grandparents were unable to sit with us. Mrs. Isaachsen was off to the Canwood doctor to have a painfully swollen hand checked.

Coffee was finished and Mr. Isaachsen was getting into his car. My car was parked some distance behind his. Papa seemed to know something I didn't. He moved towards my car, and called to me: "David, hurry up. He's backing his car. He might hit you."

Peter was drawn to Papa by the urgency of his voice. In the moments that I needed to get my keys in the ignition and the car started and in gear, Grandpa was upon me. I feared I couldn't clear out in time. I braced for a collision.

Instead, I heard Papa: "Hurry Dave, he's going to hit you, yes . . . no . . . Whoa."

He stepped between the two cars. Grandpa's head was turned, but not enough to see me. He was smiling.

"Whoa," Papa called again, "He's not the world's greatest driver."

"What?" Peter yelled, "Grandpa's not the world's greatest driver. Is that what you said?"

"Yes... No. I said he is the world's greatest driver."

Peter was gone. He was running after Grandpa.

“Peter.” Papa called. “Come here and be with me. Let’s see what Adolph is doing. Shucks, he was going to tell him what I said. That’s all I need.”

The shed was brought to Henry’s, unloaded and put into place with blocks. After dinner the granary floor was repaired, a clearing was made in the bush to put the metal shed, and these two buildings were blocked up. Peter was involved, moving things out of the shed at Isaachsen’s, riding the tractor, watching at every angle. He rode with Adolph on the way back. We kidded Adolph about the long ride. He laughed too and said something about Peter’s endless question, particularly about his hunting.

Cheryl was busy with Matthew. She found him tiring of the house so they went outside to the machinery. After the ride on the garden tractor he was never again content to be inside. Peter had him on the tractor and allowed him to steer. Then Peter, Matthew and I went out to the field to watch Leroy Larsen swathe. Peter sat between my legs and steered. Matthew stood on my legs and held Peter’s shoulder. Whenever he sees machinery he pumps his body and claps his hands. Peter was on the grey tractor alone when I was cleaning up lumber. When I was walking up from the barn, Peter on the tractor was slightly ahead. He said, “Let’s race.” I walked faster. He lost his smile, put up his hand and said, “Don’t run.” I continued closing the gap. He was so concerned he forgot about his driving and hit a tree.

Adolph left after supper. Cheryl’s parents went to Isaachsen’s to clean where the building were. Peter and I went for a

motorcycle ride. He was very tired. After putting the bike away we walked to the house.

He said, "I wonder what the doctor did to Grandma's hand."

I said, "I don't know."

"Maybe he had to cut it open. And write little words on it. And everybody would come and see the words and say "Googa. Googa-googa."

His hands held this idea like a ball.

Both boys were washed and put to bed. Leroy dropped in until Betty picked him up. The moon is full and over bright.

Tuesday, August 23

Today we finished at the farm and went home. After breakfast, Cheryl's dad and I stacked lumber in the loft, cleaned around the sheds, picked up tools, closed up the buildings and repaired damage to the trailer. Andy Larsen had brought Leroy to the field and dropped by the house with Judy's luggage. After coffee he let Peter speak into his 2-way radio. Peter will love him a long time.

Cheryl had packed most of our luggage. After we washed our hair and changed we left; 12. We stopped at Isaachsen's where Cheryl's mom spent 45 minutes picking vegetables. Peter and Cheryl visited with the grandparents. I talked with Cheryl's dad and walked with Matthew. The rest of the time we sat on the step and watched Cheryl's mom in the garden. We drove 35 mph behind the long trailer and got into Shellbrook at 1:20. Two tires were changed on the trailer at the Mohawk Service Station and we ate a big meal. We left by 3:40, stopped at Kilwinning for drinks and at Blaine Lake to shift drivers about; Cheryl's dad needed sleep. Peter had been singing and talking since Shellbrook. I drove the truck through Saskatoon to the Ardell farm turnoff. Then we separated and went home, unpacked and prepared the kids for bed. We ordered a Ryden's pizza. Peter and Matthew were in bed by 10. Cheryl's dad came over with some corn and potatoes. We went to bed soon after.

Wednesday, August 24

Cheryl had planned running around with the boys this morning. She took them to Premiere Optical and Sears to find frames for Peter's glasses. She bought white running shoes with a zipper that Peter would wear for gym and jeans that Peter liked "except for the stripes". Matthew was not easy to have along, and when Cheryl had come home at 1:30 she had "had it. The rest of my shopping will be done by catalogue." She said that Matthew had crawled out of his stroller and would not be put back in. Cheryl took the boys for lunch at The Bay. As she fed Matthew, Peter cried because he wanted to go to the bathroom. When the meal was done, Peter was still crying because "I have to go so badly," and Matthew pulled a chair over himself and screamed. I was working in peace on the writing project.

In the afternoon, Cheryl repaired a navy pantsuit, Matthew slept some and then spent the rest of the afternoon risking his life, I looked through English units for the fall and Peter played with Kelsey at her house. Kelsey had phoned twice at noon for Peter and engaged me in a volley of "byes" until I hung up on her. Peter was wearing his "guard" outfit. He blocked every doorway by stretching his arms across and saying "You can't go in there. There are prisoners in there" all in his harshest voice and frowningest look. He wears a microphone and speaker set strapped to a belt.

This morning he said, "Everybody in the world has died from germs Dr. Larsen put in their cereal, everybody except the people around here."

Cheryl's parents invited us out for supper at the Hospitality Inn as a payment for work done this weekend. Peter slept from 3:30 -

4:30. Cheryl sewed until after 5. We got the boys ready and left at 5:45. At the restaurant Peter spilled chocolate milk on the seats, himself and Mama. Everybody ordered filet mignon. Peter ordered King Crab legs. He enjoyed them but bore it with a philosophical reserve.

“Dad, I like crab. But I feel sorry that they have to be killed.” He was watching the flame under his garlic butter and rested his chin on his knuckles. “But we need meat.”

He ate most of it, shared the rest around the table, asked about the crab shell, metal lamps, and the procedure that brings crabs from the ocean to the table.

Matthew cried when the highchair he was pushing jammed against a table. I walked in the hallway with him. After supper we went to Cheryl’s parent’s place to pick up Peter. Peter mowed Papa’s lawn with him. Matthew teased Vicky by sitting close to her and making her growl.

We left there by 8:30. A strong wind came up, whipped the trees and blew in heavy clouds to make a murky dusk. We drove to my parent’s, visited for an hour, talked about family news, and drove home to put the boys to bed.

After Peter’s nap, he was crouching on his hands and knees in the living room. Matthew walked to him and pushed him back and forth. Peter reached back and pulled Matthew down. They lay quietly for a minute and then stood up together. Peter walked into the kitchen and Matthew held onto his belt, leaning his forehead into Peter’s back.

Matthew lay while in bed in his typical manner. Cheryl had the lights out and sat some distance away, near the door. Matthew was standing on blankets at the end of the crib. Cheryl asked him to lie down. Matthew disappeared as if he was lying down. Suddenly he popped up again and laughed. Down he would go, the dark top of his head visible, preparing to pull up again after a few seconds. We are never certain the silence will ever last more than that few seconds.

Thursday, August 25

This has been a day of work for Cheryl and me. The boys have played alone. Cheryl sewed clothing for school. I spent time on the writing project. Peter was in his room listening to the Grimm tape, over and over, and playing with his tea set. Matthew would spend some time playing with toys, or with Cheryl and me. I spent much of the afternoon out of the house, picking up RSP pamphlets, a weed bar for the lawn, wire for the new line to the stereo speakers, and meeting with Dr. Wilkinson about an upcoming operation. Cheryl took Matthew to Woolco after supper. I installed the stereo wire. Peter played outside. I fell asleep with Peter in his bed. The insurance woman phoned and we set up a meeting with her for Tuesday at 9 p.m.

Friday, August 26

The work (aided regrettably by the child pen) carried on for part of the day. I wrote out a problem involving information and planned to meet with PDR on Wednesday. Cheryl sewed some more, but also spent time with Peter. He has not seemed very happy. He has cried easily, taken things personally, become aggressive with Matthew and talked back at us. I had a chance to be with him in the car when I took a stew over to Daria Trischuk's. He would say only that he was angry and had been since we came home on Tuesday. We expect it has a fair bit to do with school.

Peter found that I would be returning to Daria's later that evening. Cheryl was to come but had to play the part of the babysitter we couldn't find because of Folkfest. He thinks this kind of exclusion is wrong.

"That's not fair," he said to me in the car on the way home. "I want to go to Daria's too."

"What would you do there with all those talking adults?"

"I'd just sit there. I'd listen."

Even though his humor didn't improve much during the rest of that evening, he let himself be put to bed with more from *The Hobbit*.

I spent from 9 till 12 at Daria's. I was admitted by a stranger who said, "If you think you belong here you probably do." Daria had gone to the airport to get some of the Genesa leaders. A game of "Go" was at the centre of one group, with people passing from one constellation to another. We ate homemade ice-cream. I

visited with Glenn and Sherry Christianson, Ian Erikson and G.B. Henderson.

We got the news that Michael and Cathy would not be coming to the city. They had no way of getting here. Cathy is likely to be going to U of A instead of UBC. Most of us seem happy with that. I'm sure Michael is.

Saturday, August 27

When we woke up we talked about the Genesa Seminar and decided to make what we could of it. Cheryl managed to get a babysitter for Sunday, 10 - 2, but nobody for today. We cleaned up the house in preparation for Judy and her children, phoned Cheryl's parents and got invited out for supper. Then we drove the boys out to Jim Korpan's home north of Grandora where the Seminar was being held. Everybody was on the lawn. Three crystals were set up outside. The boys roamed freely. Peter stepped on a cactus, Matthew almost. G.B. showed Peter the movements of the hands, sweeping motions in an arc along the lines of each of the interconnecting spheres and the harmony plane. Peter looked as if he were doing a silent dance within the plastic ball. Derged Langham, the originator of the Genesa concept from Arizona, discussed the applications in his field of plant breeding. Cheryl took the boys with Jim Korpan to see the purebred Irish Setter pups. One lay in Peter's arms. Another peed on the floor. The basement was full of trophies. Back on the lawn Matthew walked about with Peter's red cap pulled to the side covering one eye. He reached for a crystal. To stop him from flipping it off its stand I moved and pulled him away. When I stood up I knocked the thing off.

On the way home at 4:30 we stopped at the A&W. The sun was very hot. We were home by 5, fed Matthew and went to the car. It didn't start. Wallace next door boosted us and talked about his \$75/month piano rental. We were quite late arriving at Mano's. The others, including Erlin and Dawn-Marie, were eating pizza. We ordered, ate, watched the children run around and left by 7.

Cheryl's parents wanted to go to Folkfest. Cheryl waited for Peter to play with Erling's walkie-talkie before she took them home. Matthew fell against the door and cut his eyebrow. I stayed with Erling and D.M.. At home Peter went straight to bed and Matthew sat in the dark living room, turning the dial of the FP telephone and speaking in the receiver crooked in his shoulder: "Bye bye Papa bye bye Papa."

Sunday, August 28

Peter was happy to stay home today. Sandra came at 10. He was walking Matthew as we left. The car started. We were at Korpan's by 10:35. Everybody was on the lawn. We did movement exercises, listened to a physicist discuss the crystal, calculus and hyperspace, then broke for dinner. Some people swam, others talked about each other and Genesa, and a couple from Lethbridge played Renaissance recorder duets with Jim Velby's violin under a birch tree. We left at 1:45.

I took Sandra home. Peter liked her. "She was soft." We went to Mom and Dad's to meet with the other kids (including Sharon, Melvin and their two children) for their anniversary. Matthew was tired. After the cake and ice-cream Cheryl took him for a drive to put him to sleep. She came in to visit. It was my turn to watch him. I thought he would move when he woke and I could detect any movement when I looked out the window. I was wrong. When I went out for double assurance I found him hoarse and swollen. He took a couple of hours to stop twitching. We stayed until 5:30. Joel was at the "Border Bowl", a game between the Huskies and the Golden Bears. Matthew and Cheryl are leaving Tuesday morning sunrise.

After supper we went to Cheryl's parents. Brenda Larsen and Jamie were there. Peter dropped Matthew into a flower bed from the steps while waiting for Mama to take a picture. Matthew played with the fan, changing its speeds, placing a book on it to make it fly. Peter marched with a rifle slung on his shoulder. Cheryl and I told them about Genesa. Matthew clowned with Papa's 'Henry Fonda' hat. Peter watched lightning. He got a carrying bag from Judy.

At home the boys bathed together. Peter told me that Matthew is too interested in his penis. Cheryl put Matthew to sleep. I read several pages of The Hobbit (the dwarves pilfer treasure from Smaug). Then Cheryl rocked him to sleep.

Monday, August 29

The day was busy. Everybody is involved in separate projects. Cheryl spent a good half hour with Peter on the cello. Matthew is more mobile every day, ceaseless energy. We notice the beginnings of conflict: Matthew wants to do whatever Peter is doing, going outside, riding the van, playing in Peter's room or with records. Peter ate a peanut butter and jam sandwich as he watched Sesame Street. The part he hadn't finished, Matthew ate.

I was shaving when Peter said, "Matthew, look what you've done. Daddy, Matthew's got my sandwich!"

Matthew had torn the layers apart and put the sticky side onto the carpet. He was crawling with bread squeezing between his fingers. Peanut butter oozed between Peter's toes. When Peter came towards him Matthew screamed and waved him off. Peter came towards him again. Matthew put finger marks on his glasses. Matthew watched him until Peter backed off far enough, then relaxed.

Judy, Dawn-Marie and Erling flew back to Saudia Arabia at 7. Jim Velby promised Daria to meet the Genesa leaders at the airport at 7 am. He was the first one and pulled two tables together. While he sat a nun asked if he would mind her sitting there. He said it would be fine. She turned and waved her arms. Five other nuns came in from the lobby.

Cheryl still sews. I work on the project.

I swam at noon. Matthew was not well and stayed close to Cheryl. When I returned Cheryl went to the store for buttons. Matthew then stayed close to me. He crawled on me and lay his

head down for a few seconds. After, he talked to himself and pushed Peter's pedal tractor. Peter spent the afternoon with Erin and Laurel.

After supper we went to Homestead for ice-cream. We walked on the east side of the riverbank and University Drive. Peter sat on my shoulders. We went by Cheryl's mom and visited for three quarters of an hour. They are packing for a trip to Vancouver and the States. The night is hazy, something like early morning.

Peter was in bed by 8, cheering for Tolkien's Lake people. "They're not going to get him (Smaug). The arrows can't get through the scales." Only when Smaug did die would Peter sleep.

Matthew was angry at us for putting him to bed. I worked on the writing. Cheryl sewed a tablecloth. Michael phoned. He has moved. Cathy has quit work (with a \$6,000 severance package) and registers at the U of A on September 8.

Cheryl and I have been tired all day. I think I'll leave Lawrence on the shelf. Peter's word for women's breasts is "things".

Tuesday, August 30

Matthew had the best sleep of his life, from 9 pm to 8 am, with a quick diaper change at 6:30. But then he had one of the unhappiest days of his life. He has a cold in his nose and doesn't want to be left alone. He followed Cheryl into the kitchen and pulled her by the hand into the living room where he used all his weight to push her into a chair. Whenever Peter went outside Matthew thumped the door and cried.

Cheryl spent her morning with Matthew so that I could meet tomorrow's deadline on my 'future problems' assignment. Peter practised cello this morning for 30 minutes. Cheryl is having him practise difficult sections many times over. I asked him later if he was looking forward to lessons in the Fall.

"Yes," he said, "no."

Cheryl took Matthew for groceries, returned to put him to bed and left again to pick up some material.

Today we can deposit my pay-check. Good thing. We got another NSF notice from the bank. First Super Value, now London Life. Never before. And with a seven dollar charge on these things, never again. Cheryl wants to recover from our shame by leaving the bank. I think we should use blustering techniques, tell them that we think they are giving us rotten service, and that we might just change banks if they don't shape up.

After dinner (Peter was crazy about pita bread) we went to the bank, then to Market Mall to look for glasses (\$93 for frames). Matthew licked the windows of a telephone booth. A girl watched him from the inside with a funny smile. We went to Super Value to

pay for the cheque amount and find other frames (which we bought for \$54). We closed with a cold drink at Smitty's.

At home I do more work on the project. Peter types "the fox ran fast" and talks so that I can't think. Supper is stew. We give Peter the choice between meat and potatoes and try to get him to sit down long enough to get one of them in his mouth. He talks and forgets where he is. He tried to get an ice-cube out of Cheryl's cold water with his hand without seeming to notice he's doing it; though he's wet halfway to his elbow. Cheryl showed surprise, and Peter kept talking.

He is staying the night at Mama's and Papa's. We drove him over with his stuff. He will be going downtown by bus tomorrow. Matthew and I walked down the block. He got his foot stuck in the edging of someone's yard. We went to Ryden's for another cold drink. I think they store the day's heat somewhere and release it slowly in the evening. They must sell more that way.

Peter went home with Mama and Papa. We got the bright idea to get Matthew ready for bed and drive until he fell asleep. We found Carol and Les working at their house. We talked for a half hour and drove home. It was 9:30. Matthew was put in bed, I read, Cheryl sewed. I think history will not treat the two of us on equal terms.

Wednesday, August 31

This is the final day of our holiday. Cheryl and I have thought about it more than anything else. We have had a very good summer - to anyone else it might seem dull, but for us it has been the best yet.

Peter spent most of the day at Mama's. Matthew was awake at 6:30, which gave me an early start. After breakfast I wrote yesterday's journal and completed a problem on aging in the 21st Century. Matthew isn't up to his form and stayed close to Cheryl.

We went downtown at 11. Cheryl bought a snowsuit for Peter. I got a pair of shoes for school. Cheryl bought a blouse in Sears. Matthew was active.

I went to see Bill Krynowsky at PDR at 1:30, then Cheryl and Matthew joined me for dinner at The Bay. Matthew wouldn't sit down. He twisted out of the plastic strap and stood facing an old couple behind us. He talked. Peter was downtown too, but as we found out later he avoided us. The longer he stayed with Mama the likelier he would be riding the bus home again.

We went by Fabricland for elastic on the way to Mama's for Peter. I picked up several units of study at Roland Michener I had borrowed from Cheryl. We went to the DQ for ice-cream at 3:35. Perhaps that's an odd time to buy ice-cream, but Cheryl was fighting the fact that holidays are officially over.

We had a light supper after I mowed the lawn. I caught a couple of innings between the Expos and Giants. Peter and Matthew went into the tub, but Matthew was trying to walk from

front to back so I bathed him quickly and got him out. Peter stayed until Cheryl took his place to get relief from the heat.

The evenings are much cooler than the days. A breeze came up, cool and fresh. Matthew and I walked down the block. He walks in circles, tongue curled out of his mouth. I could hear Peter as he plays with Erin and Devon. He's between the houses, a mountain lion screaming at his prey. Erin and Devon quit before he catches them.

We went to Rose Gyorgy's for coffee. Ann, the grandparents, Susan from California, Harvey, Margaret and Roy, Steven and Jan Ardell came at different times. Matthew stepped up and down on the step into the sunken living room. Peter taunted the adults sitting on the couch. His horrible green fingers inched out from under the couches and up their legs. He was so convincing that he frightened himself. He sat with the adults who were sitting on chairs.

We left at 10:20. Matthew fell asleep. We sat on the picnic table and watched the northern lights. Peter said they were Aurora Borealis. He got that from TV, he said.

He wanted to read *The Hobbit*, but it was too late. Tomorrow Crystal comes for the day. We go to school. Things will have to be snappy.

Thursday, September 1

We had a good day. It began with a mixup; Crystal was delayed at a dentist and did not arrive until 9. We attended meetings at our schools in the morning and listened to Ray Fast's Director's Message at 2 in the Centennial Auditorium. Cheryl and I lunched at the Golden Anchor and thought that Peter might go with Cheryl to River Heights for French Immersion Kindergarten. After talking with Rita, however, we were advised to keep our boy out of the program at this stage - the French program had no enrichment and they had no language base for imagining or thinking about things except their little bit of French.

Peter had played all morning and slept all afternoon. Matthew had been talkative all day but slept twice. The kids are happy when Crystal comes over.

We took Peter to Macdonald's for supper, came home to see the latest news on the shooting down of a Korean Airline jet with 260 on board by Soviet fighters. Then we went to Margaret Fredeen's to see Alan and his new wife before they returned to California. After, we went to Grandma Hedlin's to meet her cousin Howard Neatby and his wife. They were in Saskatoon from south of London, England for a cross-country trip. Howard was second in command at the Bank of England. Strange that he had gone unknown by the other Neatbys for so many years. He was a cross between Anthony Eden and James Joyce - from a distance his wife looks a bit like Princess Margaret. They prefer Margaret Thatcher over Wilson.

On the way into the apartment we met several old women sitting on benches by the door. Peter had gone ahead and Matthew followed with Cheryl.

One said: "Now that they have a boy and a girl they can stop."

I turned to her and said that both were boys.

She giggled. "You weren't supposed to hear me."

Matthew and Peter were asleep as soon as we got home. Bard and the Master are vying for leadership in The Hobbit.

Friday, September 2

Our day started more smoothly. Crystal was ready at 8:15. We were at our schools in plenty of time. Even though the boys are very happy to be with Crystal, Peter does not like being left behind. He prefers to be out doing something, anything, to being left at home.

Both schools are looking good to us. Both of us spent the morning in meetings. Cheryl asked Rita Spencer about missing Tuesday morning so that she can be with Peter for school registration. This wasn't a great idea. Cheryl was urged to take Peter in early and miss only the very beginning of the registration.

She was home at noon and went downtown to buy groceries and material. She came by my school at 4 to see if I wanted a ride. A storm in the afternoon changed my thoughts about walking home. After arranging time for a meeting with Max regarding student government we left.

We ordered a Grumpy's pizza from Ryden's. Peter bathed. Cheryl's mom phoned to say they would spend the evening at Ione's and Adolph's. Peter was quite upset when we changed our plans to visit them. He was also very tired. He fell asleep when I was reading *The Hobbit*. 6:30. Matthew and I spent a while outside. The wind was strong and water was everywhere. Matthew didn't mind. He has a cold, so we weren't out for long. He was in bed by 8:30.

Cheryl and I did some school planning until 9:30. We went to bed knowing that tomorrow would be early. Cheryl's parents wanted to leave their house by 6:45.

Saturday, September 3

We were up at 6. We rushed about while the boys slept, then I went into Peter's room and I had hardly touched him before he said straight up and said, "Yeah yeah", knowing what I had come to say.

We went to the airport to drop off the luggage, then met Ione and Adolph for breakfast at the Saskatoon Inn. We were back at the airport by 8:35. Matthew pushed Peter around the floor on the luggage cart. We said goodbye and sat in the car so we could see the plane take off. Peter was in tears for being left behind.

Everybody went for groceries at Safeway and to River Heights to get Language Arts material. When Cheryl and I were going through the books in her portable classroom the boys ran and screamed in the black hallway. We could hear Matthew stomping in the other end but we couldn't see him.

After a quick lunch Cheryl went downtown for some dresses. Peter had a sleep. Matthew ended up sleeping in my lap. I watched US Open tennis.

Sunday, September 4

We were up early again. Matthew is teething. We prepared to be at the 9:30 service. Until then we enjoyed ourselves. Cheryl and I even sat down with a cup of coffee.

The weather was wonderful, pale blue sky, deep green in the grass and trees, a filtered sunlight. When the service ended we drove downtown for a light breakfast at the Sheraton. Matthew fell asleep on the way so we turned homeward. Cheryl slept too. Peter and I had toast. I read *Dune Messiah* and watched part of the game between the Broncos and Steelers. Peter was flying his Lego space jet in the hallway and rooms. We planned to ride our bikes to Mom and Dad's. First we cleaned the house, then changed Matthew's room around a bit. He seemed unhappy so we gave up the biking idea and drove. Mom and Dad weren't home. We went to the weir and walked along the riverbank.

We love the fall season. The wind is gentle. The sun is less hot but just as bright. The trail was crowded with strollers and bikers. A family carried a radio broadcasting the Rider-Bombers game. Pelicans swim right up to the falling water. Peter didn't want to walk at first, but he became interested in other things and stopped complaining. Cheryl and I talked about how good things were.

We went to the 21st Street Dairy Queen for hamburgers and ate them on a bench at Kiwanis Park. Matthew carried his bun on the lawn. A boy was lying flat on a super-light speedboat that made the sounds of a distant motor on a lake. Peter finished his hot dog and ran up and down the bank. Cheryl and I watched the river.

We stopped at a couple of stores on the way home. Tom Swingley saw me and talked for a few minutes before going into

the Burger King. At home Peter and I read The Hobbit. Then Peter watched Walt Disney. I practised guitar. Cheryl made a few last minute preparations.

David and Lynette Dick arrived after 7. The boys were up until 8:30. Matthew was teasing Peter, getting close, Peter telling him not to be a bad boy, Matthew grabbing Peter's hair, me clearing him away, Matthew getting at Peter from another angle and grabbing his hair.

Let's not pretend that Peter is innocent. Matthew was playing with a box in the hallway. As Peter walked past him, he kicked the box out of Matthew's hands. As Matthew walked by Peter, who was sitting watching TV, a foot came out and tripped him. I think we're going to enjoy the next few years.

David and Lynette told us about their family and farms. We told them about our holiday. We discussed school and David's practise. The rain started at 10 and continued until morning. They ran to their BMW. We were reading in bed by 10:45. I slept shortly after. Cheryl lay awake until 2.

Matthew loves Peter's red baseball cap. He wears it sideways and over one ear. He views himself in a mirror. Cheryl watched him today. He stepped in front of Peter's mirror and said, "Hiiii".

Monday, September 5

We have the Labour Day holiday today. We haven't planned much outside of having Augusta over. Peter started by practising cello. It is really coming. He seemed excited about it. The Fox Who Stole the Goosey Gander was his favourite today. He played it at speed using expression and superb hand technique. The overall tone improves all the time.

I worked on the writing project, trying to get it done. Bill K. wants it on his desk by Tuesday or Wednesday. That won't happen. Cheryl kept the boys busy doing something. Peter is so excited about school tomorrow he came into my study and asked me what I was doing. He then said, "Well, I guess I'm not going to be here tomorrow." He got what he came for, a conversation about going to school. Cheryl did some organizing for school, thinned out of her wardrobe, and labelled Peter's kindergarten supplies.

Irma phoned. They're bored and would like to visit. Cheryl told them to come over. They arrived at 4. Earlier, after lunch, Cheryl picked up some groceries at Hasty Market on her way to Augusta's apartment. Augusta was shown around the house and read the contract that Maureen had brought over. The boys stayed close by. Matthew put his hands on Augusta's knee.

The Peltier's came shortly after. We had pancakes and talked about their trailer trip to the American west coast, about the return to school, and so on. Peter and Sara played in Peter's bedroom under his quilt. They screamed the entire time and appeared periodically with flushed faces and sweaty hairlines. Matthew would have loved to be with them but can't yet open the door. He bangs it with his hand and yells. He is not feeling well.

After fussing with him—he would not be held or left alone—we discovered that he was suffering a mild reaction to carrots in his Alphabet Beef lunch. John and Irma didn't mind the frequent interruptions at the table. Irma had brought fruit/chocolate chip cookies.

When they left I read *The Hobbit* to Peter. Cheryl bathed Matthew and both of them went to sleep. Peter had both of us on his bed telling him about when he was little.

I read *Dune Messiah* and watched bits of the Dallas-Washington football game. Cheryl sat on the couch and worked on the *Games* magazine. We have decided to hold off singing in the University Chorus until at least next year. Just getting back on our feet, we don't want to wreck our little bit of calm.

Tuesday, September 6

Matthew was up at 6:30. Then Peter was too. School. We washed and dressed. Everyone ate breakfast by 7:30. Augusta was here at 7:55. How comfortable this is. I walked to school. Cheryl and Augusta went with the boys to register Peter. Cheryl went on to school. Augusta brought both boys home. They kept her busy. Cheryl was home by 12:25. She spent a relaxed afternoon with the boys. School is going smoothly for her. She and Shelley have agreed on important points. They went grocery shopping during the afternoon, then relaxed some more. Cheryl made sure that supper (chicken, rice, corn on the cob) was in the oven well in advance of Daria Trischuk's arrival time.

I walked home. School is most pleasant. The class seems normal. Staff is helpful. At the end of the brisk half-hour walk I was met at the door by Peter and Matthew. In turns they sat on my lap. Peter wanted to tell me about school and registration and putting his Kleenex box in his classroom. He goes again on Thursday in a small group before kindergarten starts its daily routine on Monday. He was laughing about Matthew. "Matthew had taken off his diaper and sat on his bare bum."

Daria arrived at 6:15, just after Irma had phoned Peter to hear about school. Mom had also phoned to say they had been with Joel in Notre Dame while he registered for the year. Leaving him in a line of boys was very sad for them. Daria brought three roses. We ate, talked mostly about Genesa and its personalities and possibilities. Peter insisted on showing her how well he could ride the bike. Matthew walked around the house, hands in the "stick-em-up" position. He followed Peter mostly, smudging his glasses when he could reach them or playing hide and seek. He goes to

Cheryl's desk and looks around the fridge expecting to find Peter behind the chair. Today Peter was under the counter by the garbage. He said boo. Matthew bit his tongue in surprise. He squealed and threw up his hands. After supper they chased each other through the red tunnel.

Daria left at 9. Matthew went to sleep. Peter talked awhile and listened to Cinderella on his tape. Cheryl read the Saskatoon magazine. It is 10:50. We are tired. We have just learned that Ray Pashovitz is dead.

Wednesday, September 7

We were up with the 7 o'clock news. Peter was home for the day. Augusta was on time. We left for school shortly after.

Cheryl still doesn't know what she is teaching. The numbers at her school are not final and teachers have no time to sit down with the schedule. She is very pleased with her partner, Shelley Loeffler. Shelley seems fair-minded and hard working.

Cheryl was home by 12:20. The boys were happy. Augusta enjoys them. She was out walking with Matthew in the stroller. Cheryl went with them again later in the afternoon. She played on the floor and read *Soup* by Robert Peck to Peter.

I walked home. Cheryl was ready for the Cherub choir barbecue at church. The air was warm and bright. Kids were eating when we arrived. Cheryl visited with Nancy Pederson, Elaine Akre and Lorraine Reinhardt. Peter ran behind the bushes and trees with countless girls his age: Katherine Akre, Erica and Ingrid Pederson, etc. Matthew walked amongst the kids with hunched shoulders and drooping hands. I talked briefly with Arvid Pederson.

We didn't stay long. The boys were tired. Peter and I finished *The Hobbit*. Matthew went through his ritual of standing, falling, rolling, scratching, patting and hugging, before he fell silent.

We had little time before Brenda Storer from London Life Insurance arrived to talk about various policies. Cheryl and I were so tired she didn't penetrate very far. We kept some information. She left by 10:40. We went straight to bed.

Thursday, September 8

Up at 6:20. These long days are killers. Cheryl and I are restless at night. We sat with the boys awhile before the time came to go. We left shortly after Augusta arrived. Cheryl drove me part way.

Cheryl still doesn't know what she teaches. Some teachers refuse to teach anything but what they've done for many years. Just the same, she has several classes into her room and does puzzles and games with them. They seem to be very decent children. Most in her class are very average: the boys talk about BMX racing, BMX bicycles, BMX clothing. She has some marriage breakdown casualties. Children tell about arguing parents, the troubles of raising themselves, and so on. So often these children arrive unkempt, hair unbrushed, clothing wrinkled and worn, struggling to be with others.

Peter had his first day at school. Cheryl asked him what his teacher was like.

"Oh, she's nice."

"Is that all you can say?"

"In fact, she's probably the best teacher I ever had."

He tells us her name is Mrs Lymon. She has black hair. The kids did some art, "painted a foot," went for recess "while Mrs. Lymon went for tea," but the break was too short and Jennifer cried a bit when her parents left. Peter seems awfully calm about this. Perhaps he really isn't bothered by all this newness.

But this is having a ripple effect. Because kindergarten is the only thing in his life at the moment, nothing else seems important

enough to do: tapes, toys, bike riding. All he does when he is at home is wander about with no purpose. He teases and disciplines Matthew, yells into his police microphone, giggles. Cheryl and I hope that school meets his high expectations. Most of his enrichment will happen outside school. We read to him, he learns the cello. Other things will come up for him to do.

The toll for a bad night's sleep was paid this afternoon at school. Active teaching feels too much at the moment; I want to work from my chair. But the end of the day came and I am still alive. The kids I've been given are good, well-behaved, most of them quite strong academically. I made myself walk home at the end of the day.

After supper we went to Canadian Tire, Safeway and Grosvenor Park Shopping centre. We bought some groceries and a teaching book. At home the boys were put to bed. I have started *The Book of Three* with Peter. Matthew took twenty minutes to relax enough to fall asleep. Cheryl and I took turns sitting by his crib, heads resting against the rail while Matthew thumped his foot onto the mattress and puffs lightly. Cheryl read the paper. I watched a bit of a Viking-49er game and wrote in the Journal. We were in bed by 10.

Friday, September 9

Troubles. Augusta was here at 7:55. She sits in the living room and laughs at Matthew while Cheryl and I prepare to leave. She had rain on her coat and hat. Cheryl planned to pick up Deena Millar. The car wouldn't start. We woke up Maureen Bingham for a boost. We weren't too late.

Cheryl has a better idea about her assignment. Science, Health, Grades Seven and Eight Art. My schedule flows smoothly: a whole morning of English, most afternoons are Social Studies and a little Art and Music. Cheryl was by the school at 4 to pick me up. I was meeting with Carl Krause about the class list. She was exhausted by the boys. They have been a handful all day. We drove home. Cheryl got some food for Matthew, then we went to the Cave for a \$10 pizza.

Peter had to go to the bathroom in the middle of the meal. I grumbled something about not needing to do this every time we go out, and when Peter asked me what I said, I answered, "I was just talking to myself."

He said, "What were you saying?"

"Oh Peter, well I guess you don't need to run to the bathroom every time you go to the restaurant." He tugged his lip downward. "That's not talking to yourself. That's talking to me."

We got home at 6. Peter had a long bath. Matthew spent his time sitting here, walking there and diving off the sofa. I stopped him from making the last step onto a stereo speaker. It's hard to keep him from climbing. I watched the Rider-Ottawa game. After Peter's bath I read to him. We went a fair distance with Taran,

Gwydion and Gurgi. After describing Gurgi's appearance and self-pitying behavior Peter was chuckling. I asked him if he could picture Gurgi. He was holding his knees and pressing his eyes into his legs, thinking.

Suddenly he pulled his head back and smiled. "I can't see Gurgi. All I can see is E.T."

After listening to Gurgi moan about hunger and needing food, begging Gwydion for something, I asked Peter what he would have done were he the prince. "Well, when you've got to eat you've got to eat."

Matthew went down quickly. I didn't hear a word from him. I came out, watched the last minute of the game, visited with Cheryl, and we watched *My Father the Fullback* (1949) with Fred MacMurray. The vocabulary and styles of a 1949 university football family are hilarious. I fell asleep before the end. We went to bed in the middle of a storm. I had to run outside in the rain to secure a banging back gate.

Saturday, September 10

Matthew and Peter wake at 6:20. Since neither had bothered us during the night this was not too much of a crime. We spent the early hours doing what has become routine. We cleaned the house, wrote in the journal, showered, dressed Peter to go to his first cello practise. Matthew and I were to stay at home, but when Cheryl tried to start the car the battery was dead again. I got Bill to boost us, dropped Cheryl and Peter off at the University and drove to Sears to buy a battery. Matthew and I spent a half hour in the service room watching semi-final tennis at the US Open. Cheryl and Peter spent an hour at the play-in with all the cellists. Suzuki waiting lists are so long that Cheryl decided to sign Matthew up for 1985. She forgot Book 2 on the registration desk.

Everyone was hungry when we got home at 11:45. Matthew was asleep. I went to school after boosting the Mazda. I spent 2 hours preparing English. Cheryl wasn't home when I returned. She had taken the boys for rubbers and a bathroom set. I mowed the yards. The afternoon was very bright and warm. At this time of year one needs to dress once for the morning and again at noon.

By this time Matthew had tired and again fell asleep. Cheryl spent some time on a Science unit. Peter played in his bedroom. I practised guitar. Matthew woke at 5:20. We prepared to pick up Cheryl's grandparents at 5:45. We went to the Cave. Peter wore his new glasses.

We had an enjoyable meal. The boys managed nicely for the 3 hours we took to eat. Matthew sat/stood in his blue hanging chair. He ate a bowl of pabulum, a half bun, a jar of pears. He played with a 2-way wheel and Lego. Peter visited with the grandparents,

engaging them in conversation about most topics. We talked about the recent bus trip to Vancouver and the visit with the coastal Skarsgards.

Matthew was restless so I walked him. He ran back and forth on the arched bridge. I had trouble steering him away. People in lines or on the bench saw him and laughed, or called to him, or tried to walk around him on the bridge. Finally, with the conversation at an end, we left. Peter was in bed with a brief reading of the Book of Three. Matthew took longer, fading slowly with three C# dashes and two snoring dots. Cheryl bathed before bed. I read Dune, watched a bit of the B.C.-Toronto game and went to bed.

Sunday, September 11

We prepared for church. Peter was to register for Sunday School at 9:45. We get more information about the Korean Jetliner. The Soviets interviewed the pilots who shot down the jet and aired it on Soviet television to give the public the official version. Debris is washing up on Japan's northern coasts. Grieving families are close to the down-site throwing flowers in the water. Two passengers have been found. The identification card of a Sault Ste. Marie woman was found.

We got to church on time. Peter is being taught by Maureen Mooney. She brought popcorn. Peter won't complain so much. Matthew was tired. I took him home, put him down, and did Social Studies preparations until 11. I joined Cheryl at church. The building was full. We came home for lunch. The air was so warm we decided to drive to the University with Peter's bike and then walked from the Diefenbaker Centre along the Meewasin trail to the 42nd St. bridge and back. Peter stopped frequently to investigate "scuffling" noises in the grass. The trail was busy. Cheryl got faint under the RR bridge where the path is built over a 10 foot drop. Matthew fell asleep. We went for milk and ice-cream afterwards.

Once home, Cheryl worked on Science and Health. Peter played with Laurel in our car and her garage. I sat with Matthew in my arms and watched some sports. He woke at 4. I helped Cheryl clean house. She dusted and rearranged Peter's room. I vacuumed and ironed.

We went to Burger King for supper. Peter was wishing for an early bed so he could be ready for school in the morning. I read to

him, played a bit of music, talked about his childhood, and said goodnight. Matthew tried several times to get in. He's funny in his footless sleepers, the legs riding up. He walks stiffly and each step causes his body to tip slightly the other way to give a stalking motion, like the fat-legged dwarves in movies. Cheryl put him down, then made lasagna and cookies. I worked on school assignments.

Monday, September 12

Rain again. With temperatures dropping close to 0 degrees we'll be waking up in snow pretty soon. When Augusta arrived, Cheryl and I left. The Mazda wouldn't start. I was going to use it for a meeting after school. Cheryl had a good morning. Her schedule is finally settled and looks good to her. She gets off Thursday at 10:40. My day as well was straight forward. There are very few teaching problems in Roland Michener classrooms so the time is well spent. Meredith Dunlap had \$80 stolen this weekend.

Peter didn't want to tell us about his day. He said they did "nothing" except take a tour of the classrooms. We plied him with questions about his first real day of school but got nowhere. Finally I told him that I needed information for this journal. He sat straight and said, "Oh". He was suddenly full of facts. The class hid in the tunnel when Mrs. Lymin was out. Peter played with toys. He didn't want to hide. The class visited the older kids who were told to be kind to the small ones.

After supper I ran some plants to school and dropped off 7 volumes of *The Futurist* at the University. Peter was tired when I got home. He bathed, then we put him to bed. I read the *Book of Three*. Suddenly he burst into tears and asked me to stop reading. He was afraid of the Horned King and Cauldron-Born, dreaming over and over that the King had thrown fire into baskets of captive men. Whirring noises and eerie whistles woke him up last night. So much for Alexander.

Matthew was sicker tonight than ever before. He screamed from 10 until 1. He seemed to have stomach pains, pushed us away but wouldn't lie in bed. Peter was awake. We didn't know what to

do. This was worse than previous allergic reactions or swollen teeth. We almost took him into emergency. Cheryl sat with him for a while and he gradually calmed down, though he didn't stop twitching. Once falling asleep he didn't wake up for the remainder of the night.

Tuesday, September 13

We've made the decision to eat porridge in the morning. We burned the first pot and had the second cooked just in time to eat it before Augusta came. Peter had a stomachache. We wondered if he should stay home from school. By the time Augusta came, however, he was dressed and ready to go. Matthew was much happier. Cheryl drove me by school. Both of us had good days. I made it home at 4:50, just in time for Cheryl to get Peter to his lesson. Diane was visiting. She had spent the day teaching in Osler. Peter was missing, and by the time we discovered him at Holt's Bernadette had phoned to see if we had forgotten the lesson.

We ask Peter about school, but he doesn't want to discuss it much. All he said was that he missed recess because Robin was getting his shoes tied. He did show feeling, however, when Cheryl brought the lasagna with spinach to the table. Peter said, "I'm not eating any frogs. You've put frogs into the lasagna."

Peter went out with Laurel. He pedaled around on the green plastic low-riding chopper cycle. I went to the bank and boosted the Mazda. I heard Laurel say to Peter, "Our cars don't run out of batteries."

Matthew is happy these days only when someone is close, either reading to him or walking with him. His teeth are bothering him.

Peter bathed. I read Tuck Everlasting after I carried him like a helicopter into his room. Matthew went to bed at 8. He is restless. Cheryl and I did some preparation and watched The Coal Miner's Daughter on CTV.

Wednesday, September 14

The morning went smoothly, except that Peter felt so sick that we kept him home. Augusta was ready for the kids at 8. I started the Mazda and took it to school. Cheryl left soon after. Things are getting hectic. I got a letter from one of last year's students. She was concerned that I had split her away from her friends. "Boone the Bonehead" got in trouble for harassing a little St. Augustine girl yesterday evening. I went directly to a Language Arts meeting at Alvin Buckwold.

When I arrived home by 5 the house was empty, or so I thought. Then I heard Matthew in Peter's bedroom. I found Cheryl grinning at Matthew with drapes pulled over his head. Peter was lying on his side with his hands pressed into his eyes. Trouble waking up.

Cheryl had the boys out this afternoon. Peter's glasses were exchanged for plastic spring-loaded arms. We expect they will look much better than his old pair.

Cheryl brought some mealworms home and had given one to Peter to put in a small jar. He said, "Maybe I could take one to kindergarten." He hesitated and added, "Oh, but I don't suppose they let kids bring creatures into school." After a few moments he brought up the topic of totem poles. This had been a subject on Sesame Street. A car on the street got him started.

"I know where that car is from."

"Oh," said Cheryl, "where?"

"B.C."

“That’s right. How do you know?”

“They have blue license plates. Do you know what else they have there? Totem poles.”

“What are those, Peter?”

“Tall poles with different animals carved with knives, like birds and monsters. The indians made them.”

Later, in his bedroom, Peter was talking about winter. “And don’t you break the ice wrinkles off the roof in the winter, okay Mom? I want to play with them.”

Matthew has been tottering around like Charlie Chaplin. He reaches for a lowered hand and pulls it along the hallway, watching feet, matching his own step with them. While eating supper Matthew sat in a box and pushed out all the sides. I had him on his back, nosing him under the chin. He laughs and tries to push up with his hands and feet. Cheryl and I were kissing. He came from the hallway and tried to push me back while pulling on Cheryl’s hand to show he wanted to be picked up. Which Cheryl did. But then she reached for me and the three of us stood together. This still wasn’t good enough. When we kissed again he pushed my head back, and with an open mouth he tried to draw Cheryl’s head his way.

The three of them went to Peter’s choir practise. Matthew and Cheryl stayed in the nursery. Peter had set the conditions before leaving: “If it’s too hard then I won’t do anything. If it’s fun then I will.”

Once home he practised cello in the basement. Peter is getting back both his form and his interest. He comes up the stairs, cheerful and ready for bed.

We read Tuck. He likes it much better now. "It doesn't give me bad dreams." He does remember the heroes of the Book of Three with some fondness.

After leaving Peter I followed as Matthew walked like a duck into his room. Then he went into Peter's room. They giggled together. Matthew showed up briefly in the hallway, then returned to Peter. Peter pulled him into the bed. Shortly after, Matthew went to bed. After leaning against me and rubbing my stomach he lay down, sighed and went to sleep.

Guitar lessons start again on Wednesday 4 pm.

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Cheryl offered Peter candy this afternoon. They stood at the bins until he decided on one lemon candy for a nickel. He kept it in his back pocket.

"Augusta doesn't understand me," he said yesterday.

"Why do you say that Peter," I asked.

"She doesn't seem to hear what I say."

It was left that way until today when I asked him again how Augusta was. "Oh fine, she understands me now."

"Good, what happened?"

"She listens to me. She doesn't say 'what' after everything I say."

Thursday, September 15

We had a tough start today, porridge and school. Peter had a stomachache and thought that perhaps he shouldn't eat or go to school. Tears, tears, tears. I think Augusta must have wondered about the noise as she waited outside our door.

We had staff meetings today. Car rallies are planned by both schools for consecutive days on a weekend at the end of this month. Cheryl was off school at 10:40, marked for an hour and came home. She left Matthew with Augusta next door and took Peter to school. He spent some time in the library and the remaining time playing in the kindergarten room. He was on the street somewhere when I got home. Matthew was sitting on the floor, wearing one of Shauna's outfits. Cheryl was on the sofa reading the paper. After an enjoyable supper Matthew walked around the house. Peter, Cheryl and I ate lasagna and broccoli. Peter mimicked Mrs. Lymin reading poetry, a perfect likeness Cheryl said.

We went for ice-cream at the Homestead. A group of people stood in a circle and Matthew looked up at them. Everybody laughed at his bold curiosity. Peter went to him and took his hand, proud.

We were home by 7:30. Peter dressed for bed and I read Tuck. He was tired. Matthew stepped on a car and fell headfirst against the side of Peter's bed. He has pushed in at least two teeth. We can't tell for sure. We are waiting for a phone-call from Dr Hamilton. I suppose he's going to need some attention. We feel badly for sweet Matthew. Peter was trying to help. He said, "I was

just lying here and I saw him disappear. Then he screamed. I jumped right out of bed.”

Everyone is tired. I marked some English papers. We went to bed at 10.

Friday, September 16

Dr Hamilton phoned at 6:30 this morning to clear aside some time to see Matthew. We took him in at 7:45. Peter and I sat in the waiting room while Hamilton checked Matthew. We found that there is nothing we can do right now. Matthew has pushed them in and back. Chances are good that they will grow out but they may be blackened or abscessed. They also may have damaged the buds of his permanent teeth: chips, white spots, or blackened. Matthew's top lip is swollen. We went home again. Augusta was watching Canada AM. We fed him some breakfast and went to school.

Cheryl was home at noon. She held Matthew the entire afternoon. He wasn't very happy. His gums hurt.

Peter's day was good, but he had a bad time coming home: "And Dad, do you know what. A boy pestered me when Danielle and I were walking home. He called me a fag. And he said, 'Hey kid, do you want a mouthful of grass?' And he tapped me on my knapsack. Boy that made me angry. If he does that one more time he'll be sorry. I'll punch him."

Our evening was quiet. Matthew is more comfortable. He was sitting with us, teasing Peter, laughing with his lips out as if sipping water with a straw. Peter, Cheryl and I had a relaxed supper. After, Peter and Cheryl practised cello. Matthew slept briefly in my arms while listening (and rocking) to Paul Simon's Still Crazy After All These Years album. After the practise we watched My Bodyguard. Peter was happy when the bully was beaten. Both boys were in bed at 9:30. Cheryl and I followed shortly. We had about 4½ hours sleep last night.

Saturday, September 17

Peter says this is his first real holiday. We spent the day relaxing, one of the most enjoyable Saturdays in a long time. Matthew was up at 6. Cheryl proposed that Matthew and I come along with them to cello, and on the way see a gymnastics display by kids Peter's age. I thought perhaps, but as it turned out Matthew was ready for a rest at 10:30. We stayed behind. Matthew is back to his devilish ways. His lip is less swollen but still alters his appearance. When Cheryl and Peter left I read *Dune Messiah*. The rain and heavy winds kept us indoors. Matthew slept for an hour. When he woke we played on the floor like Peter and I had done earlier this morning, reliving *The Bodyguard* scenes. Cheryl and Peter were home by 12:45. He had had a good group lesson. Both were cheery at dinner even though the soup I made should have had twice as much broth.

Peter rested. Cheryl went downtown to get a few clothes, earrings and a Sunday outfit for Matthew. Matthew went several times into Peter's room and banged on his bed to wake him up. Nothing happened, so he put his hands on Peter's glasses. Cheryl was gone most of the afternoon and stopped by the University for some teaching books.

We had grilled cheese for supper. Mrs. Hay from behind us was at the door to tell us the wind was blowing our gate to pieces. I went out to repair it when Cheryl came from Maureen's where she was giving an opinion on winter clothing for the children. Louise Halfe phoned and asked us over. I postponed my work. We left here at 7:30. Peter and Usne played with Lego. Louise and Peter talked about their summer in Nova Scotia and their winter plans. A fire burned in the fireplace. Cheryl and I took turns following

Matthew around. He played with Omeasoo. We saw some photos of the East Coast. After coffee and cookies we went home.

Sunday, September 18

We mixed leisure and work today. After waking at 7 and playing awhile in bed with the boys we ate breakfast, dressed and took Peter to Sunday School. Matthew was tired so Cheryl and I looked for some way to get him to sleep. We bought coffee and hot chocolate at Robin's Donuts and sat in the car at the Diefenbaker Park parking lot, watching the river. We returned in time to get Peter and attend the service where Matthew, still tired, insisted upon walking the aisle.

We were home by 12:30 and had a light meal. Peter slept. I went to school to work until 4. When I returned everyone was awake. Cheryl had fallen asleep on the floor. She woke up, thinking that a couple of minutes had passed, looked around and saw Matthew in the hallway, also asleep on the floor.

Cheryl cleaned, I ironed. Cheryl cooked pizza. We ate it in front of the TV while watching Winnie the Pooh and the King's Singers. Matthew's diapers hung down to his knees. Peter galloped in and out of the room wearing two cowboy vests.

Peter had a bath at 7. His ear bothered him. I washed his hair with care but the ear was worse afterwards. I dried his hair while he cried. Matthew was curious and came in. He rested his head against my knee and Peter's arm. Later he found Peter on the floor. He lay down, put his head on Peter's chest, patted his head for a couple of minutes.

Peter went to bed with a fruit and cheese snack. We read Tuck. Cheryl lay with him and talked about his early childhood. Matthew fell asleep. I read Bashevis Singer's Shosha, Cheryl knitted, we watched Toffler's Third Wave. We were in bed by 10.

Monday, September 19

Another hurricane blew through the house this morning. Peter had to eat porridge again. He couldn't quite believe we were putting such pressure on him to finish. He was still crying and telling me to take my hands off him when Augusta came. When he calmed down he agreed to try for a better start tomorrow. Matthew took his turn. He held onto my pant leg and walked with me to the door. He cried when I handed him to Augusta.

Both Cheryl and I were tired today. My students behaved as though they had been penned in all weekend. I made it through the day and was sitting at my desk at 4 when Cheryl and the boys came in. Cheryl looked like I felt. She had been in doctors' offices since 1:45. Lappi had checked Peter's ear and found a pimple. Romanchuk says Peter's eye is improving and doesn't need another appointment for a year. He may be out of glasses when he's nine.

We asked Peter about kindergarten. He says, "We did the same thing today." We pursued further through play-acting. Peter was the teacher and we were the kids. He becomes very rigid and demanding. We are looking forwards to Parents' Night. We watched a PBS program on Orangutans. Peter giggled at the babies. Matthew fell twice off the sofa. He cuddled with Cheryl and stroked her chin as they watched.

Peter had another very good practise. Cheryl is pleased with his knowledge of pieces, tone, technique. Peter enjoys it more now.

I read Tuck to him. Matthew gets upset when he can't come into the room. I feel badly shutting him out but he tears at the book and Peter gets distracted. After, I went into the basement to do schoolwork, Social Studies and English prep.

Cheryl put Matthew down. She read a crafts magazine and bathed. I read some composition and watched the last few minutes of a Dolphins-Raiders game. We were in bed by 10:15. I could hear rasping sounds in Matthew's bedroom. Peter is able to sleep on both sides now that his ear doesn't hurt.

Wednesday, September 21

Matthew was up at 5. First Cheryl and then I tried to get him back to sleep. He was quiet while we patted him and hummed, but we could get no further than his door before he sat up and cried. We don't want Peter awake this early.

We had trouble getting ready for school. The porridge, the boys, clothes, everything seemed to put a drag on our forward motion.

School is busy with preparations for student government elections. I made a pitch to the senior grades about good representation and then formed some balloting guidelines for Thursday and Friday.

Cheryl had another busy day. Matthew's teeth are hurting him. He won't be left alone. Peter was in his bedroom when I got home from my guitar lesson. Supper was fried rice. Peter was critical of this. During supper Matthew lay on Cheryl's lap and blew bubbles. Peter couldn't eat because of a goosebump on his head after banging a cupboard corner at school.

"But I was very quiet when I cried. Nobody even knew I was hurt."

After supper I cleaned up. Cheryl and Peter went down for cello practise. I could hear Cheryl tell Peter how well he is doing. I went down to hear him play Etude.

Cheryl and Peter were an hour and a half at choir. Matthew woke up after a brief rest and slept again on my lap. I put him down at 7. He stayed down. I think we'll be up very early tomorrow.

Peter listened to Tuck, ate a snack and then went to sleep. Matthew woke up once and Cheryl changed him into pajamas. She did some washing, read the paper, took a bath, organized things for tomorrow. I worked on lessons and wrote the journal. Bed time at 10:15. I don't care for these six-hour sleeps.

Thursday, September 22

The days have become quite routine, getting up, escaping Matthew, working, returning to the same hurry and unrest at home. One longs for do-nothing weekends. Cheryl and I prepared ourselves and the boys for school. Kelsey Millar came over afterwards to play with Peter. Actually, she was sick and Deena didn't know what to do so Cheryl agreed to keep her. She played a while and then vomited on the carpet. Deena spent an hour visiting. I arrived home on my bike at 5 just as they were leaving.

Cheryl told me that we received another NSF cheque, this time from Supervalu. It was my turn to take the money in, but the girl wouldn't accept the money until the exact amount was known. We had supper at Burger King. Shinerama stands are everywhere. They wanted to buff my runners.

We were home by 7. Peter changed and went to bed. He says very little about kindergarten, only that there is much repetition. Matthew was in an excellent mood. Cheryl had an 8:30 haircut. A schoolgirl from last year, Tiffany Lauinger, phoned me. I practised guitar. The Expos got trounced by the Phillies. Cheryl and I went to bed. Her hair is short but sweet.

Friday, September 23

And Friday it is. Let's say that a few disrupted nights put together with lively classrooms makes one very tired.

After our porridge battle with Peter, Cheryl and I went to school. Cheryl's day went smoothly. I guess I would say the same about mine. When school was over I phoned Jim Jutras about his Social Studies program, then walked to Woolco to get my hair cut. The fellow beside me was getting his hair died white. He wore red shoes.

Maureen was visiting with a petition to protest some zoning changes. Cheryl told me about her day.

Matthew is celebrating his birthday today. Peter was pretty excited and wished to give Matthew his gift.

He said to Cheryl, "When are you going to give him his birthday milk?"

"What did you say?" Cheryl asked.

"I said, when is Matthew going to get his birthday milk?"

"I really don't know what you're talking about."

"You know. When I have my birthday I get a birthday cake. But Matthew can't have cake." He patted his chest. "I thought you would give him milk instead."

He told Cheryl about an incident in school. Mrs. Lymin has spent a lot of time disciplining the children, turning heads with her hands and telling the class to be quiet. Peter's best friend

Danielle was looking the wrong way and the teacher caught her. Danielle was told to go by herself. Peter felt sorry for her.

“I don’t like my best friends to sit by themselves.”

“So what did you do?”

“I went over to her.”

“And”

“And I said I was feeling bad. You shouldn’t have been looking the wrong way.”

“Did Mrs. Lymin know you were over there?”

“It was recess. I was on my way out.”

He got his new frames today, plastic with spring hinges. Supper was salad and scrambled eggs.

We went to Cheryl’s parents to mow their lawn. After, we went to the Homestead for cones and drove around the City Park area. It was soon dark. The boys were tired. We took them home, put them in the tub to play with Matthew’s bath toy (a spitting whale) and then into bed. I practised guitar until 8:30, helped Peter into bed, read with Cheryl and went to bed myself.

Saturday, September 24

How good our weekends have become. We made a great effort to relax, do nothing unpleasant, be outside, play with the boys, get our hands on every conceivable form of entertainment and so on. This revolution was sparked by a change in our circumstances: Matthew, no longer an infant, is sleeping.

After both of us dressing and washing, Cheryl drove to Crystal Peters' and brought her over to babysit from 10 to 12, and we headed to Carl Krause's for brunch. Almost the entire staff was there. A chef from the Holiday Inn made omelets in a small pan with our choice of ham, cheese, bacon or mushrooms. Coffee, rolls, juice, bagels and cream cheese, trifles and fruit juice were also served. The house was full. We thoroughly enjoyed ourselves.

We came home by way of downtown to exchange a broken platter. Matthew had been asleep and Peter was watching a movie. Crystal seems to have enjoyed them. She is coming next weekend so that we can participate in one (of two upcoming) car rallies.

After the boys ate we relaxed in the living room. Cheryl went to school to xerox and prepare some lessons. She was home by 4:30. After the boys were in bed I went to school to catch up on my work. When I got back at 11 Cheryl was still awake. We sat at the table for a small snack and went to bed at 11:07.

Sunday, September 25

Cheryl's parents arrived home from their trip tonight, or so Peter told us when he woke up at 7. He gave us the idea he didn't get much sleep last night, so we attempted to put the very grumpy boy back to bed. This made things worse, but it got him out of our hair until I finished showering.

Peter went to Sunday School. He insisted on walking in alone. Matthew was ready to sleep so we went for a drive (past McDonald's for coffee, home to finish shaving my chin, then to Diefenbaker's to drink the coffee). We returned to church to get Peter, went to Bonanza for lunch (met Max and Dalice Abraham there) and to Circle Centre Pharmacy for Phenergen syrup. Once home Peter went to bed. I fed Matthew and watched some of the Vikings-Lions game. Cheryl put the finishing touches on the sweater for Dawn Kasdorf. I went into the basement to practise guitar and work on the writing project. Peter was up in an hour, Matthew went down but was up again in a few minutes.

I mowed, raked and watered the lawns. Peter rode his bicycle around the block with Laurel, a girl he denies having any friendship with. We had pizza for supper. Peter left his crusts. I went outside to do more lawn work. Peter went out to bike some more. Matthew tried to tackle our legs whenever we came near. Cheryl folded clothes.

The Emmy's were on. Peter was inside every few minutes asking when we were going to the airport. He ran around, bounced on the benches and chased Matthew. He was excited to see Mama and Papa. All the way home he stood between them with an arm around each.

They unpacked two large cardboard boxes and distributed the gifts; 'hacky sack' (for the males), magic toys that grow in water, blouses (for Cheryl), a digital clock, etc. Ione and Adolph arrived at 10. We had to go, so we talked briefly and took the boys home.

Monday, September 26

Max Abraham gave me a ride home after school. Cheryl was outside in the sun. Peter was on the sidewalk in shorts playing with his twisting car. Cheryl planned to go to a school meeting after supper but her parents came over with a bucking horse birthday gift for Matthew. We assembled it and the boys bounced until Mama and Papa went home.

Tuesday, September 27

Peter's breakfast consisted of a bit of everything. He was still in his pj's when Augusta came. Matthew followed close behind us and cried when we left.

Peter's girlfriends, Kirsten and Dannielle, were over. They wrestled in the living room. Peter was superman.

Cheryl came for me at school. Peter was red-eyed after waking up unhappily from his nap. Matthew was quiet. We went by Safeway for bread. Peter told me about Bubba and Babba, a book he took from the library. Cheryl had prepared a delicious chicken and rice supper. We met Cheryl's parents at Robin's Donuts for a few minutes. Matthew wandered around inside.

Wednesday, September 28

Peter received his first pair of gloves, grey knit with rather intricate red and white diamond patterns on the back and palm. He wears them inside the house, keeping his hands away from his body like a gunslinger so he can watch the gloves.

Thursday, September 29

Payday at last. We went to the Delphi restaurant for supper. Matthew sat beside Cheryl in his blue rack-seat. He banged a knife on the table. Peter was sliding under the table and tickling Matthew's feet. Both boys laughed. The woman in the next booth asked the waitress if she and her two boys could be moved to a quieter table.

NSF cheques have been coming in quite regularly lately.

Friday, September 30

Cheryl and I went to a car rally put on by her staff. We began at six-thirty with seven teams of four. Cheryl went with team 7, I went with team 5. I drove and we won. One task took us into the Woodlawn Cemetery. A Scottish woman in the back seat was constantly on the edge, calling out “hurry” as if we weren’t already going fast enough. Cheryl arrived at Deena’s looking slightly fatigued. The people in her car smoked the entire time. They came in third.

Crystal was coming over. Peter was nearly pushing us out of the house before she arrived. From five o’clock on we had no peace. He had had his assembly today. His big buddy Lindsay in Grade 7 introduced him to the school body. Peter sang his ABC’s.

Other than this sort of event, Peter is quiet about school. After several days of being asked about it he said, “You always ask me that.” We decided to stop bothering him. Tonight at supper we were eating quietly.

Finally Peter said, “Dad, you haven’t asked about school yet.”

I said, “What was the best thing to happen to you today?”

Peter said, “I don’t know,” though he did tell us who got in trouble with his teacher.

Saturday, October 1

Cheryl's parents phoned as we were eating breakfast to see if we'd like to meet them for coffee at the Sheraton Cavalier. Peter went by himself to the Men's bathroom and got lost. After coffee, Cheryl and Matthew shopped at the Plaza while Peter and I went to group lessons at the University. We picked up Cheryl and Matthew and had lunch at Zeller's in the Lawson Heights Mall. We shopped for a shirt for Matthew to wear for a family photo on Tuesday. At home Cheryl and I slept nearly an hour. It has been several days of getting up at 6 am. We had a staff car-rally that evening. I picked up Crystal. The fingers on her left hand were hurting after being shut in a car door.

Half my staff made it to Byblow's. The rally took us around the Lawson, Silverwood and River Heights areas. Cheryl's team won. We ate hamburgers.

Sunday, October 2

I spent the morning at school and Cheryl sewed. Once home I found Peter on the floor wrestling with Cheryl. They were trying to practise cello but Peter insisted on playing his 'spooky' D scale. Matthew slept for nearly one and a half hours. He woke up just as Cheryl and Peter were laying down.

Cheryl went to school for the afternoon to prepare activities for the next day's Beaver Creek trip. I washed clothes. Matthew roamed the house all day, climbed on chairs, wore Peter's pajamas around his neck, muttering, then lay his head on my feet while I ironed. Peter was outside with Erin Bingham. The air was warm.

Cheryl was home by 4. She doesn't know the way to Beaver Creek, so we drove there. We turned off the highway at the Beaver Creek sign and followed a gravel road that turned and twisted through the pastures and groves until it became nothing. Beautiful autumn colours cover the hillsides. The boys slept the whole time.

We had supper at Smitty's. Peter complained about the cigarette smoke. The boys were busy with their food. Waitresses doted on Matthew.

I worked at home on lessons. Cheryl sewed. Peter went to bed at 7. Matthew is awake. Cheryl and I tried twice to put him down, but he wouldn't stay. We tried again at 10. After listening to him complain, Cheryl went in. He is quiet, which probably means she's patting his rear. Mozart's Piano Concerto in C plays in the background.

These days Peter is adding and subtracting in his head, three digits now, even mixing plus and minus ($2 + 3 - 1$) with little trouble.

Tuesday, October 4

Matthew had his picture taken at Fong's on 8th Street. Cheryl had him in an outfit we bought on Saturday. Each time the light popped he said, 'Uh oh.'

Cheryl came by school with the boys to spare me walking home in the heavy rain. We took a cheque to SuperValu (we'd been sent a registered letter advising us the most recent cheque had been returned stamped NSF), then had supper at Burger King.

Peter had his cello lesson, and even though he has not practised once this week Cheryl said things went well enough. She spent half an hour talking about school with Garnet and Earl Francis.

Matthew wandered around the house swinging his arms and clapping his hands looking for things to do. I put on ABBA. With the first note he began bobbing and swinging his arms with the rhythm.

The NLCS begins tonight: Phillies at L.A.

Cheryl's parents dropped over to watch the boys while Cheryl and I went to Meet-The-Teacher-Night to see Peter's Kindergarten teacher, Mrs. Limin. We bumped into Jim and Marilyn Jutras. Wes Boldt (just retired after selling his shares in a printing business) came by in a black velvet sport shirt. It is raining again.

At home Cheryl set her mother's hair, I put the boys to bed, and Sylvan and I talked about indians.

Wednesday, October 5

Peter didn't have much to say about school. He had more to say about spending the afternoon with Kirsten Jensen. Matthew slept only half an hour.

I had a guitar lesson after school.

At the request of Cheryl's grandparents, we met at The Cave to celebrate Syl and Doreen's 30th Anniversary. We visited from 6:16 to 8:30. Peter sat between Mama and Papa. Matthew played for a while then threw his toys on the floor. I took him for a walk. He ran back and forth on the bridge. Everyone arriving or leaving had to step aside to let him cross, usually with a friendly word.

While Cheryl vacuumed, Matthew got stuck on the spring horse, afraid to come down.

Thursday, October 6

I picked Michael up at the airport. He flew in from Calgary at 8:30. He's happy about things, his apartment, which is two blocks from Uncle Ralph's and three from Greg Fredeen's, and a leisurely walk to work. He spends nearly every weekend in Edmonton. He has been to Vancouver for long weekends and has lots of experiences to talk about. He spent a couple of hours at our place waiting for Mom and Dad to pick him up.

Cheryl has been having troubles getting Matthew to sleep. Something seems to be bothering him. Even so, leaving him in the mornings is getting easier. Augusta gets him busy doing something. He climbs on everything. Today we found him up the back of his highchair. Yesterday he was calling to Cheryl from on top of the highchair tray. Whenever he is caught doing something forbidden or causes an accident he says, 'Uh oh.'

Friday, October 7

Peter woke up with a fever and aches. We kept him home from school. Matthew isn't feeling very well either, but that hasn't affected his humour. He went around with a diaper on his head like a deranged Bedouin until the laughter ended, then got us going again by climbing on the table.

Cheryl, Peter and Matthew went to the airport to meet Lloyd. Her dad was there too. And Michael, who went to meet Cathy. They all went together to the Saskatoon Inn for tea. Lloyd spoke about his life in Vancouver.

While the boys were sleeping, Cheryl worked on puzzles in the Games magazine. There had been plans to have everyone for supper, but Lloyd had already arranged to eat with his friends.

We had had plans to go to Cheryl's parents for the evening, but Peter wasn't well enough. He cried in the hallway after being told. Matthew lay down with him, and Peter held his head.

Saturday, October 8

We met Cheryl's parents and Lloyd at F:11 early this morning. We drank coffee while we waited to be photographed. Matthew walked around. Peter went with him to get away from the cigarette smoke. While the pictures were being taken Peter posed with his hands in his pockets and Matthew sat on Cheryl's lap. It was over in 20 minutes. We met at the Sheraton for breakfast. Lloyd told us more about living in Vancouver, and fixing the door of the Mazda, and a wedding he was planning to attend. Then Cheryl went with her parents to do some Christmas shopping. I took the boys home. While Matthew slept Peter and I played chess. I watered plants in the front yard, marked papers and watched the White Sox play the Orioles.

Once Cheryl was home we took the boys to Robin's for coffee and drove around for a while. We were home by 4. Peter and I played tackle in the front yard while Matthew watched from the front window. I brought him out while Cheryl prepared hamburgers for supper.

Michael and Cathy came to visit. The boys were up until 9, playing in the living room, even though neither was feeling well. Matthew stayed near Cheryl and me whenever Michael called him. They were gone by 10:40. Cheryl and I went to bed soon after.

Sunday, October 9

Both boys lay in until 7:40. We could hear them humming. We did some cleaning around the house before getting dressed for church. Matthew followed me into the bedroom. The radio was playing. Matthew turned up the volume, startled himself, then began bobbing to the music. He had a nap at 9:30. Peter worked on a Monchhichi puzzle in his bedroom and sang along with his Suzuki tape.

We met Michael and Cathy at church, then joined Cheryl's parents for coffee until it was time to go to Mom and Dad's for lunch. The riverbank was brilliant with fall colours.

While everyone ate Matthew went around threatening all the fragile souvenirs. He wanted the ostrich egg, he wanted to go upstairs, he wanted to go outside. No matter how many times we took him down from whatever he was trying to climb, he was back at it. Peter played with Colin and Mark in the basement. Cheryl talked with Carol about Suzuki piano. Joel, Michael, Cathy and I played football in the street.

We left there in time to have a turkey supper at Cheryl's parents'. Her grandparents were there also, and Lloyd.

Monday, October 10

We took Lloyd to the airport at 1:30. Michael and Cathy were there, waiting for Cathy to take the same plane home. Matthew walks with a bobbing action. He is busy with the carousel and luggage closets. Peter stood at a phone booth and talked on the receiver, first to himself, then with Matthew and me. Michael talked with a Soils Engineer professor, and Lloyd with a friend he had met in line.

We went to Muffin Break at Grosvenor Park Mall for coffee. Cheryl held Matthew while he slept. Peter wore a turtleneck with khaki green fall jacket that buttons cadet-like over the throat. We watched a young couple tugging on each other's arm and falling together into a puddle. Peter went home with Cheryl's parents.

Matthew wasn't happy. He stumbled around until he gave up walking and cried on the floor. He found Cheryl sewing and lay at her feet. As in the past, he was pinching at her panty hose. Today she sewed barelegged. He tried over and over but could get nothing between his fingers. She laughed and told him to scram. Eventually he unplugged her sewing machine.

We went to Cheryl's parents to pick up Peter. Matthew bashed his mouth on the coffee table, then sabotaged what Peter had built with Lego. Michael met us at our place for supper. I drove him back to Mom's and Dad's, then went by the school to pick up some tests. A house had just burned down near the school. The night was cold. The lawns are icy.

Cheryl's parents had brought Peter home. He went straight to bed and they visited for an hour. They talked about Lloyd's friends. When they left, I marked exams. Cheryl filled out Matthew's

allergy form before his Wednesday appointment with Gerrard. We read before we went to bed.

Tuesday, October 13

Cheryl took the boys to Fong's Photography to pick up Matthew's proofs. There are several we like, but we can choose only one. I was home at 4:15. We sat visiting before Cheryl and Peter went to cello. Peter will probably be getting a Chinese 1/8 size to replace his viola, for which there is heavy demand.

The World Series started tonight: Phillies over the Orioles 2-1.

Wednesday, October 14

Porridge is still a problem for Peter. He smells it and is suddenly full. Our leaving for school is still a problem for Matthew. When he hears Augusta at the door he runs to us. On the plus side his crying isn't as bad.

Cheryl took Matthew to Dr. Gerrard, the aging allergist. He was impressed with her understanding of Matthew's problem. He told her there is little more he can do.

Cheryl and Peter went to choir. Peter phoned Kirsten Jensen and invited her along. Michael dropped by for his last evening in Saskatoon before going to Regina and home. We watched Game 2 of the World Series and shared stories of growing up. Matthew rolled around on my lap, then lay on the floor with a tractor. Cheryl and Peter were home at 8. They had gone by her parents with Matthew's proofs.

Peter had popcorn and apple juice. Both he and Matthew went to bed. Michael left by 9:40. Cheryl and I both prepared for school.

Saturday, October 15

The weather is cold and grey. Winter will be here any day. I dug carrots, enjoying the aroma of the soil. Peter called out to say that Mama had phoned to invite us to the Sheraton for coffee. I put the garden fork aside and down we went. We visited until it was time for Peter's group lesson. I dropped Cheryl and Peter off at University and brought Matthew home. He slept for an hour while I played guitar.

The afternoon was spent with Cheryl and Matthew shopping for groceries, me digging more carrots, and Peter playing in the basement with Kirsten and Danielle. Mom and Dad were over having coffee by the time Cheryl got home. Peter told us about what he was learning in computer class.

Once Mom and Dad were gone, Cheryl went to school and I heated up leftovers. When she got back, we called down to Peter, who showed the girls to the back door, and ushered out first one then the other with a hand on the back.

After supper the boys bathed, I went to school, Cheryl put her feet up.

Thursday, October 15

Peter was riding his bike when I came home, and Cheryl was in the kitchen feeding Matthew. He called to me, and I sat with them at the table. I spoke about Kindrachuk's (the Education Director) visit to my school. Peter showed up and was leaning across the table for some rice and broccoli.

I said, to Cheryl, 'Kindrachuk didn't look very well. He seemed grey and pale and ...'

'Dowdy,' interrupted Peter.

It's not rare for Peter to intrude on conversations that are none of his business.

I went to the bank after supper. I read the last of Tuck Everlasting while Peter lay on the floor. He mourned aloud Winnie's death. Cheryl read Robin Hood to him. Matthew, having slept only a half hour today, was asleep by 7.

An insurance agent came at 7:30. She talked about the range of options. We purchased the cheapest term policy. She was clearly unhappy. Peter sat on my lap, trying to lie down while she filled out the forms. After she left I practised guitar.

Peter had been sleeping awhile when he woke up in tears. He told Cheryl monsters were threatening to eat us and his little baby brother.

I got a call from someone at the Mayor's office and was asked about the size of our family. I asked who this really was. Then the boy's voice broke. 'Oh Mr. Hedlin,' it sobbed, 'it's Derek. I'd better explain tomorrow.'

Matthew's teeth are bothering him. Cheryl and I went to bed at 10:15, tired out by Matthew's 6 am risings.

Cheryl had planned to go with Peter to a symphony concert this afternoon, but Matthew was sick so the plans were cancelled. She read knitting magazines while he sat on her knee, then walked around the house with a bowl on his head and pots in his hand.

Peter wants to begin to write. He has Cheryl to write things he can copy.

The boys are very affectionate with each other. They're either hugging, or Matthew piles on Peter and they lie quietly for a moment.

I played badminton at school and broke my 'a' nail. This is a much ridiculed (by Cheryl) classical guitar term. Later, Peter was in the bathroom for some time before Cheryl called, asking him what he was up to. He said, 'I'm making my nails stronger.' She found him applying my nail hardener.

I watched baseball awhile, then read *The Borrowers* to Peter. Cheryl read the paper and played with Matthew. Peter ran back and forth in the hallway. We briefly thought of going out for ice-cream, but it's Friday and we're so tired we wouldn't have beat out a fire if it was in our lap.

Sunday, October 16

I stayed home from church to work on a writing project. Cheryl was back by 11:45. We ate lunch at Ricki's with Cheryl's parents.

Peter and I went to the Centennial Auditorium for a Suzuki concert. We were home by 3. Cheryl's parents were over. Matthew entertained us with hat tricks. I dug more carrots and played guitar. Peter rode his bicycle. Cheryl cooked bacon.

We drove east out of the city hunting for a chunk of wood that showed growth rings, which Cheryl needed for her science class. We found spruce boughs near the Forestry Farm. Once home, the boys played in the back yard and we ordered a pizza.

Peter and Cheryl watched an awful Daniel Boone movie. Peter cheered during a fight. I was standing with my briefcase by the door, realizing that Matthew was near me, but not thinking about what he was up to, until the clasps clicked and the case fell open, papers scattering everywhere.

Cheryl and I are tired. We put ourselves to bed by 10:30.

Monday, October 17

Cheryl came by the school at noon to pick me up. A water main break meant everyone was being sent home. Matthew was asleep in the car, and Peter was at Mama and Papa's. We went by and had a meal of tacos. Peter told us that Papa had told him he was homesick, 'So I should be with Papa as much as possible,' he said.

Tuesday, October 18

Peter declared that he likes eggs. He says he's hungry only if he is offered something he wants. Otherwise he is full. In a fit of open-mindedness he promised he'll try porridge tomorrow. Good luck.

Matthew lay with Cheryl for much of the afternoon, kissing and being kissed.

I was home in time for Peter's cello lesson. They had practised while Matthew kept himself busy in the crib. When they left Matthew scribbled with a pen on paper and pointed with commentary to parts of each figure. Then he pulled the pen apart. He ate and ate until he put his head on his tray and watched the banana in my hand.

Peter has joined the school's computer club.

After supper we went to Cheryl's parents for pie and ice cream. Papa and Peter were in the basement using the band saw to cut a car from a piece of wood. Matthew didn't know where Peter had gone, so he wandered from room to room calling, showing a new tendency in his walking style of kicking out his right foot.

Once home Matthew went to bed and I read to Peter. Peter wondered about truth in books. Cheryl bathed and went early to bed. I marked papers until 10:30.

Wednesday, October 19

A very busy day. I went to a guitar lesson. Peter practised cello while Matthew watched, standing, in his crib. Cheryl read George's Marvellous Medicine to Peter. We ate early. Cheryl took Peter and Matthew to choir and I worked at home. Matthew played in the church nursery, then cried in the car.

After Peter went to bed Cheryl went with Carol to Zane Hrynewich's for a Suzuki Piano training session.

Thursday, October 20

I had a staff-student football game at noon. Max drove me home. I found Cheryl and the boys playing in the living room. Prior to that, Peter was riding his bike with Danielle, Kirsten and Patsy.

We ate at 6. Cheryl's dad came over and kicked the ball back and forth with Peter, while Matthew stood in the middle to block it, then carry it to Peter. When Peter had worked up a sweat, he lay by Papa's chair and puffed.

Peter had a long bath while Cheryl put Matthew to bed and marked exams, and I practised guitar and marked stories.

Friday, October 21

The days are sunny and warm, which adds tension to the wait for the start of winter. I walked home from school. Cheryl had picked up tickets for the cellist, Guy Fallot.

We dressed and drove to Cheryl's parents for supper. While pulling away from the house Peter noticed we had left the front house doors wide open. On the way we dropped off a baby gift for Barb Baillod at Diane Van Hesteren's.

The Fallot concert was one to remember. Peter was tired and lay on the floor. Mama and Papa had taken Matthew to a home show on the Exhibition grounds. They said Matthew had charmed the whole place. Peter went to bed. Ione and Adolph came by. They told us about Heather in Capernwray. Matthew wore a skidoo helmet. The weight of it toppled him backwards.

Saturday, October 22

We were awake by 7 and were at the Sheraton by 7:30. Cheryl's parents and grandparents were there already eating. We then went to Market Mall to buy flowers for Papa and check out records. We opted out of group lessons. Peter was too tired. Both boys were asleep by 10:30. Cheryl and I cleaned the house.

Cheryl's Dad took us to Smiley's for lunch. Peter ordered fish and chips but ate almost nothing. We were late for gymnastics. Peter jumped on the trampoline, did floor routines, ran in line behind the instructor. On the way home he puffed his chest and looked at his muscles. Once home, I marked. Cheryl took Matthew and Papa to the hospital for pre-surgery registration. Cheryl arrived with Matthew. He had been smitten by a girl in the hospital he had seen in in a highchair. He said 'pretty' over and over.

Sylvan called to say he was being released in time to go to Mano's for supper. Peter knocked a ball back and forth with him in the hallway. We looked over the F:11 proofs.

Matthew was in a feisty mood. He stamped his foot when Cheryl said it was time to change him, wrestled with her while lying on the table, slipped free, and landed on the floor. Papa lay down with Peter and slept for an hour. Matthew sat on Mama's lap and flipped through the pages of a catalogue. At each page he pointed and asked, 'Whats'is? Whats'is?'

Cheryl drove her parents home at 9. I put Matthew to bed. He delayed my departure by holding up a foot to be rubbed. When Cheryl returned she read, then bathed. I marked. We went to bed at 10:30.

Sunday, October 23

The day began warm but cooled off with rain and an icy wind. Winter will be here soon. Every year we are mentally less prepared for it. We took Peter to Sunday School, drove around with coffees from McDonald's, then picked up Cheryl's mom for church. They went to the hospital after dinner. They found Papa sitting in the TV room with several old women. He shares a room with three men. There's a chance he'll be bumped up to a single.

Cheryl went to Suzuki piano with Carol at 3.

Matthew slept for a while, first in his crib then in my lap. When he woke I read beginner books to him. He flipped the pages back and forth, asking, 'Whats'is?', without waiting for an answer. Peter, Matthew and I went to Lakeview Park. I threw Peter's bike in the Mazda. Peter held Matthew in his lap. Matthew and I walked on the grass while Peter rode on the sidewalk. He was in his red 'Wolf' sweatshirt and brown fuzzy-on-the-inside vest. A group of boys were playing football. A stray ball bounced near us. Matthew picked it up, threw it, fell over. The game stopped. Someone yelled, 'Sign him up.' The wind was cool. Matthew's eyes teared and his face was red. Back home the three of us played Snakes and Ladders. I lost. Peter made a jigsaw puzzle.

After supper we watched Walt Disney cartoons, which Peter and Matthew both laughed at. I went to school for a half hour. Cheryl picked up her mother from the hospital.

Matthew's latest words: 'Oh dear,' 'Key' (kitty), 'ni' (nice), 'gedow' (get down).

Monday, October 24

Matthew is happier with Augusta. He watches us go out the door, then appears at the window with Peter to wave goodbye.

Cheryl took the boys and her grandparents to Market Mall for flowers. They had coffee and cinnamon rolls. Which killed Peter's supper appetite.

I walked home from school. Cheryl intercepted me on McKercher. We picked up the flowers at Market Mall. Peter told us about his school assembly. While Cheryl ran in, we stayed in the car. Matthew tried to get out of his car seat. When they got too restless we went looking for Cheryl.

Cheryl took Peter to see Mr. Dressup. He liked the part when popcorn flew out of the horn. After, they went by the hospital. Papa had lots of colour in his face and was happy, most of all about Peter visiting.

Cheryl and Peter practised first cello, then rhythms on the piano. He seems to have a good ear.

Irma phoned and we made tentative plans to meet.

Matthew was in a teasing mood in the evening. At one point he thrust his fist under my chin to tickle and left it there as he fell asleep.

Tuesday, October 25

He has received the cello that replaces the modified viola he has played on for a year. Peter was practising when I got home. The instrument has real strings and a deeper, mellower tone. Matthew tried to pull it apart.

Cheryl was up to the hospital. Her dad was surprised at how simple the operation was and how well he feels. He was up for a short walk. He got a phonecall from Peter. He learned about Peter's computer club meeting at noon. Mr. Davis has organized two clubs, a Junior Club, from K to Grade 4; a Senior Club, from Grades 5 – 8.

Both boys were in bed by 8. Matthew took a half hour to get to sleep.

Wednesday, October 26

This is the warmest day since mid-September, but we wonder how long it will hold out. We had bagels and raspberry cream cheese and fruit for breakfast.

Peter and Cheryl went to choir. Matthew and I later joined Cheryl at Robin's Donuts. After choir, Cheryl took Peter to the hospital. He brought home a sucker Papa had given him and stories about Papa's stapled incision, the burned dairy barn on campus, and Adolph's jokes (not what the jokes were, only that they were being told).

Matthew and I read an alphabet book he brought to me, turning so I would lift him onto my lap. After awhile we shut off the lights and played Schubert's C Major symphony. Just as he seemed to be drifting to sleep I carried him to bed. Just as he lay down he sat up. We repeated this until 10:30. I think he's pulling the wool over our eyes.

Augusta reports his new words: 'pants' and 'buttons'.

Thursday, October 27

Cheryl is nearly finished Peter's costume, a steel-blue spaceman outfit with lightning bolts on the chest and a helmet. Peter can't wait to wear it. Cheryl thinks it will last him three years.

Dale and Jan had a baby girl today. 8 pounds, 4 ounces. Name is unknown.

Snow is in the clouds. We went to Eaton's with my parents and Cheryl's mother for supper. Peter went ahead of us to get a table. I found the table, but not Peter. His coat was on a chair, but he was gone. We looked for him, increasingly concerned, until he came down the hallway from the bathroom.

Cheryl had been to the hospital briefly, then took her mother to the travel film at the Centennial.

At home I read *The Borrowers*. Peter listened while polishing off a snack. Matthew's evening was spent with Cheryl's sewing machine, pretending to touch all the buttons, and a Fisher Price bus with its movable passengers. At 8 he seemed to be tired. I changed him and lay him down. He rolled over and said not a word.

I play the guitar for the Grade 7 girl's choir assembly next week. The song is *Where Have All The Flowers Gone?*

Friday, October 28

Cheryl's father got out of the hospital today, a bit early in his estimation. Peter spent part of the afternoon with him, bringing him pillows and blankets, coming up with ways to keep him off his feet.

Yesterday Peter also had an assembly. He told us they opened by singing 'Air Canada'.

Cheryl picked me up at 4:30. We shopped at Dominion while Matthew slept. We ordered salads for supper at the Sheraton. We arrived at Mama and Papa's just as they were finishing a meal of waffles. Sylvan is ordered to lift no more than 15 pounds for the next 3 months.

Out of nowhere, Cheryl gave me a 'Stempo' watch from Woolco. It cost \$6. (*In 2018 they are being sold on-line for \$11 in the 'Vintage' category.)

Peter's space suit is done, ready to wear. He can't wait for Halloween.

I returned to school at 8 to supervise a Grade 7/8 Halloween dance. Hair paint, makeup, creative clothes, mostly punk. I brought donuts home.

Saturday, October 29

This morning Peter reported being so cold he was covered with 'sugarbumps'. Group lessons celebrated Halloween. He wore his spaceman outfit there and to gym.

Matthew is always humorous, laughing at anything.

The temperature is 20 degrees, the air is sparkling. Peter and I visited with Papa while Cheryl and Matthew accompanied Mama downtown. We ate supper at Grumpy's pizza. I read *The Borrowers* to Peter. Matthew tumbled off the front porch and cut his lip. I spent a couple of hours at school.

Sunday, October 30

Cheryl took the boys and her mother to church. I stayed home to work on the Futures project. It's nearly done. We can use the money.

We went to Cheryl's parent's for lunch. To tease Cheryl, Matthew ate Kleenex and laughed more than she did. Peter watched with a wizened smile while playing with the food on his plate.

We all went for a drive around the city. Cheryl's Dad sat in front. Apparently I drove too fast. Cheryl mentioned it. Sylvan was hanging by the handgrips. Mama was 'tsking'.

Matthew spent the evening goading us, pressing his nose against the TV, climbing on the side-table by the sofa, laughing.

Peter watched Walt Disney Halloween cartoons. In one, Ichabod Crane tripped over gates and ran into trees. Peter said, 'It's not funny.' He added, 'No pictures I see scare me.'

Monday, October 31

Who can forget what day it is when Peter shows up dressed for school in a spaceman's outfit. He took enough oranges with him to feed his whole class and the 'Big Buddies'. The weather is peerless. Temperatures are forecast for 20 degrees. Shirtsleeves.

As busy as Cheryl and I are at school, we seem to have found a pace we can maintain for some time.

I was home by 5. Cheryl had spent part of the day running around town and the rest paying the taxes, cleaning house, cooking supper, and preparing for tomorrow's lessons.

Peter filled us in on his party. He wasn't happy that some kids couldn't identify his costume. His 'Big Buddy' gave him a treat of three 'Dubble-Bubble' and a sucker while they worked together on a computer graph for tomorrow's computer class. This is right up Peter's alley. The mood carried over into his cello practise.

Matthew is pushing others to laughter by ever-riskier antics. He gets on chairs, tables, steps, and dances or whatever seems likeliest to bring him down. And laughs and goes with twice the effort as we approach to intervene. He chases Peter until Peter turns the table and chases him. He appears sometimes with underwear on his head, and other times with gym pants, diapers, and facecloths.

Peter and Cheryl rounded the block getting treats and Matthew untuned my guitar. Once returned, we got ready to visit the grandparents. Matthew may have gotten the impression he was going to be left behind and appeared at the front door dragging his

outside clothes and treat bag. We dropped in on Mrs. Gyorgy. We met a new boarder at my parents', Charlie Matoot from Belize.

Tuesday, November 1

Peter practised for an hour, at his own insistence. He picked out a tune from Book II, The Hunter's Chorus. At his lesson Cheryl learned how lucky we had been not to buy the Chinese cello. The family that did was so displeased with the sound that they gave cello up entirely.

We took the boys to Burger King for supper. Bob Fedoruk was there with his daughter. Marilyn Jutras was there with a son. We didn't see Jim. Deena was there with Kelsey. Sterling, the intern from Redeemer, was there with new glasses.

Matthew was sitting on a cushion on the sofa wearing a red baseball cap pulled sideways over his eye, holding the *The Hobbit* and laughing at what he was pretending to read. Later, I heard laughter coming from the boys' bedroom closet. Peter had scissors, hair was on the floor. Thinking he had cut his own, I left for the kitchen. Matthew followed me. There I had a better look at the wedges of hair missing from the crown and bangs. Cheryl and I asked Peter if he had done the cutting. He said no. For that obvious lie we sent him to bed. We sort of missed his presence for the rest of the evening. Sort of, because he didn't stop talking from his bed, loud enough for us to hear, until nearly 9. Once the boys were in bed for good we watched the medical drama *St. Elsewhere*. We then showered/bathed and went to bed.

Friday, November 4

It's Cheryl's Grandmother's birthday. Everyone was invited to Marg Ardell's. Peter enjoyed the time playing Lego and toys with Bradley until Bradley started throwing the pieces at him. Matthew played with Michael until Michael began hugging him. Matthew found a TV remote and without knowing what he did had the TV doing strange things.

Saturday, November 5

Peter and Cheryl went to group lessons at 11. Only 3 were present. Peter and Derek played the May Song/Twinkle duet. The third boy was from Regina and hadn't played for some time.

After dropping Cheryl off downtown to do Christmas shopping, I took Peter to Gym. We were 15 minutes late. They worked on the parallel bars, trampolines, pits and floor mats. By the end, Peter was exhausted.

Cheryl's parents bought a new car and came by to show us. Cheryl was still out, so they took Peter shopping. She was back when they returned, so we went to the Travelodge for salad. Peter stood atop the barrier separating the eating area from the swimming pool deck to watch the swimmers. Matthew wrestled to get free of the restraints in his chair.

We were home by 7:30. Peter went straight to bed. Matthew refused us until 9:30. Cheryl sewed in the meantime. Doug Redl (I knew him as a friend of my Fredeen cousins at Evan Hardy and as a fellow worker the first summer at Intercontinental Meat Packers) came to our door. For some reason he thought his babysitter lived here.

Sunday, November 6

Church, then Riley's for dinner. Peter spent the afternoon with Cheryl's parents. They took Cheryl's Grandparents for a long drive in the country, and at one point crossed the river on a ferry. Cheryl went to school. Matthew and I stayed home, sitting together, looking at books.

Peter being gone all afternoon was missed. I asked why they went on a ferry. He said, 'How do you think you can get across the river when there's no bridge?'

All of us spent an hour at Muffin Break. The boys attracted attention, Matthew by hanging on the 'caterpillar' fence.

Saturday, November 12

Normal day, busy schedule.

While driving down 8th Street towards Bedford Square, Peter said: 'Matthew won't be able to honk Papa's horn.'

'Why?' I asked.

'Because me and Papa haven't found it yet.'

Cheryl arrived in the living-room to find Matthew standing without support on the space van, tapping a foot and grinning. She hurried to the bedroom to find the camera for proof of what a reckless boy Matthew has become. The picture she got was of Matthew falling backwards and Peter reaching to catch him.

Wednesday, November 16

The first Parent-Teacher Interviews of our lives with Mrs Lymon. She reported that things are well, but we left dissatisfied. Something in her comments about Peter suggests she doesn't know which one he is.

Matthew drags boots and shoes around looking for someone to help him put them on. I found my work boots on the sofa, Cheryl's are everywhere, and his are nowhere.

Peter is thrilled to be spending the evening at Mama's and Papa's. Cheryl took both boys there after choir.

The snow is nearly gone. We hear cars splashing through puddles from our bed.

Great-Uncle Alan's funeral was held yesterday at the Saskatoon Funeral Home. We weren't in touch with my family about the arrangements, so didn't go.

Matthew and Peter play a lot of hide-and-seek. Peter's normal hiding place is under the kitchen table. Matthew's usual search involves bursting into the kitchen, looking left, then right, then creeping to where he expects to find Peter, to surprise him. This time, it was Matthew's turn to hide. He hid under the desk by the fridge, head first, diapers sticking out conspicuously. Peter searched everywhere, in the freezer, in the garbage, calling his name. Within seconds Matthew had tired of the suspense, showed himself, and headed off for a new hiding place.

Sunday, November 27

Things are flowing smoothly these days, just as tired people like it. Actually, I shouldn't overstate our tiredness. Matthew's sleeping is improved. He sleeps through the night and for two hours in the day.

He took a bad fall on Friday evening. We were visiting Carol and Les. The boys were playing in the hall. Matthew was brushed aside by someone and fell down the stairs. We heard him crying. Five minutes later he was up and going throughout the house. That night was wretched, due more to his aching teeth than any injuries. Today we visited my parents. This time he approached the steps down to the 4th Level, looking into the darkness of it from well back.

Peter has in recent days been relaxed and affectionate with all of us, but especially Matthew. He is finding ways to be helpful. He makes his bed, cleans his bedroom, sets the table, helps Cheryl make supper.

The F:11 photos of the boys should be ready this week. Many were of Peter with his cello. Matthew had been restless, more difficult to photograph. We hope there are enough of both boys for a proper choice. We're lacking quality photos of Matthew.

Monday, December 5

Peter is singing 'minipops': 'Ah wanna leeeve foravuh.' He's stretching up. The crown of his head is higher than the China cabinet surface.

Piano lessons began Saturday. Kelsey and DJ attended as well. They did rhythms. Peter enjoyed himself. Now he stands at our piano and picks out tunes, mostly from his cello books.

Matthew is busy at the piano also. He plays with both thumbs. He slides along the bench, using up all the keys, turning pages of the book. During supper he ate holding and patting Monchichi. He sat on the sofa tonight, laughing all the way through the sitcom WKRP, swinging his feet. Mama and Papa came over to watch The Best Christmas Pageant Ever, a TV production with Kristen Skarsgard in a small role. Matthew went about with Peter's gym shorts on his head.

Weather: -12. Islam extremists are using car bombs in Beirut. Trudeau's peace mission is over. His last stop is Kuwait.

Year End (written January 8, 1984)

It has been a long time since my last entry.

The F:11 pictures weren't satisfactory. The boys sat too far apart in some. We had too few decent options. Jerry had told us to make sure we found something we liked. We took him at his word and arranged another sitting. The second time around was much better. The final package arrived before Christmas. Peter's cello pictures needed retouching and won't be ready until the middle of January. The one we've chosen, Jerry says, is good enough to blow

up and hang in their studio. Cheryl's parents ordered several of the four of us. They are framed and hang in our hallway.

Cheryl is a stately queen.

Peter is bright-eyed and keen.

Matthew wears his usual pout.

I more than want to ink me out.

The Christmas pre-season was a frustration with countless and ceaseless trivial arrangements and preparations here at home and at our respective schools. With little to remember of any of it, we are left tired and edgy. The relatives gathered time and again: Cheryl's family on Christmas Eve, with Peter playing 'Twinkle', 'Allegro' and 'Rigadoon', singing 'The Straw is Yellow', 'Come On Ring Those Bells', and reciting two poems. One was:

God gave his son

In Christmas love

To all the World

From Heaven Above

An Angel brought

The glorious word

And shepherds knelt

Before the Lord.

God gave his Son

In Christmas love

What is your gift

To God above?

We spent Christmas Eve at Cheryl's parent's place and opened more gifts in the morning. As proof of Santa being there, Peter claimed he saw 'a bit of red'. A gift had been left that turned out to be a 'Trail Boss' rifle and a physics set, an Alpha Star and Alpha Interceptor, some books. That's Christmas: a 'bit of red' and lots of 'bread'.

We spent the afternoon at my parents'. The family was together (excluding Michael and Cathy, but including Aunt Anne, Grandma, and Mr. and Mrs. Kardash) for open-face sandwiches. We left at 6 and returned to Cheryl's parents for turkey supper with Crystal, Ione and Adolph Peters.

By Boxing Day we had regained control of our schedule. Far less racing to stores and dusting furniture. The afternoon was spent at Grandma Hedlin's at Luther Towers with Aunt Anne and Uncle Leslie. Carol and Les arrived later. The small apartment got too hot, so the five boys chased up and down the hallway. I sort of supervised. The boys stopped what they were doing when a woman came out of her place and stood at the elevator. She said something to give the impression she believed all the boys were mine.

Michael and Cathy arrived December 28. We ate at Carol's December 29 around an oval table. Eleven of the siblings and partners went to Villi's on the 30th for supper. We enjoyed it until someone began throwing ice. The bill came to \$207.80. We subdivided the amount. Everyone added their own tips, except Ernie. Les and I made up his deficiency. The city lights are a

pleasing backdrop. Matthew, Cheryl, Michael, Cathy and Joel came to our place afterwards.

Matthew and Cheryl left on Friday. Cheryl was clearly unhappy about being separated from her family.

We went to Mrs. Gyorgy's for New Year's Eve. We played Trivial Pursuit and left before the food was served. Since Christmas Eve the weather has improved, the temperatures have risen to +5. We've almost forgotten the three preceding weeks of -40.

School started up on Wednesday, January 4. Peter didn't want to go. (Cheryl had visited the principal Harvey Welch about Mrs Lymin. Perhaps she still doesn't know if a boy named Peter is in her class. She is inattentive to the point of neglect. Harvey said he'd speak to the teacher. He advised Cheryl to give it two weeks. If there was no improvement by then, he'd understand if we pulled Peter out. It's a tough decision. While Peter isn't happy about school, he does have a pair of new Bauer ice skates.

We were soon back into our routine. We spend until 8 with the boys, and once they're in bed we begin our personal business.

In this time the boys are changing. They are more like brothers. The dynamics are increasingly complex. Matthew is bigger, more of a character, more a manipulator, funnier, more demanding, etc. Peter allows himself to be led around the house, back and forth in the hallway, to the piano where they punch out their favourite 'melodies', under the desk in the kitchen, into the living room to wrestle, or into Peter's bedroom, which usually ends with a competition for Peter's things. Peter is a gallant brother, resisting the temptation to dominate Matthew. But that means Matthew

dominates Peter, shrieking out his will and taking his pick of Peter's toys. In general Peter is reserved, thoughtfully spoken, though there are times of emotion and frustration. Matthew is chubby, Peter is ever taller and wiry. Matthew jabbars endlessly. Peter speaks sometimes about becoming a 'Space Scientist'. If the boys were ever in the company of the Queen of England, they'd drop her the instant Papa entered the room. He's better since his surgery. I'm going in for the same thing on January 15th.

Matthew's words: shoes, there it is, all done, Peter.

Peter's words: well, he hasn't cursed in a while.

1984

January 1, 1985

Holidays are half done. We've enjoyed ourselves this year more than any previous Christmas. The boys are fun. We go to bed late, the boys sleep in, and we get up about 9:30.

For Christmas Eve, the boys were shepherds. Matthew wouldn't give up the floor until he had bowed. Peter played Long Long Ago, and May Time, two piano pieces, and sang Straw is Yellow. Cheryl and I joined him with Come On Ring Those Bells. Matthew sang Twinkle by the tree and bowed while everyone clapped.

Lloyd was in town from Friday to Friday. He phoned Sunday, December 30, to let us know he arrived all right in spite of wretched weather. There were two deaths on the Chilliwack highway.

Grandma Hedlin died on Sunday around 5:30 am. The family is arriving today. The funeral is tomorrow at 1:30. She had been in the geriatric ward of the University Hospital for a couple of months after leaving St. Paul's. Most people are feeling relief. Most did their grieving after her first stroke.

Michael and Cathy are in town. Michael has a beard and small earring. They have been around here a lot. Playing Trivial Pursuit (twice), watching The Dark Crystal, The Pink Panther, Gorky Park, The French Lieutenant's Woman, and on New Year's Eve Dune and Falling In Love. They came with us to Mrs Gyorgy's. We finished the night with a drink at the Golden Anchor.

We see little of brother Matthew and Cheryl. He came alone to the Christmas Day gathering at Mom and Dad's and left before the

tampered-cookies episode (Michael taking a bite out of cookies, then putting them back on the tray) and Trivial Pursuit. Both came to Villy's restaurant on Thursday, December 27. They had planned to leave today but will stay over until after the funeral.

Joel arrived from Victoria with a friend named John. They told stories about Katimavik and the military. They will spend four days on a destroyer, practising orienteering among the Gulf Islands.

Matthew and Peter are going through many changes. Yet they are very close. Matthew talks constantly, chases after Peter, wrestles him to the floor. They scream, jump off the furniture, leave their toys lying everywhere, go-bots, transformers, pieces from the Fisher-Price farm, Lego, books, games...

The weather is impossibly cold. 30 degrees below and worse, with windchill values well over 2000. Which means staying inside. Peter wants to ski. We may not go before we join my staff at Jacobsen Bay on Anglin Lake for a weekend. Matthew will stay home with Mama and Papa.

Sunday, January 8

While Peter was at Derek Postnikoff's for a Dragon Birthday party this afternoon, my parents were over to visit. We talked about religion, Diane's, Charlie Matoot's and Matthew's. We discussed Russia and homosexuality. When Peter returned, he and Dad talked about volcanoes and moon rocks.

Cheryl's parents were over for waffles.

Peter was in bed by 8. Matthew works hard to make Cheryl laugh. At present he is watching TV from behind the sheer front-window drapes. We have tried twice to put him to bed. Each time he lies for a moment, then sits up. After 20 minutes of this, we admit failure and take him to the living room. He brings us the books we are reading to Peter or ourselves, *The Lion*, *the Witch and the Wardrobe*, *Cheryl's Passageways*, my *The Russians* and *A Case of Conscience*, and asks us to read to him. Reading to Matthew is him pointing to things on the page and being told what they are.

Wednesday, January 11

Peter went with his kindergarten class and Big Buddies to the ATC skating rink. He complained that the helmet and toque together pushed his glasses down. His new Bauer skates worked well.

Matthew is an improbable flower with far too many petals of too many colours, bending under the weight, clashing with the surroundings. Today's excess came with hitting. He'd hit someone and say, 'done!'. Cheryl took him to his room twice. Peter is forbearing most of the time, but when he runs out of patience Matthew gets an earful. Then his forehead goes puffy, his lips pout, his fingers work the fabric on the chair, his eyes turn to Cheryl and me for a sign of sympathy. It did come to the point today that Peter pushed Matthew down in the hallway in a clear-cut case of self-defense.

We spent time with Peter's physics set, observing molecules through the surface tension of water, wax, and soap. Then we all watched a National Geographic film on chimps. Peter oohed at the babies. While I read *The Lion, the Witch and the Wardrobe*, he sat against the headboard of his bed clasping his fingers across his chest while one finger pointed abstractedly as he formulated a thought on one thing or another. He had this same pose this afternoon in the living room when Matthew walked in. He called to Cheryl in the kitchen, 'Mom, your son needs his diaper changed.'

Since Christmas Matthew has raised a different kind of stink every morning we leave for work.

Sunday, January 29

Peter is at Mama and Papa's. It's now 11, so they'll be at church. He stayed the night after we'd been for hamburger and pizza at Gino's.

The temperature is up to +4. The sun is brilliant. The tire ruts are full of water. Water drips from the eaves. Outside wear is heavy sweaters, at most. How does one dress for the outdoors when one day it's +4 and the next it's -30.

Matthew spent the morning running around in his sleepers with the legs pulled to his knees. A typical morning is him spending an hour causing minor catastrophes. He finds everything that risks hurting him or being broken. While we're tending to one near disaster he's off starting another. He pulled books and paper from my night table, shredded the paper, pulled the covers off the books, climbed onto the counter in the small bathroom and pushed everything onto the floor. While we were dealing with that he went to the living room and changed all the settings on the stereo before disconnecting it from the wall. By the time we got to that he was at the kitchen table looking ominously inside the milk container on the table. It's all innocent fun to him until we've reached our limit and tell him sharply to stop it. Then he drops his hands, lowers his head, looks up with a puffy brow, pouty eyes and lips, says 'no' in a nasal tone.

The second phase is recovery. Semi short-lasting peace. He has us read to him. He has me play the guitar, which I can't do until I've shaken out all the things he has put inside it.

Then he's back at it. He stand on the carpet precisely where Cheryl is cleaning, and in the kitchen precisely where Cheryl has

swept a pile of dirt. When he goes towards a wall or furniture with a pencil or pen in hand, we tell him to think twice. He answers the same every time: 'Get down!'

He has found joy in pushing Peter towards his limit. Yesterday evening, as Peter was laying out cards, Matthew came near, snatched a couple of cards, and ran. Peter caught him and wrestled the cards away, but didn't get back to the cards before Matthew had made off with a couple more. This worked one more time before Peter resorted to grasping Matthew by both his hands. Stymied, overpowered, cornered, Matthew exercised his last remaining freedom: he made a hideous face.

While this is one pattern, another contrasting pattern is just as true. Peter responds to Matthew's active curiosity by telling him some of his own. He guides Matthew, teaches him things, shows him by example. Matthew is accomplishing far more by this stage thanks to Peter than Peter did thanks to us. He is counting (1-2-3), has polished off two wood puzzles, is adding to his vocabulary: stairs, mama, papa, please, ta-ta. His tosses have an arc that increases the accuracy, he kicks-chases-kicks balls in a long sequences, gets inside cupboards we had secured by putting stiff sealing rings around the knobs by removing one of the knobs. He only needs to hint at affection and attention to get it. He squeezes us with strong arms, lifts up Cheryl's top to lay his head on her stomach, puts his feet in our hands for a massage, he finishes off every kiss with a lick, races from the hallway into the living room to bounce off the sofa onto the floor, then crawls under the desk in the kitchen with his bottom out calling, 'Air'd-e-go'. Once when Cheryl was doing her hair in the small bathroom Matthew showed

up, took a comb off the counter, lifted the toilet lid, dipped the comb into the water, and wet-combed his hair.

For all that advancement, yesterday Matthew had his first drink using a straw.

Peter is the all-round kid, responsible, mature, self-aware, good at whatever he tries, has a driving curiosity, learns with ease even difficult things (like his grasp of the surface-tension experience), pushing new skills, even if it means sitting alone with his cello and piano, until he has achieved competence. He is reserved almost to being withdrawn, yet quick to oblige when asked to show us something he has learned. He likes the solitude of his bedroom or the basement. He ‘works out’ in the living room at things he’s doing at gym, sit-ups, shoulder stands, headstands. With this sort of vim, he goes after Matthew to tackle him, get him in a bout of wrestling, or a chase, or a game of hide-and-seek, or all these things at once. During his Wednesday morning skates, he watches other boys skate well, talks about their technique, and tries it himself. He loves gymnastics. He wants to be competitive even if it means breaking a rule or two. Once, all the boys were lined up for a ‘crocodile-walk’ race to the end of the gym and back. Three of the older boys had gotten a lead on Peter of several body-lengths. When they met him on the way back he turned (against the rules) and fought them neck and neck all the way to the finish line. They have flexed arm hang competitions and Peter hates when he loses. He wants to swim. I’ll buy an alumni pass at the end of the month.

He is happier at school since Cheryl’s visit with Harvey Welch. One sign is he’s talking more about it. He hasn’t actually said if his feelings towards Mrs Lymin have changed, but he spends more

time with other teachers, which gives him more variety. He is excited about an upcoming unit on dinosaurs and enjoys Computer Club so much he spends recesses with another kindergarten student being tutored by a senior student. He looks forward to skating, cello and piano lessons. The proposed move to another classroom seems no longer necessary.

His cello is going along really well. Bernadette is torn between keeping him with his present group, which he has outpaced, and putting him with older kids 'where he'd fit in well' in every respect except reading. He is done Book I and will begin Book II at the next lesson. He is playing Boogie-Woogie on the piano with both right and left hands and some melodies he has already learned on the cello.

Our one concern is his eating. He consumes very little. He gets halfway through his meal, then loses all interest. He slips from his chair, wanders around, sings to himself, takes up anything that comes to his eye, does something for Matthew even if Matthew is doing perfectly well by himself, and when we tell him to get back to the table he protests loudly that he is only trying to help. Once seated and told to finish eating, he says he will though the fork with food on it never gets into his mouth. At 5 1/2 he is barely over 40 pounds and seems quite small next to other kids his age. But he never lacks energy any time in the day, right up to his 7 pm bedtime.

His take on the language of adults sometimes with Matthew: 'Now look here my young man,' and 'Mom, do you see what your youngest son is doing?' One morning he found Matthew under the kitchen sink. He called, 'Augusta, come and get Matthew out of the cupboard.' Getting no answer, he called again: 'Augusta, get

Matthew.' Still getting no answer, he spoke louder. 'That's no good Augusta. You have to come and get him. Now come.' Though we chide him for the tone he sometimes takes, we don't want to discourage his brotherly concern.

Wednesday, February 1

Peter had an accident just after supper. While sitting on his folding cello chair, holding it steady with his right hand, it collapsed under his weight, catching his finger, pinching and cutting it. He was upset for half an hour afterwards. He sat with Cheryl, held a Kleenex to the wound, and cried. Eventually he quietened enough to talk about it.

‘Did you ever hurt your finger?’ he asked.

‘Yes, Peter.’

‘What did it feel like?’

‘Peter,’ Cheryl said, ‘it’s a good thing you didn’t hurt your other hand.’

‘Why?’

‘That’s the one you use for fingering on the cello. You have to bend your finger, and it would hurt.’

I added, ‘It’s good you didn’t hurt your skating hand. You didn’t, did you?’

‘No,’ he said.

Cheryl asked, ‘What is your skating hand for?’

Peter said, ‘To get up with.’

After some silence, Cheryl asked, ‘What other things will this affect?’

‘Well,’ Peter said, ‘this is my blanket hand.’

Later, he came out of his bedroom holding his blanket in his left hand. It looked awkward.

Four staff members came at noon for a visit – I'm recovering from hernia surgery) – Lynne Peiper, Jim Taylor, Bert Gogol and Lyle Oliver. Peter welcomed them at the door, served them cream and sugar for their coffee, then went into his room. Matthew opened a box of McDonaldland cookies with his teeth, ate a few, then stood under the fern watching the guests until they left. I think he was going to the bathroom.

Cheryl, the boys, and I went to Gino's for lunch. Cheryl ordered a home-made hamburger, Peter, who had already eaten, had a Diet-Pepsi in a canning jar and ice-cream, I ordered a half-sub sandwich, heated, and Matthew drank his milk, swinging his winter boots against my leg, winking with both his eyes and his mouth.

Peter is both losing and gaining a tooth. The new one is coming in behind rather than above. We've been wiggling it out. (I should say that Cheryl and Peter have. I don't have much stomach for it.) Peter spent part of yesterday tugging at the thread they had tied around it like he would a bell-rope, though staying well short of causing whatever pain is required for any real effect. Then he'd bring it near my ear and wiggle it so that it sucked and slurped in the gum-socket.

Monday, February 20

It's spring-like. Temperatures range between -5 at night and +4 in the day. The birds emptied the feeder between yesterday at 3 when I filled it and today at about the same time. Peter watches them through the kitchen window.

Peter went to church yesterday with Cheryl's parents. We've been sick with different versions of flu. They visited a while after dropping Peter off. At some point someone asked, 'Where's Matthew?' I answered, 'If he's in our room he's on the bed bashing my guitar.' Cheryl said, 'Or on my sewing machine fiddling with the tension.' Peter strolled into the room. He said, 'Matthew's taken all the diapers out of the basket and thrown them on the floor.'

The boys have been on each other's case a lot lately. Usually it's a jealousy or envy. Usually one wants what the other has, not thinking that what he has is may be more valuable, or it's what he fought for and won just minutes earlier. Matthew hits Peter. Peter says, 'Stop it.' Matthew says, 'No,' and grabs Peter and pulls him to the floor. The last time, while Peter was lying on his back, indulging his brother, Matthew got up and stepped on his face.

Today Cheryl and Peter had a long, serious practise. Peter then joined Danielle and Kirsten outside. Cheryl and Matthew went for a half-hour walk. We ate at 5:30, making no small effort to keep Peter at the table.

Three of us played hockey with a sponge ball. After getting it past Matthew too many times, he protested. When we handed it to him, and he'd squat and hide the ball between his feet.

Peter was dressed for bed by 7. After a few minutes of my playing the guitar to him, he asked to be told about the early days.

‘When I was a little boy.’

‘What times would you like to hear about most?’

‘When I was one.’

‘Mm. That was a long time ago.’

Silence.

‘When I was two.’

‘Mm. That was a long time ago.’

Silence.

‘When I was three?’

‘Mm, that was a long time ago too.’

‘But I’m only five!’

By 7:30 he was sound asleep.

When it came to Matthew’s turn, he lay quietly until 7:45, then from 7:48 – 8:10, then from 8:13 to 8:30. Since 8:32 there has been not a sound. The most recent tactic is to pat his bum. When he’s still and one stops, he wiggles it and says, ‘ahh.’ I pat him, then I stop, and he says, ‘ahh’. The third time when I stopped he sat up and began saying something at a higher volume along the lines of, ‘Cut it out. I’m losing my patience.’

Several days ago Peter lost his tooth. He woke up with two dollars under his pillow. He asked what the tooth fairy did with his tooth. He heard several answers. She eats teeth, sticks them on her

fridge, makes false teeth for old people. The next day when my parents dropped by Peter came out of his room fanning himself with the bills. When someone asked where he got them he told the story of his tooth. After sitting on Grandpa's lap for a few minutes he found a third bill. He hadn't phoned to thank Grandpa until today.

'Hello, Grandpa. This is Peter.'

He listens to the response.

He says, 'I forgot to thank you for the dollar you gave me.'

He listens awhile, shifting his position, eventually lying on the couch.

He says, 'Well, how are you today?'

The conversation carries on awhile. We leave the room.

Andropov is dead. Chernenko is #1. Gorbachev is #2. Fighting is likely. The factions are clearly defined.

Lebanon is unofficially in a state of crisis. Foreign peace keeping troops seem helpless. American troops have withdrawn to ships.

1984 Winter Games in Sarajevo ended yesterday. The Soviets won gold in hockey. Canada finished fourth.

Michael and Cathy will be in town from Wednesday to Sunday for a shower. Joel is considering two options for next year, either Katimavik or Capernwray.

Sunday, April 7

It's evening. Both boys are sound asleep. For Peter to be productive and happy, he needs to be sleeping by 7:30. Matthew now requires going to the bathroom before bed. Then he falls asleep without a sound. If we're impatient, if we hurry the process, we let ourselves in for a long fight.

Peter and I went swimming at the university. This is the first day I've felt well enough. The flu has had one or another of us down for six weeks. At first Peter was reluctant to try anything, preferring to hang on to me. But minutes passed and he grew bolder, including putting his head underwater. I asked him to watch while I swam along the pool bottom, from the bulkhead to the end and partway back.

'What did you think,' I asked. But he didn't think anything. He hadn't even watched. He said he was trying to think up some games. And he had to go to the bathroom. Twice. Otherwise it was fun.

Peter's busier than ever with music, gym and school. Cello is his biggest challenge, but we're encouraged by his being moved from level to level and getting much sincere praise from Bernadette. Peter enjoys group lessons on Saturday mornings most. Piano at 9, cello at 10, gym at 12:30. Gym is a great outlet. He is now somersaulting off the mini-trampoline and trying elementary routines on the rings and parallel bars. By the end of the hour he is hot and red. Sometimes he is impatient when he's done, sometimes he is in a state of near euphoria.

Matthew smiles and talks a great deal. It doesn't matter to him if he's only half-understood. Now that the ground has dried up and

temperatures get up to +15, he wants out. He pulls at us in our chairs, pulls coats down off their hangers, brings us shoes, even tries to get them on our feet. He watches Peter ride his bike but wants nothing to do with the tricycle.

Peter was watching Herbie the Love Bug on TV when Matthew hit him in the mouth with the oversized plastic golf club. Then while heading out for a doughnut, he fell and banged his ear and shin on the car's door ledge.

Matthew is 30 pounds. His hair has recently been clipped, but the bangs hang down to his eyes. His eyes are used to great effect. He lowers his lids and watches us through his eyelashes, catches our eyes then looks aside, catches our eyes again and opens his wide, striving for the full effect by giving us a sample of his best nature. And being rewarded for his troubles.

Cheryl and I are now talking about Easter Holidays. We're thinking about driving to PA and the lakes. The farm may have to suffice. We may attend the Leona Boyd concert, Thursday, April 12. Cheryl's birthday. We heard Nana Mouskouri on Tuesday, March 27. Cheryl's parents just returned from a two-week vacation to Mazatlán.

Michael's wedding is approaching. The boys will stay with Cheryl's parents. Hotel rooms are arranged.

Grandma Hedlin had a serious stroke in March. She was brought to St. Paul's hospital. She hasn't improved, but she's also not getting worse. She is not expected to live. When we visit she seems despondent. She doesn't speak intelligibly. She holds our hands. All her children have been in. They are discussing where she should go. For the rest of her life she'll be Level 4.

Thursday, April 26

The holidays are nearly over. Till yesterday the weather was summerlike, with highs of +28. Yesterday it snowed. The temperature this morning was -5. I managed to get most of the yard work finished on Monday and Tuesday, thatching, digging the beds. Cheryl papered the small bathroom on Tuesday.

Cheryl took Peter to see Pete's Dragon. There were some dramatic moments. Peter doesn't always distinguish between fantasy and reality. He insisted over and over, 'There's nothing to be ascares of, Mom.' After they returned, he asked me lots about the meaning of fantasy.

I said, 'The whole movie was made up.'

He said, 'But they were real people, Dad. People do those things.'

He has decided he'll have bad dreams.

Peter has been practising in Matthew's bedroom, which puts Matthew to sleep. His confidence shows in his playing. His head rolls slightly, his eyes close. He's working on the 3rd position. Bowing and fingering in that position are a real challenge. He is unfazed. He played at the Kasdorf-Kyle wedding shower on Monday. He plays at a recital next Saturday.

Matthew came out of the bedroom wearing a bra. He plays with the switches on the dishwasher to make it hum. He has stretched his stride length, dipping a bit in the middle. He speaks a lot. He took Peter's bedding apart this morning looking for Peter, and dabbed shaving cream on his face.

Peter has spent yesterday afternoon and night at Great-Grandma Skarsgard's. He phoned earlier to tell us they had taken a cab to The Cave for supper. The remote-control tractor broke. He had had a hard time sleeping alone there, so Grandma lay with him, as she has done for Bradley. But Peter was different from Bradley. With him, things were quiet. With Peter, things were conversational. It lasted until 10. Grandma dozed off several times, and each time she woke, Peter was still talking. Finally she said, 'Peter, I'll give you 25 cents if you go to sleep.' He was silent after that. He phoned a bit later telling us that things had gotten slow. He talked awhile with Matthew. He said the waffles were 'strong'. Grandma uses jam. Pretty soon they'll be going downtown with Margaret Ardell. He says we're to meet them at Hy's Steakhouse for lunch. It has been lonely here with him gone. None of his chatter. Too quiet.

Matthew hadn't wanted to sleep last night. We took him in the car and drove him to sleep. We were hoping to sleep in a bit. Matthew woke at 6. He was very angry and hit himself for effect. I left him in his crib and returned to bed, slept for fifteen minutes or so before Cheryl asked if I had covered him. I crept into his room, found him on his back, his fingers clasped under his head, watching the ceiling. I asked if he'd like to lay with us. He came with me but refused to stay. He tugged at us to get out of bed until we gave in.

We managed to get to the farm on Friday and Saturday. After having breakfast at the Sheraton Cavalier on Friday we drove up, arrived there by 1:30 with a long stopover at the Isaachsen's in Canwood. Peter, Matthew and I kicked the ball around on the grass. We found the farm in one piece, no vandalism. Peter helped

get the tractors out and the motorcycle started. He found animal tracks. Bear, deer, moose, and lots of droppings. It worried him. He didn't venture very far on his own. Peter and Papa used the Case tractor to tow the John Deere from Isaachsen's quarter. We returned to Canwood after supper and watched parts of two playoff games. Louise and Ernest were there by 9. Peter can't decide if Ernest is blind or deaf. The next morning we went to the General Store for gas, both purple and propane. We spent the rest of the day picking stones. Peter wore himself out running from one stone to the next. After hauling 4 stone-boat loads, he sat on a big rock with his head in his hands. I asked if he was tired. He looked up, his face was smeared with dirt. He said, 'No.' He put his head back in his hands and didn't move until the stone he was sitting on had to be skidded off. We left by 5. Both boys were asleep in the car.

I brought Crystal to babysit while we went to The Artful Dodger and Mad Mary's with Michael and Cathy. Peter was permitted to stay up until 9:45. Cheryl and I were so tired we couldn't manage much of a conversation. They left for Calgary at noon, Sunday.

A good holiday. We're relaxed. The boys are happy.

Monday, May 7

Cheryl is a chorus member in the upcoming Gateway Summer Players' performance of Showboat. Her first practise was last night at 7:30. She is excited.

Peter is riding his bike a lot these days. He has a repertoire of tricks: standing and bouncing, resting his feet on the crossbar, then handlebar, riding side-saddle, stopping then starting again without touching his feet to the pavement. Being clever. He convinced Matthew, who stands at the front window, resting on the sill, watching. As soon as Peter appears he calls him. 'Eedah.' There's an odd roll of the tongue in there.

Peter was at Danielle's birthday party yesterday, from 3 to 6. They bowled. He failed to get a point. My parents came over for awhile. Dad and I discussed the Liberal Party leadership convention, featuring John Turner, Jean Chretien, Mark MacGuigan, John Roberts, Don Johnston, Eugene Whelan. We all talked about Michael's wedding two weeks from now.

Matthew is waking up every morning at 6:30 and calling. To give Peter longer to sleep I bring him to our bed. I lie down, lay him beside me. He crawls over me to lie face to face with Cheryl. He falls asleep because his feet are being rubbed. In time Peter begins sighing. We call him to bed. Within seconds he's there. Five minutes later I'm in the living room with the boys while Cheryl steals a few extra minutes of sleep.

We're looking ahead to plans for the summer. Maybe Waskesiu on the last week in July. Shelley Loeffler has invited us to use their catamaran sailboat while it's there.

Sunday, May 13

Spring weather has settled in. Trees have leafed out enough to cast shadows. A robin sings every morning at 6. The lawns are green. Everyone wears shorts. We planned to go to Cranberry flats to escape the excessive visiting. Grandma is still at St Paul's. She had her second assessment. They've decided she no longer requires hospital care. A care home in Swift Current has an available bed.

Cheryl and Peter spent Saturday morning at a Suzuki Piano workshop. Matthew and I visited at John and Irma Peltier's.

I took Peter to the gym. I read *Women in Love* in Marquis Hall. A chorus of bagpipes played in the Bowl. On the way out of the gym Peter and I happened into a National Wheelchair Basketball game between BC and Nova Scotia.

Peter wore navy pants, a blue pinstripe shirt to the cello recital. He played flawlessly. Matthew squirmed, escaped into the aisle, ran in the hallways, ran outside.

Cheryl's parents returned with Ione and Adolph from Vancouver. We went to the new Renaissance Hotel for coffee. The room was small, crowded, and hot. I walked about with Matthew while Peter ate Papa's Danish.

Today is Mother's Day. Gifts were exchanged almost as if it were Christmas. We 'churched' and had lunch at The Cave. Matthew filled his mouth with fettuccine, put his hands behind his head, and fell asleep. Cheryl's parents talked about the trip.

Plans are set for next week's trip to Edmonton. I'm taking Friday off. We'll leave early in the day and be back Sunday before

the Showboat rehearsal. Cheryl is more excited about the musical than anything I can remember.

Matthew is 'potting' these days. Which means he's half-naked much of the time. He runs about the house, into the living room, clambers onto the sofa, buries his head in the cushions, aiming his bum at us.

Cheryl is busy at school getting her class ready for its first film-assembly on June 8. The kids have been slow learning their lines.

I took the boys to the park to play baseball. Peter batted and ran the bases. Matthew, Cheryl and I took turns pitching. Matthew got bored of waiting his turn and headed off across the park with his characteristic assured stride, hippy-dipping. We let him go. Eventually he turned back.

Cheryl and I have talked about going elsewhere, on an exchange, perhaps. We realize, however, that for the boys' sakes now is not the time. We want them to have the fullest experience with a neighbourhood, their home, a past with friends and family and events, a personal identity. We want unusual adventures, but those can only ever play a small, supporting role in life.

Monday, May 21

Victoria Day Long Weekend

We spent from Friday to Sunday in Edmonton. Michael and Cathy married on Saturday. The boys went to Henry's with Mama and Papa.

Cheryl and I had coffee in North Battleford, lunch in Wainwright. We arrived at the Saxony Motor Inn on Stony Plain by 4, put our things in our room, and went to the West Edmonton Mall. While plotting gift purchases for the boys we bumped into Carol, Les, Matthew and Cheryl. We returned to the hotel, changed for the rehearsal, then returned to the DeGroot's for the rehearsal party. The weather was sunny, warm, with a light breeze.

The church is shared between a Dutch Reform congregation and St. James United. The altar is a shade of pastel. The Dutch minister is Dr DeWaal. Michael and his groomsmen fitted for tuxes. Matthew tried to pay a customer he thought was staff. Joel and I returned to the change rooms to get out of the tuxes, Michael raced off to the bank for more cash, and Matthew stood alone at the front counter, worrying that we had left without him. That prompted some 'lost boy' jokes. We drove around in Michael's red convertible Dodge and arrived at the party by 9:30. The plan to stay up late fizzled. We were in bed by midnight. Sunlight invaded our room by 6. Cheryl and I were wide awake at 6:30. We dressed, met Tom DeGroot before 8 to receive the corsages, and joined everyone for breakfast, Michael, Matthew's Cheryl, Joel, Mom and Dad, and Tom, in the hotel dining room. Tom and I drove to the DeGroot's to pick up the car. We had it decorated by 10. We were dressed before 10:30. Cheryl followed us to the church. The

wedding went smoothly. Not a large crowd. Matthew needed prompting from Joel at every transition, to turn, turn again, sit, stand. The weather was perfect for taking pictures. The photographers (Galloway) required from 12:30 to 2:30. We arrived at the Convention Centre by 3. The champagne punch nearly knocked out both Cheryl and me. The head table chatted, there were kisses, speeches, music. The chicken was tasty. I abandoned the head table to sit with Cheryl. We dove into the champagne until the time came to take Michael and Cathy to the airport. They had received a bottle of champagne for their honeymoon, but Michael dropped it on the airport floor. A sympathetic crew came to clean up the mess. Michael wiped the floor with his hands and licked his fingers. 'At least I got some,' he said. The Oilers are playing on the airport television. It's the last game of the Stanley Cup final. They score first. The airport is a din of whoops.

Once Michael and Cathy boarded, Cheryl and I took Whitemud Drive to the hotel. We then drove to Aunt Muriel's and stayed until 9. We watched the game there to its end, drove downtown to The Natural Café take in the Stanley Cup celebrations, returned to our room at 11:30, then took off, just Cheryl and me, to witness more celebrations. We got a seat at Earl's Restaurant. It is standing-room-only along Jasper Avenue. Pick-up trucks roll by with their own standing-room-only crowds, braking, accelerating, risking losing everyone out of the box. We order potato skins and chicken fingers. A guy shows up with an Oiler's emblem on his face. He opens his mouth and the word 'Oilers' splits apart. Though the entire city seems to be driving impaired, we arrive at the hotel without incident by 1:15. The Rib bar is full and loud. Short fat men are bouncing with short fat women.

We find the Sunday Sun at our door in the morning. We dress. Someone pounds on the door. It's Carol, Les and Matthew. The phone rings. It's Diane. We go to the Chateau Lacombe for breakfast. Cheryl and I both order the MacDougall. We watch the city below while the room turns.

We return to the Saxony, check out, have final words with Dad, then go to the Mall to make our purchases. I had planned to phone Don Dick, but we decided to spend that time on the road. We left the city after 3 and had coffee in Lloydminster. Dad, Mom, Matthew, Cheryl and Joel showed up. A few Lloydminster jokes were told while the serving staff listened, which, to their credit, didn't hamper the delivery of our orders. We stopped at the Travelodge for supper. Cheryl went off to phone her parents while I listened to the swimmers scream. She returned almost immediately, in tears. The boys were still at the farm. We were in bed by 11 and slept the night.

We had breakfast alone and spent the morning in the yard, weeding, mowing, fertilizing, watering, went to the Cavalier for lunch, and were home again for only a few minutes before the phone rang. Cheryl's Dad wanted to meet us at the Cavalier. The boys were happy. Peter told us about the work they did on the barn, the bear droppings, and the bad weather. The boys, according to Mama and Papa, were perfect. We didn't believe them. We went by Mama's and Papa's to pick up the rototiller. Matthew stood on the door handle, held the handgrip above the window, leaned backwards to watch me drive.

At home Peter and I assembled his new kite, then took it to the park. Peter ran madly to keep it off the grass until the wind came up, bringing rain. We turned our backs to the weather and

watched the kite spiralling overhead. Though we got soaked, Peter 'loved' the experience.

We ate supper at 5 and put Peter to bed shortly after 6. He had broken Matthew's giant balloon after being told to leave it alone. There was a tearful conversation in his dark room about how he'd spend this weekend's \$5 earnings to replace the balloon. Meanwhile, Matthew sat under the bow window and ate Cheryl's apple.

Cheryl and I read the piled-up newspapers, did schoolwork, I practised guitar, Cheryl went to bed at 10:15.

Sunday, June 10

A last-minute decision yesterday sent Peter with Mama and Papa to the farm. They left after his year-end cello concert. He has reached the age that he can do real work. He shovelled barley out of the barn, mowed grass with both the tractor-mower and hand-mower, sat with Papa to cultivate the garden, and planted potatoes. Three times a bear showed up to eat the spilled barley. Peter and Papa watched from inside the truck cab. Peter did target practise with the .22 rifle and shot gun. He came home with a shattered 2X4 as proof. He tried to hide how tired he was. He was great company for Mama and Papa, we were told.

Alone with Matthew, we stayed home for the weekend. Cheryl is busy with Showboat rehearsals that run from Sunday to Wednesday from 7 to 10:30 pm and making costumes. She has never been happier. The show runs from June 23 to June 30. Michael and Cathy will be in town from June 27 to July 3. They will attend with Mom and Dad.

Peter has the lingo. ‘That’s simp,’ he says, and ‘tough.’ He tells us who’s who at school. There are seemingly a hundred names he rattles off, which becomes a problem for finalizing the invitation list to his birthday party. Names are added, then removed.

Matthew opens every closed door. He opens the bathroom door when Peter is there, stands just inside, and says ‘Hi’. We picked up our repaired stereo amp—it cost \$60—and hooked it up to our new record player and the even newer needle to replace the one Matthew had flattened. When the bath water is running, he says ‘What did you say’, and when he has something really important to tell us, he opens with ‘Um.’ He sang Twinkle with Cheryl. He

stands at the front window and calls 'Hi' to everyone passing by. His hair needs cutting. No-one can say for sure if he is a boy or girl. From his bed, after 10 pm, Matthew calls Peter.

'Peter.'

'What?'

'Peter.'

'What.'

The freeway traffic sounds like distant water. A cat moans on the fence.

The mad chiropractor next door is in black shoes and shorts, turning over the soil in the bed in the middle of his driveway. He has marigolds to plant.

Matthew helped me mow the lawn today. After a week of rain the grass is long. He brought me a rake, which was useful. Then he brought a garbage can cover, which was less useful. As we went back and forth from the back yard to the front, he opened and closed the gate. He pushed his plastic mower around the lawn. He stepped in the mud with his sandals. He pointed at all the invisible things he found in the grass, with comments. He rolled his tricycle down the block, then dragged it sideways home again.

Cheryl, Matthew and I went to the 8th Street/Louise Avenue MacDonald's at 10. Matthew played on the merry-go-round on the lower level. He lay on his back with his head aiming outwards, and smiled at the effect of spinning. We went for an aimless drive, enjoying the sunshine for as long as possible before heading home to do more work.

Sunday, July 8

School is out. I'm moving to Walter Murray next fall to teach Grades 9 and 12 Social Studies. Peter is promoted to Grade 1 with a very enthusiastic 2-half report. Cheryl's part-time load will continue until February. When Shelley Loeffler goes off on maternity leave, Cheryl will go full-time. Matthew shows changes every day, speaking more and being livelier and goofier.

Thursday and Friday were spent at Waskesiu and Christopher Lake. We would have stayed longer at Christopher had we not been bumped from Adolph's cabin by counsellors. We had arrived there by 2, Thursday afternoon, settled in, went for a walk along the beach, then drove past an unsigned bible camp at the north end of the lake onto a narrow trail through the woods to a trap-line. Peter and I spent a while in a canoe, then we waded with Cheryl and Matthew. At some point Peter went missing. Cheryl and I called but got no answer. We searched the beach, the Kinasao campground, the paths into the trees. A six year old in a forest by a lake. What could go wrong? We found him eventually. He had been hiding in the loft, listening, thinking, no doubt, that his trick was playing out very well. That evening we tried to get the boys to sleep in the same bed. It didn't work. Next morning we drove to Waskesiu, had coffee at the café, and spent from 11 until 3:30 on the beach in the blazing sun. Peter and Matthew dug sand, played in the water, looked for minnows, floated on an air raft. I am reading Michael Hayden's book about Aunt Hilda, *So Much To Do, So Little Time*, which I'll review for an STF publication. Cheryl read Stewart's *The Wicked Day*. We returned to Christopher, planning to come back on Saturday, then discovered we were losing our spot. We stopped at Fran's Diner in MacDowell. The

crops, the white picket fences, the surrounding forest, gives the place the look of the 1950s.

Besides enjoying the time off, I have a lot to do to be ready for the fall. Cheryl wants to repaint the picnic table. The Wallaces next door finished their portion of the fence, which means the yard is now fully enclosed and Matthew can have a free run. Peter played cello yesterday. We're reading *Stuart Little*. Cheryl and her mom will take the boys to tomorrow's Traveller's Day parade.

Last Saturday was the final performance of *Showboat*. It was a great success. Over 5000 attended during its run. It improved with each night. The entire thing revolved around Cheryl's performance as nun, groupie, off-stage chorus. She was clearly enjoying the whole thing, smiling and blinking her eyes like a child in the thrall of something. Last night we attended the closing event at the STF building, a dinner and dance.

Michael and Cathy had been in town from June 27 to July 3. They saw *Showboat* on Thursday. We went with them on Friday to the Tent 'n Tavern.

My toe still hurts after kicking a wall during a barefoot soccer match in the front hall of Roland Michener in June.

The boys have joined the league of break-dancers. They do a tandem version of 'the worm'. Peter flops around the room, and Matthew bows.

Peter is an increasingly assertive, even cheeky, commentator. He argues a lot, resists doing what he doesn't want, messes up his room, eats only what he likes, and when he judges that we've exceeded our parental prerogative, he says we need to change our

behaviour. He points out contradictions. The month-long ban from playing with his shotgun doesn't apply to his water pistol. He won't ride his bike so long as the pedal is injured, rides double with Papa (who can't talk or laugh without the jujubes he's eating falling into Peter's hair). He told Grandma Skarsgard that the Ovation chocolates she gave him are actually cigarettes. He has gained enough farm experience to judge the condition of crops. While on the highway he remarked, 'Oh, what a lovely rape field over there.' And enough experience with life to judge how to die. 'Dying clean,' he said, 'is far better than dying dirty, for when people are looking at you in the auditorium.' He told Papa, 'That's a good job of 'hedging' you did around the yard.'

Today we went to Beaver Creek. The four trails are now fully developed. Matthew walked the entire length of a $\frac{1}{4}$ km path. The boys ran around in the outdoor theatre. We had supper at Venice's in Sutherland.

Monday, July 9

Parade day. The event was slow to start. Cheryl followed Matthew up and down 2nd Avenue. He practised waving in the manner of the girls sitting in convertibles. Peter had been fairly impassive while the parade was on. He opened up at home. Matthew was still waving. I stayed home to work on a teaching unit and write the review. At 11:30 I went to the University to swim. Cheryl and the boys weren't back yet by 12:30, so I phoned Papa, who is lonely, and went with him for lunch. Peter and I dug up a badminton net, untangled it, set it up near the house. Peter struck the back door with every swing. The wind blew the birdie onto the roof.

Cheryl is planning not just to repaint the picnic table but refinish it. She has summer clothes to sew and strawberries to can. She sanded this afternoon. The sun is hot, the wind blows harder.

Two city workers repaired where the road in front of our house has sunk. Matthew and Peter sat on the lawn watching the truck go back and forth with its dual tires over the fresh asphalt.

Cheryl bought enamel paint for the table. Peter drummed on the padded stool in Sherwin Williams. Matthew ran around the parking lot. I trapped him inside a bus shelter across from the MacDonald's. He hit and kicked the glass and made enough of a scene to make me look bad. I took him into the store. He joined Peter and drummed on the stool. We had supper at Burger King. Matthew threw a soggy bun, which hit the back of a young woman. She looked, saw who did it, commented quietly to the fellow beside her. The bun was still on the floor when we left.

At home, Peter walked Danielle's big dog Sal with her brother Colin. There was a knock at the door. It was Peter. His shirt was filthy. I asked what happened.

'Sal dragged me.'

'Why didn't you let go? You're covered with grass.'

'Sal eats cats. I couldn't let go. And it's not grass.'

'What then?'

'The flowerbed next door.'

I read Stuart Little up to the last chapter. Peter wouldn't let me stop. Cheryl bathed Matthew and put him to bed. Peter bathed next. He lies with his head in the water to avoid hearing us telling him to get out.

'It's time, Peter.'

He watches, smiling nicely.

'Peter, sit up.'

'Peter, it's time to get out.'

'Peter, Mom's calling.'

'I can't hear you,' he says, shaking his head, smiling. 'My head's under water.'

Mama and Papa dropped by with a basket of strawberries. Both boys are wide awake, waiting to be called from their beds. Once out, Matthew kicked over a pile of folded diapers. Peter showed 'the worm' and Matthew bowed. Then he tried the worm. He twisted twice on the floor, lifted his feet, lifted his head, jerked two

more times, and bowed. He repeated the worm and his bow. Worm, bow, worm, bow. Peter followed with the broken-arm monkey-walk, the broken-leg monkey-walk, and further variations. Matthew hopped along behind. When Mama and Papa were at the door to leave, Matthew grabbed my swim bag, put the strap over his shoulder, and called 'Bye' to us. We told him it was better if he stayed. He stood next to the door with the bag strap hitched over his shoulder, hiding his face, waiting for us to change our minds. It wasn't long, however, before both boys were back in bed.

Friday, July 20

By now we have a routine. I spend part of the morning preparing for the fall. Cheryl takes the boys to the George Ward pool. Peter has his lesson from 9:30 to 10 and Matthew runs on the deck. Peter is learning the t-stroke and swimming with a life-jacket. He is over his timidity. He's always the first to jump in. Cheryl is sewing a lot and applying countless coats to the picnic table. Matthew gets into whatever he sees. His mood is unvaryingly fine. I swim every day after lunch for 40 – 50 minutes. Then the four of us come and go on chores and errands. After supper we go for a car ride or a bike ride until it's the boys' bedtime.

Schedules exist to be upset. From Friday to Tuesday we were up north. Until Monday we worked on the farm building a playhouse, cleaning brush, moving machinery, pruning back trees, hauling brush, building up walls for a gravel pit, and mowing. Matthew has to be watched all the time. A bear is somewhere in the woods. Peter refuses to go to the bathroom without someone near him. He'd rather use an ice-cream pail or pee off the front step. Work starts at 9 and continues until 7, then goes another hour from 8 to 9. Somewhere in there we get some motorcycle riding—Cheryl has learned, but she won't go out of 1st gear—or bits of reading. Peter wears work gloves and helps where he can, driving the lawn tractor and wagon back and forth between the log pile and chainsaw (which he won't come near without clamping his hands over his ears). Papa found a swarm of wasps near the house. They have nested behind the asphalt siding. I was stung while in the bush, which was a lesson for Peter. After that he wouldn't leave the house. Once I came in for water, spent maybe five minutes in the dark, cooling off, before discovering Peter on

the sofa with blankets pulled up to his eyes, wearing a crash helmet.

It's a trick getting Matthew to bed. Friday night I tried sleeping with him. At the first sign of tiredness, which wasn't until 10:15, we lay him down. He obviously believed we were playing a game. In no time he parted the curtain in the doorway, said 'Hi,' and climbed into someone's lap. This happened a couple of times, until I lay down with him. But I couldn't keep him down. He stood up, bounced and landed on his bum, and stood again. My efforts to control him weren't appreciated. He made a sharp complaint and pushed me away. At 11:15 he was still on his feet. I decided I'd let him choose his own time. It wasn't more than a few minutes after I rolled over before he was sleeping. The next problem was keeping him covered. He must have gotten the impression the bed had been turned 90 degrees. He assumed a position perpendicular to my own. Sometimes his feet were in my face and sometimes his head. I'd wake up with his hair in my nose. Cheryl's dad spent Saturday and Sunday evening rocking him. Even so he wasn't sleeping before 11.

We spent a partial day at the Isaachsen farm, along with Betty, Louise and Erling, before heading up to Waskesiu. Inside the Park we were delayed by a buck crossing the highway. Peter had been sleeping, but woke up in a hurry. We went to Bakers', found a one-room cabin on the lake front (Ireland #35) for \$29. We unloaded our things and went for supper to the Park Café. Cheryl and I relaxed while the boys played with the toggles on an idling video game. It was too cool to go to the beach, so we walked around the Townsite. Matthew goes like a car with bad alignment, bad steering, and one flat tire. Whatever our line is, his jerks left. If we

followed that line, he'd jerk further left. But by following him we do find things we wouldn't have noticed, things under rocks, on golf carts, in the back porches of stores, restaurants, on picnic tables (two old women tanning, their poodles leashed, bounding and barking), under the porches of a nightclub just opening its doors. Matthew bellows his greeting at everyone, and waves like he learned on parade day with one or both hands. We headed back to Bakers and walked some more around that area, discovered a playground by the shore. We sat on the teeter-totter (Matthew and I weigh more than Cheryl and Peter), hung from the monkey-bars, climbed a tall slide with a hollow pit instead of sand. We followed the shore. The boys clambered over spruce roots that had been exposed by the waves. While Cheryl and I sat, they spotted each other through the gaps under the roots, kicked sand, threw sticks and stones. Cheryl made a pattern in the sand with a stone that Peter imagined were tracks, and wondered which animal made them. We returned to the car and drove to get Matthew to sleep. That didn't turn out so well, so we went back to the cabin. While Cheryl rocked him to sleep, Peter and I headed out. Down at the water we found a catamaran pulled onto the shore. In the store Peter insisted I buy myself a book. I know him by now. He is thinking that every dollar I spend on myself has to be matched with a dollar spent on treats for him. As Bernadette Wilson likes to say, 'Close but no cigar.' We put Peter to bed on a pull-out couch. Matthew was put on blankets and fenced in with suitcases and bags and cushions. Our bed was a single. We read awhile. Once the lights were out, it didn't take us long to learn that the only way for one to turn was for both to turn together. That didn't work, and we didn't get any sleep. Some time before morning Peter fell on the floor and tipped a suitcase onto Matthew. Which didn't disturb

Matthew's sleep. Peter and I snuck out, showered, and found large rodents living under the cabin. Peter squatted and offered pieces of bread. A fellow saw what he was doing and brought him a handful of peanuts. Between these and the bread, one came near enough almost to touch. Just then our cabin door banged open and Matthew appeared.

'Hi Eeda,' he yelled.

The animal vanished. The guy who provided Peter with peanuts got up from his squatting position and walked away.

Matthew waved. 'Bye,' he yelled. 'Bye-bye.'

We paid our \$29 at the office, drove to the Park Café for coffee, and were set up on the beach by 10:30. Cheryl and I took turns watching the boys. I walked Matthew to the breakwater. He slipped twice in slimy water. Which surprised him. 'Ouss, ouss,' he said, again and again for the rest of the walk. We came upon a perch suspended a couple of feet from the surface.

Pointing, Matthew said, 'Whass-a?'

'A perch, Matthew,' I said.

'Whass-a?'

'A perch.'

'Whass-a?'

We remained there until 3:30. Peter had spent until then in the water, going around with small bands of kids, herding the minnows, trying to catch some in their pails, and digging the wet sand. Cheryl sunburned her back. We drove to PA, stopped at

Venice's for pizza and spaghetti. We were hungry, but would have settled for the iced water. On the drive home the sun continued to burn. One's skin feels clad in long underwear from ankles to wrists. The boys fussed.

Sunday, July 22

A phonecall came. Peter's glasses are ready. It turned out they were the wrong frames and had to be reordered. But his wire frames are broken. We paid a goldsmith \$10 to solder them. I tested them while the receptionist watched. They snapped and needed to be resoldered.

Summertime with these boys has become a routine of doing something, messing it up, doing it again.

We are going to Great Falls with Cheryl's parents on Friday. This has left us with a few errands. We delivered raspberries to Mom and Dad, and visited with Aunt Muriel. Peter sat on Dad's knee. Cheryl and Mom sat on the sofa. Matthew ran from person to person. Then Mom told Peter ghost stories. After the first, Peter smiled and said, 'Ok, Grandma, tell me another one of your untrue stories.' Dad smiled, let it sink in, said aloud to himself, 'Untrue ghost story,' then laughed, and patted Peter's leg. Later, Dad, Peter and I went to the 4th Level to see the progress on a bedroom Dad is adding. We then sat on the 3rd Level, Dad and I in the chairs. We chatted while Peter sat next to the fireplace, cleaning out the yellow bowl of popcorn. Then Peter, without looking up from the popcorn, clutching an old maid in his teeth, said,

'Dad is really a help at home.'

Grandpa said, 'I'm sure he is.'

Still looking into the bowl, Peter said, 'Really, he's not.'

Grandpa was silent.

Peter said, 'I was only being sarcastic.'

The old maid cracked. His hand went to his mouth.

Grandpa said, 'Sarcastic.' He laughed. He laughed again.

Not once did Peter look up from the bowl.

Friday night, we had a tough time getting Peter to sleep. He had wild tears and complained about stomach-aches. Cheryl and I took turns finishing up the last preparations for our departure tomorrow.

Cheryl's parents were over by 7:15. The boys were barely awake. Matthew had eaten nothing of his porridge. Peter was struggling with his bowl of Shreddies. We stopped for coffee at the Voyageur restaurant in Rosetown. It's beginning its 75th Anniversary celebrations. The station was having a Thank-the-Customer day with prizes, hot dogs, and coffee. Both boys got helium balloons. Matthew let his go before we reached the car. I drove to Havre, stopping at Swift Current for lunch. The heat had grown more intense, though the car is comfortable. We listened to tapes of Nana Mouskouri, King's College Choir, and children songs. Peter and Papa looked at a book about sea animals. Everyone took his and her turn at the outdoor bathroom at the Climax crossing. We drove through Turner and Harlem, spotted antelope in a gully, followed the #2 highway past dried streambeds, green-slime sloughs, and scenic groves of cottonwoods along the Milk River. Human settlement is continuous, disorganized. We arrived at Havre by 3 and checked the prices of Le Havre Inn, found it too expensive, drove up the hill to the Super 8, and booked a suite. At 4:20 we crossed the highway to the mall. Cheryl went with her mother, Peter went with Papa, and I watched Matthew. He spent a while in an coin-

operated convertible. He watched three teen girls as they passed by.

One noticed him and said, 'Boy, you are good looking.' To the others, she said, 'I'll wait till you grow up.'

If he heard, he gave no sign of noticing.

He went from the car to his stroller, grew tired of sitting, so stood, leaning against the back. He watched while a remote-controlled jeep sped out of a hobby shop, around easels with paintings, and back into the shop. It pulled up just short of the stroller, sat a moment as if catching its breath, then bumped the stroller. Matthew leaned over to watch it, said 'Oh oh,' and grinned. Once resuming our walk to nowhere, Matthew continued watching it, leaned too far, and fell out. Cheryl and her mother came by with a navy driver's cap for Matthew. When Papa showed up I took Peter to see the remote controlled car. Peter was intrigued. He said, 'Let's just stay here and look around a little, okay Dad?'

We went swimming at the community indoor/outdoor pool. The water was warm, soft. Cheryl, Peter and I bobbed around. Most of the children there were aboriginal. Peter crept hand over hand along the pool edge. He met a girl his age doing the same going the opposite way. Each time they met, she took the inside track. Papa watched from a window. Peter demonstrated swimming tricks, including an underwater leg performance, t-strokes. As we edged nearer the deep end a lifeguard intercepted us and said, 'Everyone has to swim two widths before going any further.' He added, 'And it has to look pretty good.'

Supper at 4Bs. Nothing worked to keep Matthew in the blue sling chair we brought, which clamps onto tabletops. We were done as quickly as possible and drove to a Buttrey Foods where Cheryl bought supplies and Peter got a solar-powered calculator for \$7.99.

‘It has real good buttons. What do you think?’ he said.

We returned to the motel and put the boys directly to bed. Cheryl and I went to the front lobby where we could converse without disturbing the boys. After returning to the room we read until 11:05. The boys had us up by 8. Peter had slept on the floor under the air conditioner, and froze. So he climbed into bed with us to warm up. Then Matthew’s head popped up, and he climbed in.

After dressing, we ate breakfast at the 4Bs. Matthew ate little. Peter finished what was left. Everyone went into the motel except Matthew and me. We found a minor road and walked a ways. To keep him from wandering off the road, I arranged a race. I set him up like a speedskater.

‘Ready?’ I say.

Matthew takes off.

‘Go,’ I say.

I run after him.

He stops. We get ready for another race.

Matthew’s run is more like jitter-stepping on the spot, hair bouncing. Eventually we arrive at a little stucco building with a chain-link fence and High Voltage sign. Matthew says, ‘Oh oh.’ He

has seen a rabbit sitting a few feet away. He charges. The rabbit runs away.

We spent two hours on the road to Great Falls. We had lunch at the 4Bs on 10th Avenue. Peter developed sharp chest pains. He was in tears in the bathroom. There have been several instances of similar ‘attacks’. Each recurrence one a bit worse. With our meals half-eaten, Cheryl and I took Peter to Emergency. We sat outside, discussing the situation with Peter, trying to determine how serious and real the pains were before committing ourselves to receiving expensive treatment. We chose the safe course and had him admitted. While waiting for him to be called, we watched the Tour de France on TV. The check-up showed no issues. They gave us aspirins. We left, searched for a hotel with Mama and Papa. Papa haggled with the desk clerk of the O’Haire Motor Inn on 7th St South about the exchange rate, settled on the price of a two-bedroom suite, stashed our bags, and took the boys to the rooftop ‘Sip-n-Dip’ pool. Cheryl, her Mom and Dad and Matthew went to the shopping centre. Peter and I stayed behind. Peter slept from 3:45 – 4:45. I read and wrote in the journal. We went on a 45-minute stroll past the Court House, touching on various topics, including genetics and law. On our return we watched part of a nature program about the ecosystem of an African water hole. When the others returned we went out to the 4Bs. Matthew played with new toys, a dashboard and a Mr Potato-head. He didn’t put the Potato-Head green cap, yellow specs, moustache and pipe where they belonged. He put them on himself and performed comically until the time came to go back to O’Haire. We went by way of the Great Falls springs and fish hatchery. We fed the trout, poked their backs with twigs and fingers, noted the deformed jaws and protuberances like puff-balls on several, and wondered about

life spent in a tank swimming just hard enough against the current to stay in one place. We picked up ice-cream cones, returned to the pool to swim. Cheryl and I switched the boys between us. Floating Matthew on his back, tossing him in the air, supporting him while he made swimming motions with his arms and legs and floated on his back, and kicked up water to splash people. When the time came that he was shivering and nearly blue, getting him out of the water was a struggle. Peter rode on my belly while I swam on my back, jumped in from the edge, floated underwater. Mama and Papa watched.

Matthew hadn't slept much all day and went down without a sound. Peter had a fresh onset of stomach pains. We don't know if it's gas or acid. We'll book an appointment for Wednesday. Once the boys were asleep, Cheryl's parents went out for coffee.

Friday, August 3

Hardly were we back in Saskatoon then plans were made to head up to Waskesiu. At the Cavalier, while eating breakfast, Peter convinced Cheryl's parents to come with us. Which delayed our intended early departure. We arrived in MacDowell for lunch and, after nearly suffocating in the hot car, reached Waskesiu by 1:30. We booked cabins, changed into our swimwear, pumped up the inflatable dinghy we had purchased in Great Falls, and went to Baker's Beach to cool off. The water was so warm Cheryl's parents came in. The air is 34 degrees.

We ate supper at the Golf course lodge. Neither boy was happy. Peter had another stomach-ache. Cheryl and I took turns walking with them.

The cabin, #307, is very small. One bedroom. When the couch is pulled out and a bed is made on the floor for Matthew, presto!, not an extra inch of open floor. Sylvan, Peter, Matthew and I hung around outside the cabin.

A black white-spotted longhorn beetle trundled by. Sylvan stepped on it and said, 'To the ages.' Peter watched with a bemused expression.

First thing Sunday morning, we walked to the Park Café for coffee. Peter rode his bike, Matthew rode in the stroller. Once we had returned to the cabin Cheryl's parents were ready for the lake. They returned to Saskatoon after lunch. We went to the main beach with the boys until 4. And returned each day at 10. All of us were brown. The boys hair is bleached blonde. They sit and wade in the water, dig sand. Matthew sees kids with balls and follows them until they include him. Even when he is shaking

uncontrollably with cold he ignores our calls to come out. Peter glides on his back, legs kicking, arms like paddlewheels. He progresses six feet and stands spitting and wiping his face. The water temperature on Wednesday was 25 degrees.

The north end of the lake is obscured by smoke from northern fires.

Tuesday, Peter and I drove to the Height of Land, where the view from atop the tower was 'lovely'. He relieved himself over the side and laughed as the falling stream broke up in the breeze. We walked down a steep trail to Shady Lake (600 paces one way). The dried mud along the shore was scored with many animal prints.

Matthew too is eager to be out. Cheryl asked if he wanted to go for a walk. He said okay and went straight to the door. With one hand on the door, he looked at her and said 'uck', repeating it until she was ready.

Peter and I made three round trips in the dinghy from Baker's Beach to Waskesiu Beach. One way takes 30 minutes. The water is clear to the bottom. The beaches are packed.

We made an evening trip to the Park Café. We raced each other home. Peter on his bike and I were neck and neck. Cheryl was close behind with Matthew in the stroller.

The time came to go home. We have had a rare time doing nothing.

We were home by 7. We found a note on our door telling us that Danny and Joan were in town and everyone was meeting at the Forestry Farm for a picnic. We quickly unpacked and headed

over. The kids went to the zoo. Wherever they ran, Peter, Jeff and Tammy, Matthew followed, shrieking, falling, scraping his knees.

‘Don’t fall, Matthew,’ say both of us.

‘K.’

Peter says, ‘Oh that won’t mean anything.’

Which is correct. Matthew pauses, then takes off again, sure to trip and fall.

Jeff and Peter like baseball. Everyone joined in. The adults and Tammy took positions in the outfield, and Peter and Jeff took turns at bat. It was not long before Matthew wanted his turn. He stood in the batter’s box, crowding the boys, refusing to leave, until they finally gave him the bat. He took his own time with the bat on his shoulder, then chopped it down like an axe at the rolling ball, over and over, demanding yet another throw, Peter standing behind, patiently picking up the ball and returning it to Jeff for another pitch.

Thursday, Jeff and Tammy came over. After much humming and hawing over what to do, hardly had they begun playing Lego inside or going to the backyard when Jeff changed his mind. Cheryl played the peace maker. Peter grew increasingly frustrated. He didn’t like trailing around while Jeff decided what to do.

We have been watching the Olympics. Peter follows with interest, especially the swimming. He explains what is taking place according to his idea of the rules, borrowing words the commentators use, like ‘warm-up’, ‘laps’, ‘training’. This puts oomph into his own swimming, which he does every day at 11:30. He is awed by the deep end. He is trying to get over his fear.

Matthew has been hit hard by a stomach bug. He spent from Thursday until Friday at noon soldiering through his usual routines, looking terrible but not complaining. He wanted to be outside. Finally he and I walked around the block.

We drove to Mom and Dad's with a gift for Beth Hedlin's wedding. It's in Swift Current. We're not going. It's too far and too hot to take the boys.

Sunday, August 5

Cheryl is bathing with one hour to go before the start of church. Peter sits in his blue baseball pj bottoms, working at a bowl of dry Alpha-Bits, biting each 'bit' into smaller 'bits'. Matthew is in his highchair wearing a baggy pj top. I am spooning porridge into his mouth. Matthew is standing in his highchair, looking at the waiting spoon, then throwing his nose into the spoon, getting it stuffed with porridge.

'Oh oh,' he points. 'My nose.'

I hold the spoon up. He blows most of the porridge back.

'There we go,' he says, before taking the spoon in his mouth.

Peter stands next to my ear, cracking 'Alpha-bits' with his teeth. Matthew begins doing the same.

James Taylor is pounding away on the stereo.

Our part of the church turned into a small tempest. The air was too warm, we were all sticky. Peter fussed, squirmed, complained about being hot, said he wanted to go downstairs for a drink. I had to stop him from taking off his shirt. Matthew had been reasonably calm, but just as Peter was settling down, Matthew began stretching his arms towards the stairs, whining, 'Go, go.'

Once home, we sat in the back yard. The boys played with the sprinkler. Cheryl and I drank coffee. Peter crimped the hose, cut off the water, promised Matthew a sucker if he'd come over, made him a sucker by releasing a jet of water at his face.

We brought the fig onto the patio to wash off the dust. The weight of water on the leaves caused it to tip. The heat of the sun causes the sweat to flow.

We went for a bike ride. We got as far as Evergreen Park. The boys played on the swings and the rocketship. Peter decided that the cockpit (Hans Solo's) was at the bottom end. Matthew got tired of swinging and joined Peter. On the way home, Cheryl, with Matthew on the back, swerved her bike to avoid Peter, and fell. The clouds threatened thundershowers—tumultuous, towering things—but passed over.

After watching the Olympics, Peter went to Danielle's. They scattered piles of raked grass, and raked them up again. Peter loves his friends.

Cheryl sat with Peter and worked on sight-reading. They do most of their practising in Matthew's room, shutting him out. Sometimes it works, and he leaves the door alone. Sometimes he throws the door open and the lesson is toast.

Monday, August 6

With this continuing heat, crop failures are being reported across the prairies. Lake Diefenbaker levels are down 4 meters, 50%. More disasters are anticipated. Temperatures are forecast to return to a more normal 25 degrees. Just not for a while.

Cousin Margaret, Peter and their 7-month old, 22 pound son Robert came with Mom, Dad and Joel for a visit. They arrived at 10, left at 1:30. They will go to Watrous for two days before heading to Toronto where Peter begins grad studies in clinical psychology. Brother Matthew arrived at 11. He is busy typing Cheryl's poli-sci term paper. We sat in the sun for awhile, then stood in the shade awhile, then moved into the house for a snack. Robert fussed. After 2 hours of walking him around, Margaret decided it was time to go. They left for Carol's.

I spent the afternoon finishing the review of Hayden's book. Cheryl visited with Dena

Millar. Peter, Kelsey and Danielle played outside and in the basement. Kelsey spent more time carrying Matthew, chasing him in the hall, and lying with him in the tunnel. The blinds have been down the whole day to keep out the sun.

Just as the boys were being put to bed, Cheryl's parents arrived from the farm with 3 buckets of raspberries. Peter stayed up and played with the walkie-talkie.

Overnight a storm struck with winds so fierce our 15-foot griffin poplars were knocked over. There is something wrong with their trunks. Rotten-looking. Even so, the branches are fully

leafed. The yard feels empty. The trees were also serving to screen our bedroom window from whoever is in the Wallace's kitchen.

Cheryl interviewed a babysitter for the upcoming winter. Mrs. Giesbrecht. She was impressive. Peter liked her. She liked the boys. After talking with a friend of her previous employer, and learning she is a 'cracker babysitter,' Cheryl phoned right back and hired her. One more thing off our minds.

I took Peter swimming. Once back, Matthew wanted to walk. We headed in one direction along the sidewalk. He stopped, pointed behind us, and said, 'No, this way.' We turned, and a few paces later he stopped, pointed behind us, and said, 'No, this way.' Three more times that happened. I picked him up and carried him to the house.

We had such a terrible sleep last night, Cheryl and I decided we'd sleep for as long as Matthew and Peter remained in their beds. Matthew's spider senses must have been tingling. As soon as we drifted off, he woke up. Peter also let us know he couldn't sleep. I went to the basement to work. Peter came down, asking for his shorts.

After supper, Cheryl and Peter went to her parents'. Cheryl put curlers in her mom's hair. Matthew and I read *I Am A Mouse*. Matthew pointed at each creature:

'Whatsisa?'

'A grasshopper.'

'Bidopper. Whassa?'

'Bug.'

‘Boog.’

We reviewed. I said, ‘What’s that, Matthew.’

‘Didopper. Whassa?’

‘A snail.’

Pointing to the snail’s shell, he said, ‘Issa diaper.’

Friday, August 10

We took the boys for check-ups to Dr Lappi's. Matthew flirted around corners with the receptionist. Both boys provided urine samples in Styrofoam cups that we put into a 'milk window'. Peter stripped down to his underwear, then hid himself under the paper pulled over the examination table. Matthew pulled off his diaper and remained in that state until the check-up was done. They were calm enough until Lappi stepped into the room. Then they got rambunctious. Peter let himself be examined but said he was worried about a needle. Matthew watched and peed on the floor three times. Each time it was mentioned, Lappi leaned over the table each time to see where it happened, insisting, 'That's all right.' And, 'Don't worry about it.' And, 'The carpet's easy to clean.' His assurances sounded awfully un-assuring.

Matthew proved the rule that bravery is directly related to distance. While he got over his fear of the stethoscope easily enough, the ear probe was a different matter. He fought away from it, tore up the paper on the table, needed to be pinned, screamed, and wouldn't let Lappi touch his ears. Lappi resorted to distractions. He produced Oscar the Grouch. 'Matthew, would you like to see inside Oscar's ears?' He stopped crying long enough to look into the scope at the spot of light on Oscar's green fur. Then Lappi said, 'Fine, now let's look in your ear.' Matthew pushed him away and began crying. Lappi reached for him across the table, circled the table several times while reaching, taking stabs at Matthew's ear but getting his cheek, forehead, nose instead, before giving up. He was no longer calm. He had lost his aplomb. He was panting. It was over and Matthew was suddenly calm. Lappi's last words about the matter were, 'If it's this difficult, there's not much

point in trying. Does he ever seem to not hear you?' I guess that's a diagnosis.

We went to Cheryl's parents for raspberry shortcake. Everyone in the family was there.

Peter learned he needs to tread water for only 30 seconds to earn his red badge. Never has he swum with such intensity. Prior to this, he has had such a fear of deep water he has been unwilling even to let go of the pool edge. Today he swam the entire width on his back, pausing twice.

After supper we drove to the Post Office to mail Cameron Haugrud's birthday card. We walked in Kiwanis Park, looked at the condominiums by St. Paul's Cathedral, and passed a group of International Folk dancers. Matthew turned away from us and joined them. After a few minutes we came to the Victoria Avenue bridge. I climbed onto the branch of a tree that reached over the water. Matthew wanted to follow. Peter cried out, 'Oh Daddy, don't go any farther. Come back.' We started across the bridge. Peter made sure someone was holding Matthew's hand. Lots of boats buzzed around, some pulling skiers. Cheryl refused to look down. 'I hate this,' she said. Matthew broke from my grip and Cheryl's grip and made for the rail. Cheryl groaned each time, stayed near the barrier next to the road, and said, 'I really can't stand this.' We got a little better than half way before turning back. Matthew slid his hand along the railing, scattering dried pigeon droppings. Peter held his hand. Andrew Skarsgard passed us on his bicycle. Once back on the Meewasin trail, Matthew was free. He lagged behind. We continued. He climbed on a park bench and let us go nearly out of sight. Cheryl turned back. He jumped off the bench and swaggered by her side. Somewhere he had found a cigarette

butt. He was holding it between two fingers right where they join. Cheryl noticed only when he put it to his mouth for a drag. The boys chased each other on the paths through the lilac bushes. More folk dancers were gathered. A fishing boat passed very slowly, pulling a skier. People just disembarked from the Northcote ferry were scrambling up the steep bank.

Saturday, August 11

Cheryl spent time preparing for family, coming to celebrate Cameron's birthday.

Peter has his Red badge, held a tea-party with Danielle, swam in Kristen's pool all afternoon. They ate at MacDonald's. He played with Anthony up the block until 7, when the Haugruds arrived.

Colin is going into Grade 7. He wets his hair and combs it straight back, parts it in the middle. Les says it's gel. Mark is in Grade 5. He wore a painter's cap with 'Skoals Copenhagen' on the brow. Cameron has changed little. A tow-head. He has Colin's stocky build. He stayed near Carol and said little.

Joel spent his time with the boys. They were all over, in the backyard, basement, hallway, bedrooms, front yard. Colin haggled (unsuccessfully) with Peter, his gel toys for Peter's shotgun. They played with the 'Lite-Brite', walkie-talkies, rode Peter's bike, threw the football. Peter got in the mix. Attempts were made to keep Cameron out of it. They tried the same with Matthew, but he didn't comply.

Mom, Dad, Les, Carol, Cheryl and I sat in the living room. The topics were Olympic boxing, military training as part of a school's curriculum, Les' business, Masai culture. Matthew showed up late without Cheryl. They both have colds. Cheryl lent Carol maternity clothes.

Matthew didn't stay long. Mom, Dad and Joel followed him out shortly after. Mom and Dad are heading to England next week. Joel goes to the Gaspé August 28. Carol and Les were the last to

leave. Matthew wanted to leave with them. He sat between the boys in the backseat.

The boys are worn out. The Haugrud cousins are a whirlwind that won't pause.

Cheryl and I watched Olympics until midnight.

We met Cheryl's parents at the Cavalier for breakfast. After, Peter went with Papa to the University to load a model of the campus into the vehicle of a Regina architect to be updated. Cheryl, her mom, Matthew and I went to Eaton's and spent time looking for Cameron's birthday gift. Matthew discovered an All-Gym exerciser. It's a bed that slides on a rack at a 45-degree angle, hiked up by hand-pulled cables. He lay on it upside down and called me to pull the cables. Shortly after, I lost sight of him in the sports equipment. I was alerted by a loud bang-bang. Matthew had gotten back to the exerciser. He was pulling the cables to slide the bed up, then letting it crash down.

The day is as hot as ever. We closed the south-facing blinds. The house was as dark as a tomb. The fan creates a Casablanca atmosphere. Cheryl and the boys went to Cameron's for his birthday. They were home by 5:30.

We had supper on the patio in the shade and a cooling breeze. Peter fed Matthew spaghetti. Danielle came over. We went to Diefenbaker Park to fly Peter's kite. Peter and Danielle took turns holding it while sitting on a wooden barrier at the top of the riverbank. They discussed whether the kite was high enough to touch the sky. Cheryl took Matthew to the swings. The wind came from over the river, bringing the sounds of a Hilltop football game. Peter grew nervous about Danielle holding the kite spool, fearing

she would let go of it. While I started the endless task of rolling up the 100 feet of kite string, Cheryl took the kids down the rutted paths of the bank to the river's edge. Maybe ten minutes later, with the kite still a long distance away, I followed them. I found them standing on stones, scrounging around the dry bed for stones to throw in the water. Matthew flipped at the water with his hand. Cheryl found a stone for skipping, took an awkward throwing stance, and sent the stone straight down at her feet. She insisted she knew how it was done but didn't try again. Peter and Danielle competed to find the largest stone.

'Oh ho, Danielle,' Peter laughed, while squatting on a boulder, rolling a stone out of its muddy hole. 'I've found the biggest stone in the world.'

Three aboriginal teens came out of the bush. Even though they appeared harmless, I finished reeling in the kite and Cheryl gathered the kids together. Back up in the park we found a wooden bench flipped upside down off its concrete stand. We drove to Homestead Ice-cream for cones. Matthew insisted on having his own chair. His head scarcely reached the tabletop. He smeared his ice-cream onto the tablecloth with a serviette. After dropping Danielle off at home we went for a longer car ride. We drove to Silverwood Heights, the northernmost part of the city, past the Correctional Centre on 61st Street. Peter asked about its lights, the tall fence with coils of barbed wire, the prisoners. Matthew interrupted him.

'Daddy... Dowad...' The whites of his eyes shone in the dusk.

Once in bed, they fell promptly asleep.

Monday, August 13

Carol and Les came over yesterday for a BBQ lunch. We ate in the backyard. The kids were done quickly and ran from front yard to back yard and up the street. Danielle came over with her doll carriage. They sat in the shade under the umbrella clothesline, talking quietly. She pointed to one of her teeth. Peter touched it. 'It's really loose,' he said. He looked more closely, touched it again. 'Maybe I could bend it. It might come out then.' It didn't come out. Danielle didn't seem to mind his trying. She did mind minutes later when he collapsed a lawn chair frame on her back.

Peter got popsicles out of the freezer. Within moments most of Cameron's had melted onto his chest and pooled in his navel.

I attended the accreditation seminar today. It went from 8:30 to 12, 1:30 to 4:30, 7:30 – 9.

Cheryl spent the day relaxing with the boys. She played with the walkie-talkie while Peter worked in the garden.

From behind her, she heard Matthew say, 'It's a ball. It's a ball.' He was holding a ripe tomato, poised to throw it.

'No Matthew, it's a tomato. Put it on the picnic table.'

Minutes later Peter yelled. Matthew was crouched on the picnic table, looking at the tomato now smashed on the patio.

Peter has new-found confidence in swimming. Today when the instructor asked who would like to jump off the board, Peter's hand was up with the rest. Cheryl watched as he advanced to the end of the board, stood a moment, looked at the instructor, then jumped and swam to the edge.

At lunch he said, 'Hey, nobody wants to talk with me about swimming today.'

'Okay, Peter,' I asked, 'what did you do in swimming today?'

'Well,' his knees were pulled up to his chin, his eyes were turned upwards at this interesting if unexpected question that deserves some thought, 'I dove off the board. Well, not actually. I jumped and swam to the side, all by myself. And you know what? The instructor never helped me. He just stood there and watched.'

When Peter demonstrates patience by calling us 'Mother' and 'Father'.

Recently we were going through Biology museum and Peter saw a rattlesnake skeleton. When we were last at Diefenbaker Park, Peter and Matthew had come running to us, Peter saying, 'We saw a garter snake.' And adding, 'And I saw a little rattle on the tip of its tail.'

We had supper at Cheryl's parents. It was actually to celebrate our anniversary. BBQ steak, peas, potatoes, fresh bread and buns, and peach pie with whipped cream. Before eating, I rode the bicycle, giving each boy a turn on the crossbar. Matthew didn't want to get off. He laughed at every wobble.

When it was Peter's turn, I pretended we were in an Olympic Gold Medal bike race. I narrated the finish.

'We're coming from behind. We're neck-and-neck with the lead man-boy-bike duo. We're behind, we're ahead. We win! Yayyy!'

I had hoped his excitement of getting a gold medal might last until supper. I brought it up while we were eating and coaxed him into relating the close finish.

The best he could manage was, 'We raced on the wrong day. No-one was there.'

Tuesday, August 14

While I attend the accreditation seminar, Cheryl keeps up the home end. Swimming lessons at the George Ward pool are suddenly over. The instructor puts a lot of pressure on the kids without providing much instruction. Which has brought Peter nearly to tears. To protect his building confidence we decided to remove him early and register him for classes this fall at the university.

Mom and Dad left for England last Thursday.

Friday, August 17

Our plan to invite John and Irma Peltier for coffee tonight fell through. Peter has a fever.

The weather continues unusually hot. We are sticky and ill-tempered. Everyone steers clear of making demands of anyone.

Saturday, August 18

We spent the morning getting ready for the farm. We left at 1:15. Both boys slept in the car. Cheryl drove part way while I tried to sleep. We went first to the Isaachsen auction. Half-ton trucks lined the road and driveway. Stuff was piled in the tall grass. People stood in the shade of sheds and trees. Only the auctioneer moved. He got \$10 for a compressor, \$1 for barbed wire. Cheryl commented later on the timelessness of the occasion. There is something of the 1930s in the look of the people. Men with faces darkened by sunburn and dust, sombre women dressed for Sunday. We didn't stay long. We dropped by the Stump Lake store for popsicles and ate them in the shade at Henry's. The boys played in the sand by the house while Cheryl and I read Time magazines.

Nanny, Danny and Jeffrey came for supper. Stew. Jeff and Peter took turns on the garden tractor and motorcycle and walked hand in hand with Papa.

Cheryl, Matthew and I slept in the white shed. It was much cooler than the house. Partway through the night, Papa moved out of the stifling bedroom to the couch and the bit of cross-breeze.

Peter continues to be concerned about bears. He'd rather relieve himself in the bushes by the house than cross the yard to the outhouse. However, we insist. Being sure that we're watching, he walks/trots, looking both ways as if for cars. On one occasion, he burst out of the outhouse and ran towards us, stopped halfway, looked bewildered. He said, 'Ohh, I forgot to lock the door.' I said, 'You'd better go back and do that.' He heads back to the outhouse with scarcely contained panic, looking-both-ways, trot-walking,

stopping and starting, replacing the turn-button, then running for all he's worth back to the house. Resuming the conversation, whatever it was, as if the nightmare had never happened.

Sunday, August 19

Thirty-eight of the Isaachsen clan gathered for brunch. Some were out chasing yearlings, returning by 11 empty handed. After pancakes, sausages, coffee and orange juice, Peter and went out to play croquet. Cheryl visited with the women. Matthew came out and Papa pushed the boys in the hammock. Peter sat with Dawn-Marie and Jamie in Judy's camper-trailer while they played with dolls. He ate several pieces of foot-long lefse. The temperature is way down.

We left at 4. Good thing, too. A half-hour after passing through Blaine Lake, hail fell the size of eggs, decimating crops, putting some farmers out of business. Prince Albert got hit worse. Trees and power-lines were toppled, roofs were blown off houses, yards were filled with debris.

Monday, August 20

I picked up some political campaign material for my Grade 12 classes. Peter almost came, but stayed home to watch Size Small. Matthew guffaws at the cartoons, which, because he's being toilet trained, he never sees right through. Cheryl went for groceries. The boys slept for 2 hours. To prep for the Grade 9s, I read Kramer's The Sumerians. As Matthew was waking, I played guitar in his room.

Suddenly he sat up and said, 'Teter.'

I said, 'Go wake him up.'

He left.

Shortly, I heard Peter calling from his bedroom. 'Dad, Matthew's trying to go to the bathroom.'

I found Matthew sitting on Peter's bed in studied silence.

While I played guitar, Matthew lay beside Peter and pulled the blanket to his chin.

Once up, the boys played, screechingly. Peter and I spent time with the Physics set, making soap film. We messed up the kitchen. Cheryl told us to make sure we cleaned up after ourselves. I don't remember cleaning up being a big deal in Einstein's life. In any case, things got worse before they got better, with soapy water getting sloshed out of the flat dish. I also don't remember Einstein breaking from his work to wrap his brother in a crocheted blanket and pull him around the livingroom.

We had spaghetti for supper. Peter took three bites, and said, 'You're not going to hear any complainments [sic] from me.'

John and Irma came for coffee. They told us about their camping trip to New York. Peter and Sara played in his bedroom and the kitchen. Matthew tried to butt in on a game of 'Ups and Down'. Peter called me to the kitchen. Matthew was sitting on the table dangerously near the game board. He had picked half the leaves of a violet plant. All that's left are a few naked purple stalks and a fringe of a few leaves. Cheryl had made 'mud pie'. The centre had melted. It's the kind of dessert one begins eating with a fork and finishes up with a spoon, or a sponge. They left at 11:30.

Tuesday, August 21

We spent half the day cleaning out the basement. Since we first moved in, it has never felt so spacious. I created a study area. To brighten up the concrete wall, I installed a few paintings I found rolled up, folded up, wrapped in cobwebs. Peter and I hauled the garbage to the city dump. A Hoover vacuum cleaner, a wok, broken chairs, and 3 boxes of 2X4 odds and ends. All the way there, he asked questions. Each of Peter's questions bears many offspring.

While driving on the freeway: 'Dad, what's that on the shoulder?'

'Some kind of animal.'

'What kind?'

'I think it's a bird.'

'Oh, how did it get there?'

'Something probably hit it.'

'What?'

'Maybe a car.'

'What else might it be?'

'A truck?'

'What else?'

'I don't really know.'

'What do you think?'

'What do you mean what do I think?'

‘What do you think hit it?’ (Peter is getting frustrated with me?)

‘A car, then.’

‘Do you think its parents will miss it?’

‘It probably left home a long time ago.’

‘How do you think the car hit it?’

‘Peter?’

‘What?’

‘Let’s talk about something else.’

‘Okay. What do you want to talk about?’

Wednesday, August 22

If there's such a thing as getting too much done, we're doing it. I spent the morning at the bank to get a hold-over loan that has turned into overdraft protection, looking for parts for our broken sprinkler, picking up books from the library. Cheryl picked vegetables, made a huge batch of soup, and 'renovated' the car. fixed the sprinkler, really.

Peter and I went to see Grandma Hedlin. She tries to talk, but is mostly unintelligible. Most of the time she sleeps. Aunt Anne came. Peter asked her a few questions. The rest of the time he sat under the bed, examining the tube to the catheter bag. He observed that single drops of urine didn't look like urine. On the way home, he and I drove along the alleyways between 20th and 18th. Peter commented on a few things he hadn't seen before.

Cheryl's grandparents invited us to the Samurai restaurant. Both courses were prepared before our eyes. It involved a lot of tossing knives, clacking salt and pepper mills, huge plumes of smoke and steam. Matthew was startled by every new sight and ate like we had starved him. Large quantities of chicken liver appetizer and vegetables and rice. Peter sat head in hand stirring his tea, rolling food over with a fork, insisting he wasn't hungry. The waitresses waited while we ate, cleaned away plates, teased the boys.

Friday, August 24

Cheryl continues to be busy getting the house organized prior to the opening of school. We installed a tack board and letter holder to get stuff off the counter.

Joe, Shirley, Larry and Natalie came from up north prior to flying to Ottawa tomorrow. Cheryl and I took the boys at 3 to her parents' for a short visit. We didn't see Larry. We had coffee. Cheryl's dad arrived early from work. Plans were made to attend Folk-Fest that evening.

We left by 4:15. We went by Consumer Distributor's. I stayed in the car with the boys. Matthew sat in my lap and played with the controls. He discovered the button for the windshield-washer. Once started, it was not easy to stop him. I had to distract him with other things. That's when Peter got the idea to poke the button with the tip of his plastic sword. I said not to and turned my attention back to Matthew. The sword tip crept back. After a couple of misses he made contact, but when he pushed the plastic buckled in three places.

Since principles are principles, I said, 'Peter, I've asked you before to stop that.'

He answered, 'I can't do it anyway, so don't bother.'

We went to MacDonald's. The boys played on the slide first, then merry-go-round. Peter sat Matthew close to him, put his arm around him, and gave sour looks to the boy on the other side who was hitting him and stepping on his feet. Cheryl had a Danish. I had coffee.

Saturday, August 25

I'm reading *The Adventures of Robin Hood* to Peter. He studied one picture with Robin sitting on a stool in an Inn. He pointed to Robin's legs.

'Is that link?' he asked.

'What do you mean?'

He pointed to Robin's jacket. 'Well that's green, so those,' the legs, 'must be link.'

'Oh,' I said, prepared to move on.

Seeing I wasn't comprehending, he said, 'Well, you just said he's wearing link and green.'

Cheryl spent the afternoon at the Norwegian Pavilion serving milk porridge. She had enjoyed the music and the crowds.

Aunt Anne phoned and invited us to Delphi's for supper at six-thirty. We were brought to a table for 9. After everyone arrived, we were 13. Joel, Carol, Les, Cameron, Peter, brother Matthew and wife Cheryl were on one side of the table. Aunt Anne, Diane, Ernie, Cheryl, Matthew and I were on the other. The waitress couldn't believe we managed such a tight fit. Cheryl left at 8 with the boys. The rest of us stayed until 11. Most everything got talked about.

Once home, Cheryl put the boys to bed and began watching *Camelot* with Richard Harris and Vanessa Redgrave on Channel 2. Then a storm struck. It was a fantastic show of lightning. She ended up with both boys in Peter's bed. Matthew clung to her.

Sunday, August 26

At 7:15 in the morning, the doorbell rang. It was Anthony Tang looking for Peter. I told him to come back later. This woke the boys. They lay with us for awhile. While Peter played with Anthony, Cheryl and I sat on the patio with tea and coffee. Matthew pushed the tricycle and got muddy in the garden. The sky was clear but the east wind was cool. We wore sweaters.

The boys were at the table, colouring. Matthew laid out his crayons, then watched while Peter worked on his picture. (It's Winnie-the-Pooh. He's taking it to Grandma Skarsgard's for a sleep over this Wednesday.) He stood and reached for one of Peter's markers, but pulled back when Peter yelled.

'Kay, kay,' he said. He held a yellow crayon to me and asked, 'Zzu-zu wara too?'

Tuesday, August 28

I took Peter and Danielle to see Walt Disney's The Jungle Book at Duffy's Cinema. \$4.50 for adults, \$2.50 for children. Danielle's mother sent her admission in a folding purse. Once at the till, I asked Danielle if she had any money. She looked at her hand holding the purse and put it in her pocket. The kids shared buttered popcorn. We found seats a few minutes early, which was enough time to ask (how many times?) 'how long till it's on?' They thoroughly enjoyed the film, and laughed long and loud at the scenes involving Baloo, the orangutan King Louie, and Mowgli's struggle with Kaa. While leaving the theatre, Peter saw a Jungle Book poster.

'I think I've seen this movie somewhere,' he said.

'When?' I asked.

'Oh, I really can't remember,' he smiled.

His good friend Kirsten Jensen is moving away. She is throwing a going-away party tomorrow at 2. The same time that Joel is leaving for the east coast.

Aunt Isabelle phoned. All Dad's siblings were getting together. We would have joined them but had plans to entertain Helen and Jed Dyck.

The wind is stiff and cool. The skies were threatening rain all afternoon. It feels like snow. Once the clouds had passed over the air remained too cool to go out without sweaters. We went to Homestead for ice-cream. Matthew refused to share his toddler cone with anyone. Cheryl bargained for a bite with a kiss. Matthew offered his mouth but held his cone to the wall.

I had trouble getting Matthew to sleep. He wanted Jed to read to him. We tried to ignore him, but his cries grew louder by the minute. I went in, took him up, and we stood at the window.

‘Matthew,’ I said, ‘look out the window. See how dark it is.’

‘Why?’

‘The cats are asleep.’

‘Why?’

‘The cars are asleep.’

‘Why?’

‘The city is asleep.’

‘Why?’

‘The universe is asleep.’

‘Why?’

‘Matthew, now you go to sleep.’

‘No!’

Wednesday, August 29

This is the last full day of family living until next June. We began with breakfast at MacDonald's. The boys played on the slide and merry-go-round. Cheryl and I drank coffee and talked. Later, Cheryl got her hair cut. While the boys watched *Size Small* and *Sesame Street*, I wrote a lengthy letter to Michael and Cathy.

Joel departed for Bonaventure today. We took him to the airport. He had made a mistake, and was to have left yesterday at this time, to meet a Katimavik rep at 7:11 this morning. Who will meet him at 7:11 tomorrow? We are concerned about his safety.

Peter attended Kirsten's party. It lasted from 2 to 6. We asked him how it was. 'Oh super,' he said.

Cheryl's parents invited us to Kaitlan's for coffee. Peter told Mama about yesterday's movie. 'It was about a man-cub, a bear and what I call a panther, but many call a jaguar.'

He stood on a chair, with one foot on the railing. Then Matthew climbed onto a different chair, and hooked his leg over the railing. Wherever Peter went in the restaurant, Matthew followed directly behind. Then Peter came to a stop and turned. Matthew turned and Peter followed. Back and forth they went, Peter in front, Matthew in front, until Matthew took off screaming, and Peter chasing.

Cheryl's parents are thinking about making a bid on a small cabin at Christopher Lake.

Monday, September 3

Labour Day, one day until the election.

Every night now Peter is dreaming of school. During the day too. After a moment of silence he shakes his head and says, 'Ooh, I'm so excited. I can't wait.'

Thursday, September 6

Cheryl and I look forward each day to get home from work to hear Peter's stories about Grade 1. He is at the front of the first row. His teacher is Mrs. Rogers. A 1/2 split, an open-area classroom. Peter has gotten the name and number of Chad.

He said, 'Troy and I are the goodest boys in the entire classroom.'

'Did anyone tell you that?'

'No, I just know.'

'What do the other kids do?'

'Oh, they disobey all the time. They talk when Mrs. Rogers reads us stories.'

Later we were in the backyard. Peter, sitting on the tractor, said, with a wave of his hand, 'I just can't get over how nice Mrs. Rogers is.'

Nonetheless, Peter needed coaxing yesterday at lunch to walk back to school. He said he wanted to start taking his lunch. But today he told Cheryl he didn't really want to take his lunch because that meant being away the whole day, and he would miss Matthew.

Matthew talked both Cheryl and me into sitting on the carpet. He pressed a lid into the carpet. He pointed to the impression and said, 'kerkle'. He made another impression and said, 'Two kirkle.'

Friday, September 7

It was raining, so Cheryl drove by the school to fetch Peter. Peter came out, using his hand as a brim to shield his glasses from the rain. Matthew saw this and did the same.

I had a phone conversation with the boys this afternoon.

‘Hello, Matthew.’

‘Hi Daddy. What u do?’

‘I’m working.’

‘Daddy? What you do?’

‘I’m phoning from school.’

‘Oh.’

I laughed.

Matthew laughed.

Peter takes his turn. ‘Dad.’

‘Hi, Peter.’

‘Guess what?’

‘What?’

‘You’ll never guess. It’s my lucky day. I’m sleeping over at Mama’s and Papa’s tonight. And I get my new cello tomorrow. And guess what? I’m going to Anthony’s birthday next Saturday. Right Mom?’

Cheryl told me later that Anthony had come by with '2:00, Saturday September 15' written on a scrap of paper, held it to the window, asked if Peter could come at that time, and ran away with the paper.

We ate supper at Cheryl's parents. Ione, Adolph and the girls were there too. Peter was done in by 8, so he went to bed. Shortly after, I heard him calling Cheryl. Since she was busy, I went instead.

'What do you want, Peter?' I asked.

'It's that story again. The one about the spell.'

Peter had recently watched a *The Muppets Take Manhattan*. In one scene they are at the Washington Art Gallery. He was frightened by an Egyptian tale in which a young boy is trapped by a spell and is unable to join his parents who have become stars. He is visited each night by the demon and tested for the special word that will break his bondage.

'Peter, that was a story, make-believe.'

'I know, but I'm still scared.'

Further attempts to reason it through weren't getting us any further, so I sat beside him, which encouraged him to do more talking.

'I'm frightened that you might be at the Saskatoon Inn tomorrow waiting for me and Mama and Papa will be stars, and I'll be here alone and you won't know.'

'Peter, how can Mama and Papa turn into stars?'

‘Well, I guess they could wear star costumes and jump around the living room, or go up in a plane and come down by parachute wearing star costumes or they could just hang onto a black wall.’

‘That’s the idea.’

‘Good night Dad.’

Saturday, September 8

This evening, we had another long chat with Peter, while the boys were getting dished up with rainbow ice-cream.

He said, 'I was out on the playground and a boy had a knee-injury. And you know you are not supposed to drag kids inside with knee injuries because that will injure them more.'

'Who teaches Grade 2?'

'Grade 2. Very simple. That's Miss Pidskolny and Mrs. Rogers.'

'Who else is there?'

'Mr. Sparrow.'

'Is he new?'

'Mr. Sparrow, he was there last year. He's been teaching for a long time.'

'What's Miss Ives like?'

'Very nice. She's young.'

'How can you tell?'

'Her skin is soft, no, smooth.'

'Who is younger, Miss Ives or Mom?'

'Mmm. Mom.'

'Why do you say that?'

‘Because her skin doesn’t have wrinkles, except when she smiles, then she gets them like this—’ And he stretched his mouth wide.

Then he saw Matthew trying to spoon up ice-cream. He said, ‘Should I help you get it on your spoon, Matthew?’

‘Mm,’ said Matthew.

Peter scooped up the entire ball of ice-cream and tried to feed it to Matthew.

I asked him, ‘Who sits beside you in class?’

‘Jocelyn.’

‘Who sits behind you?’

‘Jessica. And you know, they talk all the time.’

‘Do they ever talk to you?’

‘He rolled his eyes. ‘Of course. They ask me millions of questions.’

‘What kinds of questions?’

‘Questions they can answer themselves.’

Matthew is point to his empty bowl. ‘More, Daddy.’

‘Where did it go?’

‘Eat it, bye-bye.’

‘So, Jessica and Jocelyn talk a lot?’

‘Ooh boy, do they ever. Like when they are doing a detective sheet and aren’t supposed to be saying anything. But they do anyway. They say, “Circle this one, okay”’

September, September 18

I arrived home at 4:30 and found Cheryl and Peter in the living room practising cello.

Cheryl said, ‘Peter, if you play Long Long Ago once I’ll read for ten minutes.’

Peter twisted on his chair, kept his bow away from the cello, nearly in tears.

Cheryl asked, ‘Peter, what’s the matter?’

He said, ‘I’ve had a very frustrating day.’

‘What happened?’

‘Jocelyn wouldn’t let me hold Jessica’s hand.’

‘What do you mean?’

‘We were coming home from school, me and a bunch of kids, and I was holding Jessica’s hand.’

‘What did Jocelyn do?’

‘She said, “Do you want your glasses broken?” Then she grabbed me and did this.’ He gripped his own shoulder and shook it. ‘Don’t hold hands with Jessica.’

We went for ice-cream to the Homestead with Mama and Papa. Peter had a troubled expression. I asked what was bothering him.

He said, 'Something awful happened yesterday. A little girl caught her fingers in the front doors. They are very heavy. She had a bandage put on with a strap around her hand to hold it there. The bandage was there so nothing would affect it. At first I saw Mr. Welch standing in the front holding a bleeding Kleenex. I didn't know what happened. Then I saw the little girl.'

Papa and Matthew rolled an Austin-Mini toy between them. Peter reached for it. Matthew grabbed it away and held it behind his ear with both hands. When it was safe, he set it back on the table. Peter reached, and Matthew grabbed it up. 'Teter!' he said, looking fiercely at Peter while the rest of us laughed.

1985

Tuesday, January 8

According to my \$15 digital watch, it is 8:14. Matthew is in my lap at the table while I add this entry. He has a folded piece of bread in one hand and a pop-up story book, Bertie the Bus and Thomas the Tank Engine in the other. His mouth is full. He is bumping my hand. 'Wha doing?' Cheryl has just taken Peter to bed after reading him Frog and Toad, though he's reading easily enough by himself. She joins us at the table. Matthew takes one of her pieces of foolscap.

'T's Daddy's,' he tells her.

She says, 'Matthew, put it down.'

He leans close and looks directly in her face. 'T's Daddy's.'

A standoff. Matthew is firm, Cheryl is firm, Matthew gives in.

I have a new JVC cassette deck. Just now I'm taping Glenn Gould's performance of Bach's Goldberg Variations.

Peter keeps busy with school and music. Bernadette begins her leave on Monday after having another baby. John Payzant will replace her. Lessons now are Tuesday, 5 pm at 127 110th St.

Tuesday, January 15

The temperature runs between minus 10 and minus 5 with a cold northeast wind.

Matthew slept at 2:30 this afternoon, and didn't go down until after 9.

After leaving his room, and joining Cheryl in the kitchen, he called, 'Dad, come here.'

His voice has a lower pitch and bigger volume. Cheryl laughed and said something about Caesar Augustus.

I called back, 'What do you want?'

'Dad, come here.'

He asked for milk. He is still on Isomil. Each time we've tried natural milk, it didn't go well.

Peter had his first lesson with John. It went well enough, considering the fact he has been sick most of the week.

I was sitting on the floor against the sofa reading the newspaper. I didn't hear Matthew approaching I was startled when he burst through the paper onto my lap. This is his new thing. Every time we sit down with the paper he does his smashing thing. First it's peace, then there's the explosion. And Matthew is there, a big grin, a big stick in his hand. It gets my heart pounding every time.

Peter went with Cheryl to get the last of his allergy tests. We're trying to find out why he had reacted to anaesthetic given by a dental nurse. No luck so far.

We're planning a ski weekend with Mom and Dad at Anglin Lake for sometime in February.

Cheryl's Aunt Margaret and her Grandmother have their Christmas trees up and decorated. The family got together at the Ardell's Lakeview home Saturday evening. The Montreal Canadiens are celebrating their 75th anniversary. The boys slid down the stairs on their bellies. It's tough to bring an end to these things once they start.

Peter's eating continues to be a problem. Cheryl has made a Gingerbread House, which he'll stand beside, waiting for half an hour for permission to break something off to eat. But he'll spend a half-hour alone after supper looking at a plate of four Brussels sprouts. His head clears the counter-top now, but he's lacking flesh.

The Bambi tape has been playing in Matthew's bedroom. He sings Twinkle until he falls asleep.

Tuesday, February 5

The boys are sleeping together tonight for the first time. Earlier attempts have been aborted by giggling. Matthew's head is on Peter's arm. He is snorting and whistling.

Peter was home for the week with the flu. He gave it to Matthew. Even so, their playing together these days is a sort of spiritual harmony.

Peter and Cheryl talked about a boy named Robbie who beats up other kids. Cheryl said that someone like that is usually lonesome and unhappy. A few days later, Peter said:

'I told Robbie what we talked about.'

'What was that?' Cheryl asked.

'I said you won't have any friends if you keep beating kids up. And Robbie said, "I have lots of friends."'

'Then what happened?'

'I said I'd be his friend.'

Sunday, February 17

Lloyd Skarsgard (Sr) came through Saskatoon on his way home from meetings in Ottawa. He arrived on Friday. We had breakfast at the Saskatoon Inn Saturday. There is no cello today. Peter had only Gym at 12:30. They are working on floor routines, as well as pommel horse, rings and parallel bars. He works at the details, gets things right, loves the whole thing.

Matthew gets a big kick out of jigsaw puzzles. He'll spend easily an hour without interruption going over the same puzzles of 16 pieces, and one with 60 pieces, working mostly alone, getting occasional suggestions. Now and then he'll put a piece in my hand and say, 'You do it.' So, I do it, and he says, 'Good job.'

'Mom...we play hockey...fun. Fun, hockey 'n ball. Daddy do it. What Mommy doing?'

Cheryl calling down the stairs, 'Matthew, time to come up.'

Matthew answering, 'Ok sweetheart, coming.'

The boys are either in love (hugging, gently patting, 'I love you Matthew', 'I do too.') or in spite ('Give it to me Matthew!' 'No, give it me!') Matthew will not give in to Peter's superior strength. We play hockey nearly every night in the basement. Often the boys will choose the same stick. Peter will take one end and anchor it with all his weight. Matthew will take the other and yell, 'Give it Peter'. Getting nowhere, he plants his heels and pulls. I apply Solomon's solution, not of breaking the stick in halves and giving each boy a piece, but putting that stick in another room and giving them the choice of several sticks lying around. Each picks one and the game begins.

Music is always playing in the house. Records or tapes. Could be a Mozart concerto or Raffi or Sharon, Lois and Bram or Paul Simon. The boys sing, get busy with a personal task, and stay out of each other's hair.

Cheryl is reading a novel by AJ Cronin and bracing herself to pick up Shelly's half of teaching once she goes on mat-leave. We can only hope it is manageable.

On Saturday from 3 to 5 we visited with Mom, Dad and Carol. She came alone. The rest of her family is skiing in Banff. Carol is due in March. Peter sat with a hand on her belly, asking a steady stream of questions while waiting for movement. Matthew, meanwhile, worked on his puzzles, perusing the board while turning a piece in a prospective place, leaning his head in his hands, fingers gripping hair, then working quickly, setting down one piece after another.

We stayed home all day, relaxing, enjoying ourselves, until the phone rang at 5. Cheryl's parents had discovered a new restaurant they wanted to try out. The Station Place on Idylwyld and 24th St.

The plan had been to go in the afternoon to Meewasin rink to skate, but the boys were too tired. We thought it would be best for everyone to let them sleep. They hadn't been up for long before Cheryl's parents arrived.

Once home again, Peter's hair was washed and trimmed, I read all of *Yes I Can* (while Matthew was in the bathroom with Cheryl saying, 'I can't.') and a few pages of *Prince Caspian*.

Tuesday, February 18

John told Cheryl time and again at the lesson that he can't get over Peter's fluid bowing. Matthew and I sat outside the room and worked on a Disney puzzle. It was a picture of an alligator leaping out of a moat to bite Captain Hook. Matthew made several observations about the picture, then resumed putting the pieces in place. With no warning, he jumped at me, biting my shirt. 'I alligator, grr.' We worked awhile and it happened again, and again.

We went to Cheryl's parents for a supper of leftovers from Saturday evening's meal. Peter ate around his broccoli. Matthew has begun sitting on a proper chair at the table. He began mumbling grace, put his elbow in his food, gave it a glance, said 'woopsie', and resumed mumbling the grace until Peter grew impatient and said, 'amen'. After supper we looked at slides taken between 1971 and when Cheryl and I began dating in 1973.

Monday evening Cheryl and I went to the cinema to watch *Amadeus*. Wonderful film. Her parents came to babysit.

Wednesday, February 19

Shelly Loeffler went to the hospital for an early delivery. Cheryl hadn't planned to go full time until March 1. She spent the whole day at school. She has said how much she'll miss being home in the afternoon to sit with Matthew when he wakes up.

I returned home from school later than we had planned. Cheryl and the boys were waiting by the hole in the fence that runs along the highway. (Note: I go through the hole unless the city has patched it, in which case I throw my briefcase over, climb up and jump down; it's battle between the City patching crew and the boy two houses down from us who cut the hole to get his dirt bike through so he can ride in the ditch.) They are in their full winter gear, chilled by the minus-10 temperature, waiting to go for supper.

Every time the Smitty's waitress passed by Matthew shouted, 'Bye lady.'

Peter squirmed and said, 'Oh, he embarrasses me.'

The waitress stopped and asked Matthew, 'What are you eating?'

'S'getti.'

'Is it good?'

'Ryah. Lady?'

'Yes?'

'What you doin?'

'Oh, Matthew,' Peter says.

Every night before bed, the boys ask us to let them sleep together. Every night, we say no. I read Prince Caspian to Peter, then he listens to Tucker's Countryside. We had stopped reading fantasy for a while. Peter found the events and ideas too disturbing. He wants to try again. Matthew listens to Size Small.

Monday, February 25

Cheryl is very busy working full-time. It is not ideal. She is so lonely for the boys. We both are.

Peter practiced cello. Then it was Matthew's turn. Cheryl has spent time each evening having Matthew do basic patterns and learning the parts of the cello. One song is I'm A Little Monkey. He doesn't know the words, but sings loudly anyway. 'Ah-ah-ha-ha monkey! M-m-m-m.' He sings Twinkle to himself while drifting asleep. Peter and I played hockey in the basement. '3 And You're In'. Whether Peter is in or out, he concentrates on his shooting, on blasting shots at my legs. He falls over himself to make saves.

Cheryl found Matthew pulling at something between his lips. She asked if it was a hair. He said, 'No, it's a flower.' He b-med for Bev on Friday, jumped off the toilet and said, 'Bebeck, look, 't's an "M".'

Peter gets tomorrow is off. The teachers are attending a professional half-day. He says he's going to sleep in. 'I love dozing and drifting,' he says.

He told Mrs. Rogers about a boy in Grade 2, Robbie, who is giving him a rough time.

'Mrs Rogers went right to Robbie's room and told him that if he did it again he would be sitting at the principal's office. And Mr. Welch can be rough. I remember when one boy got used by the branch he broke off a tree. I don't know how well Robbie will listen.'

Cheryl and I are planning to replace our old mattress. Neither of us are sleeping very well. By 10:30 pm we are all in. That's too early. I can't afford it this year.

A heavy snowfall last night. The four of us went to the park. Cheryl and I pulled the boys in the sled. They dragged their hands in the snow, which made it too hard to pull, then sat quietly, seeming to enjoy each other, the heavy snowfall, the cool air. Cheryl's parents had dropped by, found us away, left Peter's stuffed dog 'Vicky' head-up in the mailbox.

Peter still sleeps with his blanket. He told me one night while lying together how much he likes feeling it at night.

'What would you do if you lost it?'

'Oh, I'd be in tears.'

'Why do you like it so much?'

'It's very soft. I can rub it like this.' He turned over and pressed it close to me. 'Why don't you try it?'

Mountains of snow in the yards. I can't remember such amounts. And we're due for more. At Cheryl's parents, the piles are over my head.

Peter slept Saturday night at her parents'. Matthew spent the evening there while Cheryl and I went to a party at Rita Hlady's. Sunday morning I woke up to one of Matthew's books dinking out The Alphabet Song. Concerned the noise would wake Matthew I rushed in, found the book, brought it to our room. A while later it started up again. I struck it to make it stop, but the sound continued. I had gotten the wrong book. Back I went, searched

under the bed, under piles of Matthew's stuff, and finally found it in flagrante delicto. Matthew slept.

Thursday, February 28

It was 4 above this morning. Snowbanks are collapsing, water is dripping. Cheryl's parents leave for Hawaii on Sunday. We had supper with them at The Station. Matthew did puzzles and Peter practiced his writing. He complained afterwards about being too full.

'I feel like I'm going to have a baby.'

On the way home we spent a few minutes in the Ski Hut to look for clothing for Cheryl. The boys sat on a bench, pushing close to a guy trying on new boots, giving him no elbow room, leaning over their knees to watch. Matthew took a special liking to one of the mannequins.

Cheryl is finding her full time position very heavy. They are in the middle of performances of You're A Good Man Charlie Brown. I chatted with Peter about the new regime, but as busy as we are we love him just as much and are just as frustrated with the lack of time together and our constant coming and going. His hands were in his eyes. I asked if something was wrong.

He said, 'My eyes suddenly got itchy. They're running a bit.'

What a fine boy he is. He's protective of Matthew, well-liked by the kids at school, and putting himself under a lot of pressure to be even better at the things he's learning. He is self-critical about mistakes he makes in writing and math.

Friday, March 1

The evening was spent with the Peltiers. Peter, Matthew and Sarah lay under umbrellas while watching Wizard of Oz. We were home by 10:15. Peter spoke from the back seat.

‘I think I would like to be a minister or a doctor.’

‘Why a minister?’ I asked.

‘I would like to teach people about God. Sometimes I dream about God and Heaven. I dream that Heaven is full of pot-holes, and children fall into them because the holes are invisible. I hold baskets under the holes. The baskets hold dozens of children.’

‘Do you like doing that?’

‘Well, it’s very boring, and tiring.’

‘What does being a minister have to do with being a doctor?’

‘I’d like to deliver babies.’

‘Why?’

‘They’re so cute.’

His hands turned over and over as he talked.

Sunday, March 3

Sunny, quite warm, but not enough to melt the blocks of ice that make driving along residential streets nearly impossible. Driving towards the house with Peter, my tires caught in a rut and turned the car right around, bringing it hard against an icy bank. Peter's head banged the dashboard. He was startled. Then he laughed.

'What happened?' he asked. After I explained, he said, 'I'm disappointed it didn't know my loose tooth out.'

Cheryl's parents will have reached Hawaii by now. We were up at 4:30, at their place by 5:30, and seated in the airport coffee shop at 5:50. The airport was full. One Hawaii charter just in, one going out.

Peter went with me to the university. He practiced his reading at a micro-fiche machine. After a while he looked amongst a collection of tapes, found one he thought might be interesting, went to the desk for headphones. He signed his name and time and sat down to listen. Shortly after I got his attention. He smiled and removed the headphones. 'Listen, It's real interesting.' I did. It was Travelling with Dutch. He asked to take it home.

Matthew spent time at home with Cheryl. He played quietly, sometimes with Cheryl, sometimes in another room. She heard 'Mmm' sounds coming from the kitchen. She went to investigate and found Matthew with raw cookie dough on his hands and lips.

We went to Mom and Dad's at 3:30. We ate sandwiches while planning the ski trip. They showed a letter from Matthew. He was awarded excellent jury marks. This has been a tough year for him.

Joel is in Midland, Ontario. Mom has assembled maybe 20 albums of family photos.

Sunday, March 10

Ski plans have been dashed. Carol is due. The baby could come this weekend. Mom feels she can't be away. The weather is beautiful, springlike. It's the season of dirty snow. We went to Pike Lake to toboggan with the boys. We found a hill with snow on the south face and spent an hour going up and down. Each time the sled flipped Matthew cried out, wiped the snow out of his face, and laughed. 'I wike that.' Sometimes he walked up. Other times he lay in the sled feet first, sometimes head first. Animal tracks are everywhere. The boys were sleeping as we passed two deer in the ditch.

We picked up a VHS machine and 3 movies. Willie Wonka, Gallipoli, and Sophie's Choice. Peter talked all Sunday morning about the fizzy lifting drinks. Cheryl had seen enough by the end of Sophie's Choice. I watched Gallipoli by myself.

We are planning to enroll Peter in soccer. Cheryl and Matthew joined me at the gym. Peter worked on the springboard, worked on the rings trying to get himself inverted. Seeing he was having a bit of trouble with the latter part, she gripped him by the sweats. Peter wasn't able to get further than parallel to the floor. The rest he left to her. Not a 10 for style, maybe, but he did get upsidedown.

Matthew is more aggressive now. This showed while at the Medicentre to get his ears checked out. He didn't want to share toys in the play area, and looked suspiciously at any kid who came near, and even pushed them away. A three-year old biffed him on the mouth with a Fisher Price airplane, cut his lip in two places. On the bright side, it couldn't have happened in a better place.

Peter and I went to the Greystone rink to play hockey. We put on our skates, but the ice was soft and bumpy everywhere but near one end. He had fun hitting and chasing the puck. Once home we went to the Homestead. Peter wasn't happy we ordered him a toddler cone. We had a conversation about the weather and used 15 napkins to soak up the ice-cream on Matthew's chin, cover-alls, table, his hair. Somehow he got ice-cream inside the napkin dispenser and from there on me. We drove through City Park. At one intersection the water was so deep cars were forced to detour. Peter invited us to McDonald's. Papa had given him \$20. He asked if after we ordered might he keep the change. The boys played on the slide and merry-go-round. We got home in time to see Disney's Swamp Fox. Peter practiced cello. Cheryl and I took turns on the rowing machine we borrowed from her parents. The boys were in bed by 8.

Sunday, April 14

Last day of the Easter Holidays. We spent the entire time at home. I spent time getting mid-term marks ready for tomorrow. Cheryl and Peter are booked for dental appointments. The temperatures have gotten up to 16 degrees. Wednesday and Saturday were spent outside in shirts and shorts. We went to Mom and Dad's to celebrate Cheryl's birthday. Uncle Ed and Aunt Audrey were also there. Cheryl got the newly illustrated edition of *Wind in the Willows*. Peter then went to another birthday party. At home, I mowed the lawn, trimmed shrubs, scraped and painted over rust spots on the Toyota, installed new windshield wipers. When Peter returned home, Cheryl's dad phoned to meet them at Robin's donuts. We went to Canadian Tire to buy a tricycle, two bicycle bells, and miscellaneous items for home repairs. We are getting ready to stain and paint the house.

The things we'll remember most from this holiday are the walks. The hour-long walk from Cumberland along University Drive to Rotary Park and back, wandering around the City Park neighbourhood, going back and forth in the area bordered by 15th Street and Elliot, Cumberland and Clarence, and in the Buena Vista neighbourhood. Peter mostly rode his bicycle. He'd stop at each corner and call back to us, 'Which way now?' Matthew rode quite content in the stroller, looking everywhere, chattering. Which is an improvement over our first attempt to walk, with Matthew veering towards pools of melting snow, getting soaked.

The walks gave Cheryl and me lots of time to discuss the future. Will we have a third child? Will we arrange a teaching exchange? England or Australia? The tentative time-line is 3 years from now. Peter's soccer. Our summer. One concrete decision was to sell the

red Mazda. It sat for half the winter at Skarsgard's. Given tight money, we'll plan nothing more for summer than a week at Waskesiu.

The boys ride their bikes back and forth on the sidewalk. Their tall red flags wave overhead from side to side. Matthew utters flurries of commands. 'Don't leave me', 'Stay off the street,' 'I can't do it by myself. I need help.'

Dad phoned to say that Billy Strachan, the principal of Capernway, had spoken at Westgate Alliance Church. They're interested because Joel is talking about going there next fall. Brother Matthew is now finished at the U of M. They will be returning to Saskatoon and look for a job. Michael has written his last exam at the U of A and will spend 10 days in the Vancouver area while Cathy writes her finals. They plan to spend part of the summer in the Yukon. Diane is pregnant, expecting in November. She is very excited. Carol had her fourth son, Graeme Vaughn. She is slowly recovering. We have seen them now and then.

Peter is proud of being able to read *The Cricket* in Times Square. He lets everyone know it's a Grade 4-5 book. He is missing both front teeth. Matthew is now fully toilet-trained. Bev got the process started before the holidays, and we made it a routine. No more diapers.

Wednesday, April 17

We went with Cheryl's parents to Homestead after driving by Carol's to get the maternity clothes Cheryl lent, which we'll give to Bev for her daughter. Peter refuses to accept that I get two scoops and he gets one. Cheryl's dad says he's going to Baltimore tomorrow for several days. Cheryl has made arrangements at school, which has resulted in a better situation. She's much more at peace than a month and a half ago. Peter is also. The frivolity is back in his relations with Matthew. He teases, holds Matthew's hand, squeezes him with hugs every night before bed. He's writing stories at school. Most are six pages. One he called 'Magic Garden.' He reads more every day, working on words he finds difficult to pronounce, eats more than ever, rides his bike at every spare moment. He practices cello well, and likes receiving stickers every time something new is achieved in practice. He has begun *The Two Grenadiers*.

Always after Peter is done, Matthew insists on having his turn. Cheryl gives him pitches, which he finds with no trouble. They sing cello parts. 'I'm a little monkey, climbing down the ladder, going to the bottom, to eat my banana', and 'birdy-birdy pop-pop, birdy-birdy pop-pop', and 'Where is the finger board? Here is the finger board. Where are the ribs? Here are the ribs.'

His independence is increasingly emphatic. 'Don't touch me!' 'Leave me alone!' 'I do it myself.' Just try dressing him when he wants to dress himself, and he'll strip everything off beyond where we started and put it all back on, and take much longer at it. His pajamas go on alright until he gets to the last arm. He turns round and round trying to catch up to the armhole, never quite getting there.

The boys are in bed, tapes are playing in both rooms. Matthew calls, 'I need to pee.' We listen to the click of the gun he has taken to bed.

With springtime, fresh grass, our new mattress, things are quite all right at the moment.

Monday, May 27

The leaves are out, blossoms are thick, the birds have us up by 6, some at are it even earlier.

Mom and Dad have gone to Winnipeg to attend both Matthew's and Cheryl's convocation ceremonies. They'll drive their new Mazda 626.

Peter plays soccer twice a week. I coach. Cheryl comes for every game. An interesting age. No skills, short attention spans, some begging to get off the field, others begging to get on. They call me 'Coach' and show the tooth they lost last night. The dreamiest of them is Colin Croquet. He was standing while the play went back and forth. I called. He didn't hear. I went to him (there are no rules against coaches entering the pitch).

'Colin,' I said.

'What?'

'What are you doing?'

He pointed to the sky. 'I've seen that cloud before.'

'Where?'

'On TV.'

Peter works hard, is proud every time he gets into the play, recalls them after the game. 'Hey Dad, did you see that ball bounce off me? I didn't have to do anything.' As if the less you do, the more skilled you are. Cheryl and Matthew stand at the sidelines. Cheryl says that every game feels a bit longer. The further these kids go into the season, the less they seem to do out there. She

visits with other mothers. Matthew mixes it up with the other players. His windbreaker reaches his knees. He runs around with a ball, drop-kicking it everywhere.

Peter is busy with school. They are working on time, money, measurement, reading. He is increasingly socially aware. Friends mean something different than they used to. He has already attended several birthday parties. His own is near. Each day he reminds us. We see his new teeth coming. An eye-tooth is nearly out since Matthew cracked it with his head. He was thrilled by the blood on his lip and gum. Peter read several books to Matthew. Curious George and a variety of animal books.

Matthew talks and charms. Everyone adores him, just as they adored Peter at that age. He is sure of himself, flirts with his eyes, uses language that seems quite advanced for someone two and a half years old.

Bev told us, 'Peter and Matthew are the best boys I have ever taken care of.'

Matthew's current best pleasure is to be read to while sitting on the toilet. He'll be still for 15 minutes. Cheryl and I take turns reading.

Monday, July 1

We're getting our first real taste of holiday. Cheryl and I are getting over the mind games, pretending tomorrow is Monday and it's back to work. All day the sky was clear of clouds, not a breath of wind, the searing sun.

Both boys had their first swimming lessons today. Both are tanned with sun-bleached hair, looking healthy and young in their swimsuits. Cheryl took the boys. First it was Matthew for the parent-tot session, while Peter waited on the side.

Joel came over at 12. After lunch he, Peter and I biked to the park for baseball and soccer. Peter kept count of the number of balls he hit over Joel's head. He played goalie while Joel and I wrestled with each other over the ball. We kept at it for an hour and a half, but the sun took its toll. Joel and Peter looked overheated. We were all dehydrated.

We watered over at Cheryl's parents and ate supper early. BBQ hamburgers, fried onions, potatoes, pickles, cheese, and mushrooms. Joel left to meet Beav (real name Brendan Taman). Peter caught sight of Danielle on the street and ran out to play. Matthew and I biked to Lakeview's new play park.

Before going to bed, the boys had a bubble bath. They wrestled, splashed, made so much noise that could only get louder that Cheryl and I decided it was enough. Peter was out first, as usual. He was in his bedroom, calling to me while I was dealing with Matthew, telling me he wanted to be timed putting on his pajama bottoms. I couldn't not oblige him. He had already started. 'On your mark,' he said, 'get set...' In the instant of saying 'go' he showed himself at the door, dressed, grinning like a hillbilly.

Meanwhile, I have to get Matthew out. He is slippery as an eel. The routine goes: I pull the plug, the water begins to drain, Matthew scrambles to find it and put it back in so he can play some more. Today I hid it. That didn't phase Matthew. He slid to the front, stuck his heel in the drain, turned his back to me, fiddled with his toys and sang his version of O Canada. They finished the day with Peter reading Winnie-the-Pooh and Matthew listening to nursery rhymes.

Cheryl and I rented a VCR for July for \$45. We watched CHAЯLY.

Yesterday Peter said he was so happy school was done. This morning at breakfast he told us, grinning, 'I can't wait till Grade 2,' and started an argument about the size of pencil crayons we should buy him.

We went for a walk along the riverbank. Matthew had to be watched. Every chance he got, he ran off the path. He climbed a slope and looked beyond. Peter, imagining a precipice, was nearly in tears with worry.

'I can't stand it,' he said.

Matthew fought our grip and said, 'No, I don't want to walk on the sidewalk.'

Twisting free, Peter followed on his heels, grasping at him, trying to herd him. I told Peter I'd worry about Matthew. That meant following him through grass higher than Matthew's head and onto a sandbar. Back to the sidewalk, Peter gripped Matthew's shoulders with both hands.

Once home, Peter had headed off on his bike. Matthew said he wanted to ride his trike down the block to find him.

Cheryl said, 'Okay, but not around the corner.'

Matthew was already on his way. He said, 'Yup, I'm riding my bike around the corner.'

In a contest of wills with Matthew, one must also apply physical restraints.

Mom and Dad are in Hawaii. Joel is home alone and lonely. Diane is nearer her due date with twins. Matthew and Cheryl are living in a Dufferin Avenue hermitage. Michael and Cathy are in the Yukon. Carol and Les are spending the week at Waskesiu. Mama and Papa have arrived at Vancouver after a trip up the west coast. Cheryl and I are at home.

We met Irma and John at Kinsmen Park where the kids played on swinging tires. Matthew went for a comical walk, planting his leading foot, swinging the other forward and around the first, his face turned sideways as if watching the shifting horizon. On the way to Peltiers', we stopped at the Homestead by Bishop Mahoney school. They're heading to Southern California this weekend.

Wednesday, July 3

Hot and windy. I stained until 4:30. Peter worked on a patch on the west side, his eyes inches from the wood, studying the bare spots of wood, the cracks and bulges in the parging, while the paint dripped from his brush. 'I love helping,' he said, grinning. I wonder when his teeth will grow in. He is 48" long.

Mama and Papa were back in town in time to call to go for supper at the Brass Rail, a rather Yuppyish joint on McKercher and Stillwater. Yuppies must be drinking less coffee. We received fewer refills here than anywhere in town. Peter is not as fascinated with public bathrooms as he used to be. That's Matthew's thing, and Matthew is just a little kid. No sooner do we find a seat and Matthew says, 'Papa, I have to go to the bathroom.' If anyone else but Papa takes him, his urethra goes on strike. No point even trying. Cheryl and I make a show of it, saying, 'Okay Matthew, come with me,' but his answer is emphatic and the same: 'No, Papa take me.' While everyone laughs, Papa pushes away from the table. Matthew leads him faultlessly through the maze of hallways to the bathroom he had seen only once before.

Cheryl got her hair cut, a neat punk-style: short on the sides, long on the back, curling backwards along the top. Her ears have a lovely gloss from the wax sprayed to keep everything just so... punky. In her bright yellow knee-length shorts, I'm not quite sure who she is. What marvelous things, these female humans.

The boys go every weekday morning to their swim lessons. Peter's coach told him his backstroke is the best of what he does. He says he likes the backstroke best. We spent additional time, yesterday from 5:15 to 6:30, back at the pool so Peter can work on

his skills. Matthew is at the pool's edge, standing like a swimmer waiting for the bang of the gun. He calls us, waits until he's sure we're watching, then jumps feet first, keeping the diving stance all the way in.

These days the boys are always yapping. Except when they're together, then they scream.

We watched the Black Stallion last night. Peter enjoyed himself. He said, 'I'm going to have good dreams tonight.' Peter wants Matthew to call it by its proper title, not Black Horsie.

These mornings Matthew calls Cheryl to lie with him. He hugs her tight. But neither can stand being so close. They're both claustrophobic. They last a few minutes face to face, and when I arrive a few minutes later they're lying cheek to cheek facing the ceiling, smiling. This afternoon I went into Matthew's bedroom. He had just wakened from his nap.

'Lie down with me, Daddy?'

'How about if you come into the living room?'

'I want you to lie down with me a little bit, but just one more time, okay?'

'I'm an elephant and I'm going to eat you if you don't get up.'

He jumped from his bed and ran to the door. Looking back, he said, 'Hey, elephant can't eat me up.'

This evening while with Peter, he said he was very happy. He counted the toys beside him to prove it.

Monday, July 15

Last night, Peter slept at Cheryl's parents'. We began the day at church, sitting across the narthex from Mama and Papa. Matthew waved and winked at them the entire service. After coffee at the Cavalier, we changed and headed off to Diefenbaker Lake to see the dam. The boys slept on the way. When Peter woke up, he sat between Mama and Papa and stroked the back of their necks. We listened to music, some zither tape of Papa's, Bob Schneider, and the Academy of St. Martin in the Fields. We passed a pasture with a bloated cow, and further on a farmer examining a car he had flipped in the ditch the night before. At the dam, we followed a path along the stone shore, past the gates for the turbines, and watched as two scuba divers carried their get down to the water. Papa took several snapshots of us, then several of Peter or Matthew, or Cheryl and me standing on a large rock looking at the lake through binoculars. We had coffee at the information center, sat in the small theatre to watch the film *Making the River*, and looked at the displays. Several people were tanning on the beach. We got back in the car, drove across the spillway, passed through Macrorie (I updated my foggy memory of this small town where my mother came from), and returned to the city for a supper of waffles. Cheryl and I planned to take the boys to Kiwanis Park to hear a brass band scheduled to play. Peter was happier being left behind.

Lessons ended, Peter fulfilled the requirements for the Maroon badge, but we've decided to hold off going any further for a couple of years. He was the smallest in his class. Most were in Grade 5 or 6. Matthew had loved his lessons. He was shy with the other kids at first, didn't know what to do with them. After two days he was

playing all sorts of games, mixing it up with everyone. Hokey Pokey, diving/jumping, being a frothing motor-boat. He belonged there as much as anyone else.

Peter and I went to the downtown library by bus. We left at 10, arrived not until 11:15. We talked along the way about the city's newspapers, bus advertisements, the other passengers. We withdrew several books from the Children's Department, then sat on a couch near the periodicals to read Babar, Alec Builds a Sandcastle, George and Martha, Chicken Soup with Rice, along with other titles I've forgotten, until Cheryl arrived with Matthew just after 12. We went to Max's Diner for lunch. The boys do well in restaurants. I got the largest-ever order of onion rings for \$1.50, which Matthew rummaged through looking for the babies. We bought swimming goggles for the boys at Al Anderson's SportCity. I lost Peter's at the pool the previous afternoon. At home I wrote for a couple of hours. We rented two movies, Karate Kid and Pippi Long Stocking, dropped by Renovation World, where Les, Curtis and Gary were sitting together at a desk. A fire at Doug Richardson's house behind us got quite a crowd. We visited briefly with Cheryl's parents, then put the boys to bed.

Wednesday, July 17

Peter is still having nightmares. He wakes up crying, telling us while they're still vivid:

‘I was in a pool and these hands appeared from the side and kept pushing me back... I was walking down our street and when I looked behind I saw I was being followed by men in yellow shirts that said, “Ghost Managers.” They came into the house and filled up my room and stared hard at me. I was leaving a restaurant and went the wrong way. I was in the back and had to climb a fence. When I tried to get back, a whole bunch of guards popped up with knives and swords. But I protect myself. Some parts of my bedroom are good and some are bad. This side is bad, this side is bad, because they can come in the door or up from underneath. My bed is good because I’m safe here with my blanket. I have to rub my blanket with my finger, like this, well really, with my fingernail too. Sometimes I rub the hot spots and sometimes the cool spots here on the edge. I have to be careful not to put holes in it.’

Monday, July 22

Last Wednesday evening, I was surprised by a birthday celebration. I got a propane BBQ to take to the lake this weekend. Mom and Dad were there also. The boys were sitting by the stereo speakers trying to hear the music we had turned way down. My mother began laughing at something. Matthew spoke sharply to her. She is hard of hearing, and it didn't register immediately before realizing he had been speaking to her.

She asked, 'What did he say?

I said, 'I think he said, "Be quiet Hedlin."'

'Be quiet Hedlin,' she said. Then the laughter came and she couldn't stop. When I phoned the next day she was still laughing. Matthew wanted to say something to her.

'Hi Grandma.

Mom said, 'Maybe you could come to visit us.'

Matthew answered, 'I not go to your place. I go to Mama's.'

Mom laughed.

Matthew said to me while holding the phone, 'Great Grandma is still in bed.' Followed by something incomprehensible, then: 'She singing in bed. I go now.'

We ate breakfast at the Cavalier Saturday morning with Cheryl's parents and grandparents. Grandpa sneezed. A bit of food flew across the table. Matthew exclaimed, 'Grandpa spit. Grandpa spit.' Grandpa doesn't get what the fuss is about and smiles at

everyone. Cheryl mentioned that I was writing this journal. Everyone thought it's a great idea.

Stopped at the traffic light the top of the Broadway bridge, windows open, warm air coming through, a truck pulled alongside. Near enough for us to (if we had wanted to) reach out our window and offered to shake the driver's hand. Matthew called out, 'There is a fat man. There is a fat man.'

We drove to Waskesieu on Sunday. On the way up we stopped in Rosthern to visit Diane and Ernie. Diane was resting. Ernie had arrived from church just before we left. They are happy to have company. The Smurfs were on TV but snowed under by bad reception. Over and over Matthew said, 'Fix the Smurfs.'

The boys slept until we were 15 miles from the lake. The weather was cool when we checked in. We went to the Nature Centre. Matthew tried to bat the stuffed pelican off its stand. Peter was repulsed by the slime on the glass of the aquarium. We watched a fifteen-minute slide show about the original Canadian National Parks. Followed by an eight-minute animated film about litterbugs.

Matthew hums O Canada and Mary Had A Little Lamb, going from one to the other, from one pitch to another, from softly to very loudly. Peter, looking sideways to us, said, 'I'm kinda getting sick of that song.'

The sun burned from 11:30 until 6, when it felt suddenly extinguished. We've finally arrived at a state of deep relaxation. The boys spend their best time on the beach, flicking sand with shovels, squatting at the water's edge, sitting ten feet offshore in the dinghy, mingling their honeyed hair, returning to us when they

want a snack or sandwich. When Matthew is reckless and abrupt, Peter gets anxious. He grits his teeth and says, 'Matthew!', even though we tell him to pay no attention. The most trying times are on the breakwater. At the end the water seems depthless and cold. Matthew fights to be at (beyond) the edge.

Peter is impatient with himself. If he doesn't get something right off he goes inert. He is cautious. He doesn't like being in new situations he can't see through to the end. He needs to feel in control. Matthew, by contrast, says what he's going to do and walks off to do it. Calling him gets no answer. We race after to save him from some disaster. Stepping off a wharf into twelve feet of water to get a closer look at the minnows, or just to avoid us.

He is performing a new song:

'Mary had a little lamb, little lamb, little lamb.

Mary had a little lamb.

Her fleece was white as snow, no-bo, bo-bo-be-do.'

Followed by curt bows in every direction. He came up with this version some time ago, we don't know from where.

He is reading a few words written in a list. Go, Step, Matthew, Peter. There's no tricking him.

Wednesday, July 24

‘Waskesieu Weather’ (Cheryl’s term): It has been two days of a cool wind, cloud, and periodic rain. When outside we wear sweaters and rain gear. There were occasional breaks in the cloud today. The sun shone through and we were briefly warm.

Peter and I went hiking along the ‘In The Winds’ trail. Animal prints galore along the shore. We took pictures of each other.

Cheryl and Matthew joined us on the ‘Boundary Bog’ trail. We found six-inch leeches like squirts of tar and Pitcher Plants. Peter brought one home. Later, when Cheryl found the door had been left open, she told him the mosquitoes were coming in. He answered, ‘But Mom, we have a little helper’, a stickleback fish he thinks eats mosquitos. We roasted marshmallows on the BBQ. Matthew preferred eating them cold. We asked why he doesn’t try eating one hot.

‘I’ll hold it then,’ he said. ‘See, it’s getting warm.’

I said, ‘No, use the fork.’

He said, ‘Okay, I’ll burn it, Daddy.’

Though the mosquitoes are thick, it’s the blackflies that do the most damage, large welts. We bought Stingoes to stop the itching.

We visited the library on Montreal Avenue. We all found something to borrow. Having left, we discovered that Matthew had forgotten his car. We turned around to get it.

The boys spent a lot of time at the beach playground. Peter met some kids and played tag. Matthew went down the slide. At the bottom, instead of getting off, going around to the ladder, climbing

up, he insisted on crawling up the slide. Which stopped kids from coming down. Parents looked ready to say something unpleasant.

While Matthew slept and I read Vidal's *Creation* Cheryl and Peter explored the townsite.

Thursday, July 25

We started the day doing laundry. We tramped from store to store, hunting down a supply of quarters. Cheryl and I ordered coffee and the boys iced tea at the Park Café. Matthew went twice to the bathroom, once to 'go pee', once to 'go toilet'. The second time he instructed me to sit on the sink. Then he told me to leave.

'Why?' I asked.

'Go eat your coffee.'

'My coffee's done.'

'Go eat Mommy's coffee.'

But Matthew-in-the-bathroom is no quick affair. So long for so little. He whiles away humming his favourite one-line tunes while I wait, feeling like a hostage. This time I interrupted his thoughts, hoping to create a world beyond all this.

'We're going to the lake when you're finished.'

'To the lake?'

'Yes.'

'With sand on the beach?'

'Yes.'

'And stones?'

'Yes.'

'And wear shorts?'

'Yes.'

He thought, blinked twice, and his voice popped up an octave. 'What a good idea. Let's do it tomorrow.'

His elbows settled on his knees, his head dropped, and he hummed the last bars of O Canada.

We spent two and a half hours on the beach before the clouds swept in, threatening rain. Peter and I dragged the dinghy to the car, let out the air, packed it into the back seat, and returned to the cabin. We drove to PA, visited the Lund Wildlife Exhibit Mall, the Co-op for coffee, and Pizza Hut, before driving to the southeast corner where Dale and Jan Ardell live. While we visited, the boys got acquainted with Kimberly and Kristen. On the way back, we drove along the river front from the sewage plant at one end to the PA Penitentiary. We were in Waskesieu by 10 pm. Peter ran to the toilet. Matthew found a large wasp on the floor. Cheryl sent me to the store for Kleenex. She placed a tissue over the wasp, then Matthew crunched it underfoot. I headed outside with it. Matthew said, 'Don't throw it outside in the Kleenex. It wants to fly.' He cried and hugged Cheryl's leg.

Friday, July 26

The forecast for sun and warmth has been dashed. We kept busy nonetheless. We slept in. The boys woke not completely rested. We attempted a walk along Waskesieu River, but clouds of mosquitoes attacked our scalps and rain came in flurries.

We hurried back to the car, drove to the Nature Centre, and booked Peter on a tour from 2 to 3. He enjoyed being with kids his age. They caught frogs. He met a girl named Cheryl who, ‘was real weird. You know, after everything she said, she would say, “You bet.”’

Cheryl’s parents arrived at 3. We spent time in their room. 110 Lakeview Hotel. Papa walked with Matthew. Peter the secret agent followed close behind, slinking from tree to tree, standing around the corner of the Nature Centre, putting his ear to the door of their hotel room. At one point he knocked and ran away, full-tilt into the family emerging from their room across the hall.

Tenderloin for supper.

We played baseball in the park. The wind and surf were both up. Everyone took turns at the positions. Matthew was Player-Manager. At his turn to bat, whoever pitched tried to judge the best distance for throwing. Between pitches he said, ‘No, I get closer.’ Coming ever nearer, he was a bit terrifying with that heavy aluminum bat on his shoulder. The balls that did reach the outfield were chased down, dived after by Peter. ‘I’m trying to do my best,’ he’d shout. Papa went after balls too, and stepped on them like mice. Matthew ran the bases, his baseball glove clearing the ground by an inch or two.

We visited the Big Olaf Ice-cream shop and sat at a table under an umbrella in frigid wind. Before returning to their room, Cheryl's Mom took pictures of the sunset, then said it was too dark for what she wanted. Cheryl's Dad suggested she use the other camera with the flash. We spotted a deer feeding at the roadside. She positioned herself to take the picture, but hesitated (vacillated, prevaricated, hummed-and-hawed) until the deer wandered into the trees.

The boys were asleep as soon as they lay down.

Carol and Les have had boat trouble. They phoned to say they won't arrive until tomorrow.

Monday, July 29

The weather didn't improve. Even so, we were determined to get Les' boat into the water for skiing and hydro-sliding. The lake churned with whitecaps. We found calmer waters up near the Narrows. Peter got his first-ever boat ride. He also wanted to hydro-slide. We decided it was too cold, raining, windy, rough. I spent two hours in a wet suit. One couldn't have endured for long without something. Colin skied also. Matthew called it 'skating'. He wanted to try. He settled for the swing. Cameron pushed him. Then they teeter-tottered. The others arrived at a designated cookhouse at 4. Hotdogs and hamburgers and more clouds of mosquitoes. Graeme was covered with bites. Curt skied until it was time to go. The boys returned with Papa to the Hotel. They spent the night there. Les and Carol and the boys came to our cabin for more visiting. We drank coffee and chatted until midnight. One by one their boys fell asleep.

Cheryl and I felt the sadness of our last evening.

On Sunday we drove back to the Narrows to retrieve the boat and drive it to Christopher Lake. We spent the afternoon eating a lunch of BBQed smokies and skiing. Peter got in his wish to hydro-slide, had powerful doubts, then went double with me. He lay on my back, clung to my neck.

As the boat started the water boiled in our faces. Peter said, 'I hate this. I want to get back in the boat.' In seconds we had surfaced and were skimming and bumping on the surface. 'I like this now,' he said. As the boat gained speed, the wind buffeted, and we skidded and bounced, his qualms returned. 'I want to get back in the boat,' he said.

Once in the boat he couldn't wait to get back on the hydro-slide. How overwhelmed he must have felt, his first time with a boat, its noise, its speed, the violence of the water. He won't forget it for a while. Matthew sat with Cheryl in the boat and got very worried each time someone went under water. The first time it happened to me, he was nearly in tears. We were done by 5:30, left by 6. We met Cheryl's parents at Frans in Macdowall, checked in on Diane and Ernie in Rosthern, but they weren't home, and reached the house by 9.

Today we ran errands and did chores. Peter raked grass with me. Matthew ran his tractor through one pile. When Peter tried to rake the scattered grass Matthew refused to move. Peter asked him what he thought he was doing. He said he was farming. Then Peter brought Matthew more grass, for a bigger pile.

Cheryl was in the house, organizing, washing the floor, helping me weed the back beds, thinking how better to arrange her flowers come next spring. Soon the boys were chasing insects with nets. Peter caught a dragonfly. Matthew let it go. Peter hid in the beans, watching. He came out chasing something, then circled back and hunkered in the beans for another try. Then we played baseball. Peter squatted behind Matthew at bat to catch, holding his glove as he had seen it done in a Tigers-Royals game, with his elbow sticking out. He broke a thumbnail and it bled. Cheryl had gone to VIM. He wanted to play until she got home. He wanted her to see how well he was doing.

Matthew carried a glove to his trike, slung it on the handlebar, and seated himself. He said, 'I'm going to a game, yup.' He calls us Mudder, Fodder, and Brudder. He plays his own game of Who's-Who?

‘I’m Mama, you’re Peter,’ he tells me.

Tuesday, July 30

Peter is brightest first thing in the morning. He lies awake, thinking thoughts, then explaining them to whoever is first into his room. This morning while Cheryl and Matthew lay together in bed, Peter sat with me in the living-room.

He said, 'Are you worried about the bear?'

'A little.'

'You aren't, you know, supposed to be worried about tomorrow.'

'Oh?'

'Yeah. Kenny Grambo sings it in his songs.'

'What does he sing?'

'He's a minister. He says God will take care of tomorrow. So you don't need to worry.'

I laughed.

'It's true, Dad.'

His eyes are deep brown. He smiles. His new front teeth are very short.

Cheryl, with Matthew, asked if he was ready to get up.

'Mmm, not yet.'

A little later, 'Are you ready to get up?'

'Mmm, not yet.'

A little later, 'Are you ready yet?'

'Mmm. Okay. Where are we going?'

Matthew: 'I'm going on the kite.'

Peter: 'You can't fly on the kite.'

Matthew: 'I going fly n' the kite.'

Peter: 'It's not like an airplane. You can't fly on it.'

Matthew: 'Okay. I fly on the airplane. You want to come with me Peter?'

Matthew, in the bathroom: 'I do it myself. Would you turn on the light and ge-owa here.'

My family is celebrating birthdays. Matthew's Cheryl and my own birthday are a couple of days apart. Everyone is getting together at Mom and Dad's. Matthew and Cheryl, Carol, Les and the four boys, Cheryl, Matthew and Peter. We spent the first part of the evening in the back yard. The boys went crazy with an air-filled chair. They kicked it around and around the yard. The adults conversed on the patio. Diane phoned. By that time it was dark. We went indoors. We passed our Waskesieu photos around. The boys had made a mess of the bedrooms by the time it came to leave.

Wednesday, July 31

We were invited to a BBQ at Grandma Skarsgard's to see Peter and Paul Skarsgard. Pots of food, gallons of ice-cream. Matthew and Peter played with Michael, Bradley, and Kristen until they were sweated to the tips of their hair. Matthew didn't want to sit to eat. He wanted to run in for a bite and run off. I was holding his hamburger.

I took him on my knee. 'Matthew,' I whispered.

'What?' he whispered back.

'I have something special for you.'

He leaned back and put his mouth directly to my ear. 'Daddy, want to know something?'

'What?'

'I don't want anything special.'

He slipped off my knee and away.

When the time came, Peter didn't want to leave. Matthew has been very thirsty, and coming to us for drinks all evening. Now he's between a rock and a hard place. He has to go so badly to the bathroom he can't stand still, but he must because he is on his third straight glass of orange juice.

Saturday, August 3

We are on our third day at the farm. Our big job is painting the barn. Red.

‘So red,’ said Peter, who was on the scaffolding left of the front doors, ‘I could just kiss it.’

We painted straight through from Thursday evening to Saturday at 5. A heavy rain interrupted us with less than a half hour of work left.

A bear has been seen recently. The boys coming and going is an issue. We have tried to keep Matthew where we can see him. Being on the scaffolds makes that difficult. At one point he raced towards the house. I called after him, reminding him of the bear.

He stopped halfway to the house. ‘Where is it?’

‘In the woods,’ I answered, waving at the general direction.

‘Let’s go get him.’ He was already running the way I was pointing.

The bear is real. Papa has taken pictures of one prowling around the grain bins and by the cabin window. It has torn the screen so badly it can’t be repaired. Peter wanted to bring his pop gun. As a precaution we spent \$12 on batteries for Peter’s tape-recorder to play music while we painted.

Peter wanted very badly to help paint. I thought he had had enough experience with a brush when he helped me stain. The heat was also an issue. We tried to occupy him with other things. Driving the lawn-tractor, playing with Matthew in the sand by the playhouse or inside the barn on the McCormick Farmall tractor,

even being up on the scaffolding or the ladder helping us scrape. The first time up he waved his arms and said, 'See, I'm not scared up here. In fact, I love it up here.' Too many arguments against arming him with a brush: wasps were a bother, the sun was hot, and Peter reacts to the heat almost allergically, it was too near finishing time in the day or on the job, too many people already crowding the limited room on the planks. All along it seemed that there was so much to do, we might find the perfect moment to give him a brush. Meanwhile, when he's not with Matthew, he hangs around. At one point he knelt by a can of paint and said, 'Ooh, that is such a bloody red.'

A significant difference between the boys is this: Peter asks questions in long sequences and Matthew says things straight out. They use the same number of words in a day. With Peter you have long conversations. With Matthew you laugh. For example:

Peter asked, 'Do you think the bear will be in the woods when we're at the farm?'

I said, 'It could be.'

'How do you know?'

It has been there several times when Mama and Papa were up earlier.'

'Will it be dangerous?'

'Not usually. Remember the bear film?'

'Oh yeah, like where the guy got his head ripped open like this, and another guy down the back.' He traced the extent of the damage to head and torso.

‘That bear had been spoiled or teased.’

‘And the bear at the farm isn’t spoiled?’

‘I don’t think so.’

Matthew said, ‘Let’s find the bear and fight it.’

‘No Matthew. The bear is very strong. You can’t fight it.’

‘Okay, let’s ride the motorcycle.’

‘I’ve got to work.’

‘You’ve got to work. I’ve got to work too.’ He took hold of my hand. ‘C’mon, let’s go work.’

‘Are you going to help me paint?’

‘Ya, I’m a painter. I go back to the house. I need my gwubs.’

‘No, Matthew, you don’t need your gloves. You come with me now.’

‘Nooo. I get my gwubs.’

While I painted, Cheryl cut the grass. Mom and Dad are heading up. The barn looks almost new. We worked until 9:30 Thursday night. It was dark by then. Tonight wasn’t so late. Cheryl’s parents must be satisfied. Everything they have aimed for has happened. Including a half-inch of rain. Once it started, we raced around getting everything closed up and put away. Back at the house I saw Matthew on the lawn halfway to the barn, soaking in the fat drops of water.

‘Matthew,’ I called. ‘Come to the house. Get out of the rain.’

‘Nooo.’ He then bent down, made himself a ball, as if to be smaller. ‘I go to the barn with Papa.’ Even his voice sounds squeezed into a ball.

‘Come out of the rain.’ I used my firmest voice.

He grinned as I approached him. He ran, backwards, grinning. Later he was still outside, standing in the steady drizzle with his hands and plastic diving-man in a basin of soapy water.

The rain quit before supper was finished. I snapped some pictures of us playing baseball. Peter used the aluminum bat. I pitched. With Matthew leaning against my leg, my throwing motion went the added distance around his body. Though Peter had some trouble wielding the bat, when he did make contact, it flew into the bush. Matthew set off. ‘I get it!’ He’d stop at the edge of the grass and reach, lean, kneel, and say, ‘I can’t see it. It’s in the bush.’ I joined him, plucked it out of the grass and tossed it to him. He’d wait until I reached the pitcher’s ‘mound’, then throw. Too far away, for sure. But he relied on the sloping ground for some help. Peter, meanwhile, stands patiently with his bat. Once when Papa was pitching and Peter was catching, the ball struck Peter on the chin.

I laughed and said, ‘Good thing you have a chest pad.’

‘Ha,’ said Peter, with a grin. ‘I need a good chin pad.’

‘I’m so sorry, Peter,’ said Papa.

‘Oh, that’s all right, Papa. I’ll forgive you for everything.’

It came Matthew’s turn to bat. This puts a lot of pressure on the pitcher. One must aim at the bat during its swing. If the bat

and ball don't meet, Matthew brings the bat to the ground like a club and the abuse begins. 'You missed it,' he'd say. And, 'C'mon Papa, hit it.' Then, 'You missed it again.' And then, 'Ooh, Papa, you missed it again.'

When contact was made, and the ball was sent towards the pitcher, Matthew said, 'I hit it, Papa.'

'You sure did, Matthew.'

'Yup.'

Then a lengthy series of misses. And Matthew begins creeping nearer the pitcher. 'I stand close, awright Papa?' Over a course of ten pitches, the infield will have moved 15 feet nearer to the outfield.

The day finished with a motorcycle ride for both boys. They were washed from head to toe and put to bed. Almost. Three whitetail deer bounded across the canola field, their white rumps flashing in the dark. The bear is now a mythical presence. It's the bear that caused the deer to bolt. It is the bear they hear cracking in the bush.

Thursday, August 8

Michael and Cathy are in town for a four-day weekend. Michael's haircut is a lot like Moe's of the Three Stooges.

Since returning from the farm, the boys have done a lot of screeching and wrestling. We send them outdoors, and suddenly they're aimless and come back in. They both spot the one toy they both must have, and the noise starts up again. Matthew will bolt out of Peter's bedroom, his hands clasped tight to his chest, heading to the sofa, lying on his back, his feet poised to kick.

Peter is bothered by the heat. He turns red and lethargic. When it's cool, he's bright and active. Matthew isn't affected so much.

Yesterday Matthew found a crab from the tree in the back yard. He bit into it, chewed awhile, then came to where I was sitting with the pulp between his lips. He spit it into my hand. He said, 'Yucky. I don't like sour beans.'

Peter goes around wearing a hiking pack. It's filled with who-knows-what, playing who-knows-what with Erin next door. He kept busy for a while with a plastic hatchet, breaking open a weed stem to get at the vascular pith. At other times, he has been busy refining his Lego spaceship.

Cheryl took Peter shopping for runners. They stopped at Burton's. Peter was mildly disturbed with the several pair of girl's shoes the salesman wanted Peter to try. The final purchase was a white shoe with both laces and Velcro straps.

I mowed. Matthew helped me rake the grass. He gathered it up from the piles and threw it into the garbage. A bit more focused than before, when he threw it everywhere but. Matthew conducts a

test of wills. No matter how many times he's been told no, the next time is like the first. He wanted to play outside in the rain. I said no. He answered, 'Yes I am,' as matter-of-factly as if I'd just asked if he would please play in the rain. Peter answers with reason. Matthew at this stage requires an unflinching firmness.

Both boys have interesting teeth. Matthew still shows the injury he sustained a year and a half ago when he stumbled against the base of Peter's bed and drove one tooth back into the gum. It is now an 1/8th inch shorter than the other and slightly turned. Peter is still growing his two permanent teeth. One eye tooth is being pushed at from underneath and points out of line with the others. He'll get some work done this fall.

Wednesday, August 28

Our last day of summer holidays. We've had our fill of visiting. Peter and Louise spent Sunday night here on their return from Ontario. They arrived late, visited long into the evening. They were relaxed, in no hurry, as were we. We had an early supper of BBQ sausage, corn on the cob, and garden vegetables. The boys played heartily with Usine and Omeasoo. Peter and Usine chased around with guns, inside the house, outside over the fences. Matthew and Omeasoo were turtles in the living room. Plans were made to visit them in Meadow Lake sometime before November.

I spent five days working on the Toyota at a fix-it-yourself bodyshop on 17th Street W. Removing rust, applying body molding, sanding, prepping for painting. This last task was done by the young proprietor. He did the entire thing inside the close space without a mask. A fog of paint. We replaced the seat-covers and side molding. The car looks almost new.

On top of staining the house, painting the barn, swimming lessons, a rental VCR, hours of biking and walking, two trips to Waskesieu, waterskiing, story writing, books and books of reading, having company, being company, the yard and garden, organizing the house upstairs and in the basement, it has been as full a summer as one can imagine. Next year we plan to travel through the Canadian and American west, as far as the coast, renting a car and camper. Vancouver is celebrating Expo '86. Mom and Dad are also planning to go. Dad has meetings in late June, and may add holidays.

We were at Robin's Donuts. Matthew was in my lap.

Papa asked him, 'Matthew, would you like me to hold you?'

Matthew was quiet for a moment and said, 'Peter would like it.'

On the toilet, Matthew pees, waits, then squirmed off. I thought he was being too hasty and put him back.

'Matthew, go to the toilet.'

He sat quietly, then said, 'I thought I was done.' Then another brief pause. 'Yea, I done.'

Peter has resumed cello practicing. I've joined Cheryl. She works on his pieces, I work on his sight-reading. His new music stand has heightened his enthusiasm. He shows it to everyone. 'I just love the cello,' he says. 'I could play for hours.' His sound is awfully good, especially Two Grenadiers. He sways as he plays.

The boys were in the front yard, wrestling and screaming. Peter more loudly, more physically. He slam-tackles his brother, inciting him to scream. He carries him on his back, lifts him on impulse, swings him until he's dizzy. They ride their bike and trike together around the block, fire their guns, and so on. Partly, this is Peter on edge, excited about seeing his friends again. Danielle was over after being away. Like long lost lovers, they held hands, played in the hallway and basement. Each said to the other, several times, 'You're my best friend.'

All of Christopher is getting its road repaired. The trucks have been thundering back and forth for over two weeks beginning at 7:30 am. The boys have to be closely watched.

They slept until nearly 9 most mornings.

Cheryl contacted Bev Giesbrecht last night about coming over Thursday and Friday. She has missed the boys. Matthew is no

longer calling her 'Bebeck.' But he is adding accessories to his comments, 'Though', 'In fact.'

Michael and Cathy were back, Michael for ten days for a field seminar, Cathy until the end of the weekend, before seeing her mother in Edmonton.

Sunday, September 1

We attended Hartley and Margaret's 35th anniversary. After, we drove to Woodlawn Cemetery to view Grandma's grave. We couldn't find it. The effort fuelled an argument between the boys.

Matthew said, 'Where is Grandma?'

Peter said, 'She's dead.'

'She's not dead.'

'She is so dead.'

'Grandma's not dead. She's standing on her feet.'

They must have been talking about different Great-Grandmas.

Sunday, September 15

The fall schedule is up and running. Peter goes to cello twice a week, gym twice a week, for two hours each time, choir and Pioneers on Wednesday. If anything, he's happier than ever. His body is developing. He puts an arm out and gives the muscles a surreptitious glance. He wrestles with Matthew and the other kids around us. School seems easy. He's in a small reading group, and 'science is a cinch.' He's wise to us, gives sarcastic retorts to much of what we say: 'Oh come on,' and 'Yeah, really.' He's growing out of his clothes. His eating is robust. He's always on the move. But he won't turn down being held, petted. When either Cheryl or I sit beside him on the sofa, he remains leaning forward until an arm goes around him. He prays each night, like a machine-gun: 'God bless tat-a-tat-a-tat and forgive the sins I've committed.' First thing he does after getting out of bed is come to our bathroom, spray down his hair, push it behind his ears. At breakfast he looks nearly drowned.

Matthew too is happy, even tempered, mostly reasonable. Presented the right way, he can be made to see some value in what we tell him. Often he settles for one simple explanation. He wants to 'go to schoo-a just like Peter.' He wants belted pants, like me. His thoughts come more clearly and complete. Above all, he is funny. He rolls his eyes for effect, sings all the time, his private thoughts turned into lyrics to the tune of O Canada. Some lyrics are quite simple:

Car car car-car,

Car car car car car...'

He attend his first Sunday School class (his first real structured experience), colored intensively, and made a big deal of leaving: 'Bye teacher!!' Loves getting onto the cello after Peter is done.

Peter instructs Matthew, is protective, generous, gentle. Matthew in turn mimics and dotes.

Saturday, October 20

Repeated threats of snow, but otherwise the days are sunny and warm. Last year we had drifting snow, cars stranded in the middle of roads, 30 below, high winds. This year we are outside a lot, walking in the evening, sitting on the front step, riding bikes. The grass may need to be cut.

Both boys continue happy and busy. When Peter is not at school, gym or cello, he carries around his baseball glove and books. He is finished Suzuki Book II. He'll spend the week reviewing all the songs, play them for a certificate, and begin Book III. The beginning of practice is a bit of a chore, but he quickly forgets why he was resisting and becomes as engrossed as in anything else he enjoys doing. He has a new chair. It doesn't fold. Matthew climbs onto it to practice. I'm A Little Monkey and other Top-of-the-Chart hits. Matthew sits in the living-room with his pile of well-used toys, humming to himself.

He lost an incisor today. Knocked it out with his baseball glove. This one was a surprise. Other teeth are looser. He makes sucking, slurping sounds through the new hole. Conversations with him are involved, long, interesting. He wonders many things about what's on the news, but mostly about things beyond us all: I should read up more on the universe and God, whether he is all-seeing, and if so, does he watch it on TV. The same boy has an intensifying blanket dependency.

Matthew wants 'fat books' read to him, which means real stories. He interrupts, saying, 'Let me read,' and proceeds to sort of do so: 'Once upon a time...' We had received a postcard from Cheryl's parents. The stamp was of a lighthouse, smudged with

ink. Matthew read, 'Once upon a time there was a shadow on a beach.'

Both boys dressed for the Halloween party at Suzuki group lessons. Matthew as a clown, Peter as a spaceman. They performed for 45 minutes, teachers included, and had cookies and juice. Matthew followed one costume wherever it went. 'Nook nook, Mom, at that spaceman.' It was a robot with blinking lights on the forehead. Matthew gets himself in the middle of groups of kids. He is outgoing, fearless, confident, will say anything to anyone. 'You're cute,' a girl told him. 'I know,' he answered. Each night we prepare Matthew for bed.

'Do you want anything?'

'No.'

We tuck him in and settle ourselves in the living room.

'I want milk,' he calls.

Cheryl has a much more accommodating teaching schedule, vastly improved over the four months of full time last spring. She has hastened to fill her 'empty' hours with Norwegian class, cake decorating, Sunday school teaching, etc.

In my second year of teaching High School, with all the new classes to prep, assignments, exams, papers to grade, meetings to attend, extra-curricular duties, I'm managing just to live.

We're cashing in investments with Principal Consultants after hearing the firm is on shaky grounds. Several bomb scares in the city. The police say it's conflict between rival gangs. The Blue Jays lost to Kansas City in the 7th game of the League Championship.

We'll probably buy a VCR. I put two new tires on the Corona. We sold the Mazda about the same time I had the Corona painted. Matthew thinks we pulled a switcheroo, and the Corona is actually the Mazda painted over.

We're going to the early service tomorrow. Matthew's cherub choir is performing for the first time.

Matthew follows Peter everywhere, copies what he says, what he wears, when he changes. 'I want a muscle shirt just like Peter!' he tells us.

Bebeck is now just Giesbrecht.

Sunday, October 27

The Cherub Choir conductor, Susan Grosse, had a hard time riding herd for the 20 minutes of the service before the performance. Sitting together the kids were noisy and mischievous. The boys lined up the hymn books along the front rail, were in and out of their seats, and shushed, each separately and all together how many times. When they did make it to the front, they didn't pay much attention to Susan. They turned their backs to her, sang or not. Matthew flipped through the pages of a hymnal, and now and then looked in Susan's direction to catch up on where she was in the song. 'He-he-he-he-he loves me. Ho-ho-ho-ho-hosanna,' to the tune of There was a Maiden Singing.

It was 15 degrees today. We played baseball twice. Once in Papa's back yard, once in the Lion's Park ball field behind Holy Cross school. Papa behind the plate, both boys taking their turn at the bat, me pitching. Then a plane flies overhead and the boys stop to watch. Matthew needs to go to the bathroom. They fight over who gets to bat next. All the things the pros do before stepping to the plate to bat, adjusting the cap, practice swinging the bat, planting the feet, Peter does before every pitch.

I stayed with Matthew while he slept. Cheryl went with Peter and her parents to a Parade of Homes. When Matthew woke he wrestled me, then he rode me horseback. 'Are you thirsty, horse?' he asked. I nodded yes. He milked me like a cow and put the bowl at my nose.

Peter has lost his second incisor. He had been fiddling with it this morning. I biffed his elbow. He showed mild shock, gave a

twist, and presented the tooth. Very funny. Lots of black when he grins.

Matthew stood up in the car while it was moving.

Cheryl turned and said, 'Sit down, Matthew. Do up your seatbelt.'

'You have a choice, Mom,' he begins, but gets no further before finding himself seated and buckled.

Sunday, November 3

Both boys went Halloween-ing for an hour last Thursday. The weather was scarcely below freezing. They'd yell Halloween Apples at the door. Matthew kicked his bag as he walked. He hesitated saying thanking for the candy until the door was already closed.

At one door, someone said, 'Is this a space monster?'

Matthew said, 'I a clown monster.'

At another door, he was told, 'My that's a sharp outfit.'

'Yeah,' Matthew answered. 'I a sharp clown.'

After church we ate dinner at the Cavalier, then started out for North Battleford. The snow started flying when we reached Borden, so we turned back. We had coffee at a barren little place called Shanty's on Idylwyld. Cheryl's Mom left the entire piecrust. Once home, Peter and Matthew conflicted over a black purse with three clasps. Matthew saw Peter with it, and wanted it himself. He followed Peter into his room. That's when the trouble began.

We all watched a nature show on Channel 2. When a Ganges crocodile was being force fed by a team of conservationists, I groaned.

'What's the matter, Dad?' Peter said. 'That's life.'

Matthew has a conflicted relationship with propriety. He argues to get his way, telling us firmly, 'That's my choice,' then apologizes if he feels he has said the wrong thing. 'I sorry,' he says, even for making embarrassing noises.

He is not out of the stage of wanting to be held. He got out of bed last night at 9 and joined us while we watched The Falcon and the Snowman, and ate most of our popcorn, with lots of questions and comments spoken with a full mouth.

Saturday November 16

Diane just had twin girls, Larissa and Loreena. I can't tell them apart. Others say they can. Tests are being done to determine if they're identical. Diane and Ernie are very happy. Peter was excited about them, and pushed us to see them. While stroking the head of one, he said 'I wish I had two baby sisters like this.' Mom will live with Diane until the 23rd.

Peter performed the best handstands yet at gym. He kicks up, holds himself tight, receives a touch from his coach on the back of his legs, then lowers his feet. Over and over. His muscles are more defined. One can see this translate into self-assurance. Matthew does handstands too. He forms a bridge, his legs are grasped and held vertical. For the grand finale he pulls his hands away.

Peter's first report card. He is praised for leadership and effort, 'But he does need to set a goal of an improved quality of response.' Peter turns his palms upward and says, 'I'm not quite sure what that means.'

Though the temperature is around 0, snow is falling. I had walked to school on Friday wearing tennis shoes. One can barely see Haley's Comet in the south.

Cheryl has been on the floor putting together tomorrow's Sunday School lesson. That done, she is on her back, a foot up, stretching. It is 9:30 and Matthew is giving us a regular hard time from his bed. 'I want popcorn?'

Monday, December 2

Three weeks until the start of Christmas holidays.

Peter has reached the middle of a reading competition. He sits second having read 78 books. He'll settle for nothing but first place.

I tried counseling him. 'A good thing to get from this contest is better reading.'

'Yeah,' he answered, 'and beating Chad.'

It's the same in gym. He is intent on getting perfect form for head stands, handstands, from raising one foot, the second, holding the line, then lowering one foot, then the other. All his routines show big improvement over last year, last month.

Matthew prays before going to sleep: 'I say prayers first. Then you say them. Thanks for Mommy and Daddy. Thanks for teachers. Thanks for Peter my brudder. Thanks for Mama and Papa. Thanks for Grandma. God. Amen.'

Peter asked me to 'lie with' him. (As Matthew would put it, 'Just for a little bit.') I told him we would sleep together in the holidays. From the dark room he said, 'Yeah, okay!'

Our most fruitful time with the boys comes when we have one each. I'm not sure why Matthew complains every time Peter leaves the house, because he complains worse when Peter stays.

I was shaving Sunday morning.

Matthew came in and said, 'Daddy, Peter is hitting me.'

Shortly, Peter came in and said, 'Dad, Matthew took those books from me.'

Then I noticed three small books in Matthew's hand.

'Who had them first?' I asked.

Peter said, 'I did, but I left them on the table when I went into the living room for a second. Matthew grabbed them and ran.'

When do parents step aside and let the kids fight these things out on their own?

Monday, December 30

Holidays are half done. The Christmas tree is turning brown. The umbrella plant will have to be given its place back in the sunlight before it loses even more leaves. Lloyd left today after a week's visit. Michael and Cathy leave by train tomorrow. It will be quiet again.

Christmas Eve was the standard fare. Peter played March in D and sang Old Toy Trains with Matthew (who swung his arms back and forth through all the verses).

The boys are already thoroughly engaged with their new toys. Peter is madly building with his Fisher-Price Construx and preparing coloured pictures for several people with his 60 new pencil crayons. He adds expressions of love and long rows of Xs and Os. He got a stamp album from Mom and Dad. He goes everywhere with an Ever-Sharp clipped to his shirt collar.

Matthew has added to his lineup of cars a Fisher-Price racing car that comes apart with a wrench that doubles as a spoiler. He tackles Peter from behind, or catches a leg while Peter is stepping over, and they tumble together, laughing, the noise growing, and then suddenly they're sitting in separate rooms, quiet.

Bedtime is still sometimes like a high-level summit. Peter needs his fluorescent cross visible, stuck to his chest of drawers. Someone asks for a drink, a tape, asks to 'sleep with me a little bit.' Matthew is done with diapers, but we'll finish off the rest of our supply before he begins sleeping in underwear.

Michael and I played some racquetball this morning. The boys took care of Cheryl. She is expecting.

The weather has been kind, with light winds, and moderate to balmy temperatures. The sidewalks are covered with clear ice after a week of melting snow.

Cathy and Michael took Peter to 101 Dalmatians last night. They enjoyed themselves as much as Peter did. Afterwards he had questioned them about all sorts of things, including military defense and cancer. Michael said, 'Compared to him, I was just a blank-headed kid.' This afternoon we visited with Diane and Ernie, their girls, Lee Fredeen, Arthur, Hartley, Margaret, Shirley, in fact everyone but Matthew, Cheryl and Rae-Anna, who visited her father in Wakaw.

Matthew lifts his chin and asks Cheryl if she'd like to 'rub his soft'. He sits on Cheryl's lap with his whole arm down the front of her blouse. He still likes being fed, slowly.

New Year's Eve at Mrs Gyorgy's was cancelled. She has had a bout of flu. Instead we're gathering at Ardell's at 5 January 1. Cheryl's Grandparents are finding things harder. Slow, having to sit, more dependent, arthritis, a cracked rib, etc.

It's been a year since Grandma Hedlin died.

1986

Thursday, January 1

The boy performed lots this season. Since playing at the Centennial, Peter played at school and for both families. Matthew did not play for school, but he did play Twinkle (beautifully) at Christmas Eve and when my family visited Sunday, December 28. He is mindful when he plays, takes care with his fingers and bow, exactly as he's been taught, deliberately, with about as much tone as can be gotten from an instrument that small.

Erik cut his first tooth. We found it last night (New Year's Eve) at Mrs Gyorgy's. In spite of the pain, he has been very manageable. The only complaining happens when he needs changing, feeding or sleep.

Thursday, January 9

The temperature gets to plus-2. Grass everywhere. And ice. I've been back to school. Cheryl spent the week at home with the flu. Now she's pregnant, we're being extra careful. When we finally told Peter about the new baby, he didn't believe it. After thinking bit, he asked, 'Dad, when did you fertilize it?'

We ate supper at Venice House. Peter pretended he was smoking a cigarette made of chocolate. The waitress asked, 'What do you have there?' she asked. He didn't answer. He tapped the ash, set it against his fork, moved his head to the music of the sound system. It's hard to tell if her biggest first impression was of a cigarette being consumed in a non-smoking section or a cigarette being consumed by a seven-year-old.

Monday, January 13

Snow is just about gone. Temperature tomorrow is forecast for 8+.

Peter attended Erin's birthday party yesterday. They went water-sliding at the Travelodge. By the time we arrived, he was too busy to notice. He finally did see us, he waved, grinned, then went under the water. Matthew stood against the glass partition and watched his every move.

The word is pretty much everywhere that Cheryl is expecting.

The boys continue with the request that they sleep together. We gave it a shot. At first it worked, then it didn't. Matthew was waking up with sore legs, waking Peter up. Which finishes off the rest of the night. Each passing day they became more tired. Breaking them up was hard. They actually wept.

Matthew wants someone to sleep with him. 'At least, say prayers,' he asks. When I do say prayers, he criticizes. 'You didn't say Grandma. You didn't say Auntie [whoever]...'

The wind wrenched the Toyota door from my hand and sprung the hinges. It opens and closes now with a bang.

Bev Giesbrecht has to leave us. Her mother needs full time help. Her daughter is in town for the mean time. Bev's last day is Monday. Cheryl has arranged with Maureen to share sitters.

Thursday, January 30

Peter has spent the last two evenings constructing a model of the Space Shuttle. We bought it at a hobby store on Broadway for \$21.95. He dripped glue onto the kitchen tablecloth. Matthew sits with us and talks while he watches.

The Challenger Space Shuttle blew up two days ago, 14 km after launching. As upset as Peter had been after watching the televised event, by Wednesday morning he was saying that more than ever he wanted to be an astronaut.

While sitting with Matthew before he went to sleep, he said, 'You be Papa. Mommy be Mama. And I be...a lamp. No, I be...a hammer, and do like this.'

He got onto his knees and drove his forehead into the blankets.

'And Peter be...a thing.'

After getting him back under the blankets, he said, 'Mommy be mad at me. I was playing with the black tape recorder and Mommy yelled.'

He wears his blue flat cap with a chickadee on the front to bed. When he gets up to go to the bathroom he closes the door, then it opens a few inches and his head is plainly in view, watching us. A real spy.

Back in bed, he calls, 'Come and find me, doink.'

'What's in the bed?' we ask.

'A lump, doink,' says a voice.

He treats 'doink' like a real word. We don't know what part of speech it plays. When we are leaving, he stands by the front door and ushers us out with his hand. Bye, bye, beep beep,' he says.

Peter says it's time we got him handgrips for the high bar.

Wednesday, February 19

The boys have headed off to choir and Pioneers. They're busy but seem not to notice.

Cheryl is in her 4th month. Pale, somewhat disconsolate, hoping to be feeling a lot better before labour begins. The boys raise the subject of a baby now and then. Peter wonders how Matthew will adjust.

'About the same as you did,' I tell him. 'It was hard at first.'

'I guess I know why,' he says. He doesn't explain himself.

Matthew thinks every day that this is the day the baby will come. He is suggesting names. Today it's John. He is concerned about how Cheryl. 'Are you feeling better?' he asks. 'Mom had something stuck in her throat,' he tells me.

Peter finished first in his class in a reading contest. 200 books since October. He likes school. He prefers to walk home alone. He wears a shapeless toque that pulls down in a mask (though he never does), a neck warmer, and grubby-white boots. We've let him stay for lunch a few times. He gets almost as excited by that as sleeping with Matthew. His latest accomplishments are Boccherini's Minuet, backflips and high bars. The Shuttle is still being built, but slowly. We haven't touched it in two weeks. I'm too tired, playing floor hockey at school, racquetball, and walking both ways to school.

Matthew's language is changing. He says, 'Where is that crazy ball?' and 'That's gross,' and 'Peter's bugging me,' and 'Come see your gauchies, Daddy. I threw them. They're hanging up (on the knob of our chest of drawers).

He dresses himself. His long johns go on backwards.

He sings, 'I am a pomputer man. I can do anything you can' while his arms do breakdancing motions. He has combed his hair to hide his eyes.

Sunday, February 23

After a spate of cold weather, it has warmed to minus-8. We went tobogganing yesterday at Diefenbaker Park. The boys laughed all the way down, and harder at the bottom. Peter ran ahead up the hill, counting his steps. I pull the toboggan with Matthew hanging on, until he lets go, lies awhile, then is up, running awkwardly in his snowpants, his toque covering his eyes, until he catches up to my hand and we walk together. They like it best when we hit a bump that sends the whole toboggan into the air.

Sunday morning: The boys eat, dress, and Matthew hurries into the kitchen with Cyclone in hand, Peter on his heels.

To Matthew he says, 'Give that back!' To me he says, 'Dad, Matthew stole my Masters of the Universe.'

I ask, 'Where are Matthew's?'

'Here.' Peter holds out Stinker and Whiplash.'

I ask Peter, 'So you give Matthew the toys you don't like?'

'No,' says Peter. 'They're the bad ones. Matthew likes them.'

Matthew is clutching Cyclone, saying nothing.

I get a big idea and take Peter aside. 'I know what. Pretend you love Stinker and Whiplash. Matthew will soon change his mind.'

Getting the logic right away Peter turns to Matthew and says, 'Oh good, Matthew. I get to play with Stinker and Whiplash.'

'Hooray,' says Matthew. He runs out of the kitchen with Cyclone.

Peter looks at Stinker and Whiplash, then in the direction Matthew has gone, then at me, and with very little enthusiasm says, 'Do you think it will work?'

Peter performed round-off handsprings for the first time yesterday. After each time, he pushes his hair behind his ears.

Monday, February 24

We watched *Anne of Green Gables* with Megan Follows as Anne. Cheryl sat on the sofa. I sat on the floor, leaning against the sofa. Matthew lay across my legs. Peter sat beside me. It was peaceful until Peter pinched Matthew's bare bottom, which made Matthew laugh. Anne didn't stay on for long.

Matthew must have a half-filled cup of water on his dresser next to the night light. Peter slurps his water because he thinks it's funny. Then they're in bed. Matthew with a toy, Peter hunkered down behind a wall of blankets and stuffed toys he has arranged. We gave him our alarm-radio. It wakes him up at 7:30. He dresses and makes his bed.

Cheryl and I are back to our shared routines with Peter's cello. She has never left off. I'm just getting back to helping him sight-read. Then Matthew takes over.

The weather is warm. The beds at the front are mud.

Matthew will go to gymnastics with Shauna Bingham and Jessie the babysitter tomorrow.

Mom and Dad had their carpet pulled up while we visited. The boys helped getting up the staples and rolling the carpet. Brother Matthew was also there. Through the entire process, nothing could be said to my brother without Matthew saying, 'Are you talking to me?'

'Would you lift the rug and set it against the wall, Matthew?'

'Are you talking to me?'

Peter worked until the sweat came.

I've started standing on my head in the morning, yoga fashion.
It helps the blood flow in the right direction.

Sunday, March 2

Both boys have been sick since Tuesday. Cough, high fever, vomiting. They're a bit cheerier today, though Peter is still in his pajamas with a flushed face. Matthew fell out of bed during his afternoon nap. They're sitting with Cheryl going back and forth between a Peter, Paul and Mary special on channel 2 and Telemiracle 10 on channel 9. Cheryl went to Sunday School and I stayed home and read to both boys. We're all feeling cooped up, wanting to be outside in the fresh air. Perhaps running to the video store to pick up a film for my Grade Elevens will do.

The streets are full of water, the sidewalks are dry, only remnants of snow left where the piles were highest. We're concerned about sudden deep drops in temperature killing our plants and trees.

Matthew was at loose ends. He unwound two music cassettes and smeared Vaseline in his bedroom.

I'm reading Peter Susan Cooper's *The Dark is Rising*. He's crazy about any story with supernatural powers and mystical creatures. He is still skittish when violence is brought in. He refuses to touch Lloyd Alexander since getting spooked by the *Cauldron Born* as a 3-year-old.

Matthew explained why we call some colds flu. 'It's because the virus comes.' He opens his mouth and points a finger inside. 'And flies in. That's flu.' He nods.

The babysitter is working out all right. Her smoking is a bit of a bother. She brings the stale air in with her. The boys say she

smokes all the time. Peter said he hears bubbling in her breathing. I wonder if she realizes she's being so closely watched.

How soon will it be when the boys don't want to sit with us, hold our hands, embrace us, speak affectionately?

Ferdinand Marcos is out in the Philippines. Corazon Aquino has taken his place. The PM of Sweden was assassinated Friday night while walking home from the theatre.

The sunlight is too bright for us to stay inside and leave it for everyone else.

Tuesday, March 11

Matthew was crying this evening. First, Cheryl called Peter Matthew. Then Matthew discovered that his bed was still unmade.

The boys like to be drilled on skills, Peter on adding and spelling, Matthew on number recognition. He says, '6 has a handle on top.' We say words for Peter to spell: man eater, man kisses, eyeball sucker, number cruncher, glass smasher, bum kicker, worm sniffer.

Peter wants to read to Matthew, though Matthew gets distracted by whatever he has on his own lap.

'Matthew, I want you to listen.'

'I listening.'

When Matthew continues with the thing in his lap, Peter sighs.

Peter is feeling much better this week. He is happiest when he is busy and with friends.

Cheryl went for her 5-month checkup. She got a good report. Her weight gain is on target. She has only a mild cold.

I will pick up Peter's new bike tomorrow. It is a red L'il Bighorn Raleigh mountain bike with hand brakes. Can we keep this \$160 thing a secret? Not if he reads this.

Matthew is rather confused about the baby.

He said, 'The baby will come in a week.'

I asked, 'Where is it now?'

He said, 'At Carol's with baby Gram and Mark and Colin and Uncle Les.'

Friday, March 14

Just as the snow is finishing up, Cheryl's parents are preparing a short trip to Panorama.

My family got together last night to celebrate Mom's birthday. We sat on the bare plywood. Twice Matthew found Graeme venturing too near a nail head or vent and called to us for help while he wrestled the baby away from danger.

Peter got his report card today. He got 3s in handwriting. The rest of the scores were good. He told us that he knows what he has to do. As he walked down the hallway naked, with his pajamas over his arm, he said, 'If I didn't have anything to work on, school would get pretty boring.' Wise words for a guy with such small butt cheeks.

We ate supper at Venice's on Central. Matthew wanted to draw a picture of Cheryl while pregnant. He got a pen and paper. He drew a big circle, and a much smaller circle attached beneath. Then he was stuck. I told him that since she had a body, he should draw her head.

'And what else?' I asked. 'How about a pair of legs.'

Matthew said, in full voice, 'First her privates.'

'Matthew!'

'If she has a baby, she needs her privates!'

Papa asked, 'Matthew, what are you going to be when you grow up, a doctor or a broadcaster?'

Having just received a report card, Peter thinks everyone else should get one. He gave Papa a piece of paper he said was Papa's exam. It was one whole side of check-marks. At the bottom: 100%.

Peter came home from two hours at the gym Thursday before supper and slept for 20 minutes. He woke up still tired. His hands were scuffed up by the parallel bars. He was walking with them in front, held up as if to dry. As if pleased. A little pain is better than nothing.

Matthew was being noisy while Peter slept. Cheryl said, 'You'd better be quiet. What would you like to do?'

'Cuddle.' He said, to me, 'Dad, I like my Mom and Dad. Do you like your Matthew and Peter?'

Later: 'Would you sleep with me a little bit?'

Yet later: 'Mom?'

'What?'

'Could I have a sandwich or something like that for a little bit before I go to sleep?'

Matthew sleeps with a nightlight. He's frightened by the shadows on the ceiling.

Peter wants a lot of time to practice spelling and doing math drills. It's all fun right now. How long will it last?

Matthew was driving his matchbox car in the air. He turned it upside down and wiggled two fingers. In a high-pitched voice, he said, 'Help me mister. I fell out of the car.' Only when I take each finger and push its tip into the window is he ready to go again.

We've planned to take Peter to a cello workshop tomorrow and Sunday, for a couple of hours each day. To prepare, he practiced Gavotte and Boccherini's Minuet.

Sunday, March 16

I'll ride my bicycle to school tomorrow. Why not? The roads and sidewalks are nearly dry.

Cheryl's parents left for BC. We're thinking ahead to Easter. We're thinking of destinations like Drumheller, Calgary, Banff or Edmonton.

Peter enjoyed the entire workshop. The instructor was from Edmonton. A talented teacher. The experience gave a boost to Peter's skills and enthusiasm.

We went water-sliding at the Ramada Renaissance yesterday with Peter Butt and his kids. Matthew and I went from 9 until 10:30. Cheryl and Peter joined us from 11:30 to 1:15. I took Matthew down the slide with a water sprinkler. Matthew didn't like it. He was frightened. He wanted the slide 'with a little bit of yellow in it'.

After, Cheryl dropped Peter and me off at gym. For some reason Peter was upset and wouldn't go in. It required a half hour of talking before I found out the problem. When we did go in, the door to the gym was locked. It had been cancelled for the day. I've got no car. I phone home. Cheryl is tied up there, waiting for Shelley to drop over. 'Take the bus,' she says. We walked to Place Riel, got instructions about schedules and told to catch 6A 'right across the street' in 3 minutes. Across the street referred not to across from Place Riel but across from the University, on College. We watched it sail by. The next bus would come in 30 minutes. We walked to DQ, ordered drinks, and caught the bus, picked up transfer slips and sat. We were taken twisting and turning through Eastview.

Finally I asked a girl across from us, 'Where is this bus going?'

'Downtown,' she said.

'I want to go to Lakeview.'

'You should have transferred way back,' she said.

'Enough of this,' I told Peter.

I rang the bell. We got off. The bus left. All its right and left turns confused me. I didn't quite know where we were. Peter saw the freeway between some homes. We found an alley that brought us behind the houses. We hopped a chain link fence, picked our way through bush, deep snow and water, and ended up on the shoulder of the highway miles from anywhere.

'This is sort of like a hike, isn't it Dad,' said Peter.

We reached home after 3:30. I described what happened to Cheryl. The dear girl laughed until she choked. Peter and I removed our soaking socks. It turned out Peter's gym was at 6:30.

At 8 I attended a guitar quartet from Vancouver performing at Convocation Hall. When that ended, I drove downtown to pay a parking ticket. I got home to find Cheryl on the phone with Michael. He and I talked for an hour.

Easter Sunday, March 29

We are on the third day of our holiday. Cheryl's parents were with us as far as Tyrell museum. They had visited it briefly on their way home from Panorama. We left Good Friday, travelled in short spurts, to Rosetown for coffee, to Alsask for lunch, to Hannah where we took a stretch. The boys took turns driving in Cheryl's

parents car. Twice we crossed paths with Diane and Ernie on their way to visit friends in Calgary. We reached Drumheller in time for supper. We first checked into the Drumheller Inn (409/411) and hunted down the Corner Restaurant in the middle of the very small downtown area. The motel had a small pool and whirlpool. Peter dove from the side. Matthew sat on the pool steps, hanging onto the rail or my neck.

The weather is shirtsleeve warm. The wind is light, the sun is brilliant. Drumheller feels like a strange town, built at the bottom of the valley where the streets twist and finishes in a dead end. The houses sit in small clusters, connected by streets that follow the base of hills. The homes are small, old, with yards of stone and scrub grass.

Saturday was sunny until piles of cloud tumbled over the cliff-tops into the valley. Morning is cool and windy, but by noon the wind stops, the clouds disperse, the heat rises. After breakfast in the motel, we went to the museum. It's made of granite, glass and pipe at a price of \$30 to \$40 million. The boys played at every available computer and physics demonstration, walked through the many levels of displays and film kiosks showing prairie life over 3 billion years. Matthew grew harder to manage, so I let him lead wherever he felt like going. Through groups of people, under railings, into the theatre niches, several times out of my view. At some point we met the rest, let the boys pick a souvenir (both bought Plesiosaurs), and went for lunch. We ate again at the Corner Restaurant. Cheryl and her parents stayed downtown. I took the boys back to the motel for a short sleep. When Cheryl returned we drove outside the town limits, and found a stone

embedded with petrified wood. Then to Rosedale and the swinging bridge. Expectant Cheryl remained in the car.

The boys and I began a short hike. Gandalf (me) followed Thorin (Peter) and Bilbo (Matthew) across the bridge and along a narrow path through the hills. The hobbit and dwarf found hidden canyons, magic crocuses, deer prints, coyote dung, a staff much like the one Gandalf would have had, a small lake they threw stones into, rivulets in beds of mud and clay, wide assortments of stone, a ball of coal, patches of cactus, and a loaf of bread. After an hour, Gandalf led the way back, testing cracks in the ground with his staff.

‘What now, Gandalf?’ asked Bilbo.

‘Quiet! Goblins are near.’

‘What should we do?’ asked Thorin.

Bilbo, clearly up for adventures said, ‘I’ll fight those goblins.’

After getting clear of the bridge, Bilbo said, ‘Thorin?’

‘What, Bilbo?’

‘Who is Bilbo?’

Peter was let down by the hoodoos. ‘Those Indians were pretty silly to be frightened by those things.’

We joined Cheryl’s parents at the motel, rode between floors with ‘an elegator lady’, and had supper at Romeo’s. The air cooled quickly in the twilight. We went swimming and to bed.

Sunday, April 13

The day after Cheryl's birthday. 32 years.

We bought a car last Thursday in a private deal. Matthew asks over and over if this is our car.

Reading by everyone has been the order of this weekend. Matthew was frightened by Disney film about an epileptic boy. After supper at my parent's place, Matthew came into the room.

He said, 'I don't want to watch Disney anymore.'

'Why?'

'I don't like it.'

'What's wrong?'

'The doctor drew a cross on the boy's head with his blood.'

'What did the boy do?'

'His brain was dead. He was bald and the doctor drew on his head like this and looked in his brain.'

Later, in bed, while he lay close to me, he brought the topic up. 'It's alright for big boys to watch, but little boys can't, like me and Cameron.'

Yet later, after sleeping awhile, he called, 'Dad? Is our house flying up?'

'No.'

'Just spaceships?'

'Just spaceships.'

‘Is it just pretending, then?’

‘Houses don’t fly.’

‘Do they belong on the ground?’

‘Good night.’

It took Cheryl a while of lying with him before he went to sleep for good.

Sunday, May 4

We get great enjoyment watching the boys together, listening when they're apart, each going on about the other. If we've been critical of something Matthew's done, Peter comes to his defense.

Matthew's eating has improved. He feeds more independently but still gets filled too quickly and must have the rest of the meal forked into his mouth by Cheryl or me, but only after we've let him sit on our lap so he can stroke our neck.

Peter's physical growth has reached a plateau. After several months of eating well at every meal, he is picky and doesn't finish his portion. Otherwise he is very happy. Gym, soccer, cello, school, reading, playing with friends (except with Laurel Wallace, who, together with her mom, accused Peter of being rough. They claimed he had grabbed her by her collar and shaken her. Peter said he didn't. He had grabbed her lower down and shaken her. But he was justified he said. 'She has an abusive mouth.'

Bev is back after several months of caring for her mother. This has made Matthew much happier. Before, he pleaded with us to stay home. Now he asks Bev to come on Sunday. His thing just now is the 'Money thing'. 'On the side, down low, up high, split the nickel, tickle, tickle, tickle.'

Peter brought his bicycle off the sidewalk and lay it on the grass. Matthew dragged his trike on the grass and tipped it beside Peter's bike.

We went to Mom and Dad's. Peter and Matthew ran in ahead of us. Dad asked if he drove over alone. Peter smiled and said, 'Yep.'

Matthew talks about blood and gore. 'Will blood come out?' he asks. 'We have bloods,' he says.

He pretends he's pitching a baseball. He picks up an imaginary resin bag, scuffs dirt with his toe, winds up, calls a strike.

Peter and I spend time kicking the soccer ball back and forth. Last night I advised him to concentrate on kicking with the lace part of his shoe. He woke up this morning and asked if I saw the damage in his room. In his dream he kicked a ball with his laces and broke all his lamps.

Saturday, May 10

Friday night I dropped by the library. Cheryl stayed with the boys in the car. Matthew was sleeping. When I returned, Peter was out of his spot, sitting with his arm around Matthew. He had told Cheryl, 'I might as well do it now, since it's the only chance I get.'

This morning Matthew woke up coughing and upset.

When the spell ended he said, 'I should go to the doctor to stop my cough.'

'What good would that do?'

'He would help it to flow out.'

A few days ago he was lying in bed with us, his arms behind his head, his legs crossed.

'Mom, somebody hurt my heart.'

'What do you mean?'

'Well, what I mean, somebody hurt my feelings.'

'Who?'

'Peter hurt my feelings.'

Matthew called Cheryl from the bathroom. He needed help feeding the monsters in the toilet. She found him dropping bits of toilet paper in the water. 'I've been in the woods,' he said.

At breakfast he refused to eat. Cheryl asked him what was wrong. He said, 'My brain and body and blood are hurting, so that's why I can't eat.'

Tuesday, May 27

The temperature has risen as high as 33 degrees the past few days. It's windy. Peter says everyday how he dislikes the heat. His face is strawberry red, he is confused, irritable, short-tempered. He takes a fan everywhere he goes. When his body cools down he gets busy with all his tasks, working on his cello, mastering the round-off backspring, unassisted.

And playing soccer. I'm the coordinator of community soccer. I get to see most of his games. Matthew comes with Cheryl.

He told me, 'Dad, I'll be a coach and you be a soccer player. I'll put the ball here and you run and kick it over there.'

I did so.

'Good, soccer player, now you be the coach.'

Peter is an attentive player. He knows his position, even if he backs up too much when an opponent advances towards him with the ball. He kicks well, is an intelligent passer. We will put him in summer soccer school in August.

School above all is his highlight. He reads every spare moment: The Boy Who Wanted a Family, Pirate Island Treasure, Dorie the Witch series and detective novels without end. I was playing guitar while he read.

At one point, he said, 'That song makes me sad, well not sad really, it reminds me of when I was a little boy. I used to put my feet on the guitar, like this.'

Matthew was listening. He jumped up, sat on my other side, and said, 'Was I this little when Mom took me out of her tummy?'

Two of his teeth were filled. He received several stickers from Dr. Hamilton. Cheryl found the episode unpleasant. She said she doesn't know how one can do a job that makes children cry.

Matthew said, 'I cried just a little bit, this much.' He showed half his finger.

Cheryl then asked Matthew if he would get her something. He jumped to his feet and said, 'Certainly I will. Certainly, Mom.'

Now is not a good time for Cheryl.

Peter's birthday is coming up. His biggest wish was to get a red mountain bike with hand brakes. And what do you know? But I wonder if a Raleigh will meet his standard. Cheryl and I are equally excited about him seeing it for the first time. We hope we don't lose him to a life on the street.

Peter and I are playing checkers these days. Every game he shows a 100-fold improvement over the last. Not me. Who said getting old means losing gracefully?

Last night Matthew went to bed shirtless and embraced himself all night. When he's with Cheryl he says, 'I love you Mommy,' before sliding his hand under her collar, down her back. He sings lots wherever he is, whatever he is doing. The Smurf Song, as arranged for Peter's Spring Thing, is his favourite. He has a good voice.

He appeared with a small chair turned upside down on his head, looking through the slats. He said, 'Look, my head is in jail.'

Sunday, June 22

Peter went on his first date a while ago. Jocelyn Roston asked him to go to the Lakeview confectionary after school. He asked us, then accepted. When it came time to pay for their treats, Jocelyn discovered she had left her money at home. Peter paid for everything out of his own pocket. Since then he has been trying to understand how that happened.

Summer preparations are officially begun. Everything Peter had been doing through the winter are done, except for soccer, which has two games left.

Yesterday was Peter's 8th birthday, which began on Friday. He brought four boys home after school: Brock Eidem, Dale Smith, Heath Kruger, and David Stearn. We started things off at Putt 'n Bounce. For an hour balls were flying everywhere, over hedges, under fences, across the road, and through flower beds, cutting the heads off marigolds, filling the air with the pungent aroma of the recent-living. At every hole they created line-ups. Matthew golfed too. Cheryl asked him at the end of each hole in the front-9 how many strokes he had taken. 'Three,' he said. After the 10th, and from then on he said four. 'Why four now?' Cheryl asked. 'Because I'm almost four.' For the next hour we ate pizza at Geno's. We were slightly delayed going in. The boys had a sort of ceremonial letting-go of their helium balloons and wouldn't move until the last boy had seen the last balloon disappear from view. At home, we gave Peter his red L'il Big Horn Raleigh Mountain bike. He's hardly been off it since.

We attended Kathy Ardell's wedding. It lasted from 10 to 3. After, Cheryl's parents came over with gifts for Peter, which

included a pair of Norco binoculars. We went to Traeger's for a light supper, then to Roy Ardell's for a come-and-go tea to celebrate their 35th Anniversary.

Matthew asked questions about the wedding. We discussed it while sitting on the terrace balcony behind the Bessborough, with a view of the garden where the ceremony had taken place two hours earlier.

He asked, 'Are Kathy and Bruce the Caboose married?'

'Yes.'

'No they aren't.'

'Why not?'

'Cause they didn't dance.'

'You mean like Cinderella?'

'Yeah, like her.'

He asks similar questions about our wedding. He's prompted by three of our framed wedding pictures on our bedroom wall, two of which show us together. 'Are you dancing?' he asks.

It won't be long before Matthew is ready to have training wheels put on Peter's blue bike. The question we'll have to deal with then is, Whose bike is the blue bike?

Father's Day: Matthew climbs into bed with us this morning and tells me, 'You're the best dad in the whole forest.'

Peter's soccer team won more games than they lost. Peter has enjoyed playing. We've spent many hours in the park kicking the ball to each other, passing and shooting. Peter likes goal the most.

He's not afraid of hard kicks, even though he's been hurt a few times. Now and then he goes through the living room kicking the ball while he walks.

Cheryl is well on with her pregnancy. The baby is very active, and at times I can see it, like a mole pushing from under the surface, from across the living room. It's most active when Cheryl is relaxed, mid-evening. When she rubs her belly, the baby pushes back. Wherever she places her hand, that's where the baby pushes. It is quiet when Cheryl is sleeping, but becomes active at 6 am. Cheryl lies awake, feeling it. Often I wake up with Cheryl propped on pillows, eyes wide open, both hands on her belly. 'Feel this,' she says. We're very excited about its arrival. So are the boys. They spend long periods rubbing it, their faces close, talking to each other. Matthew said once, 'This baby's cute.' It hears their voices. Its movements quicken when they're close, startles when they talk.

Tuesday, July 1

Last Thursday, Cheryl and I went to Damn Yankees. Friday, school ended. Saturday, I picked up the shed and extra 4X4s for the base from Beaver Lumber. Sunday, Joel and I played tennis. The boys went to the farm by way of Christopher Lake. Cheryl and I had supper at The Keg. Monday it rained in Saskatoon, but was sunny and hot at Henry's. We were home by midnight, very tired. Peter and I had gone out on the motorcycle in search of the Sturgeon River. Which meant travelling along the gravel road straight north of Henry's, onto a dirt track for a mile, turning at some old buildings towards the river. As we got nearer the bush grew thicker, the mosquitoes more bothersome. We turned back short of the water. On the way home, Peter picked flowers for Cheryl.

This morning, everyone slept in, Matthew until 10. By the time his breakfast was beginning, ours was done. He sat alone with his Shreddies, putting on sugar. After spreading one spoonful, he went back for another.

'One is enough,' I said.

'Peter uses two spoons.'

'You have plenty with one.'

'Peter cheats.'

Cheryl was busy washing the work clothes. I began assembling the new garden shed. The first task has been to set down concrete slabs. The boys were in and out of the house, helping me (Matthew several times standing with me while I shifted and leveled the slabs with his hand on my back or around my neck), riding to their

friends' places. Danielle was out but showed up later. David Stearn was out but showed up after supper.

Matthew went with Peter to Danielle's after getting upset every other time Peter has left without him, using every technique to break Peter's will. He says, 'I will miss Peter,' and 'I want to be with Peter.' Bit by bit Peter's resistance wore down. Today, after working for two hours in the heat, I went in and sat with Matthew on the sofa to read. Fifteen minutes of that and he asked me to stop reading. He went outside looking for Peter, just as Peter was heading to Danielle's. I found them both a bit later playing in Danielle's van. I asked Peter later how Matthew had been.

He said, 'Oh, really fine. Well, I guess he was being a little silly.'

'Was that a problem?'

'No, he was entertaining us.'

I asked Matthew what he had been doing. He hooked his fingers in his mouth and stretched it wide.

We had a BBQ supper at Cheryl's parents. We set up a tent, the boys climbed the willow tree. Papa urged Matthew to go a little higher. He said, 'No, Papa, what if I break my arm.' This from a boy who has insisted he can slalom ski.

Wednesday, July 1

I started early on the shed. By the day's end, thanks to help from Cheryl and the boys, it is nearly done. Peter spent the day with Danielle and Suzanne, David and some other boys. We've given him more freedom and a longer leash. So few friends who live in our block are available when he wants to play. Other homes are blocks away.

Relationships with girls are complex. Peter gets frustrated. They have conspiracies. Peter is often the object. He had been swinging in our back yard with Danielle and Suzanne. The decision to leave was made by vote. Peter was the minority. They all went off. Every turn in the road involved a vote. Peter always the minority. He is thinking the girls are a well-orchestrated coalition. He bore it, then broke away. He asked if he could ride to David Stearn's. He spent the afternoon in their pool and playing Monopoly.

Matthew slept part of the afternoon, and when he woke up, came outside onto the patio with us for a cold drink, which he poured onto the grass. After giving me some help with the shed, he went next door to Laurel Wallace's. We heard a sudden cry. Matthew came into our yard with his hands on his ears. We asked what he had done. He sat on the grass and said, 'I don't want to talk about it.' But talk we did, and in the end he admitted to pushing her off the slide.

By 10 this morning my back was burned. I'm writing just now because going to bed means lying on it. I hope it doesn't rain on the unfinished shed. We plan to purchase a new turtle sand-box to replace the one we have, which is filled with swamp-mud and

bright red worms. After Matthew and I had watched them for a while he said, ‘Those are nice worms. They don’t bite you.’

Friday, July 4

The shed is done. The yard is trim. Peter and Matthew played hide-and-seek with Danielle and her 5 year old brother, Colin, while I weeded the garden. Matthew and Colin went between our house and Bingham's and counted. Peter and Danielle hid behind the apple trees. When the count was finished, Matthew and Colin searched everywhere, hopelessly, fruitlessly. Finally Matthew said, 'Colin, I think they're really lost.' When it was their turn to hide, they picked behind the shed, and hunkered down.

Peter and Danielle counted to 10, then called, 'Where are you?'

'Here,' they answered.

A few seconds later, Peter and Danielle arrived at the shed. Peter said, 'There you are.'

After a moment of silence, Matthew said, 'You peeked.'

Matthew has his hands on his ears a lot these days. 'To keep the noise out of my head,' he says. Most often when he's caused a problem and doesn't 'want to hear about it.'

Whenever Peter and Matthew are in the car, they begin to bicker.

'I'll see the 'versity first.'

'No, I will.'

'Mom, Peter said he will see the 'versity first.'

'Boys, it's not important.'

'Peter, Mom says I get to.'

‘No, I do.’

‘Mom!’

‘Boys, be quiet!’

Peter is reading One-Eyed Cat in bed.

He asked, ‘What does p-a-r-s-o-n-a-g-e say?’

‘Parsonage.’

Matthew was at that moment sitting on his bed reading. He asked, ‘What does A-x-6-6-6 say?’

‘Picture,’ Cheryl answered.

Thursday, July 10

Peter and I arrived at Waskesieu Wednesday at 1:30 after breakfasting and visiting the library with Cheryl and Matthew. We enjoyed the ride up. Sun, warmth, good conversation. We planned the next three days. We will hike, fish, visit the Nature Centre, and so on. Peter is in high spirits. At 8:55 pm Peter was trying to sleep in the blue-domed tent. I sat in the Pontiac reading. It has been raining off and on, sometimes sprinkling, sometimes like heavy weeping. That doesn't affect Peter's high spirits. He wants to stay busy.

We lunched on sandwiches and chips at 3 after booking a room at Northland's Motel for Cheryl, Matthew, Mama and Papa, when they arrive on Saturday. We put together Peter's new fishing rod with an 89 cent leader, signed him up for a Junior Naturalist session, and went to the Waskesieu River to fish from the bridge. I cast out and Peter reeled in, over and over, and all we caught was a bale of weed. Every time the hook snagged on the shallow bottom, Peter chided me. 'Dad!' We BBQed wieners and beans for supper, washed the dishes. I phoned home to see how things were with Matthew. Cheryl said Matthew slept in his sleeping bag. I talked to Matthew.

He said, 'I don't like to wait two long days to go camping.'

I said, 'But you're waiting for Mama and Papa. You'll come up with them.'

'Yes, but I would also like to go with you to camp.'

Peter was in bed by 9:30. I read in a chair until 10, then moved into the car for more light, and read for another hour. Peter had a

rough time trying to sleep. He was bothered by the sound of mosquitoes, though all but one were outside the tent. The one inside left him alone. He heard a vehicle in the woods and the wind in the aspens overhead. He wasn't properly asleep until the dawn light appeared.

We were up by 8:30, walked to the shower, found a repairman at the door of the Men's bathroom. He instructed us to use the Women's side. I went first to shower. A 'Repairman Inside' sign stood at the door. I joined another man and his wife and small child. Peter stood outside. When I was done, I asked if there had been any trouble.

He said a woman had come and asked about the sign. He told her, 'Actually, there are no repairmen inside. They are working in the Men's bathroom. My Dad is showering and I'm waiting for him. And she said "Oh," and went away. Sheesh,' he tossed up his hands with a grin, 'What did I do wrong?'

We ate a quick breakfast, drank coffee and pieces of melon provided by our neighbours, had more coffee at the Park Café, went to the Nature Centre to watch Up North, a slide-tape presentation of Waskesieu. Peter stayed on to watch Grey Owl. I read in the car. We had lunch under cover in a camp kitchen where swallows were busy with their nest, had a conversation with Dale and Jan, who had happened by on their bicycles, attended the Junior Naturalist program, which involved making a puzzle that became one of Grey Owl's beavers (I was never clear how that worked), drove to PA to withdraw cash from the automated teller, ate at a Mexican restaurant, visited Coles' bookstore in the Plaza, then returned to the lake by 7 to walk the Mud Creek Nature trail. The rain was coming down heavily by this time. I said to Peter that

this didn't seem to make sense, and why don't we do it tomorrow in better weather. Peter answered, 'We can't stop hiking because of some rain. Let's go, Dad.' So we did. Through 2 kilometers of sodden undergrowth till our clothes shone with water. Now and then I asked how he was managing. Each time he grinned. We watched for beavers, listened for birds, and felt away from everything in that silent wood. After the hike, while enjoying hot chocolate at the Park Café, he thanked me for the hike. I said, 'You're a good boy, Peter.' He answered, 'You're a good man.' To go with that attitude is a mature face, crescent dimples and faintly cleft chin.

Wednesday, July 22

Three short-haired males beating the summer heat, just when the temperature becomes more moderate, breezy, cloudy.

Peter helped Cheryl make my upcoming birthday cake—German Chocolate—by cutting out large circles in wax paper

Two days left of swimming lessons. Both boys have enjoyed the water. We don't want to push them too quickly. Matthew starts by getting his hair wet, face in the water, blowing bubbles, singing games in circles: 'What time is it Mister Woof?' He will wander, which means the instructor retrieving him, returning with him under her arm. Peter is still the littlest in his class. How to get around that when he is always first in cue, following instructions to the 't'—head in-head out, scaling the dolphin, HELP (heat-escape-lessering-posture), which is used if one has fallen into cold water), rescue breathing (which he struggles with a bit, doing it on strangers, which is anyone who is not family). He said, 'I could spend 5 hours in the pool.' He'll spend the next two weeks at the University doing an hour a day (5-6) on stroke improvement with the Goldfins.

Cheryl's parents returned from Banff after attending Rob Ardell's wedding in Calgary.

Cheryl is on her last legs. She cannot wait for the baby to arrive. Once can see its movements through her clothing. Matthew thinks it's cute, rubs it carefully. Peter can't wait for it to be born. He's sure it's a girl.

Matthew has a new friend. John Scott Ford. They play football together, and baseball, tennis, and birdball. He plays tricks on

Matthew. He takes Matthew's wallet, hides his shoes. His hair is dark. He is bigger than Matthew. He is entirely in Matthew's imagination.

Peter played cello for the first time since early June.

We have just purchased a set of bunk beds. Lately they have been sleeping together and wake every morning wretched with tiredness. One night Matthew fell out of bed, taking the quilts with him. This doesn't stop them from being up early, engaging with each other all day.

Peter put out 2 old teeth for the tooth fairy.

Prince Andrew and Sara Ferguson married today.

Friday, August 1

I put together the bunk beds yesterday with the boy's help while Cheryl shopped for sheets. After that, Peter sat on the top bunk with Matthew, Kelsey Miller, and Erin and Shauna Bingham. Peter arrived home with Danielle and asked if they could read together on the top bunk. Matthew came up too and wouldn't leave them alone. Eventually the party broke up. Today was Matthew's first nap in the bed.

The previous weekend had been spent with Danny and Joan, Jeffrey, Tammy and Erin. The older children played from Friday evening (at this time, Matthew watched Mel Brooks' Young Frankenstein with us) to 3 pm Monday. Baseball played in the park was havoc. Base running was unorthodox. Twice Matthew broke away from second base to home, straight over the pitcher's mound. Once he ran from second to first to visit with Tammy. The mosquitoes made life difficult. Ending the game at 3.34 innings. Peter and Jeff rode bikes, played Atari. Matthew and Erin were glued together, chasing Peter, Tammy and Jeff around the house in an unconventional game of hide-and-seek. We ate Saturday breakfast at David's Restaurant, and Monday lunch at the Blue Diamond'. It didn't matter what Peter said, Jeff giggled.

Lessons having ended for both boys, we see that Matthew will have to practice putting his face in the water, and Peter his front crawl. Since Peter began lessons at the University, that stroke has improved greatly. They use the flutter-board for front and back crawl, alternating hands and breathing. He wears goggles, the straps flap when he walks. He's showing a strong competitiveness. Everything becomes a race, whether or not anyone else is aware of it, though I'm sure one or two others are. Once while diving in to

begin a lane swim he emerged with the goggles down on his nose. He tried to fix matters with one hand while keeping pace with the others, fixing, stroking, head up, desperate above all not to be left behind, goggles still around the nose.

Peter and Danielle were together in the basement, making canals for running marbles through. She has just returned from a trip west.

The boys will go to the farm tomorrow with Cheryl's parents. They don't know it yet. No doubt they'll see plenty of the Isaachsen kids. Carol and Les had invited us to spend time at a cabin on Christopher Lake, but Cheryl is under strict orders to stay near home. The baby will come any time within the next two weeks.

Mom and Dad went to Nebraska for a family reunion. We're talking about a Hedlin reunion in Vancouver next summer. Thinking about the possibility of buying a tent-trailer. We want something to help break from our everyday routine. I hope to complete my Masters by next fall.

Saturday, August 16

Today is THE day. Cheryl is expecting at any moment. Just not this moment. Just now she is playing the piano, claiming she is feeling better than she has in a long time. To provoke the fates who she is sure are listening, she says, 'I expect that the baby won't come for a week.' (wink-wink) Today is our 11th anniversary. Will the baby come in time to help us celebrate? Turned out, today is not THE day, just another day.

During the past two weeks (August 4–15) Peter has attended soccer camp, completed Levels I and II of swimming in the Olympic Way Goldfins program, one week at VBS and one week at a Sport Study on reaction time (for what it's worth, his high scores were 49/50 and .255 seconds). In this same period, Matthew attended VBS. Actually he made the rounds of all the classrooms, which made him evermore confused about who his real teacher is. He is the only child there to convocate from 3 grades simultaneously. Each day, Peter contained Matthew with his arms to get him going up the stairs in the right direction. Somehow, it didn't quite work. That's Matthew.

Several times at home Matthew had been perching on Cheryl's semi-lap, trying to rouse himself. On one occasion he said, 'I've just got tired veins.'

Michael and Cathy were in last weekend (August 8–11). Michael had made arrangements to come some time ago without knowing if his thesis would be completed on time. He brought Beatles records, which I taped. We watched Fun with Dick and Jane, pulled the whole family together on Sunday (August 10) for a ball game and doughnuts, with one mother or another breaking

one child or another for a stroll around the park, then corn-on-the-cob at Mom and Dad's.

We had an anniversary supper at Sawyer's on Wednesday (August 13) with Cheryl's parents. The central feature of the place is its pool that runs alongside the tables and under a bridge full of fat goldfish. Imagine the boys with that.

Cheryl's condition has us limited to 'gentle' activities: car rides, ice-cream, videos, reading in dim, cool rooms, me running the boys here and there, to avoid, in spite of Cheryl's deepest desire, the onset of premature labour. That was the case with Peter and look what happened.

This morning began with having breakfast for 8 at the Treetops restaurant in the Bessborough. The boys are noisily searching through Lego pieces and singing. We just finished watching a most charming film we've watched as a family, the animated *Wind in the Willows* (1983). The plan is for coffee with my parents after lunch.

Sunday, August 17

Still nothing.

This evening I played guitar for the boys. One piece was John Denver's My Sweet Lady (a man who deeply loves a woman wonders why every time he has to leave they fight and she cries, and all he wants to do is lay with her). Matthew was very affected by the song's mood. With legs crossed, head hanging, lip out, eyes brimming with tears, he said, 'That's just a sad song.' I followed that gem with Paul Simon's A Most Peculiar Man (about man who lives alone, gases himself on Saturday, and the landlady Mrs Reardon says it will be hard finding anyone to attend the funeral) during which Matthew grasped Peter's arm with one hand and my arm with the other. The charming concert was concluded with Pete Seeger's Where Have All the Flowers Gone? (about the flowers all having been picked by girls to give their boyfriends, who go to war and don't return, and 'when will they ever learn?') Matthew asked, 'Did they kill themselves too? Next time I want a happy-sad story.'

Tuesday, August 26

Tonight is probably the last night before the long-overdue baby is born. My certainty is due to the decision for Cheryl to have it either spontaneously (and at this moment her contractions are stronger than ever) or by drip tomorrow. She had a non-stress test this evening at St. Paul's. The child showed plenty of activity and acceleration of activity on a graph sheet that folded itself on the hospital floor. The boys stayed at Mom and Dad's during the two-hour appointment. Peter is curious but impatient. He said, 'I'll probably have a beard before the baby comes.' Matthew is mostly affectionate. 'Mom, your baby is cute.' Recently, wherever he was walking with Cheryl, he had one hand on her belly.

Holidays are over. Today was a half-day. Tomorrow I'll be off. Our frustration is that the summer has ended after a period of forced idleness just as our desires are strongest to get away.

Peter completed Level III. He has made exciting advances in the last 4 weeks. Peter is so excited with what he is able to do, what he has attained. Matthew has a mostly-theoretical breast-stroke. Wearing goggles, he performs a nearly perfect whip-kick on the living-room floor.

Monday, September 1

Erik Mitchell Skarsgard Hedlin. He was born Wednesday, August 27, 7:45 am. Cheryl is now home from hospital. Erik wasn't jaundiced enough to warrant keeping them any longer. Cheryl signed herself out 'against the wishes of her physician', and we arrived home at 11:30 am. This morning Peter said, 'Boy, Erik was good last night. I had an excellent sleep.'

The boys are both thrilled. Matthew shows no sign of feeling displaced. He held him in the hospital and again at home. It's best when one arm is propped on a pillow. As careful and attentive as he is determined to be, Matthew can't sit still long enough to let Erik rest. Peter wears a long smile when Erik is in his arms, shifting him from his lap to his shoulder as the need arises, patting his back for burps, and 'hitting him on the bottom' when needed.

The past few days, we've done very little cooking. Tuesday (August 24) was at McDonald's, where Joel watched by boys while Cheryl and I worked out baby names. Wednesday (August 25) was supper at Cheryl's parents. Friday (August 27) was at Mom and Dad's. A man named Pung from Beijing was visiting. He cooked a supper of stir-fry beef, vegetables, and rice. Saturday (August 28) we went to Windows restaurant with Cheryl's parents and Grandparents. Otherwise I'm 'batching' with the two boys. Sunday (yesterday) the crowds came to see Erik and Cheryl. Mom, Dad, Carol, Les, Colin (with muffins he baked), Mark, Cameron, Graeme, Mama and Papa. Coffee and squares.

Thursday, September 4

Papa said he wanted to keep Erik. Peter said, 'You can't have him for anything. He's worthless.'

Yesterday, Matthew held Erik for 90 minutes. He wakes up only twice a night for half-hour feedings.

Peter talked Cheryl into bringing Erik to Show-and-Tell next week.

Mama offered Matthew a bowl of peaches.

'Does ice-cream come with it?'

'It could,' she said.

'I'll have just the ice-cream.'

Sunday, September 14

The routine has returned. Saturday morning was spent at the University with both boys. Matthew has officially begun playing cello. He was unhappy that his group didn't actually play their instrument. When asked who knew Go Tell Aunt Rhody, Matthew said he did. He added that he knew a lot of other things. Bernadette agreed that Matthew talked a lot, quite a bit more than Peter ever has in her four years with him. Matthew is by far the youngest. His group ranges in age up to 10 years.

Last Sunday (September 7) we went to the farm. Cloud persisted all the way to Shellbrook, then the sun appeared brilliantly and made the early fall colours sparkle. We followed Papa's dust plumes along Stump Lake and Blue Heron road and arrived at the Isaachsen's in Canwood just as they were getting out of the truck. We ate, then went for a long walk around the village. We used Peter's binoculars to see if anything was happening inside high school windows, the boys skipped on and off curbs, Matthew fell in oily dirt (getting grease on his pants doesn't bother him much; he's not even bothered that his mother is bothered.) We found the streets and alleyways curiously haphazard, short, with intriguing ins and outs, abrupt ends in odd places, like a private garden. Cheryl and I talked about the pros (the charm) and cons (everything else) of living in such a small place. We found a playground, but it wasn't long before Cheryl decided she was wearing the wrong shoes. We returned to the house in time for the second meal. From as far off as the high school we saw Cheryl's Mom holding Erik. Peter confirmed it through his binoculars. The drive home involved trading the boys back and forth with Cheryl's parents. Matthew sang Twinkle with little flourishes. When Peter

wasn't discussing his impressions of what made people in the family similar and different, he was watching Papa and Mama in the truck through his binoculars.

Yesterday: We waited for Peter to finish with orchestra before shopping for new glasses and a baby seat. It is cool and cloudy. We're not much encouraged to be outside. But we did go for a donut with Cheryl's parents. This evening I took the boys to a Hilltop football game at Gordie Howe bowl. Peter fiddled with his gloves, getting the elastic sleeve just perfect, looking up now and then to see if the score had changed, finally taking the gloves off. Matthew was sitting, standing, wondering each time the crowd cheered if the game 'was over, and when can we go to the next football game.' We witnessed vagrancy at its most perfect. The thousand and more fans were up and down and around all night, to eat, stretch, visit, go to the bathroom, and eat some more. We left before the end of the third quarter.

Sunday, September 28

Last Sunday (September 21) we drove north in spite of heavy rain and wind to be briefly at the farm for the boys' sakes, then in Canwood for multiple birthday celebrations, then to PA, where we bumped into Dale and Jan at Robin's Donuts. We returned home in the dark and the pouring rain.

Bernadette is happy with the progress of both boys. She is impressed with Matthew's ear. 'I can't stump you,' she said. She had told Peter he was playing very well and asked how much he practiced.

'A little,' he told her.

'And what if he practiced a lot?' That question was aimed at us.

Yesterday we went to my parents' for Matthew's birthday supper. We walked Captain, a sheepdog belonging to neighbours. Mom and Dad had agreed to look after him for a few days. Peter had the leash. As we were exiting Weir, the dog must have gotten a sniff of the great beyond and took off. Peter, refusing to let go, was dragged through the grass along 14th Street.

Matthew is changing his clothes in the night. Once, he removed everything, and woke up in the morning wearing only Peter's red shirt. A second time we found him completely naked, legs crossed. The third time he was naked and had somehow found a pair of Cheryl's panty-hose which he had pulled up to his thighs.

We spent the day at Batoche. We watched the 40-minute film in the theatre, then tramped the path to the church, the rectory (where Matthew slipped under the ropes more than once), and the cemetery. From there, the view of the west bank is magnificent.

We drove to the East Village. Cheryl stayed in the car to feed Erik. The boys came with me along the freight trail to Batoche Avenue to see the remains of Latendre's store and home, and the gun pits the Métis had made in 1885. The trees gave off a sweetish aroma. Peter checked things out with his binoculars. Matthew complained that his legs were 'sleeping'.

Tuesday, October 7

We attended Open House at Lakeview school last Wednesday (October 1). His teacher explained the curricula and looked at examples of Peter's work, which she praised. His French teacher said, 'I love Peter.' We saw a report on Canadian provinces, a story about our family, samples of handwriting and artwork. We met his Métis teacher. (We heard a day later that she had been burglarized.) Matthew tells us his own stories about his school, about the work he does, the sports he plays. We question nothing.

We think Peter has Strep throat. He went to school today only briefly. His teacher, Mrs Reimer, phoned, telling us he had been crying during handwriting.

Matthew went with Peter to his cello lesson and sang several songs: Twinkle, Go Tell Aunt Rhody, and so on. He has begun playing I'm A Little Monkey.

Erik has been the easiest of the three boys. He never fusses, is wakeful and content for most of the day, coos, smiles, and sleeps the night, except for one feeding. Cheryl can hardly believe the ease of it. It's like the court-appointed torturer has reduced the punishment of boiling oil, thumbscrews and cat-o'-nine-tails with one of the above, Cheryl's choice. Peter and Matthew step in to help with Erik, holding him, doing more for themselves, and for the most part behaving well.

We're wanting to decide how best to spend the Thanksgiving Long Weekend. Another trip up north? Cheryl's parents will be away at that time. My family is scattered far and wide. A Thanksgiving meal looks improbable.

This has been for me a very busy month. Mostly due to coaching the Murray boys' soccer team. I'm not sure why its worse this year than last. The boys are much more self-sufficient, and Cheryl doesn't seem to mind my late nights.

We acquired a 1/2-size cello after getting the green-light from Bernadette.

Boston played the Angels in the first game of the playoffs.

Saturday afternoon (October 4) I took Peter and Matthew to a Huskie soccer match. The weather was dull and cold. Cheryl stayed home with Erik and pulled up plants in the garden.

Sunday evening we went for a stroll around the neighbourhood, the boys biking/walking/pushing Erik in his stroller. Matthew tried to show us where his little friend David Hedlin lives.

Friday, October 17

Last Friday (October 10) John and Irma visited in the afternoon. We walked in Lakeview Park. Diane and Ernie came for supper. Their twins, nearly a year old, crawled over each other like kittens, and laughed and butted heads. After supper we were invited to Mom and Dad's to meet Warren and Joanne from Bemiji, Minnesota. Everyone showed up except Matthew and Cheryl, Michael and Cathy.

On Saturday, Peter and I went to Newsham field to watch the Under-18 Boys' Soccer tournament. Alberta Juventus won gold. I was struck in the back by a stray ball from the Women's Ontario-BC game in the next field.

Sunday, we drove to Diefenbaker Lake to see the dam. The boys found monkey bars on the beach and a rocket with computers. And Peter taking command. I wandered alone to the spillway and watched the boys play through the binoculars.

The weather stays warm. It's steady at 20, with sun and light breezes. The Red Sox play the Mets in Game 1 of the World Series Final tomorrow.

At 1 this morning I was called by Matthew. He had to pee. He ate a handful of raisins while he sat. One fell in. He said, 'A raisin just dove into the toilet. His eyes were open. He didn't have any goggles.'

Peter spent this evening at the gym. He went through all the routines, including the L-sit (which he holds for several seconds) and vault. He has been registered for Level IV swimming in January, the season of frozen hair.

Tonight Peter called me from the bathtub. He was reclining on one arm. When he had my attention, water squirted out of his mouth. 'I'm a statue,' he said.

We're looking at getting Matthew into a pre-kindergarten gym class. It will go if the numbers are right. All day he jives and dreams and entertains us all evening long with sit-spins. Gym would be good for him.

Erik is the perfect infant. He sleeps most of the night, is up no more than once (unless Cheryl eats pizza for supper). He smiles, is highly responsive to his brothers. I'm holding him while I write this journal, and kicks my arm, which excuses the illegibility. He calls us (with the look of a loon) when he needs something, rarely cries, and makes things so easy I'm nervous about the direction this may take Cheryl's mind.

The new cello buzzes a bit around the fine-tuners but has a rich tone. Peter is getting Scherzo ready for next month's recital.

For the last while Peter and Matthew have had troubles settling down to sleep while in the same room. Matthew will call to complain.

'Dad, Peter keeps on sticking his hand down at me.'

Peter then calls, 'Dad, could you tell Matthew to quit talking. I'm trying to go to sleep.'

So we've been starting Matthew's night off in our bed.

Monday, November 10

Last Saturday (November 1) the boys slept at my parents'. We went to Leask for Andy's wedding.

Last Wednesday evening (November 5), the boys played at their recital at St. Andrew's Presbyterian church. Dad and Cheryl's parents attended. Matthew performed I'm A Little Monkey. Peter played Scherzo. Both were happy with the results.

The weather has suddenly turned bitter. Minus-24 and an 1800 wind-chill.

Peter and Matthew are spent this Saturday at Cheryl's parents. We went with Cheryl's Grandparents to the Station Place. Erik came along.

He is vocalizing more, smiling constantly, watches whoever is talking to him, no matter how far he has to turn his head. He is peaceful in his chair, blows bubbles when he's excited, concentrates on things until his eyes seem ready to burst, throws his hands and kicks his feet and pants with near-frenzy when he's excited. He laughs easily, especially when he's naked. He has a particular call when he wants our immediate attention. He had lost most of his hair, but it's growing back; a little long on the ears, straight up on top.

Peter received his report card: 25 Consistents and top marks. He was happy enough but still asked us if we thought he might improve in some area.

Cheryl's parents came over yesterday and we played Scotland Yard. Matthew's favourite part were the boat rides on the Thames. He even rode the Metro from one side of the city to the other. We

caught Papa on the last move. Both boys want to play again tomorrow.

Sunday, November 30

Matthew has a cold. It makes him pretty antagonistic. His ear was itching. I went after it with a Q-tip. That didn't help much. Peter spent some time reading *The Hobbit* and some time on the 'Physics Lab'. Erik has just fallen asleep and will remain that way likely for the rest of the afternoon. Cheryl is in the bedroom sewing a dress. I'm watching the Eskimos play the Tigercats in the Grey Cup. It's 20-0 for Hamilton. Matthew just walked into the living room wearing shoulder pads stuffed under his shirt and swim goggles on his forehead.

This whole month has been mild, rarely below minus-5.

Peter is so steady, light-hearted. He utters jokes and sarcasms almost steadily. 'Oh right, Mom, tell me another one.' Teasing us, frequently doing handstands, wanting to be counted to 10, cooing with Erik. 'Hi, Erik, hi, hi Erik, hi, hi...'

Matthew is mostly keen about getting older. He imagines having a sister, another brother. Related to nothing, he said, 'When I climbed a mountain, my friend died when he fell off a cliff.'

Sunday, December 7

Peter has been very excited this past week about Suzuki program rehearsals and performance with the Symphony. Even though the practice on stage of the Centennial Auditorium has meant lineups for tuning, sitting long stretches when the Orchestra is doing their thing. All 160 kids did really well.

Matthew told me, 'Dad, I'm stronger than you.'

'Why?'

'I can pull your leg. You know, when I'm joking.'

Tuesday (December 2) Peter Butt came over with Cheryl's parents for a supper of stuffed salmon. Wednesday Peter stayed home sick. He was wakened early that morning not able to breathe. It frightened him. Cheryl and Matthew went to choir. I went to an Amnesty International Executive meeting. Thursday we went to Mom and Dad's to celebrate brother Matthew's 30th birthday. It was a full house. Partly because a massive architectural drawing done as part of his M Architecture requirements was laid across the floor. Friday night was Peter's performance night. Matthew watched intently, applauding every piece. Peter said he would like to play a solo to a full house. He added that he would prefer to play in front of his school to playing alone at home. 'I like people to hear the sounds of my cello.'

Christmas preparations are making things busy around here. Cheryl shopped yesterday morning. I repaired tree lights. We put the tree up in the afternoon while Mama held Erik and Papa slept.

Two weeks until the beginning of holidays. The boys watched the same production of Swiss Family Robinson I remember seeing as a boy.

We think Erik has begun teething. He fusses more, has bright colour in his cheeks, chews on everything, including our fingers. It's likely. Matthew was this age.

Cheryl drove Matthew to choir. He sang Silent Night to himself: 'Saturday night, Saturday night, mm-m-m...'

After choir, Matthew told Cheryl he didn't sing.

'Why didn't you sing?' she asked.

'Because I told my teacher I have a sore throat and she said I didn't have to sing, so I didn't. I lay down too.'

'Why did you lay down?'

'I told my teacher I was very tired and she said I could lay down, so I did.'

Tuesday, December 23

Christmas Eve (Wednesday) was at Marg and Roy Ardell's. The boys played well with Bradley and Michael. Another huge meal, with bowls of chocolate mousse and whipped cream left uneaten. To illustrate the quantity of food, Cheryl had brought two bowls of broccoli and cauliflower salad, but it was forgotten. Someone found the box with the bowls on the fridge after the meal. The standard concert: Christmas carols, presents, songs played, the Christmas scene. Gifts for the boys included clothing, 'Contruxts', books (including The Magician's Nephew), a walkie-talkie set. We moved our operations to Cheryl's parents where more gifts were opened. The last of us didn't make it to bed until 2:15.

Christmas Day (Thursday) started with breakfast. While the boys played we got things ready for the trip north for another huge meal at Betty's. Peter and I 'took turns' driving the Delta 88 while everyone else slept. We counted 100 electronic controls. While the adults visited, the boys played hockey in the basement. Cards are played, some of us walk to Andy's trailer. At 10 we left for PA. We checked into the Imperial 400. Peter and Matthew slept in Cheryl's parents' suite, #117. We kept Erik next door.

Boxing Day (Friday), we began with a long, relaxed breakfast at the Sheraton Marlborough (on us, \$19.95). Our coffee cups were filled many times. Papa talked about a prospective retirement. Peter held Erik, who smiles any time someone looks at him. We returned to the motel and played on the waterslides. Peter went with Papa. A good thing. Peter was needed to give Papa a push when he got stuck. The first time down, Matthew needed a bit of coaxing. After that, though, he pushed to keep at it. 'What will we do now? Go on the waterslide? Okay, Dad!' and he skips away to

the ladder. He doesn't like the tunnel, won't go on it. At 2 we packed up and went across the street for lunch (Matthew fell asleep chewing his food) and drove home.

Saturday, December 27

Sunday, December 28

On Monday December 29, Joel and I went for a game of racquetball, then came home for tomato soup and cheese biscuits. We visited, talked about Navy discipline (Joel is in Navy boot-camp in Nova Scotia), and how tough it will be to go back. Peter joined him for a wordsearch puzzle. I drove Joel downtown in a snowstorm. When I returned Cheryl had begun a large jigsaw puzzle of a Japanese garden. I finished off Name of the Rose by Umberto Eco and began Mailer's The Executioner's Song. Jed and Helen Dyck came at 7:30.

Matthew proved difficult to put to bed. In the morning he wants to come to our bed. We say no, which makes him very unhappy. He calls from his bed every few minutes, wondering something: Were Jed and Helen were still here? Why isn't the light on? Why are you so loud? Etc.

Tuesday, December 30

Wednesday, December 31

The new snow has freshened everything. I skied on the new tracks on the Wildwood golf course. In places they were obliterated by several families. Once around was enough. I've got to work on endurance. At home, Cheryl was busy with her jigsaw.

The evening was spent (two hours of it) at Mrs Gyorgy's. Matthew jumped from the steps onto the slippery living room rug. Breakables are everywhere. Several attempts were made at conversation. Peter succeed better than the rest of us. He talked with Marg Ardell about surgery. She said he is a lot like Dale was at the same age. Then the food was ready. We had time just for a bit of shrimp crepe, and left. We're taping Die Fledermaus at home.

1987

Saturday, January 3

Thursday, New Year's Day was brilliant and mild. As warm as minus-5. It has been this way through the entire holiday. The sun turns snow to slush in the streets. What's happening to winter? One might even begin enjoying winter on the prairies.

The day began at Cheryl's parents', playing Atari. We took the boys to the Meewasin rink to skate. I got a \$40 seatbelt violation on the way down. Matthew skates faster, and with more confidence. Peter bumped into Anthony Tang there. They practiced their hockey-stop. Cheryl pulls Erik in a sled until she gets too cold and takes him to the car. We get a copy of *The Gods Must Be Crazy* (on Anne Skarsgard's recommendation), invite Cheryl's parents for pizza, and laugh uproariously at the film. The boys' favourite line from the movie is 'Aie-yi-yi-yi-yi.' They repeat it to each other until they fall asleep. Cheryl's parents leave soon after it's over.

We begin Friday with Cheryl's parents at the Parktown for breakfast. The sun was bright. Erik needed changing. Matthew and Peter ate reluctantly. We spent an hour returning gifts, returned home to read and do the jigsaw puzzle. Cheryl has moved the puzzle to the red table into the living-room for better light. I took Peter and Matthew to the hill with our Krazy Carpets. A Polish boy from down the block joined us. The three boys raced downhill. Matthew's toque sits high on his head, flopping over like melting ice-cream, bouncing while he runs up the hill. The rest of the time their collars are pulled up, their toques pulled low. Just eyes and cheeks when they smile. Cheryl's Dad came for supper. We watched the Penn State-Miami College Championship. Cheryl gets her Mom from Sears and they finish the puzzle.

Saturday was spent getting groceries, having coffee, and visiting Coles' Books to spend Lloyd's \$15 gift certificates. Matthew found a coin-operated motorbike next to Wizard's Corner. Bill and Maureen came for supper. The kids sat together at the table, laughing, sneezing and voting on the food.

Matthew said, 'Girls talk to girls, mans to mans.'

'Why?' asked Erin.

'That's pradiation.'

The Christmas tree lights stay on, even when it's too bright for the bulbs to be visible. The needles are still soft.

Wednesday, January 7

Cheryl is so much more relaxed now than before Christmas, when she was so busy shopping, baking, getting the kids ready, that she even sleeps in the afternoon with Matthew lying beside her with his seaman's cap pulled down over his face 'because that's what the skipper (in Gilligan's Island) does.'

Peter is happy to be back to school. He had a girl over, Erin Berg, to practice the Norwegian lines they'll be speaking together at this Friday's school assembly. Peter had been asked to play his cello, but we decided not to. It's too soon after all the playing he had through the holidays. And he'll be playing twice more later this month. Matthew had cello this morning. Both boys went to choir and Pioneer Club this evening.

Matthew said, 'You know Nels? Little Nels? He pushes. When we were running, he pushed me.'

Cheryl asked, 'Were you running, Matthew?'

'Well not really running, kinda jogging and not going anywhere.'

Peter has begun Goldfins again. They must have gone $\frac{3}{4}$ km using different strokes. He enjoys it now as much as he ever did. Matthew and I sat together on the side. Except for my down jacket, which I had to remove because of the humidity, it feels like last summer. Matthew wore his goggles. As soon as we were home he lay on the floor and thumped out a wild sort of breast stroke.

Erik has a charming smile. It's a perpetual thing. He was on the jolly-jumper today. He laughed every time he turned and saw Matthew.

Monday, January 12

Record high temperatures in western Canada, contrasting with the record lows in Eastern Canada. Europe is reporting the worst winter in memory. Here it's running water, sweaters only outside, too warm to ski, cars covered with grime. Yesterday it reached +7. Calgary reached 17.

Peter went to Erin's birthday party at the Travelodge. They spent three hours on the waterslide. Their knees were sore-looking after skidding time and again over the joints. Cheryl's parents and my mother came over for Sunday lunch.

Matthew entertained us with tricks. The first was what we're calling, 'The Disappearing Act'. It involves draping a large handkerchief over my head and saying, 'Abracadabra, make this book appear.' He whips off the cloth, shows me the book, then puts the cloth back on my head, and says, 'Abracadabra, make this book disappear.' He pulls the cloth away and says, 'Now it's gone, see Dad?'

The next act is called, 'Which hand?' Matthew says, 'Which hand is the thing in?' He holds out both, points to his right, and says, 'You can't say this one.' I point to his left. He opens it, grins, and says, 'Nope, you're wrong. Do it again.' His hands are jumbled together before becoming fists. He asks, 'Which hand is it in? You can't say this one,' point to his left hand. I point to his left. 'No! You can't say that one.' I point to his right. 'Nope.' He grins. 'You're wrong again.' We can't figure out how he does it.

Erik is unsettled again. Maybe it's stomach pain or more teeth. One minute he's as happy as ever, but suddenly he cries out, is

inconsolable for ten minutes. Nursing makes no difference. He lies in bed, making noises, never waking up.

His brothers love him to the point of asphyxiation. They hold him around the neck and tell him how sweet he is, and he fights for air.

Peter must have strained his Achilles tendon, possibly at Gymnastics. He has spent most of last week limping. He went swimming today, but he's taking a bit of time off the Gym.

Sunday, February 15

Nothing especially 'Valentinsey' happened yesterday. We (Peter and I) are just done a four-day weekend. I spent Thursday and Friday at Institute and Convocation. Peter was home the entire time and is eager to get back to the classroom. He's happiest when he has a plan. When time is on his hands, he becomes indecisive. Get him started on something, however, and he is chipper, productive, talkative. He is reading *The Lion, the Witch and the Wardrobe*.

Peter is off swimming for a week. Then both boys are supposed to begin a six-week session. Expectations for those in Peter's group is to commit three days a week, with Wednesday being an optional 90 minutes of flexibility, video-tapes, instruction and stroke-improvement. I think Peter will not do the optional Wednesday. But Matthew is very excited. Peter's gym coach arranged an hour of family swimming at the old YWCA building, from 4:30 – 5:30. Matthew and I floated around in the deep end while Peter and a few others played football keep-away in the shallow end.

After some deliberation, Cheryl's parents have decided on a two-week trip to Hawaii. They will leave next Saturday. We'll be away at Anglin for a two-day ski weekend. Saskatoon should be a quieter place.

Matthew said, 'My voice is lower than Erik's, but yours is lower than Peter's because you're bigger, right?'

Erik eats rice pabulum every night before bedtime. He sleeps until 4 am now instead of waking every 90 minutes to feed.

Peter competed at a Taiso Invitational Meet. He enjoyed the pomp and ceremony of all teams filing in to Chariots of Fire. He is interested in doing all the meets now, when they happen. The next is a provincial meet in Regina at the end of March. He intends to be wearing the full competitive outfit by then, including blue singlet, white leotard pants, and grips.

Cheryl and Peter went for a walk today. Cheryl is looking entirely recovered from her pregnancy. She wore scarlet hood and gloves, an attractive short coat and leather boots. Peter went only so far before asking to go back home for a rest. We have fresh snow. It must have worn the poor boy out.

Mom and Dad are returning from Cornwallis after being present at Joel's graduation from Navy Basic Training. He'll be thrilled to be done.

Michael phoned. Classes are going well. Catherine (no longer Cathy) has a birthday on the 18th. They bought an \$1800 Italian leather couch. We talked about travelling to the coast this summer and spending a few extra days on the west side of Vancouver Island. A brand new experience.

Canadian NHL teams tied at 2-game series with the Soviet Red Army team, 1-1.

Temperatures drop to -10 at night, and -2 in the day. It's fresh with the new snow. Perfect winter scenery. Matthew helped me shovel snow. After we were done he stayed out for a while. When he was ready to come in, he had gotten caked with snow from toque to boot.

Peter doesn't feel ready for competitive swimming. He doesn't like kids rushing him. He complains about everybody's impatience. 'Why can't I swim the way I want, take it easy and have fun?'

Peter performed Let There Be Peace On Earth at Erik's baptism. One remark about Peter's playing: 'He played perfectly but I wish I could have seen more than the top of his head.' Carol and Les were sponsors.

Matthew has making great gains over the first six months of cello. He's nearly finished Book I. He shows surprising patience, sits by himself, works out the fingering to his pieces, maintaining a good 'tunnel', fingers never splayed or out of place.

Tuesday, February 24

We spent the weekend at Anglin Lake with 8 other staff members and their families. The drive up was tricky. Heavy winds, icy roads, drifting snow, cars in the ditch between Duck Lake and PA. One staff member, Phyllis Wilson, struck a tow truck as it was pulling one vehicle onto the road. We were slowed to 45 mph, hoping that oncoming cars could see the centre line. Peter sat up with me. He was nervous. Cheryl sat in the back with Erik, who was not happy with the seat restraints.

Our suite had two pullout beds, rearranged to allow more space for Erik on the floor, plus a round table, range, fridge, fireplace, and a balcony accessed by French doors.

The temperature was minus-5. Snow fell intermittently. The lodge is on a rise above the lake. The boys sledded for hours. Ice-fishing huts are specks at the far end, with thick grey brush on the slope behind. The trail wound around the lake, through dark spruce, across a bridge, up and down slopes. It was a 'blue wax' snow. We ended our tour at the Snail-Pace Café for cappuccino. Cheryl and I visited it twice. We were tired and not interested in moving, only talking to new people as they arrived. Cheryl had a long talk with Debbie and Jack Greening. Matthew played with Debbie's five-year old, Dylan. Peter made friends with Allison while sledding. Her family had driven up Friday night. Both their snowmobiles were wrecked on the way.

Peter and Matthew skied Sunday afternoon. Peter went ahead with Cheryl, I followed with Matthew. Erik was strapped to my back. He slept nearly the entire time. We got as far as the Trailhead and back. The boys were happy to get back to other

things. Cheryl and I skied to the bridge, 2.4 km each way. Erik's hands were cold by the end. We warmed them up at the Café. Saturday we walked along avenues with cabins. Most seem closed for the winter. We found a small rink lined with stakes and fluorescent tape. Peter played on a swing-set while the rest of us went a little further on.

The drive home was a breeze. We ate supper at Frans'. A group of ski-doers sat at the table behind us.

Monday, March 9

Matthew, on how to make bread: 'First you grease the pan. Then you put on the dough. You poke it down, put a blanket on it. Let it grow for a minute.'

Peter is still talking about being Pediatrician.

Matthew was asked to join an older group of cello students. In the present group he's second youngest. While he is nearly completed Book I, the others have scarcely cleared of I'm A Little Monkey. We're not sure. The kids are so much older, their nature so much different from his.

Cheryl's parents got back from Hawaii on Saturday. Her grandparents went with us to the airport. Afterwards, we went to the Travelodge for lunch. During the meal, Matthew complained of being cold. He had whiskers on his arm.

Erik sits alone, chewing on every toy in reach. The teeth haven't come through. The pain is continuous now. He smiles and winces at the same time, puts up his arms at every passerby. The flu has come through the house. Everyone had a cough. Erik doesn't have a cough. But he mimics coughing.

Peter is getting ready for the Science Fair. He is studying the surface tension of several liquids. He measures how quickly each liquid climbs up chromatography paper and dissolves the dyes. He watches closely. He makes lots of suggestions.

Matthew is drawing. His subjects are varied, a globe, my guitars, our car. He studies, places his lines, sometimes making an outline of the object in the air before committing anything to

paper. His drawings end up with fine details that are often hidden under his colours.

Every morning the routine with Matthew is to complain about eating porridge, then eating it as fast as he can.

‘Mom, I don’t want porridge today. What do you say?’

‘I say, “But Matthew, you must eat it. It’s good for you.”’

‘And what do I say?’

‘You say, “Okay.”’

Matthew giggles, and digs in.

Tuesday, April 21

It's our fifth day of holidays. It is presently 12:45. Erik has slept for 90 minutes. Cheryl and I are in the living room. Peter is outside with David Stearn. Matthew is at Derek's birthday party. The snow is long gone and the neighbourhood is busy raking, mowing, watering. The grass is almost green and most plants are budding. For procrastinators like me, it's still too early.

Peter is playing chess. We've played a game nearly every day for three weeks. I borrowed a Bobby Fischer book from my parents. Both of us are reading it for ideas. When not with me, he's lying on the floor before the board, playing by himself or with Matthew, who knows the positions and moves of most of the players. Yesterday, working from diagrams, I was setting up checkmating situations for Peter. Peter was working on solutions while making a lot of noise and standing on chairs and dancing around the table. But today he is more subdued. He can't go more than a day feeling completely happy.

Matthew has gotten so skinny, clothes sizing is going in reverse. Last year he wore size 4X jeans. This year it's size 4. But it doesn't affect his agreeable temper. He spends a lot of time riding his bike. He's sticking with the side-wheels. We'll keep them on until next year. By then he may no longer forget what he's doing and coming close to disasters. By then he might not ride down the curb and tip over, or run into the side of parked cars. We keep a close eye on him. He brought a basketball up from the basement and bounced it on Bingham's driveway while Peter and some friends shot baskets across the street. When he's inside, commonly he brings two buckets of matchbox cars into the living-room, dumps them out, and makes meticulous arrangements.

Both boys got their haircut, bringing to view patches of untanned skin.

Erik is as lively as ever. He tries very hard to stand with or without help. He pulls himself up on furniture. If left for too long he collapses to the floor, startling himself. He is making greater varieties of noise and waves goodbye. His new teeth grow. Two have come from the top. His height and weight put him in the 20th percentile. Dalen Miller is younger but much heavier. He is eating strained foods. He chokes on meat but washes it down with milk in a cup. He smiles. When he is especially excited he screams. As he tires he grows more active and noisy. He bangs spoons, pulls things away from his brothers, gets himself into a crawling position without actually crawling.

Soccer season is nearly here. I'm coordinating the community. I've been hours on the phone with parents, coaches and other coordinators. Peter is excited. Matthew will play next year. He's in a growing phase. When we go for a walk or he is riding his bike, he tires quickly.

We attended church both on Friday and Sunday. We haven't been to Easter services for a while. We think back to last Easter in Drumheller and Edmonton. Good memories.

Peter and I are playing Scotland Yard on the floor. Erik is tugging on Peter's shirt, trying to crawl onto his back.

Sunday, April 26

Peter and Matthew left for the north yesterday with Cheryl's parents. Cheryl and I stayed behind, tending to Erik's fever. We hoped it would be down today so we could follow. It's not. He has been needing holding since Wednesday. He's happiest just now when we have him at home.

In all, the break has been relaxing. We were at Cheryl's parents on Thursday, removing two trees and raking the lawn. We worked a bingo on Friday for the last time this year.

Peter beat me for the first time at chess. When it happened he had a stunned, Cheshire Cat look, fighting with his smile, wanting not too badly to keep it to himself.

Matthew sets up players for a new game.

He asked, 'Why do knights see us in the night?'

I said, 'What do you mean?'

'Because they have to guard the king.'

For some reason, both boys are interested especially in the knight. Peter dreamed he was one, forced to take two steps forward, one to the side. Peter explained to me Bobby Fischer's unique way of moving knights with the tone of voice one uses when explaining to someone who hasn't a clue.

Cheryl went to Kim Krause's wedding shower. She went with my mother. She wore a long smock-like blouse the colour of mustard, with black pants. She is looking great.

The Skarsgard family had a serious scare yesterday. David went for surgery to relieve dizziness and vomiting. In the course of this he went into a coma. He went through two more surgeries in the afternoon and evening. The doctors were attempting to fix the new shunt that drains fluid from his brain. He regained some consciousness by 4 this morning. By 12 he was fully conscious and talking about his Tuesday evening class.

I'm now reading August 1914. I just finished Michener's Hawaii.

Peter and I are back to school tomorrow. He was feeling desperate on Saturday. He realized he had left homework with no time to complete it. 'I'm going to be way behind,' he said. He worked intensely for a couple of hours, making up for most of the procrastination.

The sky is pale, the wind hisses. It's too much to go walking with Erik.

With the boys up north, Cheryl and I went out for two meals. We walked in the Lansdowne-Albert Avenue areas for half an hour, until Erik got hungry. We went to Peter D's for souvlaki and cheese toast. Today at noon we had chicken fingers, soup and salad at Delphi's, then went to my parents' for a short visit.

Diane's twins are a bigger handful every day. She gets tired. Ernie is busy either at school or on his Dad's farm.

Peter's soccer season begins in two weeks. Lots of arrangements yet to make.

It is the second round of the hockey playoffs. The Oilers played the Jets. We look in for scraps of the action to get the vibe of the

situation. The House of Commons begins a death penalty debate on Monday at a time when the US has begun broadening its application. Tamil rebels fight the Sri Lankan army. Hundreds were killed last week.

Peter has begun seeing a counselor regarding some concerns. This involves lots of discussion around family life and dynamics, anger, power, achievement. He was in turns interested and embarrassed at the things he is asked to share. Cheryl and I hope it works.

Erik is sleeping soundly for the second time today. It's a good sign that he's feeling better. Also, he is goofier and cheerier. He works hard to stand and walk. As recently as last Thursday he was lying in someone's lap.

Sunday, May 9

Mother's Day was spent entirely away from the house. First church, then Travelodge for dinner, baseball at Cheryl's parents, supper at my parents', then coffee at the Ardell's with all the relatives. Joel drove into town with a navy companion for two days. He's headed to Esquimalt. Some periods of strong gusting wind, but warm.

The boys have just retired. It is 10:10 pm.

Matthew was balancing on one foot on one of Cheryl's flip-flops. The other foot came down behind it. 'I'm a skateboarder,' he said. That's the thing he wants at the moment.

Most of Erik's time is spent standing, solo for short periods. With help he walks, usually to the piano. He stands there, pokes at the keys, and grins until the drool flows.

Swimming lessons for Peter and Matthew are nearly done for the year. Maybe we'll take them to summer classes. Cheryl and I are talking about getting tennis lessons for Peter. He'll need a racquet. Birthday gift?

Sunday, May 17

We spent our days up north, mowing lawns, picking stones, planting the garden. The boys went into the wood to arrange sawn logs for a fort. It has a doorway, walls, a coat rack. Peter even cleaned up the floor. We took two walks down to the logging trail, to what Ione calls 'fairyland'. Between the house and 'fairyland' the spruce is thick, entangled, the grass is tall. Suddenly it's an open carpet of thick, springy moss, scattered rotting stumps penetrated with curious holes, perhaps by rodents, or as Peter prefers to think, by gnomes. It is dim there and quiet. Birds call from the distance, sunlight is patchy. Cheryl joined us for the second trip. She wasn't pleased by all the mosquitoes getting in her hair. We followed a deer path with plenty of droppings, came across a nine-point antler, came into the clearing several hundred yards from where we had entered. On the way back to the house we found one tree with a couple of large, well-maintained badger holes under its roots, and another tree, freshly-leafed, with claw marks, antler rubbings ten feet up. Was it a moose? A bear? Am I a naturalist?

Peter is practicing riding the motorcycle. He began nervously, preferred if someone came alongside. He learned to shift from 1st to 2nd, was more comfortable increasing speed. His legs are hardly long enough to reach the gear changer.

Matthew's face has never been filthier. He spent a lot of time with Papa on the lawn tractor. They both came in covered in dust. Matthew has used wet fingers to rub his eyes, mouth, his ears.

Sunday, May 24

The last entry was stopped abruptly when the Coleman lamp quit. Peter has mastered the motorcycle in 1st gear, and goes round and round the house.

Monday was frigid cold. It felt like snow. Edmonton and Calgary each got 20 – 40 cms. Flurries were predicted, but nothing came.

Erik has a 5 word vocabulary: Mama, Dada, Papa, bye-bye, and No (which is made more emphatic by waving his hand side to side). He stood for half a minute unaided. He stands by the sofa, anchoring himself with an elbow, getting his hands busy with something else. He has a ferocious energy, that gets him everywhere in the house. One can trace his movements by things he has tipped over, scraps of food he has dropped, pieces of things he has broken. He has the most amiable nature. He is rarely not smiling, not relaxed. We listen as he lies in his crib, kicking the Fisher-Price play center, or striking it with a toy, rattling and banging and not sleeping.

We've a family of sparrows moved into the red birdhouse. The parents come and go all day long, feeding the chicks, following the same flight path past our kitchen window and up over the roof. The red dowel perch is constantly dislodged.

Peter, Matthew and I went to Lion's soccer field Saturday evening. Peter worked on dribbling, passing and shooting. Matthew protected the net. When there were no shots, he was in the dirt, throwing hands full of it into the stiff wind, enveloping himself. It came to an end when he punted the ball into his own face and cried. We joined the others at Cheryl's parents for coffee.

Peter's team is the Leopards. They've lost every game. Erik like the ball to be kicked to him. He holds it against his mouth and makes blatting sounds.

Peter and Matthew went to John's for lessons.

John said to Peter, 'You are obviously listening to your tape.'

Peter said, Well actually, John, I haven't been listening to it very much.

John said to Matthew, 'Did you know you are a very good cellist?'

Matthew said, 'Yup.'

Cheryl and I are planning to bring the boys to an 'Abolish the Death Penalty' march across the 25th Street bridge.

I read a story from Winnie-the-Pooh about the bear visiting Rabbit. Matthew laughed at each of Rabbit's tricks, and at Pooh's bashful weakness for honey. Cheryl read Hans Christian Anderson to Peter.

Peter still talks about pediatrics and playing in the symphony.

David Skarsgard's surgery to deal with the growth in his brain seems to have gone perfectly in Montreal. His recovery has been quicker than anyone expected. Everyone is anxious for his return.

Monday, May 25

Supper at Delphi's. Cheryl got her Income Tax return. Ravioli again for Peter and Matthew, their favourite. Peter's one gripe is the cheese.

The Leopards played a home game against a College Park team, and lost 5-0. Peter ran, got hot, his face grew red to bursting. Matthew and a friend named David kicked a ball down the hill.

Peter wants cleats.

Sunday, May 31

Peter has cleats. We got them just in time for his Wednesday game. It got rained out. Peter came out of his room with the cleats around his neck.

I was up early Thursday morning to get ready to take a class to Batoche.

Erik cut his sixth (eye) tooth yesterday. It was a bad night for him. He was up twice. We hope he'll sleep better now. He stands unassisted more often and for longer. He works at making people laugh, usually by being comical himself—faces, scrunching his nose, sniffing, then getting us to copy. He crawls, the feet of his sleeper dragging behind. Cheryl calls him Swee'Pea. If that's so, she's Olive Oyl. He hunts down the source of every noise, plays alone in the boys' bedroom, pats the door of the stereo cabinet until it springs open. Everything goes in his mouth, including paper. Maybe paper's the least of it. The boys keep a close eye on him. They grasp him under his arms and drag him into the living room. Sometimes Peter is more vigilant than Cheryl and I: 'Dad, shut the kitchen door!'

Inside the house, Matthew stays busy with toys and drawing. He lies on the floor, speaks to himself as if having a conversation with the plastic humans he fiddles with. He plays with Kerry Wallace. Usually they're digging tunnels in the turtle sandbox.

The Oilers won the Stanley Cup tonight.

Peter and Matthew have been playing soccer in the park. Peter's cleats have given him sore feet. He is wearing runners, mostly.

Matthew has invented a lace-tying technique. He wraps the laces around his ankles and tucks them into the sides. He explained himself to Cheryl. 'First I tie it around my knuckles. I mean my waist.' He went to school on Tuesday for a trial afternoon. He drew, played with other kids who've been scheduled for the same class.

Two weeks left of school.

Peter's birthday may be early this year to include Danielle, who is moving June 11. They've been playing with real intensity to make up for an entire future of not playing. Peter is not happy about this. 'Danielle is a true friend,' he said.

Monday, June 8

We had Grade 12 Graduation on Friday at the Centennial Auditorium. Staff met between the ceremony and banquet at Willoughby's in the Holiday Inn.

Saturday was the cello concert and picnic. This involved 150 kids. Peter played with the orchestra and. Matthew played everything up to Allegro.

Peter played in a soccer tournament at Forest Grove Park. Two games on Saturday, one on Sunday. The weather was cool and blustery. Peter improves in every game. By the end he is flushed and happy.

The afternoon was spent at a Suzuki piano picnic. Hotdogs, a 'pinny-back' race between parent/child teams. Peter spent a long time kicking a ball to other kids. Seeing that Matthew was standing apart from the others, after kicking four times to others, he kicked to Matthew. Matthew scrambled after it and fell on it before the others came. He then stood near enough to Peter to hold his hand. Peter volleyed the balls. Each time, Matthew shouted a number, 100, 600, the value he assigned to every successful catch.

A fat bee crawled in the grass. We moved it to safety in the bushes. Erik sat in his stroller. Every time we put his hat on, he pulled it off.

Yesterday Peter celebrated his birthday. He invited Erin, David, Devon, Danielle, Mark (Tomteen), Craig and Matthew. We took them to the Travelodge to play on the waterslide. We rented a room where everyone went at 4 pm for hotdogs and cheezies and

gifts. Peter got rocket-hockey, GI Joe, marbles, Master of the Universe, etc. We got home in time for me to get to an 8 pm Amnesty Executive meeting.

Wednesday, June 10

Cheryl spends her day pretty much following Erik, mostly stopping him from putting paper and dirt in his mouth. It's the same thing when I get home. He goes to the stereo. If he can, he'll pat the stereo glass door open and fiddle with the knobs and switches of the amp and tape player. If he can he'll lift the record player cover to fiddle with the arm and needle. He knows the difference between 'can' and 'may'. Once while in the living room together he crawled behind the rocking chair next to the stereo. He went silent. Moments later he peered around the corner. He was standing, clearly with the intent of fiddling with the stereo. His eye was on me. Mine, as he could see, was on him. 'No, no,' I said. He sank slowly to his knees, our eyes still in contact. I took him to the public library. He pushed in every book on the bottom shelf.

Monday, June 15

It is near +40 and windy. The house is hot. All the windows are open. We have a fan in every room. Erik woke up last night soaking with sweat and crying. His first really hot night.

He's now busy with wall receptacles, tugging to get plugs out, trying to fit loose plugs in. He sits at the front door trying to put on my shoes. He cries with temper whenever we take him to his room for a nap. He gets into rooms and closes the door behind him, for privacy. He squeals at Peter and Matthew to rouse them to play with him.

Peter has been sick for a few days now, coughing, dizzy, ear-infection. We enjoyed him at home. Today he was in the rocking chair with his feet up, listening to the tape of Sgt. Pepper's Lonely Hearts Club Band.

Matthew and I were outside yesterday afternoon. We were using 'those orange things like witch hats' for goal posts, running back and forth in the back yard, trying to score on each other. He's got spunk.

The weekend was peaceful. No cello, gym or swimming. We worked together in the yard, mowing, clipping edges, trimming bushes. The Spirea and Mock Orange are in full bloom, the garden is coming, the grass is dry.

My parents invited us over on Saturday at 3 for Peter's birthday. Cake and ice-cream. Afterwards, Nicole Yahnke babysat Peter and Matthew, and Cheryl and I (with Erik) went to Jack Nepjuk's for lobster. I took Erik home at 9. The boys were still up.

Matthew was trying to trick Nicole into going into Peter's bedroom while he was changing for bed.

Peter, having missed school from Wednesday on, had forgotten that Danielle was leaving this weekend. When he remembered, he hopped on his bike to see her one last time. He returned almost immediately. 'She's gone,' he said. He disappeared. I found him lying on Matthew's bed, crying bitterly. 'She was a very good friend,' he said.

Tuesday, July 7

Peter is 9 years old.

Cheryl and I are finished painting the house, which is not easy in the company of three kids. We didn't paint two bedrooms. We stayed two nights at Cheryl's parents while the paint odor was worst.

Cheryl has gone to the hospital to visit Mom. She was readmitted after failing to recover from the June 1 laser eye surgery. Erik is napping. He goes down easily just now, once in the morning, once in the afternoon. Peter and Matthew are playing Lego in the bedroom with Mark Tomteen and Kerri Wallace. They're quiet presently, for Erik's sake, but I doubt it will last. I'll have to go in and send them somewhere else. When Cheryl is back, Peter and I will work on things he's learning at tennis camp at the University.

Peter and Matthew came with me to Ed Walliser's north of Sutherland, to see if he has managed to fix the Pontiac air-conditioner. He found a hole in an aluminum hose and filled it with epoxy. I used the car hood for writing a check. As I was entering my signature, something under the hood banged the hood precisely where I was applying the nib of the pen.

'I guess it didn't hold,' Ed said.

Peter said, 'Unlike a good movie, this one didn't have a happy ending.'

He made other jokes about the timing of the explosion until the subject had been laughed fairly dry. For the remaining time there, the boys chased three kittens, held them, dropped them, chased

them some more. They watched a cat eat a mouse. Matthew removed his thongs, which he'd gotten muddy.

Erik spent last week with a bronchial and ear infection. He was unhappier than any other time in his life. He is showing six teeth. He's over that now and in as good a mood as he's ever been. He crawls to a wall, stands, follows it as far as a piece of furniture, follows around the furniture to the wall. He rolls back and forth on the floor. He takes something interesting in hand and examines it closely. He crawls and pushes Matthew's cars. He takes out boxes from the cupboard and sort of puts them back (Cheryl is now putting sealer rings around the knobs). He stands at the boys' bedroom door and bangs and calls.

Matthew continues to suffer from ear-infections. He isn't hearing very well. Otherwise he's content. He's happiest when he is by himself. He will occasionally scrap with Peter. One or the other will complain to us. Peter used to have a lot of private territory. He doesn't have so much any more. He's keen to protect that. Matthew knows as well as Peter what that territory is. It's marked with Peter's things. Matthew is intent on violating those boundaries, which he does by stealing Peter's things. He's ready for Kindergarten but talks about it less often than he used to. He writes the letters of the alphabet, as well as letters in his invented language, which is written from right to left. He has several Curious George books. He keeps these in a pile (or under a pile of other books), which he gets at to reads to himself. Or plays tapes of Robert Munsch and Frog and Toad, and so on, for himself. Whenever we're going somewhere, he wants to ride in the Toyota, not the Pontiac. He drew a picture of a sun among other things and wondered if he might give it to Jesus who originated it. Jesus

travels around in space with other spacemen. If he wants something from earth people he uses the 'Canadarm'. That's how Jesus will get the picture Matthew wants to give him.

Peter has been thinking almost exclusively about tennis ever since receiving a racquet for his birthday and watching Wimbledon. He talks names, scores. He mimics forehands and backhands, uses the outside of the house as a back board, asks every day if I'll play with him, even makes up songs about tennis that he sings into his microphone/radio. He asked if Boris Becker could beat me. I avoided answering it, to leave him in the haze of imagining for just a little longer that I'm much better than I am. He asked Papa who he thinks is better, Pat Cash or Ivan Lendl. He supported the latter in the Final until he perceived that he wasn't trying hard enough to win. Which is typical of this boy. He sweats profusely while working out. And if he isn't sweating profusely, he hasn't tried. He keeps his eyes on the larger world. He asks about Amnesty International, about the current Iran scandal. He has plans to be good at everything, and can't wait until school starts in the fall. He's so independent now. He runs errands to the confectionary, cares for Erik, enjoys a good tangle with Matthew, who isn't one to walk away from any confrontation. While eating a meal at Burger King, both boys sat apart from us, even turned their backs to us. When all of us were at Robin's Donuts on Louis Riel Day Matthew waited for us to seat ourselves, then sat on a chair at another table.

Sunday, July 12

Thursday was spent at the Exhibition. It has been rainy. We were lucky to pick the one day that was all sun. We went at 2, found a parking spot, paid the \$10 admission, and went to every free event on offer. The first was Superdogs, an oval area with a track in the middle. Matthew was one of three kids picked to open the show. They were to march behind the Emcee with stiff leashes for their invisible dogs. Wearing yellow 'I Love No-Name' caps, they sat on a special podium at one end of the track. We walked among the rides, watched people trying to flip rubber chickens into rotating buckets or shoot water into the mouths of plastic clowns in a race with others to be the first to pop their balloon. Stunt men tossed each other around a western-era stage. We went into the Wheatland Building to see the photography and art entries and science displays. We sat for stage performances by 'Pepper' the mime and the Walters family. We sat in the Open Air theatre for 30 minutes of a Saskatchewan-Talent performance. We had a meal at Cyrils', snacked on candy floss and spudnuts, and were back in the car by 7. We dropped by my parents' and arranged to take them to the airport the following day at noon.

Friday night was spent at Cheryl's grandparents. Harvey, Anne and David were there with Rose for raspberry shortcake. Peter and Matthew stayed overnight.

Today we were on the road with Cheryl's parents. We drove to Viscount where Papa reminisced, told us the story about a man we know, Herman Austensen. They had grown up together in Viscount. Herman has always been very careful with his money. One day way back when they were boys, walking together in Viscount on a hot day, Sylvan asked Herman if he'd like an ice-

cream cone. Herman answered that he'd prefer the nickel. We drove to the homestead and explored inside and around the farm house. It has been badly chewed up by raccoons. Cheryl's Dad pointed out where the original building had been added to, and where that addition had been added to. We found the swings, the arched gateway, and a fountain. Lilac bushes have grown against the house, the grass is waist-high. We drove to Viscount beach on Lake Manitou. Papa, the boys and I walked down to the shore. Peter and Matthew waded and skipped stones. Matthew splashed water onto his face and wore salt-stains the rest of the day. We ate BBQed hamburgers and cinnamon buns, listened to the cattle on the far shore, watched teenagers swimming, screaming, throwing each other in and splashing around on a tractor tire tube. We drove around the lake to Manitou Beach. We were rather surprised by how this old place has kept up the 'glory' of the '50s. The shore is crowded with sunbathers, courts are busy with tennis games, people are strolling along all the streets. There is even a viable massage parlour for 'people suffering from headaches or nervousness.' We headed up to Watrous. We parked. I put Erik on my back and walked while he slept. We drove around the town before heading back to Saskatoon. Almost everyone slept on the road. We had supper at the Cavalier. Peter had somehow gotten tar on his shoes, which ended up on his chair. We talked about the possibility of a trip while the boys played and ate. Peter had had too much sun and wasn't feeling great. A big tent is in the park. The Nightcap Players are performing Macbeth there. An actor was doing pre-performance stretches on the grass. We went home for raspberries and cream. Erik is thrilled he is now free to move. He helped me unload the dishwasher. He picks out the plates and hands them to me, one at a time. Peter grieved over the dying

farmhouse. Matthew sat on the curb and floated things in the gutter. Erik floated in bathwater, his head back to submerge his ears, and called and called. Matthew joined him. Peter sat on the sofa reading *The Mystery of the Flaming Footprints*. He was in bed by 10, coughing from time to time. Matthew is asleep. Cheryl's chair is set against the stereo to keep Erik away. She's reading *Fortune* magazine.

Sunday, July 19

The French family reunion ended today. Yesterday at 8:30, after several mornings of Matthew asking if it was tomorrow that we were going, we left for Regina. The rain started at Davidson and poured until early Sunday. Water was heavy on the highway. We checked into the Sandman Inn, carried our bags (and sundries) to Room 308, then received notification that eating was happening in the Heartlands Restaurant. There we found Diane and Ernie, Matthew and Cheryl. Their kids together were kicking up a real storm. They were dumping water onto trays and the floor, which they drained back into the cups. They spat mouthfuls of coffee onto plates, picked and pulled the loose floor mouldings, and crawled under the tables, ours and others. Cheryl and I decided to let the others drive to Weyburn, we'd stay back for a nap. We shut off the lights, closed the drapes. Cheryl lay down with Erik and Matthew. Peter, who was not tired, sat in a chair by the window until I took him to the pool, where he waded and dunked. It wasn't long before Cheryl and Matthew arrived. Matthew was rosy from his sleep. He entered the pool tentatively. We saw Dad and invited him to have coffee with us in the café. Mom had stayed in her room. She is still recovering from the surgery. He sat with us for an hour. A BBQ at cousin Ed's place is set for 5. We got the boys out of the water in time for them to dry and dress, then drove north to 2727 Partridge Crescent for hamburgers and beans, potato salad, new carrots and dessert. We met some relatives for the first time. Peter and Matthew played all evening with Danny Fredeen's children, Chris and Erin Zayak, Shirley's daughter Mvawnway (Muffin), and Kathy from Colorado. When they weren't laughing at one thing or another in the garage, they were

pulling each other through the crowd in the house. Erin and Muffin poked Matthew everywhere to see if he was ticklish. We tried unsuccessfully to talk Carol and Les into staying the night, to swim and watch a movie. We went back to the motel at 10 and put the boys to bed. Erik refused to lie down in the playpen. We sat in the dark and rocked him. By 11 Cheryl and I gave up any hope of reading, put the sleeping boy in the crib and went to bed.

Erik woke at 5, joined us in bed and slept until 7:30. Dad phoned to invite us down for breakfast. We got down by 8:30, helped ourselves to pancakes and cold cereal and coffee. We were joined by Uncle Hartley and Aunt Margaret, Aunt Muriel Welling, and eventually by her daughter Lynn and her boyfriend Bruce. The boys went back to the pool, swam until 10. We were packed and checked out 20 minutes later. I gassed up at Petrocan and arrived at the Franciscan retreat at Lumsden at 11. Cheryl spent several minutes turning the car inside out looking for a wrist chain she had caught and snapped on the door. We then went in. We found a circular brick chapel, a row of easy chairs lined up by the large fireplace, and the cafeteria where everyone was lining up at tables with fruit, pancakes, sausage, ham, butter, coffee, and Saskatoon berry pie with ice-cream. Brother Matthew and Cheryl sat at our table. Peter did not eat. Matthew sat at a table with a boy his age with no name or known association. When the meal was finished we went to another room where Hartley and Howard were showing and narrating their canoeing adventure films. Erik got up the steps to the projector, which (the projector, not Erik) we rescued time and again. He wouldn't be diverted, so I took him to the lobby with a view of the valley and a corral at the bottom of the hill. I chatted with Aunt Joan Fredeen while Matthew, Peter, Cathy and Muffin played. Many had gone outside to kick balls and

throw Frisbees. The rain was over, the sky had cleared, the sun was brilliant, the breeze was light. Erik squatted on his knees and made sounds at whoever came near. People began leaving. Many had a ten-hour trip back to Calgary or Edmonton. Some are flying out of the Regina airport tomorrow to homes in Seattle and Vancouver. After Matthew was done making promises with Muffin to visit, and providing her with phony home addresses and phone numbers, we left. We spent the \$2 Aunt Margaret had given the boys at a confectionary on James Street. Once on the road, we didn't stop. The boys slept the whole way. Erik woke briefly when I got coffee in Chamberlain. Matthew's last words before falling asleep were, 'Dad, I'm going to ask Muffin to come to Christopher Lake. Okay?'

Wednesday, August 12

We've returned from a few days at Christopher Lake. We went up August 2, Sunday afternoon. Adolph Peters lent us his partially completed cabin. The finished part gives more than enough space for us. Ione stayed that night at sister Shirley's before spending a few days at a family reunion in Chelan. We weren't properly settled in until Monday. It took a day for Erik to be accustomed to his new place, not least to the new noises coming from outside and inside the house. His crib was in our room. When he woke, we woke.

Lots of watercraft at our disposal: Ed Kasdorf's flat-bottomed (Huckleberry Finn) sailboat and a 35 hp motor boat, Adolph's canoe, Doug Hopkins' 18 ft fishing boat with Cheryl's Dad's 7.5 hp motor, Obert Friggstad's Hobie 16' catamaran, two doors down is Harry Njaa's Laser II, and last but not least, our inflatable dinghy with oars. The boys found goggles and snorkels hanging on the stairway wall. Adolph showed me how to get in the shed where he keeps the life jackets.

Monday was hot. Tuesday and Wednesday were forecast to be even hotter, beyond +40.

Each day I was up by 7 with Erik, started the coffee, heated water on the stove. He ate Milupa (glue) while in the blue canvas chair that clamps to the tabletop. Cheryl was up by 7:45. While she was with Erik, I swam and washed my hair in the lake. As cold as the water was on entry, vigorous thrashing warmed me up, and the water became refreshing. The ducks went by in tight packs.

By the time I was back in the cabin, Cheryl's parents and the boys were in the kitchen. We served ourselves cereal and coffee

and sat in the easy chairs. Matthew took even longer to eat here, with all the curiosities he found in this place. We were cleaned up by 9:30, then made plans for the day.

Early on the weather held, and we spent most of our time outdoors. Nearing the end, the weather turned and we spent more time inside. We read while the boys played.

Cheryl brought Erik to the shore. He wanted to get more of himself in the water, until Cheryl ended up taking off most of his clothes. She sat at the submerged end of the dock and he splashed.

Peter and Matthew spent time in the canoe. Matthew sat in the centre, uneasy when they first moved away from the shore.

I borrowed Ed's sailboat, even in mornings when the breeze could barely nudge it. When Matthew joined me he held onto the mast in the middle. When the wind pushed us further from the shore than I had intended he said he wanted to go in. Easier said than done, I thought, but did not say. The boat moved even more slowly against the wind than with it, and sometimes not at all. At one point he asked if Jesus made the wind. When a gust pushed us a few feet Matthew, who was kneeling, embracing the mast, said, 'I asked Jesus to do that.'

Peter was more relaxed than Matthew, but even he gasped when the wind gusted and caused the boat to lurch. Once we returned to the shore he got out and Cheryl got on. She took the 'helm' for as long as the breeze was strong enough to get us here and there. But drawing near the shore, where the trees broke the breeze, the boat died, and so did Cheryl's interest. I took over. Cheryl teased and laughed at my alternating use of the paddle and sail.

In total, only three days were worth real sailing. On one day the wind pushed me to the north end of the lake and around the island. From there I struggled trying to tack back. I was gone from Ed's for three and a half hours. Another day I rode on Obert's catamaran. Yet another I joined Bev Kaiser on his Laser II. He gave me the job of helmsman. I didn't know what that meant. I did find out what it didn't mean. A strong gust hit the boat. I 'hiked out' as a counterweight. Then it died. Then an opposite wind hit the boat. In my 'hiked out' position I was thrown off the boat. That's when I learned my true value as a crewmate. The boat went skidding away, Bev in charge, not noticing me missing. He went maybe a mile and was just turning back into the breeze when he discovered that the counter-weight he was relying wasn't there. The wind brought the boat so far onto its starboard side that the entire centre-board lifted out of the water.

The most memorable sailing moment involved Peter and Matthew. We were well off-shore and going at a good clip under a steady breeze when the black clouds I had been watching to the west passed suddenly overhead, bringing with them a literal gale. I had no choice but to go wherever the wind was driving us. We were nearly hydroplaning. Peter was near the bow, Matthew in his tiny red bathing suit was clinging to the mast. Neither boy spoke. I told them to hang on. Just as we skidded onto the far shore a woman came out her cabin and down to us, saying she had seen us and worried about us being capsized. While the boys warmed up inside, I phoned Adolf's. Cheryl came around and picked us up. I spent most of the next day's afternoon sailing the boat back, into the wind, tacking almost pointlessly across a distance maybe four times what we had travelled the day before. I might have been seen in by a nervous, excited crowd. Instead they were inside

having supper. It took a few minutes of me presenting myself before anyone seemed to remember who I was.

But all's well that ends well. My enthusiasm and confidence always rebounded once back on land. I tried to talk Cheryl's Dad into joining me. He wouldn't do it. Until the last day while we were packing things into the cars. Then he admitted that I had survived and said, 'I should have tried it.'

Lunch was usually at noon sharp. Sandwiches, sliced meat (ham, moose sausage) and peanut butter. It was on Cheryl's insistence that this meal be kept simple.

Depending on the afternoon, we went fishing. Peter caught three. One slipped his hook. We got a look at it. Papa estimated it was the largest of all, maybe a 4 pound pickerel. The rest of us caught zero (unless one counts Peter's hook Matthew caught in his life belt). Matthew's job was to reel hooks in and steer the boat. Eventually this wore thin, and he wanted to go back. On another occasion, Cheryl went with her dad and the two boys. That time they caught 9 pickerel. She lost her favourite hook. She came in looking terribly attractive and young in her bright orange vest and curly hair. Peter got shut out. Matthew decided fairly early that he wanted to go back. I spent that same three-hour period on Ed's sailboat.

On another occasion I canoed to what had appeared to be an island, which ended up being separated from land by a canoe-width span of decay-stenching mud. I landed the boat, startled a crane from its nest (and myself) in the reeds. The two most lasting things from that adventure were these memories and terribly burned thighs.

The boys spent much of their time on the beach. The Kasdorf's joined us once. Ed brought his boat. We skied. Ed skied too in his white cap, shirt, shorts, and glasses.

On two afternoons, Cheryl and Erik went with her parents to PA. Peter, Matthew and I joined them later for a meal.

Suppers varied. We ate one meal at 'Amy's on 2nd, one at Adolph's with Ed, Shirley and daughter Dawn as guests, once at Ed's for hamburgers, another time at Ed's for fish and bones, and skiing until it was so dark Cheryl's dad hit rocks with the motor.

After suppers we walked, usually along the shore in front of cabins, Erik in a canvas framework on my back, his hands gripping the bar or striking my head. We drove once to Emma lake to look at cabins, and once to the where Emma and Christopher are connected by a creek, much of which is a large swamp which cabins of both lakes back onto. Just north of this we came across a vacant summer camp with a zip-line that the boys tested. Parts of the afternoon were spent reading while the boys napped.

The boys were in bed usually by 9. Once Peter and Matthew were down, Cheryl and I would take Erik in the car to lull him to sleep. Or we'd walk. Once we tried swimming, but by sundown the breeze was coming up, Cheryl found it too cold. Once everyone went to Kasdorf's to bathe. I stayed back with Erik, whose only problem there was keeping away from the log-burning stove. Several evenings we all drove to Logan's for 25¢ ice-cream cones, twice to the Trading Post for cheese bread, twice to Fat Emma's in Christopher Lake for great French fires and lemon meringue pie. I read two novels, David Copperfield and The Natural . Cheryl tried to get into Michener's Texas. Her dad read a book on Custer called

Save The Last Bullet For Yourself. We were usually in bed no later than 11. We never knew when Erik would be up in the morning, or how many times before then. The outhouse was a busy place, with its soft earthen path and air heavy with the aroma of...spruce.

Since our return Monday evening, we have been busy. Cheryl has her lists of things to do and I stroke the items off, one by one. Nothing very exciting, except Adolph's plan to help me finish our basement. He came Thursday to look it over. This week Cheryl and the boys have been to VBS. Cheryl is teaching a handful of boys that need a lot of attention. Each day at home she shakes her head. She is also busy getting materials ready for fall. The table usually covered with scraps of bristle board and paper. I've spent lots of time with Erik, doing odd jobs, working on Amnesty. Matthew went with me to school on Friday to copy materials. He stood where the paper came out and kept them straight. Cheryl had the boys downtown and got great buys at Eaton's. I joined them for coffee at Kresge's. Another day we went to Wolfe's Carpets to get prices for our basement flooring, and had coffee at Robin's. We ate supper at Delphi's. Erik got his first baby plate, Cheryl and I split a Caesar's Salad, the boys shared a pizza.

Erik is walking almost non-stop. He lurches a bit, but turns corners without hurting himself. He carries his bottle of milk wherever someone is seated and to his mind waiting to hold him, hands it up, says 'Ta', and climbs aboard.

Peter and I have been out for tennis. He had his best day Sunday afternoon at Griffith's. I used my new Donnay aluminum racquet.

The boys visited the dentist on Monday. Matthew lay, his mouth wide open, his eyes squeezed shut, asking inaudible questions until he was told his mouth doesn't need to be so wide just yet. The dental assistants found him funny. As engaging as he tries to be, one can sense how tense he really is. Peter is losing two teeth on the bottom. The permanent one is visible just beneath. Matthew is losing two on the bottom, one on the top. We are planning to have photos of the boys. It's better if we do it before they lose everything.

Peter Butt phoned Monday evening. We're planning a trip to Meadow Lake on the 21st. I suppose that will be our last adventure of the summer.

We watched Karate Kid II last night. During the scene where the hero is being taught to focus, I noticed both Peter and Matthew going through the same hand motions – hands going straight to the side, then back to the chest, then forward. Erin and Shauna toyed noisily with Erik.

Wednesday, August 19

Erik walks everywhere, until he falls. Then he crawls to the nearest chair or to the wall, hoists himself back up, and walks again. He walks as if the floor were covered with a thin coating of glue, and each step required pulling the foot free: jerky. He walks with his hands above his head, grinning, hair curly, long at the ears. He takes the straightest path to his goal. Say it's the stereo. It doesn't matter what's in his way – Cheryl's or my body, a chair – he goes straight at it, head down, pushing, pressing, clambering over.

Peter has two weeks of swimming at the Phys. Ed building. He has added nose-plugs to his equipment. He swims with boys and girls a head taller and two years older, but goes like a tiger. His butterfly is much better than a year ago, both in how far his body comes out of the water and the discipline of his dolphin kick. He is friendly with two or three others; lots of laughing and chatting on the pool deck.

Matthew joined me today, so after dropping Peter off, we went for a walk. I'm without my glasses, so he pretended to help get me where I needed to go, holding my hand forward, steering. He asked me again if we can get a sucker, like yesterday, from the old commissionaire at the Plant Technology building where Dad works. He gave it to Matthew as we went through building security. He pointed out whatever caught his eye in the dim hallway.

Sunday, August 23

Just back from Meadow Lake.

We drove up Friday, and spent two nights with Peter and Louise. They live on a quarter section of bush and wheat eight miles south of the town. Peter, Louise, Cheryl, Erik and I went for a walk around the land, through the bush, along a stream, passed several fresh beaver dams and what remains of several after spring thaw. We walked around the 80 acres of wheat and back home. We saw a kingfisher, a blue jay, a headless rabbit, an area where the wheat had been flattened (bear, deer, moose, elk?), countless trees toppled but not yet moved by the beaver, a muskrat, a ridge of fir, and crows everywhere rising, circling, settling in the trees. Louise and Cheryl picked a few blueberries and bunchberries. 'Not much taste,' Louise said about the latter, 'but good for medicinal purposes.' During the hour we were gone, Peter, Matthew and Omeasoo played in the yard, in the barn and old log house, around the teepee by the pond, down by the stream and rabbit-hutches, back and forth on the yard with two dogs on their heels—King is German Shepherd, Patsy is part Poodle—throwing sticks, hiding from each other, exploring the house and barn, sitting with the rabbits in the hutch, and with Willard the Rat, a Guinea pig that sits in a box in a corner of the kitchen. It looks up with frightened red eyes and makes the sound of a gentle alarm. Erik liked to walk to the box to hit it and set off the alarm.

Saturday's weather was warm and sunny. After a lazy start, we drove to the town and on to Kimball Lake to spend the afternoon on the beach. Peter and I rented a Sunfish sailboat. Unfortunately the wind was coming straight into shore, so with the time we had we couldn't do much more than scuttle up and down the shoreline.

Cheryl and Louise stayed on the beach with the kids. Omeasoo's voice was raspy from the cold water, though it went non-stop in the dis-jointed way she has of talking.

After the BBQed steak supper, we sat around a fire in the teepee. As chilly and dark as it was outside, we were content inside, talking, watching the flames. Erik sat awhile with Cheryl, and grew more intrigued by the light and heat of the flames. Eventually Matthew and Omeasoo fell asleep. Peter and I took them in. Cheryl and Louise remained until the fire died.

It rained Sunday morning. After visiting, Cheryl and Louise drove to the Flying Dust Band reserve. Cheryl bought moccasins from a 75-year old 'mother' (guardian) of 11 or 12 children, now mostly full grown. Louise spoke to them in Cree. They answered in English.

After a stand-up lunch and conversation on the back porch in the hot sun, Peter and I took the kids into Meadow Lake to see the Hospital. Our Peter was particularly interested in the x-ray images of fractures, cancer of the lung, constipation and gas, and a bent spine.

We started for home with great reluctance at 4:40. Erik and Matthew slept nearly the whole way.

Sunday, September 13

We have celebrated Erik's first birthday. The Grambos joined us from Brooks Alberta. Erik got a Coleco Music Van with a button to activate a merry-go-round. He got a camera he poses for, a Cabbage Patch kid he leaves face down in his toy-box.

Matthew has begun Kindergarten with Mrs Limin. For the first two weeks his class will alternate days with the other. After that he will go every day. On Thursday he came with me to my high school soccer practice. He held my hand everywhere we went, then refereed the scrimmage. He started gym on Saturday. They played on the high bar, ropes and vault. Today he came with me to Isaachsen's farm and helped dig vegetables. Cheryl and I aren't used to the gap in his front teeth.

Peter began gym last Tuesday. We're scaling back. He will attend only twice a week instead of four times. This was a tough decision. He is enjoying himself as much now as he did last year. He told me today he doesn't like being called a child. He doesn't mind 'kid', but 'youth' is better. He went to Reed Moore's for a birthday party. They went roller-skating at Saint's. Though the soles of his feet were made sore by the skates, he said over and over how much he enjoyed himself. He bought himself a skateboard.

Since last writing, we went to Candle Lake with the Haugruds, brother Matthews' family, and the Kardashes. We drove up Sunday, September 5. The weather was cool and windy in the day. Though the trees between the lake and Sandy Beach campground provided some shelter. Even so, it was so cold at night we had to continually check that Peter and Matthew stayed covered. Erik

slept with us. Monday was sunny, but scarcely warm enough to ski. Les went out. Colin and Mark and brother Matthew followed. Ernie skied last. We filmed him using his camera. Mom and Dad showed up at 11. After a short visit and some food, we headed home. Cheryl and I were the first to leave. The CB radio set Les had lent us was turned over to Dad to use for the drive home. The forests are turning with the fall, providing us many beautiful views. We arrived by 5:30. School began the next day. Cheryl had a lot to do to be ready.

Sunday, September 27

Fall continue to be glorious. The trees are at their best. Every day the temperature rises to 20° with light breezes. We walked as a family along the Meewasin trail. Peter and Matthew both skateboarded. Matthew's came as a birthday gift. It has handlebars. He is five.

They went far ahead of us. We got nearly to 42nd Street bridge before turning back. They finished, still full of pep. Erik rode in the stroller. He pointed at nearly every bird in the crowded sky, at the river, his forehead conveying an expression of puzzlement, telling us something important.

Peter is going to the gym 8 hours a week after all. 2½ on Monday and Tuesday, 3 on Saturday. It doesn't seem so bad now that we've done it. Peter is grateful to be busy. He's with boys more his age. He uses handgrips on the rings and high bar.

Cheryl's parents drove to the coast on Saturday by way of the United States. They'll be gone for 3 weeks. My parents are off to the Soviet Union on Friday. They'll be back by October 31. Michael and Cathy are in NYC, heading back to San Diego tomorrow. In a few days Michael begins a 3-week cruise to the Galapagos Islands.

Grandpa Skarsgard suffered a stroke a week ago. Grandma is presently on the phone with Cheryl telling her he seems to be improving. He is at City Hospital.

I had my vasectomy Friday at 1:30 at City Hospital. Dr Fentie did the honours. We haven't told the boys. Matthew would be very upset to find out he's not getting his sister.

Erik has become screechy. Cheryl thinks he's frustrated that he can't actually say what he is thinking. When he is stuck under a bed, or can't take apart certain toys, or can't get at the stereo, or can't get the door open, he lets out a short scream. He gets up on all the furniture, moves chairs to the piano to take things down. We got photos back from The Bay - Erik is sitting with coveralls and no shirt.

Cello lessons are on. Peter is practicing every morning at 8. Cheryl is finding half-time teaching heavy on top of everything at home. It's no surprise, since everything she does is to the nth degree.

Sunday, October 12

We're nearly at the end of the Thanksgiving Day holiday. Summer weather continues. Temperatures get to 24, winds are calm, the sun is, well, sunny.

We went for a 3.7 km walk around the University area. Peter and Matthew skateboarded. They were so hot that they took refuge in the shade of the spruce trees in President Murray Park while waiting for us to catch up. Erik sat some in the stroller, then stood more. Once back in the car, Peter asked for air conditioning.

Grandpa Skarsgard is not well. Cheryl got a call at 10 this morning from Anne Skarsgard saying that he had a high fever and was not expected to last out the day. Cheryl went with others to see him. The temperature had come down by the afternoon. She was back in five hours.

We went for a short walk on the Meewasin trail but returned sooner than we wanted because darkness comes so quickly now. We had ice-cream at the Dairy Queen. Erik ate a Dilly bar while sitting between us. All we heard from him was 'Mmmmmm'.

Matthew's top tooth shows no sign of coming. Cheryl took Erik to the clinic for his annual shots.

Peter, Matthew and I played tackle football yesterday and today. Erik refereed. The Barbarians (me) tied the Scrappers (them) 35-35. Real pluck shown by the underdog Scrappers after falling behind 14-0. A time-out was called when a Scrappers player went to the sideline crying about being poked in the eye. The ref was also injured. He stayed on the field, his head down, also crying about his eye hurting.

Sunday, October 18

Erik gets further, faster, more furiously every day. He moves more chairs more places to get at more things. We've had to tip most of them on their sides. He grunts away, trying to get them back on their feet, and when that doesn't work, makes high-pitched sounds at whoever is in the room, pointing at the problem, demanding it be fixed. We've had to move the turntable from the living room to a shelf in the basement. The needle has been ruined again and can't be made safe no matter how many obstacles are put in his way. The chair we've pushed against the cabinet is no barrier at all. He climbs on top to turn on the TV. He has turned into a comic. He'll do anything for laughs. Tilting his head sideways and turning round and round until he loses his balance. If we laugh hard, he laughs harder. Perhaps it's his laugh in his ears that persuades him how much fun everyone else is having. Sleeping in the crib doesn't go nearly so smoothly. Putting him down for the afternoon nap means crying until someone picks him up and returns to the living room for him to sleep on the floor.

While shaving this morning I listened with great enjoyment to the sounds of the house. Cheryl was practicing a Junior Choir piece on the piano, Peter was in the bedroom following along on a recorder, and Matthew kept saying to Erik, 'Quit hauling everything out!' He was trying to stop Erik from pulling all the clothes out of the bottom dresser drawer and throwing them on the floor. (Hm. See any time in 1984; Sunday January 29, 1984 in particular.)

Peter and Matthew are progressing on the cello. Erik is presently pushing Curious George on my lap ahead of his arrival there.

Sunday, October 25

At 5:30, just before the beginning of a World Series final game between the Cardinals and Twins, the temperature is 6. Earlier it had been 12. Above. What more could we hope for.

Fact: I can put my thumb in one of Erik's armpits and my index finger in the other.

Peter and Matthew spent almost all afternoon playing in their bedroom. Occasionally one came out to complain about the other:

'Dad, Peter isn't being very nice.'

'Dad.' Peter is exasperated. He has no other words.

'Dad, Peter pushed me back and I hit my hand on the thing you nail things into.'

'Matthew can be a bit of a brat.'

Just as quickly they're back in the room for another long bout of quiet. With the door closed. Erik hates being shut out. He stands with his back to the door and bumps it with his bum, screaming out now and then.

All three boys had their hair cut on Friday at 4, simultaneously, each in his own chair. A sort-of barbershop takeover, Three Stooges style.

Driving to church, Erik sat on Cheryl's lap. I leaned towards him and said, 'Hi Erik.' He answered, 'Hi Dad.' Everyone laughed. Erik didn't laugh. Then he did, loudest of all.

Peter, Matthew and I cleaned out the yard yesterday, loaded the branches on the truck I borrowed from Les, and drove to the

dump. All of us ended up at Carol's. We delivered a spruce tree we dug out of our back yard and stayed for coffee. I have booked the school's video camera for next weekend.

Tuesday, November 10

Today is Parent-Teacher Interviews at Lakeview. Peter brought home his best report ever, and is excited about what others might find to say about that. Matthew is saying he doesn't like school. He complains every morning about stomach-aches until Cheryl reminds him that if he isn't well enough to go to school he'll also miss Pioneer Club, or whatever else he likes to do in the evening. He wants to do 'Grade 2 stuff'. He reads to us each evening. We are very curious about his interview.

Weather stays warm. Sunny, scarcely a breeze, highs of 8 to 10, lows of -5. The boys played outside yesterday for most of the afternoon.

Erik says, 'Cock-a-doodle-do.'

Sunday, November 29

No snow. Temperature is 6. People everywhere in light jackets.

Peter bought his own copy of Bobby Fischer Teaches Chess and spent 1½ hours working on it last night.

The boys went for a second try for photos at Fong's. The first time, Erik sabotaged Fong's good humour by breaking away and touching a large photograph on display. Fong then rushed several snaps but didn't produce anything we liked. We arranged a second sitting for yesterday. Unfortunately Erik is ill with an intestinal virus, hasn't eaten for 5 days, and wasn't his most photogenic self. Matthew is still self-conscious about having only one visible tooth out front and sucks it every time someone wants to take a picture.

Matthew wants cello practice every morning. Cheryl spends 15-20 minutes with him, but he continues alone for 20-30 minutes. He has only 2 songs to learn in Book I. Peter will have completed Book III this week. We spent \$42 on Book IV and the companion tape. He is eager to play for others. He has offered to play cello for his music teacher at school. He is asked to perform his recorder solo every time the class is practicing.

Adolph Peters hasn't come yet to begin work on the basement. We have the plans. We've put dibs on a carpet.

We've cleared plenty of space in the basement for hockey. Matthew is in and out of the game. Erik wanders around with a Styrofoam helmet and one white boot. Peter tries all sorts of dekes and body-checks, determined to score. The last game finished with at 17-17 tie. Our one fan stayed upstairs.

It isn't the weather to put one in a Christmas mood. Stores are open, lights are shining, decorations are everywhere, but it feels Octoberishly premature.

Joel is done with the Navy. He thinks he has a job in Vancouver with a window-making company.

Cheryl, Peter and Matthew have gone up to the hospital to be with her Grandpa. He had a bad night Friday, is much better now. Cheryl's parents have suspended their Hawaii plans.

Money is tight. Taxes have to be paid from an empty account. I'll have to drive cab over the holidays, and teach night school if the chance comes.

Brother Matthew and Cheryl moved to PA two weeks ago. He got a job with a small architectural firm. Both enjoy living there.

Over the sound of the boys playing is a hint of the Robert Shaw Chorale Christmas album I borrowed from the library to tape.

Erik is having a good sleep. Maybe he'll behave at the Advent service this evening. Both Peter and Matthew are singing in the choir.

The Grey Cup game begins in 10 minutes.

1988

Sunday, March 20

It has been too long since my last entry.

Erik is talking all the time now. Nearly everything is understandable. He repeats everything we say with minor modifications. We say skunk, he says 'nunk'. Nobody is happier with his verbal skill than he is. He speaks, then claps and waves his hands above his head. He brings books everywhere, usually with a bottle clenched in his teeth by its nipple, and offers to sit with whoever is sitting down, squirming into his or her lap. He has begun with a blanket. It began with him going to the bedroom, freeing his hands by clenching the bottle's nipple in his teeth, choosing one from the pile in his crib, pulling at it through the slats, complaining loudly if it gets stuck. It goes everywhere, and if he's not carrying it, it's hanging on a doorknob, slung over a chair, piled on the floor. Now he begins the day with the blanket. At 6:55 he calls, 'Dad!' When I arrive, he's standing, his blanket heaped in front on crib rail. I bring him to bed, he drinks milk, then rolls around while Cheryl and I get dressed.

Erik and Matthew are inseparable during the day. If Matthew is sitting somewhere, Erik runs from behind and pulls him back. They chase each other in the living room and hallway, shrieking, reckless.

Erik pees every time he is put on the toilet. Each time is a big moment. He has a few ways to celebrate, to self-congratulate.

Matthew draws endlessly. He copies from books, draws from memory. Mostly people. 'Can I take artist lessons?' he asks.

Peter has a gym competition coming up this Sunday. Provincials. We're driving to Regina Saturday night, returning Sunday evening. Peter is very excited and anxious. He'll be performing new routines he has not yet mastered. Cadet B.

Cheryl signed up for 2 bookkeeping classes at the YWCA. The boys stood in line with her. I was out in the cab. She is excited. Classes begin Tuesday, March 29.

I will be at an Oxfam meeting Tuesday from 6 – 8:30 to meet 5 Salvadorian refugees.

Monday, May 2

We're busier now than ever. The boys' schedules have made things quite hectic. For Peter and Matthew it is gym, cello, Pioneer club, choir and school. Add soccer practices and games to Peter's days. After two weeks of intensive practice, Peter's choir performed Psalty's Worship Workshop. He is also getting ready to play in a quartet in the Festival on Saturday, May 7. The piece is Blow the Wind Southerly. Two practices remain. They performed it twice already, on Solo day and at yesterday's recital. Matthew attended a birthday party. Peter's class performed two poems at the Festival and received a score of 86. Peter performed his first unassisted roundoff/handspring/back tuck/back layout on the high bar. We remain undecided which way to go with his gym next year. It only means more times per week than now. Peter has said he's not ready for such a single-minded commitment. And as parents, we value other things he's doing and don't want them to take a back seat. And we want our time with him too. He's only 9.

Matthew continues in his particular line of development. He's at once independent and expressive of affection and feeling for us. He spends a lot of time in the morning playing on his own. That's how he wants it. After school, or if time permits on weekends, he canvasses the neighbourhood, going to one of his friend's homes to see if he can play, then coming home, telling us that so-and-so isn't home, so he's going to someone else's to check. He and Peter have decorated their spokes with plastic reflectors. With all the flash and colour, they look like circus performers. Matthew is determined to get his training wheels removed. We're not as confident about that as he is. He dreams in his sweet but (where safety is concerned) maddening fashion, riding into parked cars,

and who knows what else. He doesn't tell us. A few days ago Cheryl sent him to school with strict instructions to stay out of the water. He came home dry but covered with mud. 'You didn't say anything about mud,' he said in righteous defense.

Joan Ardell had premature twins. One is being closely monitored. After a week he seems to be doing much better.

Erik is promising to be as stubborn and headstrong as his brothers. He is in the midst of his terrible twos. He wants to do everything himself, is almost impossible to feed, and points his fingers and says 'No!' at whatever he's been asked to do. 'Do you want to get out of the tub?' 'No!' Pointing. 'It's time for bed.' 'No!' Jabbing his finger. 'Do you want to go to Mama's and Papa's?' Pause. 'Papa's?' Pause. 'K.'

He has words for most things. 'Ooshes' for shoes, 'ocks' for socks, 'noose' for nose. He loves the outdoors. He pursues relentlessly the next door cat, and when he catches it, pokes it until it can't take any more and escapes. He loves sitting with Peter and Matthew. He rolls over them, stirs them up for wrestling, or embraces one in a moment of peace.

The Israelis are trying to mop up the Occupied Territories, but drawing a lot of unsympathetic attention from the world.

Hockey playoffs have reached the Conference Final round. Peter and Matthew like to watch a little. They make a point of cheering for the wrong team.

Cheryl is taking her accounting class. She finds it easy. I hope she finds a way to apply it, make it useful for her.

Carol and Les opened Darby Doughnuts outlet last week on 42nd Street. Business is steady so far, growing.

I've been driving Radio Cab a fair bit since Easter. Car 42 for Yuki. Cash to put in a drawer.

Peter raked the entire backyard yesterday. Matthew and Peter made a city in the sandbox. Erik tries to stomp it down and collapsing the tunnels.

School limps along. I'm thinking more about Law school. We won't afford anything until 89/90, in spite of my parents' generous offer.

Sunday, June 12

Summer is almost here. Peter and Matthew are busy. Cello is nearly done, but they're both playing soccer. Peter is discussing next year's commitments. Cheryl and I are both busy with the school spring rituals. Field trips to farms, Batoche, Victoria School House, kickball.

Matthew now demands that we take the training wheels off. He says he's 'only' 5 and can't wait to be 6. It gives us headaches to watch him ride. Daydreaming off the curb into the middle of the street. He tries very hard to keep his presence of mind, but it ain't working.

Yesterday, Peter, Matthew and I went to Griffith's to play tennis. Matthew was thrilled. 'I love it when people teach me things,' he said.

We've got some plans for the holidays. For a week beginning the first day Cheryl, Peter and Matthew will go to Vancouver on the train with Cheryl's Grandmother. Erik and I will stay home. (This is the happiest Borghild has been since Christmas.) I've arranged with Yuki to drive cab July 11-18. The boys will be registered in summer sport camps. Perhaps we'll put Peter in gym camp at Emma Lake. Erik will be through with Outpatients by July 15, but not fully recovered for 10 more days. We are planning to camp in Cypress Hills, then carry on to Rapid City to meet Cheryl's parents. Maybe Lloyd as well. We're wanting to fit in a weekend at Chitik Lake with the Haugruds. It's going to be tight, since the only free weekend seems to be when the Hedlin Reunion is booked at Watrous.

Erik talks continuously. Has troubles pronouncing 'l', 's' and 'f', but applies audible 'patches' or approximations when he's wanting to be understood. He counts, '1-2-3-4-Go!' then, without us understanding the logic, follows with a few notes of a song. He runs not quite in a straight line. He scars the walls with knives and pens. He wants to be read to. We're taking him off the bottle. He hates us for this. 'Bottle!' he says. 'Cup,' we answer. He runs to the fridge and stands there with the door open, searching for the bottle. He refuses the cup, cries angrily for half an hour, then forgets he was ever thirsty. He is unbendable, perverse (show him how to do something one way, he insists on doing it another way. Like me, Cheryl says.) He is in a real bed now. The boys are all in their own rooms. Matthew and Erik are upstairs, Peter is in the basement in what was for a short time the 'guest' room. Everyone has more room now. Except me. I have less of the bed than I used to, fewer drawers, less closet space. Next I'll be walking sideways in the hallway.

Erik is calling me from his bed. It is 8:50 pm and he doesn't care. As easy as it would be for this bull-headed boy to just get out of bed, he doesn't. Well, sometimes he stands by his bed and waits for someone to retrieve him.

'Dad. Daaaady! Daaaaaaah!!' Silence. Silence?

Matthew is happy to have his own bedroom. He didn't like fighting with Peter. (He started most of the fights.) One on occasion he accused Peter of making him lie under the bed. In fact he was hiding under the bed after getting Peter angry. He complained that Peter snored. Matthew snores. He wouldn't have heard Peter snoring if he lay awake all night trying.

Last weekend was spent tenting at Pike Lake. A Pioneer campout. 41 straight through. Erik stayed behind with Mama and Papa.

Cheryl is hoping for full-time next year. She's likely to be at Buena Vista, teaching Grade 3 or a 2/3 split. There's not much else available just now.

Sunday, June 27

37 with high winds. Perfect for kite flying? We were in Lakeview Park. Peter caught the string in 2 different trees. He wasn't happy. I used Matthew to 'anchor' one kite while helping Peter with the other. Erik slept in the Pontiac and Cheryl read.

While driving on Idylwyld past the mostly demolished remains of the Buy-Rite furniture store, Erik said, 'Oh gross'.

While changing Erik for church this morning, he used me in an anatomy lesson. He pointed at one of my aureole and said 'button'. He pointed at the other and said 'button'. My nose was also 'button', my two eyes were 'eye' and 'eye', and my eyebrows were 'broom' and 'broom.'

Peter's birthday was split over three days. Mama, Papa and Cheryl's Grandma came Monday night for ice-cream cake. He got a clock radio with a night light and a flashlight. Tuesday morning we gave him (and Matthew) Walkman/radios. Friday night he had invited 4 friends for a sleepover: Cory Friess, Aaron Boyko, Brody Funk and Jeff Boldt. We ordered 4 large pizzas, went Putt 'n Bouncing—Matthew mixed very well, especially with Brody—came home for sundaes, to the park for a dusk-lit soccer game, then home again where the boys finally—11:45? 12:14?—went quiet in the basement, and were up again just after 6:30 for a pancake breakfast and more play. Peter had a lot of fun.

Dad is in Ottawa for an ASHRAY meeting. We took my mother to Darby's for coffee this afternoon, then to St. Paul's where Carol is staying with Graeme who is having his tonsils and adenoids removed and tubes inserted.

Friday, July 29

Tomorrow we leave for holidays to Cypress Hills and the western states. Cheryl's parents will accompany us to Rapid City and maybe Yellowstone Park. Everyone is excited. Tonight we're going to Gordie Howe Park to see the opening ceremonies and first two games of the International Softball Federation World Championship. Erik may stay the night at Cheryl's parents.

The boys are fully settled into their summer. They attended art classes at the Mendel for one week. Peter attended Tennis-and-Golf camp for a week, the same week I was driving cab 12-13 hours a day and Cheryl was doing school work. He was most thrilled with the golfing part.

Erik had a little treatment performed at City Hospital, hence our timing for the trip. He is fully recovered.

Peter helped Matthew learn to ride a two-wheeler. This happened in a single day. The next day Matthew (and every day since) he insisted on us seeing his tricks, like popping up his front tire and skidding the back tire. He has improved very much after some long bike-rides, which gave us the chance to observe and comment. Mostly our advice had to do with staying close to the curb and proceeding in a straight line. He is still iffy about street-crossings. On one ride we got into East College Park. That's where Erik fell asleep in his chair on the back of Cheryl's bike. She had to hold up his head with one hand and steer with the other. It was a long ride home.

More of Erik's character comes every day. He has the luxury of two older brothers who'd rather give him whatever he wants than listen to him complain. At every encounter he walks away with a

grand prize. We're trying to put a stop to this, thinking what he might become if this continues for a few years. He speaks, though there are still a few words only we understand. He doesn't say 'I' or 'sh'. 'Mamew seeping.' He eats very little at meals, and makes up during all the hours in between by asking for milk or juice. He went with Peter and Matthew to Erin's and Shauna's. We weren't at all surprised when Erin brought him back early and raced away. He likes to sit with books. Plural. He points at everything, names it, hurries to pick the next book. He fell in the bathtub and bit his tongue quite severely. His mouth was full of blood and he cried hard for a little while. Shortly, however, he stopped crying, said 'hurt' for sympathy, and made us kiss the tip of his tongue and both knees, which have been scraped in unrelated incidents. He refers to motorcycles as 'Muggas' when with Papa. Which is a bit of a tease, since he says 'motorcycle' to everyone else. He points at everything, as did his brothers. An airplane passes overhead. 'Daddy, pane in ki, gone.'

Matthew's tooth has finally shown up. Where he should have two, he is getting only one. He'll need orthodontic work. Just like Peter. Erik will with our luck go the same way.

The boys are at home and away in other homes playing with friends. Guns (they fight over who gets the rifle), housework, hide-and-seek. Matthew often gets frustrated by all the technicalities that Peter introduces at strategic times in games. You can hear his voice from blocks away. A small problem we're trying to address.

Sunday, July 30

Yesterday we drove to Williston. We spent today driving to Rapid City. We spent the day driving from Williston. Cheryl's parents are with us. It was hot. 103. The Pontiac is packed to the gills. Our a/c was limping. The boys were spread over two cars. Peter spent most of the time in the cool of Cheryl's parent's car. When he wasn't watching through the rear window, waving at our blistering faces, he was dozing in the back seat. Erik rode with them from Williston to Belfield (near Theodore Roosevelt National Park) with a foot against the steering wheel, feeling its mild vibrations, getting lulled to sleep. Matthew stayed with us most of the time. When alone in the back seat he centered the baby seat and sat with a foot on each of our shoulders, listening to Paul Simon's Graceland on his Walkman. The a/c conked out for good at Belle Fourche, 90 minutes north-west of Rapid city. Cheryl and I angled for a radio station that wasn't country/western. No chance.

We ate at the Trapper's Kettle in Williston and Belfield. Erik and I ate and walked outside while the others finished. In Williston Erik and Matthew picked lava rocks off the street and hucked them. Matthew handed me a handful of pebbles to keep for his collection. In Belfield we found three old wagons of the sort used a century ago in pioneer caravans. One was covered. When the others joined us, Papa had us pose for picture after picture. We warned him the sun was going to fry his brain. It was the only way to get him to quit.

The hotels enroute had indoor and outdoor pools. Erik enjoyed the water. He wanted to be carried or thrown in the air, but wouldn't let us get near the side of the pool if it meant getting out.

Erik talks all the time. He gets especially animated when a motorcycle goes by. 'Atch, Peter.' He makes motorcycle sounds and pretends to work the throttle with his hands.

We went all the way from Buffalo to Belle Fourche with no services. We nearly ran out of gas. It was a long climb to a ridge, then a sharp decline. Smoke creates a haze. Fires are burning around Rapid City.

We have neighbouring rooms, 167 and 169, at the Ramada Inn. These access the deck of the swimming pool. The bathrooms have no lock. Erik adjusts easily. We put him on the bed to sleep. He looks around, smiles at everyone, kicks up his feet, sings, then falls silent. I bought a soft drink to split with Cheryl while we read.

After supper Cheryl took restless Erik for a walk around the hotel. From the back there's a good view of the city. In time I replaced Cheryl. Just as we started our walk, Erik said, 'No more... Mom...see Peter!' I talked him into going just a little further. We strolled across the extensive parking lot, noting the number of states on the car plates.

Tuesday, August 2

Yesterday we went to Mt. Rushmore. Very crowded, though temperatures were way down from Sunday's 105. We watched a large group of Japanese posing by the lookout platform while a white guy laboured through cameras piled on the asphalt. We spent the afternoon at Keystone, as bad a tourist trap as any carnival midway, with not a single attraction pretending to be authentic. Hard selling if not outright barking.

The day was spent travelling the wildlife loop around Custer State Park. Driving was slow, up steep slopes, around sharp turns and along spiraling bridges, through tunnels so narrow the car has no room for error. An RV had a difficult time navigating through one while cars waited, the lines grew long, at both entrances, and people were out with their cameras, perhaps hoping to catch a mishap in the making. We encountered a herd of bison and small groups of mules. One ate Cheese Balls straight from my mouth.

Papa took countless pictures of different combinations of people posing in front of many views.

Lunch at the Blue Bell Café just outside the park, amidst lodge pole cabins one might see at Waskesieu: dark, spacious, substantial. Music was playing out of a 'coinola o-rola automatic instrument machine' dating back to 1901. The staff wouldn't let it be touched. A cross stood at the base of a large rock, which the boys scrambled on.

The first real camping. Tee Pee Campground. We're on the side of a hill overlooking Rapid City. It is pitch black. Cheryl is in the tent while the boys fall asleep. Crickets compete for airtime with the big trucks going up and down the steep grade of Highway 16.

Rain was coming down in the morning. Which obscured the view of a rancher from Helena, Montana in his 3500 Dodge Ram with reinforced bumpers who backed into the Pontiac and tore apart driver's side from the headlights to the door. We spent a while at a car repair shop getting the door to open and close.

Friday, August 5

We spent the day on the road. Our first stop came at 11 am in Deadwood. This after spending nearly an hour sitting in the car waiting for a parade to pass. Once parked we walked through historic Deadwood with buildings going back to the 1870s, made famous by Wild Bill Hickok and Calamity Jane. Photos abound on walls that include the less-well known characters: Potato Creek Johnny is one. We ate at the Franklin Hotel (1903)—Cheryl watched an old man holding his false teeth like a harmonica, sucking on them to remove bits of food—with a large L-shape dining room with a hardwood floor and 20-foot high pressed-tin ceiling. We bought the boys two time-piece rifles, looked around inside the No. 10 Saloon where Wild Bill was shot in the back. His chair was placed in an alcove at the entrance. His poker cards —‘Dead man’s hand’—were framed and set on a post by the bar. The walls were covered with framed memorabilia, the floor covered with sawdust. In that dark, crowded place, we were made quite conspicuous as Papa photographed a few or all of us at different tables, each with its own noteworthy artifact serving as backdrop. Peter laughed out loud at the sign by a chair used to prop open a door that read: ‘This is the only chair in Deadwood that Wild Bill Hickok wasn’t shot in.’ Worthy of mention is the Harley Davidson bike convention that clogged up the streets. Not a man under 35 years. Not a woman under 200 pounds.

We went to Story Book Island. Matthew and Erik raced around while Peter sat wretchedly in the car with stomach flu.

We left about 1:30 with Erik in the back seat of our dented, unconditioned Pontiac. We took the I-90 west to a small town just outside Gillette. Everyone woke up for lunch. We ate. We drove

the remaining 150 miles to Sheridan. The smoke from forest fires obscures the mountains. We found a reasonable motel with 3 beds owned by a family from the Middle East.

We ate at Perkins' 'Steak-Bake-'n-Ache', had a few laughs about the day, played at Kennebec Park on interesting slides, swings, a working shovel, rocking animals, and sand pits. Peter, recovered from yesterday, raced with his brothers from feature to feature, more noisily than the other children. Matthew and Erik ('Air-rack' is what he says, repeating it every time someone calls him, because he enjoys the sound of it) bathed, then Peter and Matthew played guns, then everyone went to bed.

Tuesday, August 9

The day after arriving in Sheridan, we made our way slowly to Cody. The first 60 miles through Big Horn National Forest brought us through spectacular climbs to an elevation of 8500 feet. The grade at times became so steep we were reduced to 45 mph. While stopping at the Visitor's Centre to look into the deep river gorge, we noticed heavy black smoke coming from beyond the next bend. Given the dryness, we assumed part of the forest was on fire. We didn't expect to find an RV in full flame. Waiting with the rest of the traffic, within 45 minutes it had collapsed, with only blackened framework remaining. The owners were up the road, standing amidst the curious. Park workers were above the RV in the trees creating a firebreak.

We ate lunch in Greybull by the Bighorn River. We shopped for groceries and enjoyed the luxury of air-conditioned respite from the hot car. We found a city park, set the food on blankets, and ate while the boys played on swings and painted tractor tires. They wanted to stay longer.

We got only as far as Cody. By 4 it seemed too late to try to drive to Yellowstone. The boys have had enough driving. We made the decision to stay while eating ice-cream at the Dairy Queen. Cheryl and I went looking for a campground, located the Gateway Campsite, set up our tent, then joined her parents for supper at Buffalo Bill's Irma Hotel, named for his daughter. It was a unique place with high tin-pressed ceilings and cherry wood bar, built in 1902 for \$100,000. Erik was fussy, so I took him for a walk up and down the street past stores full of western-style products. We washed our clothes at the Wild West Laundromat, bought rodeo tickets, left Erik with Mama and Papa at their hotel, and made it to

the stadium just west of Cody in time for opening ceremonies. We sat in the Buzzard's Roost and watched bareback and saddle broncos, bull riding, calf roping, team calf-roping (a neat maneuvering to catch the animal's hind foot) and barrel racing, with brief comic breaks provided by 2 trained dogs, pole-climbing clowns, and our own son, Matthew, who along with other children tried his luck on the back of a galloping sheep.

We spent time in a futile search for my remaining Travellers' cheques, visited the Trading Post where Matthew and Peter picked up some sheriff badges, gassed up, and left by way of the Shoshone Canyon, past the Buffalo Bill Reservoir along a deep canyon drive, through a tunnel, to Bill Cody's hunting lodge outside Yellowstone Park east entrance. We ate lunch in the dining room. Erik went several times to the souvenir shop to hug every stuffed toy in reach, including bear-paw slippers. He pointed at the mounted moose head and said 'cow?' We entered the park at 1, followed Lake Yellowstone, saw where the forest fires were still active. Provisional water pipes crossed the road, bringing water where it's needed. We were stopped at one point, told to keep our headlights on and not stop. We reached Old Faithful by 4, watched a film, walked to the thermal holes, and returned to the geyser in time for its 4:50 eruption. Erik sat on my shoulders most of the way and asked about things with a hushed voice. His patience wore thin when Old Faithful was delayed. Mama bought us double-dip ice-cream cones. We drove away along a highway with a view of spectacular falls, fields of massive boulders, herds of elk, lines of fishermen working the river, into Mammoth Hot Springs (a tidy Cedar-built government town) where we got our last look at the park, then down to Montana. We ate supper in an expensive restaurant with a beautiful view of the southern hills, then

followed the Yellowstone river valley up Highway 89 to Livingston and onto the I-90 to Boseman.

We visited the Lewis and Clark Caverns in Montana. Mama stayed with Erik in the parking lot while we joined a tour and climbed a steep slope for $\frac{3}{4}$ miles to a man-made mouth into the caverns. Papa had a tough time. Matthew stopped half-way then rode on my back the rest of the way. At one point, with his arms in a strangle-hold around my neck, he said 'Dad, boy am I sweating.' We took photos of the Jefferson River valley, then dropped into the caverns. The guide began by warning that we mustn't touch the stalagmites and stalactites. The natural oil on our hands will affect their growth.

Shortly, Matthew asked, 'Dad, what did she say about growth?'

A bit later he asked Cheryl, 'Mom, how tall am I?'

She said, 'Well, I don't think you've grown much since you came in here.'

He looked worried.

We visited the Twilight room, Cathedral room, and so on, following steep, long, sharp-turning stairways. The guide spoke of pack-rat urine trails, bats, pigeons, the worker who in the '30s, stole into the caverns to take things he thought he might sell to raise money for his fare back home and was lost for two days in the pitch black. He told also about another worker who fell from the spiral staircase into a 90 foot hole, about the ribbon rock ('cave bacon'), popcorn, the Fantasy Room with its stone shadows. We descended the Bear's Slide, hit the 'speed bumps', went through the Chinese Back Scratchers and the 'Head-knockers' (where

Cheryl grabbed the arm of a small girl who was sitting at the edge of the black hole where the worker had died). The temperature in the caverns were 50 F year-round. They were discovered in the 1880s by a rancher who had watched steam rising from the mountain. Peter was so excited by the descent past damp walls and cellar-like staircases he said he would love to do it on his own.

We drove straight to Helena before eating at Frontier Pies. Erik slept the whole way. Add that to the hour he slept in the parking lot, that means a stretch of 3 ½ hours. After lunch we drove to Great Falls. The highway along the Dearborn and Missouri rivers is as scenic as anything. We checked with the KOA, found the \$20/night price to be exorbitant, and opted to stay at the Fox Hollow Inn with Cheryl's parents, a two-bedroom condo behind the Heritage Inn on 10th Avenue. We watched an old Hollywood Channel, The Monkees and Car 54 Where Are You?

There was shopping at Target in the Village Inn Mall for clothes and shoes and pots and pans for Lloyd, then 4Bs for lunch.

Matthew's version of 'I've Been Working on the Railroad' ends with 'And scrubbin' on the ol' banjo.'

The boys bought a 'safe dartboard' and played in the living room while Erik slept. Dennis the Menace was on TV.

While in the mall Erik sits in his umbrella stroller, then gets out and pushes it with zig-zags and wheelies, nearly taking out displays and legs, refusing to let go. We visit bookstores and toy shops while Cheryl looks for pants for the boys.

We have supper at Elmer's. Erik bit into a cherry tomato and squirted the juice on Mama.

We were in bed early. It's Canada in the morning. Matthew slept in the closet. After packing and breakfast we were on the road. We had a three-hour stop in Havre while Papa looked for unlined gloves. The roads to Consul were mostly poor. Hitting one particularly sharp bump, two plastic hubcaps were jarred loose, rolled ahead and alongside the car a short distance before veering into the ditches, and history. At about this point we parted company with Cheryl's parents. We reached Cypress Hills by 4.

We tented amidst beautiful Lodgepole pine at #32 campsite of the Rainbow campground. We roasted marshmallows, the boys played in the woods, 'thrashing' stumps with sticks, sword fighting, Erik joining in with a leafy branch. Peter tended the fire. 'I'm good at this,' he said, while tossing in wood, building the flame. We visited the swimming pool Thursday afternoon. Lots of shallow areas where Erik splashed and Matthew went gliding, imagining himself a swimmer. Last night he couldn't sleep because he dreamed he was doing tricks in gymnastics that other kids couldn't do, which meant being bumped up to the men's competition. 'Some' people were cold during the night. The breeze became cool and even in the bright sunlight the boys got chilled. I took Erik into the hot tub. He smiled as his face slowly became flushed. Peter, Matthew and I went on a short hike in the Windfall valley. Peter gave a couple of trees a hard whack with a stick and said, 'This is where my head got manufactured.' Earlier, Peter and Matthew had been arguing about who had the bigger brain.

Monday, August 15

We had originally planned to be home on Saturday, but changed it with a new plan: drive to Fort Walsh Friday morning and drive home the same day. Getting there was not easy. We went by way of Gap Road. Wherever it wasn't pure corduroy there were round rocks one could scarcely clear without taking out the oil pan and muffler. Our speed over the 40 miles rarely exceeded 20 mph. The scenery made up for it. Driving down from the heights, we passed through 'foothills', pastures, herds of cattle, and a bull staring us down at a Texas Gate. Once at the Fort, we took a rambunctious bus ride to a couple of reconstructed trading posts where life in the 1870s was re-enacted by park employees. Then we took a wagon ride along the Fort Benton trail. The boys sat at the front with the driver. We made slow progress uphill, along a twisting trail, across the Battle Creek, and finally back to the Fort. We toured around several buildings then went up the hill to the Visitors' Centre. Erik rode on my back. He said 'horse', which was my instruction to gallop. We had a small, expensive lunch, filled containers with water for the drive home, and were on our way by 2.

We took an irregular route home: From Maple Creek to Leader – where I was stopped and ticketed for not wearing my seatbelt – to the sand dunes near Prelate where we burned off steam, to Lemsford where we turned north along Highway 649 to the Lemsford ferry (where we were entertained by a heard of pronghorn antelope), then north to Glidden and Kindersley (where we went to Venice's for supper), jogging south at Rosetown to Highway 15, across to Outlook (stopping for refreshing drinks), finishing on Highway 291 (which prompted a conversation about

meeting girls) to Saskatoon. We arrived at the house in the pitch black by 9:45.

Saturday afternoon we went to the farm. Peter and Matthew went earlier in the truck with Cheryl's parents. Cheryl and I brought Erik. Peter took his first shot with the .22. Papa's story was that Peter's shot entered the same hole as his own, right next to the bulls-eye. Peter laughed and said, 'I didn't draw the same conclusion. I think I missed it completely.'

Erik went with Cheryl and Mama to the garden. He fell in the pumpkin patch. Only his face showed amidst the leaves. 'Hep. Hep, Mom.' When returning to Henry's, Cheryl hit and killed a dog. Its name was Suzie. Erik went to the barn over and over, wanting to ride the McCormick.

Monday, September 5

Labour Day Weekend: We have made final preparations for the start of school. Cheryl labeled the boys' school supplies, shoes, pens, crayons, notebooks, knapsacks. We cleaned the house, mowed the yard, husked corn. The three-day weekend has been warm, calm and sunny.

The boys were back up to the farm Saturday afternoon and all day Sunday. They helped dig vegetables, shot a pellet pistol 125 times each at tin cans, until Peter's arm was sore from cocking the barrel. They played with other kids at Betty's. Hide-and-seek around a tractor and trailer, eating, seeing little babies, hearing of more babies to come. They were home by 9 pm. Matthew slept the whole way. He was still tired and lay on the sofa until the time came to help him get to bed. He was too tired to take off his own socks. Peter was less tired. Cheery, humorous. He told us how Matthew wanted hair like Mr Rogers, adding that he reminded himself of Alfie—Alfalfa on *L'il Rascals*—giving his face just the right contortion to prove his point.

We went downtown to buy me shoes and look at waterbeds. We ate a rib and cheese-toast lunch at Cheese-toast. We took a long bike-ride to Albert Avenue up to Temperance. Erik began falling asleep. We visited with Scott and Lara Farmer's at their house on Albert and Main while Erik slept. When he woke, refreshed, we returned home and watched the 1987 Kevin Costner movie *No Way Out*.

We went with my parents and Graeme Haugrud to the go-kart track at the 33rd Street Co-op. The wait turned out to be 2½ hours. We joined the line for a while, then decided to go, in spite of

Graeme's protests: 'Mom said I could ride!' We headed over to Darby's for ice-cream. Erik and Graeme screamed and chased each other. Enough was enough. We abandoned that, went to Cheryl's parents to pick up sacks of vegetables and put the baby's crib into the garage rafters. We caught them in the middle of painting trim and garage doors. We didn't stay long.

Peter auditions for Junior Strings on Wednesday at 7:35. He has been practicing hard. We just got a call from Peter's coach, Kelly Thompson. Gym begins tomorrow at 6:30.

Tuesday, September 27

Ben Johnson has been stripped of Gold for alleged steroid use. Disappointing but not much of a surprise.

Matthew turned 6 last Friday. We couldn't have his party then, so we moved it. My mom phoned Friday morning to wish him a happy birthday, but he said, 'Well, I'm supposed to be six, but they've changed it to Sunday.' We had seven boys over for what turned out to be a noisy afternoon at home. The action continued at the bowling alley. They weren't as interested in bowling as in listening to the returning balls rumbling along the tunnel, then hurrying to the place where the balls popped up into view. Jason was feeling sick to his stomach. I took him home in a light snow storm. I returned home with the other boys. Cheryl doled out their treat bags with clear instructions to wait for home before opening them. Which must have sounded to them as: 'Wait for maybe one minute, then do whatever you want,' because in less than a minute the boys were trading their cars and poppers.

Omeasoo fell from a set of monkey bars and cracked her skull at its base. Louise came from Meadow Lake by ambulance and Peer was called up from meetings Friday night. Omeasoo was semi-comatose over the night but showed improvement through Saturday and Sunday, and released on Monday. Louise stayed in Peter's room.

Sunday, October 23

Temperature reports have the temperature remaining above normal levels until the middle of November.

Cheryl's parents returned from two weeks of travelling through the western states with 400 pounds of fruit from Penticton.

Friday night we had supper at Dolphin's with Cheryl's Grandmother. Pizza. While Peter and Matthew ate, Erik lay on the spacious window ledge. Grandma was stiff but in good spirits. Her sister Myrtle was in town Thursday night. They didn't go to bed until 4 am. They were singing Bobby McFerrin's smash hit, Don't Worry, Be Happy.

Erik provides us with a new word every day. Some we can't recognize. He is on the heels of his brothers wherever they go. This afternoon, Matthew played hide-and-seek with a friend. Erik hid also, but no-one noticed. He calls milk 'cow duce'. We're not sure how that came to be. He looks much like Matthew did at this age, but has the same gadget-fixation as Peter.

Matthew spends long periods drawing and colouring. His characters have the same look as Shel Silverstein's in *Where the Sidewalk Ends*.

Cheryl, Erik and I went for a brisk walk after supper while Peter and Matthew watched a Disney movie. Erik rode in the stroller, head back to watch the lights go by. By 6 pm, it is night.

My soccer season is finished. More free time, finally.

Peter and Matthew practice cello for nearly an hour each, from 5 to 6 pm. A recital is looming. Peter played Chorus at Redeemer

last Sunday. He is polishing the Brevall Concerto. Matthew is in Book II.

Erik was busy at church. He stood on the kneeling pads and blew the hair of the old woman and young girl sitting in front of us. They didn't let on that they knew, but when he blows, he spits, and that can't be missed.

Peter built a large complex of blocks in his bedroom, and like everything else he makes he didn't want this taken apart. I lay with him before he went to sleep. We had a good ole talk about everything he could think of to keep me pinned down.

School goes well for both boys. Matthew is a challenge, but Mrs. Reives keeps him busy and out of trouble. Peter always enjoys school. He helps in the library on Fridays, brings homework, talks about his friends, the aquarium animals, and anything else that is currently of interest.

Cheryl has just received a new computer for her classroom. School is going well for her too. Her kids, she says, are sweet and appreciative.

Anytime we put on our coats, Erik thinks we're 'going shopping' or 'car ride'. Even though he gets angry if he isn't coming, he concedes with a wave from the front window.

Matthew is wearing high-top boots around the house. I don't know why. No sooner did he lose his sixth tooth last week than he began back-pedaling on his disavowal of the tooth fairy. He allows that she is 'someone who looks like his parent.' Four girls in his class call him 'Dude'.

Peter told me that his very best friend is Erin Bingham. He knows that if he tells a secret, she'll keep it. Next in order of confidants are Ginelle and Tina. Never will he tell secrets to a boy. 'They'd blab it to everyone. I just can't trust them.' Cheryl and I don't seem to be considered for either category.

Friday, December 24

We are in the middle of Christmas holidays. The boys are presently watching Mr. Dressup. Peter is waiting for Cheryl to be done a phone-call to her mother about gifts they're putting together for a family on Avenue P, and I'm waiting for Cheryl to get the car out of the driveway so I can shovel the foot of snow that fell through yesterday. The only snow we've had so far.

We're busy getting ready for Christmas I can never believe the amount of detail involved in these occasions. There will be no peace until 6:30 tomorrow night when supper is served. Cheryl and Peter are off to ToyCity. We've taken charge of a family. We delivered a food hamper yesterday. The mother of these children sat on her porch seeming bewildered by all the boxes and bags building up around her. We'll deliver clothing and gifts today. Peter and Erik helped haul things while Matthew slept in the front seat.

The past few months have brought many changes in Erik. This is due partly to the natural growth of unique qualities, partly to his brothers' influences. He is active, highly interactive, humour loving. He trails his brothers everywhere, plays with their toys with or without their agreement. And when not, we hear sudden outbursts: 'Erik! Please give it back! Mom, Erik has my car!' Moments later Erik races past us. Often he has to be talked out from under his bed. He attacks them from behind with a shriek and a choke-hold, pull them over, instigates a body-roll, while the brothers gasp for breath or laugh. And then peace again.

Erik talks freely, fully, tells us whatever he desires. His older, gentle, tolerant brothers have given in to him enough to make him

extremely headstrong. Sleep ends for us every Saturday and Sunday morning around 8 when sounds start up in his room, then our door bangs open, the crown of his head passes by the foot of our bed, where he stands like a cowboy who has entered the saloon, and waits until we call him in. He climbs up and strokes Cheryl's face and rubs his feet against her legs.

His regular routine is to sleep until 7:15, get us up, lie in bed while Cheryl prepares in our little bathroom and I shower and shave in the basement. He eats from our bowls at breakfast and is fed a second breakfast of porridge when Bev or Darlene find the time. He plays, or may watch Mr. Dress-up or Sesame Street, talking along with the TV, repeating letters, numbers, or French words. He has a large lunch of peanut butter and jam sandwiches cut on the diagonal, or warmed-up suppers like spaghetti and meat-sauce. At 1 he sleeps. This he loves to do, smiling as he lies down, pulling his blankets to his face, locating a toy, talking and singing for a quarter of an hour, kicking the wall, picking at the wallpaper seams, sometimes standing at the window and playing with the blinds, pulling out the wood slats and whacking the retaining bar still attached from the old days when it served as the upper bunk. He sleeps for 1½ hours, then shows up in the hallway when he's done, most often in the best mood. He plays, or is read to. He doesn't sit on a chair. He prefers the corner of the sofa, and leans against the chair to look down on the pictures. He persists in this good mood until the boys arrive home from school. He might watch TV with them or wrestle or play in the basement if that's where they choose to go. By 5 he becomes aggressive, loud, whiney, and stays that way until he's had his first mouthfuls of food: hunger aggravates him exactly as it did the other boys at this age. When supper is over, Cheryl and I spend time with him doing

whatever comes to mind. Peter and Matthew are in bed before Erik. By 9 or 9:30 we undress him, share affections, play in the living room, then put him to bed. He insists on prayers being said. He repeats them line by line to the end. He takes awhile to settle down, never fussing, except if he wants a drink, which he takes sitting amidst the turmoil of his bedding. Then he's quiet.

Thursday, December 29

Erik is a cat. He lies in the tub after the water has been drained and meows until someone lifts him out, limp, and dries him off, and carries him to the bedroom where he is dressed, still mewling. The instant a brother wanders by he runs after them, calling out, Erik again.

1989

Sunday, March 5

Peter and Matthew had cello Master Classes this afternoon in Room 1036 of the Education building. Nuttall came from Edmonton to work with cellists, the Mauers came from Colorado for the violins. Though there were plenty of things planned before and after this class, going from early Saturday morning to late evening, and early Sunday until 3:30, we had time only for this one thing.

The winter weather thus far has been cold. We're feeling the creep of cabin fever. Tempers are short, the boys are aimless and fretful, antagonistic and hyper energetic. If we could get them outside to play for 5 to 6 hours, that would be something. Especially Matthew and Erik. Peter, at least, gets his 10 hours per week of gym. Cheryl and I get our long daily walks, and, since January, badminton at the Lakeview gym Mondays from 9 to 10:30 pm. We were playing until I cracked a rib hitting a brick wall in a floor-hockey game at school. But even this exercise seems insufficient for two adults getting on in years dealing with weight, personality change, altering perceptions that bring more intense moods, such as growing anger over the increase of general social inequalities, and other things so subtle it is easily not noticed until something happens. We got brief respite from our gloominess during a visit to Grandma Skarsgard's, who is staying in a room in at the Lutheran Sunset Home following a lengthy stay at City Hospital to recover from a stomach operation. Her room is cheery, her mood is light, she was upright and fully clothed on her bed. Cheryl's Dad sat in the blind-side corner stealing a few minutes of sleep while the boys sat in the wheelchair and made too much noise. I spent fifteen minutes with my Great Uncle Leslie Neatby.

He is also at the Sunset Home. He seems grateful for conversation of any sort. His memory still seems good. I introduced myself—reminding him who I was—and he asked how Cheryl was.

Erik continues with his super-abundance of energy, his good nature, his talk, which is part and parcel of the impulse for laughs: an occasional pseudo-prodigious phrase, mimicry, expressions of affection and sweetness: it's no wonder countless children are born 3 or 4 years apart. By the time a child is 54 months (or thereabouts), we've forgotten the inconveniences and stresses pursuant to conception and say, 'Why not have another?' But they are wise who don't quite forget. By 'they' I mean women. Vasectomies would not be a thing if not for women. Human history as we know it wouldn't have been a thing if the Tree of Knowledge had been sterile.

We're attending a ski-weekend at Camp Kinasao next Friday. Several Redeemer families will attend.

Cheryl's parents are going to Mexico and California for three weeks. After a week at home, they'll be off again to Vancouver for another ten days.

More of Cheryl's family has moved there. Now it's Darrel and Joan, Cathy and Bruce.

Peter has a gym competition at the end of this month, and a Festival competition a month later.

Wednesday, March 26

It's Easter holidays. Cheryl has planned a haircut. Peter and Matthew are in the basement (2:30 pm) with Aaron Boyko. Erik is sleeping. The sun is bright, but the temperature is stuck below 0. Winter hangs on, we stay indoors.

Two weeks ago we were at Camp Kinasao. All of us had fun. No place better to be in the winter than amidst the northern pines. The sun was bright, snow fell now and then, we followed winding ski trails up and down the hills, along the lake front, getting a close look at the array of animal tracks in the snow, but mostly squirrel and rabbit. The kids had loads of friends for company. The boys formed a 'boys' club' to get back at the girls. They played soccer and ping pong in the basement lounge, and scrambled on the apparatus outdoors. Bed-time was made as late as possible. We played Kaiser, 'Pigmania' and You-Blew-It!. We consumed hot chocolate and cookies and told jokes. Each family had a semi-private room upstairs in the dorm. Matthew slept in a room with some men and boys. The set-up was like a series of caves inhabited by Neanderthals.

Cheryl's parents are home for a few days. We had lunch with them yesterday at DiAngelo's. We are planning supper and a Blades' playoff game against Lethbridge Hurricanes.

Thinking back over past Easter holidays, we can see that as the boys get older, things become more laissez-faire-c'est la vie relaxed. They play well together. We hear them laughing in the basement. Matthew shows the biggest change in this regard. He went to a friend's house to play for 2 hours. Erik wants to play with his brothers whenever one or both are home. They do get

impatient with his 'style' of play which involves crying and coming to us with stories of all the bad things they've done to him. 'Matty won't let me play.' 'Peter hit me on the head.'

Erik does play very well by himself. He lies on his side on the floor and talks to the motorcycles as he pushes them around. He has had us read to him, though those requests come less frequently these days.

Peter competes this Sunday. I went Friday night to assist in setting up the apparatus.

Cheryl's parents kept the boys Sunday evening. We took full advantage of our freedom. We saw *Dangerous Liaisons*, then went for breakfast and lunch on Monday while hunting for new living room furniture.

Peter and Matthew had watched *Crystalstone* part way in the evening and the rest when they woke up. Erik watched some of it, but he gave it a critical shrug: It wasn't "cary like *Ghostbusters*."

Brother Matthew and Cheryl made the big announcement on Sunday that they're moving to Nepal. Joel is in San Diego for a visit before returning to some job with the Riders. Ernie has handed in his resignation at RJC. He's not at all certain what he'll do now. Les and Carol are looking for someone to buy Darby's. Les' job is keeping him busy. He's doing well, according to the most recent reports.

Catherine is very pregnant. Michael is excited about the child. He has set a tentative finish time for his thesis. Lloyd isn't selling trucks at this moment. He is looking at other possibilities. Landscaping? Buying and selling cars?

We will rent a camera before the holidays have finished. It's time to get our family on film. Erik is going through rapid change. His language mostly. He has lost most of those charming inflections.

We're talking more about an exchange to England. Lots of planning and things falling in place to make it happen.

Friday, August 4

Many things have happened since the last entry. We're in the middle of our summer holidays. All three boys are attending VBS this week. Erik has been a real surprise. He is excited every morning about 'going to school, seeing my friends and teacher.' He has brought home a crown, binoculars, a fishing pole, and a giraffe. He waves at Cheryl whenever he sees her around the church, performs all the actions for all the songs, works well at the table, talks excitedly about the whole experience back at home. Peter and Matthew have also been enjoying themselves. Peter's teacher is Cheryl. She laughs whenever telling me what he says and does during class.

Cheryl's Uncle Lloyd and Aunt Marg have gone on to Regina after visiting with family here, especially Cheryl's Grandmother at the Circle Drive Alliance Old Folks Home. Everyone came together at Cheryl's parents' Tuesday evening. The boys ate in the kitchen and played wildly in the back yard, losing a ball on the roof of the garage several times. The next night we gathered at Terry and Joanne's on the farm at Vanscoy. The boys were off immediately, into the tree house, onto the huge swings, packed on the back of a 3-wheeler driven by Dale, hunting down rabbits to pet (Peter chased one that escaped all over the lawn), playing Frisbee until they were eaten up entirely by mosquitoes, and petting Skip the dog: Erik asked me to see the dog with him, but as we got closer he said, 'The dog is friendly, isn't it Dad...? Isn't it...?' His tentativeness originates with an incident involving the cat next door. It scratched him after he pulled its tail.

From Sunday July 23 to Thursday July 27 we tented at Beaver Glen in Waskesieu. Four good hot days. Peter made friends with

two girls from Calgary and spent hours with them kicking around on the dinghy. Two girls from Redeemer saw this asked Matthew if they were his girlfriends. Matthew said yes. They spent a lot of time ridiculing Peter. Meanwhile, Matthew and Erik played in the shallow water. Erik walked in as deep as we dared let him, and if we didn't hold him back, he'd have gone in who knows how much further. They carried sand here and there. Whatever Matthew managed to build, Erik flattened it. We attended night time presentations at the Nature Centre, had a campfire with marshmallows, were up early each morning for coffee at the Parkside Café. Erik and Matthew sat at one or other video game and watched the characters go places. Peter and Matthew stayed in the 'pump tent', though it wasn't much good after two of the three poles snapped, and the tent drooped onto their heads. The zipper of Erik's new sleeping bag wouldn't hold. One cold night Cheryl tended to him, but couldn't find him. He was curled up at very bottom of the bag. The boys played with squirrels. Peter took pictures with his new camera. We'll have to see how they turn out.

Peter spent a week at YAS Basketball camp. He earned the medal for 'Best Effort'. Matthew went to summer gym camp and worked himself into a state of total exhaustion. He fell asleep at home sitting up and couldn't get himself up in the mornings.

Cheryl papered two bedrooms. It was a great job done under difficult circumstances. While I was away at Fort San for two weeks at a writing workshop, Cheryl managed the boys and her friend Christine's son, Justin Opheim, while stripping and papering Erik's room and getting through half of Matthew's.

Cheryl and I have saved our daily walks for the late evenings. Sometimes Erik joins us. He talks continuously to himself. His

language has achieved a sort of perfection, his vocabulary is as complete as anyone's, and he uses it to leverage his natural assertiveness. He won't be pushed around. He is much loved by both brothers. They think he's adorable and want to cuddle with him every chance they get. Most times he pushes them away. He favours 'Mom's soft' over anyone else's.

Matthew's ears are a problem. They were tested on Wednesday. His left ear has suffered profound hearing loss. He will have tubes inserted in September. He's not happy about this. He has become a manic reader. Yesterday he spent four hours with his books. Either he gets a haircut or a ponytail. He's considered a ponytail ever since Shauna Bingham made one for him with an elastic band. He has seen one on others, and being rather bold he'd like to try it for himself.

In a few minutes I'll be going to church to work on a skit. Erik is excited about it. He had his first good sleep after several bad nights, but came to our bed this morning quite unhappy. 'I can't see,' he said. 'My eyes are stuck.' His lids were sealed shut and needed soaking with water. That done, he was happy again. He gobbled his Cheerios and got dressed. His independence has extended recently. He is almost completely toilet-trained. He asked for his hair to get fixed 'just like Peters', with a well-defined part on the side and the bangs across the forehead, just so.

Michael and Cathy are expecting the baby this month. Michael is very nervous and imagines everything going wrong. Carol and Les nearly moved to Vancouver after Darby's collapse. Yesterday they made the decision to stay. They sold their cabin at Martin's Lake to cover some of the debt. Les will build a new house and sell their present house, hoping for enough profit to erase the rest of

the debt. Brother Matthew and Cheryl are living in a Roman Catholic compound in SE India. We hear from them now and then.

Thursday, August 9

At this moment, we're waiting for movers to bring a freezer and fridge.

Peter's week at Kinasao is nearly over. We'll pack and drive to Christopher tomorrow, then stay until next Thursday. We're looking forward to seeing him again. Our last photos were of him heading to his cabin with other boys to meet the rest of the campers and their counselors. He gave a quick wave and was gone. We went to Adolph's cabin, found them sunning on the front deck, and arranged our upcoming stay. After the visit we drove to Karen's Restaurant in Christopher Lake for a drink and ice-cream, before driving cross country to Henry's where Cheryl's parents were waiting. They had accompanied us to PA, had lunch with us, then gone ahead to the farm. We mowed the grass, took several motorcycle rides—Matthew sitting behind, Erik in the yellow helmet on the gas tank with legs crossed and his hands gripping the crossbar—and weeded the garden. Erik dragged a hoe around, 'killing weeds' with a sharp striking action. Once the boys were in bed, Cheryl and I sat outside watching the stars until the mosquitos took over. Matthew drove home with Cheryl's parents. He steered the truck all the way from Canwood to Penguin Park on the north end of town. Now he thinks he can drive whenever he wants.

From Tuesday on, Cheryl and I have been working in the basement, cutting out shelving to make way for a new freezer, throwing out bags of garbage, packing boxes for our upcoming garage sale, and using Papa's truck to haul things hither and yon.

Erik and I went to Jack Nepjuck's to visit with Jack, Scott Farmer, and Jack's exchange-partner from Cornwall, England. Erik played with Beth. We talked North American football versus European football.

Work is not easy in this heat. Temperatures are in the mid-30s. Cheryl and I enjoyed the air conditioning in the mall while shopping for the fall. Matthew brought along his book *Chocolate Fever* and read aloud while we drove.

Cheryl picked up our photos from McMaster Studios.

Thursday, August 17

We have just returned from Christopher Lake after six nights. We went up on Friday to get Peter from camp. He enjoyed it to the limit. He told stories about 'Wildman', the team-effort obstacle course, about Darla Wendland, about Grant the muscle-bound comic-collecting counsellor, the monk's supper, campfire skits, etc. We moved everything directly into the Peters' cabin, then went into the lake to wash off the sweat we'd built up during the hot drive up. Cheryl's parents arrived after supper. From that point on we had a relaxing routine, reading in the mornings, a pick-up breakfast and lunch, sunning on the beach and dock, canoeing with Cheryl or Matthew or Erik or Peter or everyone to Bell's Beach and back, sailing with Ed's boat in rough waters, and even in a rough squall that snapped the sail, tore the rope from my hands, and nearly overturned the boat before pushing us at a boiling rate all the way across to Clearsand Beach. Matthew was in tears. Peter held him in his arms and consoled him with 'Honey, Honey.' Both were chilled and shaking while I tied down the sail, then went into a cabin at the owner's invitation to phone the Anderson's cabin next door to Adolph to ask Cheryl to come with the car. We went to the Trading Post for ice-cream. Cheryl and I walked towards Bell's Beach along the road behind the cabins. Erik played for long stretches in the living room with his Garfield skateboarders. Peter and Matthew moved about in the water gathering minnows with an orange bucket. We found a caterpillar as thick and long as my index finger, luminous green with tufts of hair along its back, growing out of reddish globs, each tipped with the tiniest diamond. Erik let it go. Peter and I canoed across the lake and back, then around the island. We faced a stiff wind

coming back that buffeted the canoe and made it hard to manage. Tuesday evening we drove to PA, walked a few blocks with Erik trailing most of the way with a heavy stick, whacking trees, rocks, curbs, then running to catch up. We went to Digger's for coffee, drinks, mud pie and sundaes.

We returned to Saskatoon Thursday at noon, cleaned up the house and yard, then began organizing everything for the garage sale at Cheryl's parents. We took junk to the dump, hauled sale items to 833 East Centre, set up the tables, laid everything out, hung up the clothes, attached price tags to everything. Saturday began early. People came in waves all morning. That's when most sales were made. We netted \$533. Most people wandered around, looking at things, not buying. I considered going from an unstated policy of 'Touch it, it's yours' to 'Look at it, it's yours'. The day finished with pizza at Venice's on Central Avenue. Cheryl and I turned in at 9:30. The physical part of the day wasn't so much, but we were still drained.

This morning Erik showed up at our bed, only to find Cheryl missing. She was having a bath. He pushed his hand under the blankets on her side so just the tip of his hand showed and said, 'Would you at least rub my finger?'

We're going to visit the Summer Games Plaza to see the variety of things we've been hearing so much about. Fireworks at 9:30.

Sunday, August 27

We celebrated Erik's third birthday a day early. The Grandparents and Carol and Les came at 4:30 for supper. We ate tenderloin roast, corn on the cob from Campbell's (picked that afternoon by Peter and me, Peter less interested in corn than he was in the bone-handle knife sheathed on a boy's belt), potato salad and buns. The company stayed until 10. The boys played outside. The next morning we found clumps of Mountain Ash berries scattered around the yard as testimony to the 'energy' level of the play. Erik got a Fisher-Price instrument that can be assembled in different ways with three mouth pieces, and a set of drums. When the three boys play, two on these fluty instruments and one on the drums, the result has the vibe of Asian mysticism.

Matthew goes everywhere with one shoe completely undone. Usually it's the left.

Peter bought a model airplane. He spent yesterday afternoon and evening on it and part of today. It is almost painted, just the nose piece and decals left. I had expected it would take him until the end of the week.

We're getting Lloyd's old alto saxophone repaired for Peter. It will cost \$300 to change the pads.

Erik continues to receive the care of Bebeck and Darlene, though he's been asking to see others, like his brothers do.

Cheryl has been taken completely by surprise by the discovery that we are returning to school this coming Thursday and not the Thursday to follow. She's sure she won't be ready in time.

Peter has been asked to play cello September 10.

Peter and Matthew are excited about school. They've been footloose long enough, I think, and running out of things to do. Most of the neighbourhood has been quiet all summer, so they've stayed pretty close to home. They play a little basketball or football or cello or read, but they are looking for more structure. At the moment they are at Devon's.

Erik is now employing logic to get what he wants. A couple of days ago Matthew was playing with a toy. There was a sudden (silent) burst of action, with Erik taking off with one hand behind his back. Matthew told him to give it back. I asked Erik what he was holding. He showed me.

'You shouldn't have that,' I said.

'Yes,' he said.

'Why?'

'Cause it's yittle.'

'So?'

'And I'm yittle.'

He values mostly the things other people have. He can be convinced to value something no-one has, though only if it's done in just the right way.

Cheryl invited her Grandma downtown, met her at the plaza where the special bus had dropped her off in her wheelchair, and took her shopping and for lunch at Smitty's. Then it was time to get back on the bus.

We celebrated our 14th anniversary with a night out. Wednesday, Cheryl's Mom kept the boys and we went to DiAngelo's for supper: sole and tortellini with white wine. We took in Batman, which has been setting box office records this summer. Peter was jealous. He was put out that the film was rated for 12-years and older. We didn't make his annoyance worse by telling him that a 10-year old girl from Redeemer was there. He was helped by the news that the film will come out in video. Given its popularity at theatres, it'll probably still be playing when he turns 12.

Erik still wants his hair parted 'just wike Peter's.'

The boys went to the University Hospital for their check-up. Lappi has moved to Edmonton. Their new doctor is Swanson. All three like him. The boys sort of took over the waiting room. It's harder to keep a lid on whatever the three cook up together.

Wednesday, September 6

Today was the boys' first full day at school. When I arrived home Erik called me and waved his hand from the end of the block. He was on his tricycle. Darlene was standing nearby. He came into the house with me, gave me a big hello, asked about my day, and gave a ball a hard kick that nearly toppled a plant off the stand. I told him not to kick the ball in the house.

He said, 'Yes,' as in I will, in spite of what you say.

'No Erik, it will break something.'

'Mommy said to.'

'No she didn't.'

'Yes.'

When Cheryl got home, I said, 'Erik told me you told him to kick the ball in the house.'

She said, 'No Erik, you mustn't kick the ball in the house.'

'Yes,' he said.

'No Erik, Mommy and Daddy say you can't.'

'Well,' he said, 'Jesus says that I should kick the ball in the house, and Mama does too.'

Peter's teacher is Mr Hagberg. He's very happy. He has acquired two particularly strong interests: 1. Friends. 2. Neat hair. There are lots of kids he is friends with. He showers every morning or night. He studies himself in the mirror. He applies corrective

touches to the bangs. He told me he is practicing different ways to do his hair. He showed me how.

He wore his Joker t-shirt yesterday and today. Matthew wore his Batman t-shirt. Peter has decided he wants to play indoor soccer and basketball, plus whatever clinics he can get on soccer and tennis that may come up.

Matthew's teacher is Mrs (?). I asked how she looked. He said good, then laughed. I asked why he was laughing.

He said, 'Nothing.'

'Tell me Matthew, why were you laughing?'

'Because I thought you'd think I'd think she was my girlfriend.'

Thursday September 7

Supper tonight was potatoes, coleslaw, corn on the cob and Salisbury steak. Erik didn't want the meat or potatoes, only coleslaw. After cleaning that off his plate he ate his cob of corn, but only if an adult held it so he could gnaw at the kernels. Cheryl then looked into the pot of corn and asked me if I'd like more. Erik interrupted.

'I do, Mom.'

I said, 'You're still working on your first cob.' I added that he's like a dog in a manger.

He said, 'What is Dad talking about, Mom?'

Matthew attended his first gym class at 6:30 to 8:30. Kelly said he had been the hardest worker at this summer's camp.

Peter played catch football from 6 to 7 with a friend in the park. The plan was to return home and watch Mission Impossible. We took Matthew to the gym, shopped for groceries, retrieved Matthew, then went home to take Peter and his friend to Tim Horton's.

Thursday December 14

Matthew was invited to Jason Boyko's birthday party, but he won't be going. He has been ill with the flu since Saturday. Peter has been ill since Monday. It is 1:30 and both are sleeping. I've been home from school for two days. Erik is at his new babysitter's, Shirley Scott. He too was sick but would not hear of being left behind for one more day. It's very quiet when Erik is away.

Since last entry we purchased new furniture, a pivot rocking chair, a chesterfield and loveseat, a coffee table and two end tables: cost us quite a wad, I must say. It has given us far more seating options. I may invite the History Department over in January.

Peter loves school. He quotes Mr Hagberg more times than we can count, who has opinions on every subject under the sun. His performance reports are always good. Peter has been appointed house leader. This puts him in charge of noon hour games for Grades 4, 5 and 6. He was a greeter during Career Day.

He has something scheduled for every day. Cello lessons and soccer practice on Monday, track, band and basketball on Tuesday, Pioneer club on Wednesday, track again on Thursday, work in the library on Friday, and Saskatoon Strings and league games on Saturday.

His Strings are going well. They placed 1st in Unifest and were asked to perform with seven other groups at a special concert on Saturday night in the Phys. Ed. Building. They performed at the Christmas Concert with the Saskatoon Youth Orchestra last Saturday at 7:30. At the half-time break, Papa (Mama was at work), Cheryl and I took Peter to the Tortenhaus for coffee. Peter

with comic effect removed his bow-tie: '1-2-3-aaaaah.' Then we returned home to the babysitter, Shelley Hill, where Matthew and Erik were not sleeping. They were in bed but awake. Erik was bothered by all the talking and started to cry. I went in and asked what was wrong.

He said, 'I feel sick in my stomach.'

'Why?' I asked.

'From sleeping and laying down in my bed.'

Since one can never take a child's stomach-ache lightly, I got him up and out in an instant. He sat with us in the living room for 20 minutes as cheery as can be. Then the time came when Cheryl and I had to leave for her staff Christmas Party at the Sands' Hotel, and then to the Bessborough Lounge to meet with Christine Lee Choi and her new boyfriend Colin Tennant. The cold was bitter, but we had a very enjoyable time.

Matthew is hardly less busy. Whatever we have scheduled means first getting him to put down his drawing pencil. Ninja Turtles are his favourite subject at the moment. He has gym twice each week, Saturday from 2:30 – 4 and Thursday 6:30 – 8:30. Piano and soccer are on Monday and cello lessons on Tuesday. He has recently had tubes put in his ears to repair profound hearing loss.

Tuesday December 27

We have seen a lot of people over the past couple of days and eaten a lot of food. Michael and Cathy flew into town December 20 when the temperature was -40. Their baggage was delayed in Calgary. Michael had only a shirt and tie. 'What the hell am I doing here?' he asked in the car on the way to our place. We were joined by my parents and Carol and Les. Margot, their new baby, slept most of the three days of their time in the city.

Christmas Eve was spent at Cheryl's parents'. We ate turkey and everything else, opened gifts, went to Anne Skarsgard's for coffee, returned to Cheryl's parents to sleep. Erik had the most fun of all. He opened gifts, thanked everyone with high-pitched excitement, and talked continuously. At Anne's he stood by Grandma Skarsgard's wheelchair and watched while she opened her parcel from Cheryl's parents and us: a sheepskin. The plastic wrap had an image of a baby.

'Oh Grandma,' he exclaimed. 'Diapers.' While pulling away the plastic, he felt the wool and said, 'Oh, it's a pet.'

A little later, in the kitchen, he turned the outdoor light on.

Mama said, 'Maybe Aunt Anne doesn't want the light left on.'

Erik went to Anne and said 'Well, do you want the light on or off, or what?'

After a time of rather limited conversation between everyone present, Cheryl and I decided to take the boys home. Matthew was in the middle of a serious conversation with Uncle Harvey about the art on their dining room wall. Erik went to the middle of the living room, then pointed to everyone.

‘Him and her and her and her and her and her and him and her. Should I hug then all?’

Peter gave Michael a good game of chess. Michael thought Peter will be beating him in a year.

Jed and Helen came over with gifts. Michael and Cathy were here at the time. We have gotten a Gourmet’s Guide full of discount prices at a number of restaurants. Cheryl and Matthew spent part of the afternoon at Shelley Loeffler’s. She also visited with Dena and Bob, Kelsey, Denton and Dalin Miller. They’re in the city for Christmas. They flew in from Lahr, Germany, where they’re living for three years. This gave Cheryl some ideas.

The Pontiac has given some trouble. Its tire went flat while Cheryl was driving. She returned home, and we had it towed to Sears for a replacement. The block heater failed, which put too much stress on the old battery. The car sat frozen for two days.

We had a very noisy time yesterday at my parent’s. The house was full but we managed to squeeze everyone around the table. After cleaning up we had a gift exchange, followed by a 45-minute call to Matthew in Nepal. We watched the twins and Renee tear around the house. We left by 9:15.

We had two breakfasts today. The first was with Cheryl’s parents and Lloyd at the Saskatoon Inn at 8:30. Peter and Matthew ate with headphones on their ears. Presents from Lloyd. At 10 we met my family at the Park Town Hotel. Cheryl’s Mom came to see Margot. They stayed for coffee. Diane and Ernie were not able to make it. The weather has turned sharply warmer and the streets are sloppy. We went with Michael and Cathy to the airport and stayed until they boarded.

Cameron stayed the night with Matthew. They've done everything possible in the shortest possible time. Peter gave up trying to figure them out. He played his Sega games most of the afternoon.

1990

Monday March 5

We're on our last day off following Institute and Convention on Thursday and Friday. From Monday to Thursday of last week, two other teachers and I were at a Futures Conference in Regina with our Grade 10 Advanced Class. I haven't actually taught for a week.

Erik is in bed singing: 'Space worms...Space worms...Yi—yi—yi-yi-yi.'

Matthew, also in bed, has just complained that Erik is kicking the wall and keeping him awake. His Mozart tape is over, his night light is on. Peter has been ill for well over two weeks: cough, running nose, etc. We've given him antibiotics, but he shows no sign of improvement.

Cheryl's Dad retired last Wednesday. The boys stayed with him on Thursday and Friday. The next morning Cheryl and I went for breakfast to Kelly's (omelets), for lunch to Tree Tops (club sandwich) and to Genesis with the whole family for supper (Chinese food, Papa's treat).

Brother Matthew and Cheryl were over this afternoon with their girls. Rea-anna is Erik's girlfriend. They leave for Vancouver tomorrow where Matthew is taking up a position with an architectural firm near False Creek. They had sold everything before going to Nepal. They have a single outfit of clothing each (or something very near that).

Peter has proven he can take care of Matthew and Erik. Yesterday and today Cheryl and I left the boys in his hands and went to the riverbank for a walk. We bumped into Bernadette and Tony at the top of the Broadway bridge. They invited us for coffee.

We spent an hour at their place. We walked the bridges twice today. It is sunny but the wind from the east is chilly. It was -1°. Last night, again with Peter's assistance, we went to the Pacific Odeon to see *My Left Foot*, about the early life of Christy Brown, the working-class Irish artist with cerebral palsy.

Peter and Matthew are coming to the end of their soccer and basketball seasons. Both boys play in a non-competitive cello festival this coming weekend.

We had intended to spend last weekend skiing, but Peter had to participate in a track meet. Then he was too sick for any of it.

I arrived in the living room at 7:30 this morning. Matthew joined me shortly after. We heard something in the hallway. Erik showed himself tentatively, asked if we were up, then came to me and said, 'I heard you get up, so I sneaked out of my bedroom and saw you here. Should I go back to bed?'

Wednesday, July 11

We are well into our holidays. We have had tempestuous weather for the past few weeks: tornado sightings and warnings, heavy downpours (yesterday we got 2½ inches in just half an hour), with water in saturated ditches for days after. Today is the exception: 28°, sunshine, calm. BC has its mountains, but we have cumulonimbus clouds. Mountains are inert. These clouds sail overhead like an Armada.

We've been to the dentist. A pretty standard summer-time activity. Erik had his first appointment ever yesterday. He did everything he could to accommodate the dentist and his assistant. He calmly received a fluoride treatment while clamping his teeth onto a suction tube, wearing headphones connected to the TV.

We purchased a tall pole from Inland Steel, sunk it in a hole we augered by the patio, then secured it with concrete. We purchased a basketball backboard for Peter's birthday. He spent the night of the 21st with his class on a camping trip at Pike Lake. He spent different night at Devin Molberg's for his birthday.

We give him plenty of babysitting opportunities, two hours over several afternoons while Cheryl and I visit the Saskatchewan Archives Board at the University to research the WWII period in Saskatoon. I hope to develop a story using this information. Erik has gotten much better about being left behind. His only request is that when Cheryl gets home, 'We'll cuddle, all right?' Erik is a sweet pest. He steals his brothers' things, jumps on them relentlessly, hits them with whatever he is carrying, then drops onto the floor singing the tune from the chorus of Judas

Maccabaeus and playing with his cars. His sounds are as soothing as water running in the bath.

We spent Sunday at Canwood participating in the Isaachsen's 60th Anniversary celebrations. Peter played Squire, Matthew played Berceuse, they performed a duet of French Folk Song, Erik stood on the stage with a microphone and sang the Johnny Appleseed for grace. Cheryl gave a tribute on behalf of the grandchildren. I took the boys for a walk past a blacksmith shop and senior duplexes, along a grassy alleyway and back to Elk's Hall. Erik chucked gravel and whipped the grass with branches. Peter beaned Matthew with a pinecone, which Matthew didn't appreciate.

Matthew continues his drawing. He sits at the kitchen table sketching Ninja turtles, skateboarders, cars and motorcycles. He writes scripts, which included an entry in his school journal of a conversation with his teacher. Matthew has defied our expectations of him becoming a physical force. Instead he is sweet, smiling, and quiet. Occasionally he raises his voice or utters something raucous at Peter or Erik. Otherwise he is the silent partner.

We spent three nights at Baker's Bungalows in Waskesiu early last week. Beautiful weather mixed with heavy rain. The boys played soccer or Frisbee in the park or on the beach. Cheryl and I read. We all walked to the Park Café for coffee or went sightseeing in the car. Once behind the shack tents on a new road we spotted two deer. We stopped briefly to watch.

Erik said, ‘Mom, do deer actually eat fish?’ Soon enough he decided we’d been long enough in the car and asked, ‘Can we go back to the cabin?’

Cheryl answered, ‘No, Mom and Dad are getting out.’

‘Good,’ he answered. ‘Do that. Then we can drive the car.’

Friday July 20

This is the last day of the boys' camps. Peter has been at SciFi Camp for kids with interest in engineering. He worked with two boys from PA and one from Humboldt. They worked on a Goldberg machine, something designed to break an egg and separate it. They have a large rectangular frame on which to hang the workings, including a small motor, a mousetrap for breaking the circuit, tubes and a strainer. He has also made holograms and observed one machine that tests materials and another that builds whatever is commanded. He spent time in an echo chamber and wind tunnel. At the end they will demonstrate their machine and get judged. A BBQ will follow. Peter has invited Cheryl's parents. They financed his tuition as a birthday gift. In Peter's words, 'IloveitIloveitIloveit.'

Matthew was at soccer camp. They introduced him to many skills, some that are brand new to him, like punting and heading the ball. They play keep-away, shooting games, and scrimmages. He wears a long red Huskie shirt. His lunches are larger than usual.

Erik plays around the house. He runs through rooms with toy characters. He talks all the time using different voices. He is often enacting some dramatic scene. One involved a man near death in the hallway dragging himself to safety. Another is an angry father. He sings songs he has learned or provides his own lyrics to familiar tunes. Every song finishes with an operatic flourish. He appeals to Cheryl, 'Mom, can we cuddle?' He strokes her 'soft' every time she comes within arm's reach. He sits for breakfast with his cereal bowl touching hers. He is up early enough to spend time in our bed.

Yesterday we attended a Storm basketball game. Peter's friend Taylor came along. The team lost 123-119 to the Illinois Express. Peter and Taylor jabbered and giggled throughout the game. I'm not sure if they saw any action, though Peter insists they did. Matthew cheered in his very quiet way. He wouldn't shake the pom-pom he bought for \$1.50. Erik stayed with my parents. He wore a small backpack stuffed with a National Geographic tape about tigers, several books and toys. He was very happy to be picked up at 9:45. Grandma was laughing about his gentle forthrightness. He asked her, 'Mama, do you think you should get some grapes?' They visited Hartley's and fed two sheltie collies. Grandpa photographed the event.

Cheryl and I, but mostly Cheryl, painted and papered our bedroom. We had a garage sale last Saturday. Mostly it was baby items and baby clothes. I've been spending time at the U of S and the Public Library looking into the Saskatoon Light Infantry.

We're putting the final pieces together for a trip to the States. We leave Sunday July 20 at 8.

Peter and Louise are moving into town. Their new address will be 503 Smoothstone. They plan to stay three years until Usne finishes high school at Aden Bowman. Cheryl is reading McMurtry's Lonesome Dove. I am reading Doctorow's Billy Bathgate.

The weather is cool and sunny. I went to the farm on Wednesday to mow and pick stones. Cheryl is getting her hair permed.

Yesterday morning, Cheryl, Erik and I went for a walk along Saskatchewan Crescent. Erik dallied. He picked up sticks and

banged them together to attract bears. That didn't work, so he began calling them. 'Yoo-hoo, bears!'

Last Sunday we visited my parents. We spent nearly four hours on the deck. Peter joined us for intervals. The kids were watching The Man With A Golden Gun. He told us that Matthew and Erik have been 'influenced' by the movie. They were doing karate on each other while it played.

Sunday July 29

As arranged the previous night, Cheryl's parents arrived in the van at 7 am. The suitcases had been packed the night before. When the boys woke (Peter claimed he hadn't slept at all) they dressed. After a hodge-podge breakfast, dishes were washed, windows were checked, the water heater was turned down, the suitcases were packed.

Peter and Matthew sat in the back seat with their Archie comics, toys, games. Extended quiet prevails. Cheryl, Erik and Mama sit in the centre. Papa and I sit in the front, spelling each other off. Papa drove the first shift to Rosetown. I drove to Swift Current. We pulled up to the Horseshoe Motel at 10 for breakfast. We were shown to a large round table. Erik preferred standing by a cigarette machine to pull the knobs, hiding every time I came around the corner to see what he was up to. Matthew spent more time in the bathroom than at the table. Which is par for the course. When Cheryl took Erik to the Women's bathroom, he protested. He declared it's time he went to the Men's room with his brothers. He finally joined us at the table. After eating his eggs and toast, Cheryl and I took him for a tour of the outdoors to burn off some steam. In time he complained that one leg was tired. Back at the restaurant, we found everyone raring to go.

The drive to the border was uneventful. Nothing very dramatic to look at. The US Customs official at Climax had wandered up the road visit with his Canadian counterpart. When he arrived he asked us almost conversationally what we were intending. We crossed over, pulled into the parking lot, and everyone went to the bathroom. We passed Turner, glanced off Harlem, went through Loma (the bridge across the Milk River), Chinook, then into Havre

by 3 and up the hill to the Mall. Mama needed a pair of shoes. It would take only five minutes. It turned into 2 hours. We left at 5. Cheryl followed her mother from store to store. Cheryl found clothes at Herberger's for a discount on a sale's sale. Peter wandered with Papa, then joined me at a bench where I was keeping an eye on Matthew and Erik, who were climbing over each other in a flying saucer, then running back and forth between that and a motorcycle and a helicopter. I recalled how five years earlier, when Matthew was 2, a teenage girl stopped to admire him. She said, 'I'll wait for you'. Once the buying was done, we went back down to Havre for supper at the Four-Bs. We drove to Great Falls and checked into the Super 8 just off 10th Avenue, behind another mall. Hardly were we settled in our rooms and Cheryl's parents were heading to the Target store. Peter and Matthew went to bed. Cheryl and I took Erik for a walk through the residential area across the street from the motel.

Monday July 30

A designated shopping day. We were up by 7:30 and at Elmer's Pancake house by 7:45. We sat at a long table, ate, then drank coffee while waiting for the stores to open at 9. We went to Shopco to find Sega parts. Everyone wandered freely. The boys handled toys, others exclaimed at the low prices on everything. We went next to Target, purchased a large quantity of little items: a Sega converter and joystick, batteries, a Fisher-Price Tape machine, adapter, paper, and so on. We went to BEST warehouse, found nothing more, ate lunch at Four-Bs (soup, salad, sandwiches), returned to the motel where Erik napped and Peter and Matthew played with Lego in Cheryl's parents room. I read a not every good Wilbur Smith novel and drank hotel coffee. Cheryl went across the parking lot to the Mall to look for clothes. We agreed to meet at 4:30 by the Orange Julius stand. Erik was up by 3:50. The boys and I found Cheryl and wandered while Erik performed karate on Matthew, ran in the aisles, and occasionally disappeared. Eventually we bumped into Cheryl's parents and went for supper to Perkins for salad and sandwiches, then back to the motel so Cheryl and her mother could change, then to Target, where we bought five hubcaps for \$5.99 each. We found the State Fair. The boys took several rides. Erik and Matthew bounced inside the 'Moonwalk' for ten minutes. Peter, Papa, Matthew and I went on the Ferris wheel that Matthew was sure would crash. Peter and Matthew rode a swing round and round at 40 mph. The place was packed. It's hardly different from our own Exhibition. We were in bed by 10.

Tuesday July 31

We were up by 6, at Elmer's by 6:40 and on the road by 7:30. The drive took us through Helena and Butte. Erik woke up in time for lunch at Dillon. Before reaching Pocatello we stopped at a large lava field for pictures. Mama was annoyed with me for driving too fast.

We were in Pocatello by 5 and checked into a Motel 6. While Cheryl's parents went for gas and scoping out the restaurant options, we swam. The small pool was already busy with a baseball team. The coach called the players one by one for a shot of Gatorade. Cheryl and I sat on the deck. Erik sat on the steps into the pool and kicked water. Peter and Matthew wrestled. We went to the room at 6, changed, and waited. After a while we discovered that Cheryl's parents had come back and were waiting for us in the next room. With that discovery, we went to Pioneer Pies for supper. We returned to the motel and the boys went swimming. I read on the deck. Cheryl went with her parents to the mall. They were back by 9:30. By then the boys were sleeping. Peter and Matthew had to begin in separate beds. They read comics awhile before turning out the lights. Erik wasn't ready to sleep. I sat with him while he played with cars and the Lego we had bought at Target. He was still fully alert when Cheryl got back. We left him with her parents and went for a walk. The night was black, the wind was refreshing. We wandered into a residential area. Older homes with front and back doors wide open, families sitting on the front steps, fans blowing from behind, kids standing around cars.

Wednesday August 1

We were up by 5:30 and in the van by 6. We carried Matthew and Erik still in their pjs. We planned to get to Twin Falls for breakfast. Just short of that, we pulled over to look into the river canyon. We couldn't get near enough to the edge to get a real feel for distances. We threw a few stones in and took a couple of pictures. Mama stayed in the van with a magazine.

Breakfast at a Best Western. The best coffee so far.

We drove south to Wells Nevada through parched land, ashy-white soil, tumble-weed, sage, high hills at a distance from both sides of the highway rising to 4000 ft. A few small ranches, though nothing like in Montana. Peter thinks we're in rattlesnake country. At Wells we had our first encounter with slot machines. A bank of them were in the gas station, being played by locals. We got on the I-80 and arrived in Elko for beef and barley soup at the Coffee Mug restaurant. It is attached to a motel and swimming pool. The further we get, the more stereotypical the places seem. Women with long platinum hair. We arrived in Winnemucca at 2. Papa had made motel reservations there These were cancelled. Erik woke up and we had ice-cream instead. I felt some regret we haven't the time to explore these places. It doesn't take long to find out there isn't much on either side of the main drag. Erik and Matthew sat with their cones at a little wooden table. Peter took offense when we suggested he sit with them.

The drive to Reno was 160 miles. Matthew sat on the red igloo cooler between Papa and me. While Papa slept he asked me about some of the jobs I had worked at, and the jobs I might have done if I wasn't teaching. He would like to be an illustrator for kid's books,

or a police investigator, the kind that travels around the world. Eventually Papa woke up. Matthew moved onto his lap and counted dust devils. ‘Mini tornados lost and looking for their father,’ he said.

We arrived in Sparks-Reno by 5:30, followed a complicated route to the centre of Reno, found the Sundowner, parked in a massive parkade, went to our rooms on the 11th floor south towards Circus Circus and Harrah’s. Once settled, we walked to Circus Circus for supper. Which wasn’t nearly as straightforward as I expected. The place is monstrous beyond imagining. One walks through sea-sized rooms of slot machines, stunning with their light and sound. Pass through a maze of carnival and video games, always keeping a grip on Erik. We find a large area designed for circus acts. Ten-minutes long with a half hour in between. Trapeze, cannonball, sword juggling, dancing dogs, a circus announcer, and a two man band performed for the packed crowd kept back by a perimeter railing. After taking in two acts and .25 worth of shooting rifles for each boy, and poking each other in front of mirrors, we went for the smorgasbord. We found one room with three rows of buffet counters and separate rooms with tables. The décor was white with red stripes with a clattery ambience. After eating we returned to the circus, watched two more shows—one, actually, because the second, a motorcycle riding around inside a metal globe, was cancelled. Erik and Matthew climbed onto the retaining rail, enjoyed the dog act, and took another ‘shot’ at the rifle gallery. For Erik I sighted the gun and held it while Erik squeezed the trigger. On the way back to the Sundowner we strolled along the main avenue with ‘The Biggest Little Town in the World’ sign, and storefronts with flaring, sparkling neon signs, traffic flowing by on parade, people

streaming in and out of the casinos. Eventually the boys were tired. Erik shows how tired he is by how hard he is to handle. We took them back to bed, opened the drapes of the wall-sized window, and watched the lights. Everyone was worn out by the 570 miles of road and went to bed at 10:30.

Thursday August 2

Up at 7. I read awhile in bed. Erik woke up and joined me until Cheryl woke up and the day began. Cheryl's parents suggested we go to Bally's in Sparks for breakfast.

The parking lot and casino makes Saskatoon Inn look like a dollhouse. Even more slot machines here than in Circus Circus. The Patio Restaurant is lined up. While Mama keeps our place, we go by escalator to the sub-floor where we find large shops, a theatre, wedding chapel, golf shop, and bowling alley. We arrive at the restaurant just as Mama is being led to a table. While eating, Matthew draws a mountain scene. When we're done, Cheryl, Mama and Peter go back to the sub-floor to shop. Matthew and I wander around the slots. We come across Papa while getting his shoes shined by a 44 year old grandmother. I win \$2.50 with a dirty quarter. Cheryl returns with a \$150 silk jacket. Her mom buys a matching skirt. We watch a woman working three machines, taking dollar coins from a tray. A floorwalker tells Matthew to leave. Nevada law doesn't permit anyone under 21 within four feet of a slot.

We climb several thousand feet up a steep winding road to Virginia City, then go sharply down and around a curve. Cheryl won't look out the window. There are houses on the summit connected to the main road by primitive trails. How does one get in and out when it rains and snows?

Virginia City is a replicated 19th century mining town with boardwalks, the Delta Saloon's 'suicide table', the Bucket of Blood Saloon, a mansion, an opera house. Slot machines are everywhere. We ate a lunch of sandwiches and Sprite with (Mama's opinion)

too much ice. We pass abandoned mine works on the way to Carson City. The road to Lake Tahoe is uphill, twisting, two-way, crowded with vehicles, much of it through Jeffrey, Sugar, and Ponderosa pines. Once at Lake Tahoe we turn into an avenue of cabins (an almost ironic term for places that are huge, professionally gardened, make one think of millions stashed in Swiss accounts), tree-lined avenues, curving streets, more professional landscaping, long bungalows with brick fences, some so high one has to wonder what they're hiding, more casinos, and a large crowd on the street watching a boxing match, people streaming in every direction on foot, bikes, and a private airport full of 'daddy's' jets. We take the road out of town on the way to Sacramento on a 6% grade. Mama's terribly nervous. Cheryl is looking everywhere but out. Logging trucks and road construction slow the traffic. We cross bridges over ragged streams, pass by valley-cleft settlements. We're passed by cars travelling high speeds. A campervan with two wheels sits stranded on a sharp curve.

Once out of the mountains, the lanes east and west are separated by boulevards of pink bougainvillea. Two lanes each way become three. Traffic is increasingly heavy. Lane-jockeys confuse things. It's a jeep-jamboree. We reach Sacramento by 5.

We search for our Motel 6. We get too far down Howe Avenue and have to turn around. Most stunning, even for the summer season, is the wealth of vegetation, the flowering shrubs, coniferous varieties, and California sycamore. We take our rooms—two boys will sleep on the floor—and go for supper. Cheryl had read about a pizza place somewhere on J Street. We follow Folson Blvd past 67th. I check maps. Annabelle's is on 200 J Street, West

Sacramento, 65 blocks away. We come to old interesting homes at 40th Avenue, palm trees in every yard: the advantage of a year-round growing season. Finally we get to Annabelle's, park the van, and can't resist (some of us) looking in on every other restaurant. We follow a flight of stairs into an old building, its window propped up by a car jack. Once seated we learn that the unlimited pizza/pasta deal was only for lunch. We order the family special and a small #0 Cheese. After we've eaten, we head back onto the boardwalk, wandering from store to store: kites, books, gadgets. Peter and I walk in the back alley and listen to the sound of reggae coming from the other side of a stone fence. We meet three young men soliciting a crowd to hear three 'great' reggae bands. Many are sitting on the grass or standing by the wall, listening to this appealing, enlivening sound. Others stroll past or cross the main road and tracks towards more restaurants and a riverboat nightclub. We walk until dark, drive past Popeye's Place with a long line of patrons onto J, and back to the motel. Matthew and Erik get the floor, and Peter the single bed. Cheryl and I read the Sacramento Bee until 11.

Friday August 3

Cheryl, the boys and I went to Denny's next door for breakfast. Waitresses in red outfits and beehive hairdos. Busboys with foreign accents and a whipped-dog slouch scrambling to do table service. Four young guys eating at a table behind Cheryl, an Asian sitting alone obviously disgusted at the time he has had to wait for his food, the chubby head-waiter on the run stopping just long enough to give assurances that the food is nearly there, and at another table three young women the same shape, same outfits, same hair.

After breakfast we crossed the main street for a walk. Everything is clean and luscious: shrubs covered in white and pink blossoms, the green vines covering walls, hanging overhead, the street glossy black, freshly painted lines, fast heavy traffic on the four lanes, which makes it very difficult to cross with children. We follow paths that swerve through redwood and cedar townhouse complexes, past playgrounds, along a red-brick wall with a U of C Sacramento sign, crossing at lights with uncertain duration while cars speed around tight curves, there without warning.

Back at Motel 6, two boys spit at Peter. We didn't know this until later when we watched as they bumped him and spilt ice on him. Cheryl verbally undressed them. Then we changed and were in the pool by 9:15. Erik jumped in from the side. Reminding us of the time seemingly ages ago when he, not having been in water deeper than a bath, did the same at the YMCA and had to be rescued. Cheryl's parents find us here after returning from breakfast. Papa snaps a few pictures. We swim and sit and swim again, then dry off and get ready to go back downtown for the rest of the morning. We plan to leave after lunch.

We drive to the State Capitol buildings but have no luck finding any place to park. We return to Old Sacramento, find a parkade with spikes at the entrance and a sign that says, 'Avoid reversing to prevent severe tire damage'. Once on the sidewalk we vacillate about our next destination. We decide on the Mustard Seed café for coffee. Mama didn't see dessert on the menu, so she stayed out, choosing instead to go through the shops. We order drinks, Root Beer for the boys, play briefly with a peg-board IQ game, finish our drinks. The bits left by Peter and Matthew are drained by Erik. Then we go looking for Mama.

We decide to split up. The boys and I went to the river, explored the Delta King river boat hotel, ignoring the 'For Hotel Guests Only' signs to take a closer look at what only hotel guests are permitted to see. Luxuriant bedrooms, shining brass railings, spacious dining areas. We visited the floating dock where the 'Globe' is moored, a dinner ship that for \$20/person offers a meal and 3½ hour river cruise. The boys hold onto each other, a bit unnerved by motion of the dock underfoot and the river's sweeping current. Huge motor boats passed under the I Street truss swing bridge. We examined the Santa Fe 5021 locomotive, watched joggers going both ways, took the boys to the washroom, and took photographs. Erik waves at the camera. We finish at a reconstructed schoolhouse where a former schoolteacher serves as a guide.

We meet up with the others at the appointed time and go for lunch at the Whistle Stop. The boys order cheeseburgers, which are sent back to the kitchen for being too pink. We finish with a dessert of stacked brownies and ice-cream. Matthew is too tired for an appetite. He had gotten out of his sleeping bag the previous

night and didn't sleep well. Eating the burger is a slow business, but he perks right up when the dessert arrives. Civic crews are hurrying around putting up fences ahead of a bicycle race.

By 2 we are back in the van, take the main drag through West Sacramento, gas up, then merge onto the I-80. Traffic is bumper to bumper, even where it widens to three lanes. Where the map suggests open country, we find continuous urban settlement. Here and there is a patch of pasture and tan hills topped with deep-green cottonwoods, and always the centre strip of bougainvillea. It's wine-making country. We pass UC Davis campus on the way to Vacaville. We spend from 2:30 – 4 at the Nut Street Factory Outlets. We turn in the direction of San Rafael, north of San Francisco. As we come nearer, smoke grows heavy in the hills and across the bay. Road repair creates a slow-and-go rhythm. We pass along the scrubby salt flats, enter a two-way highway into Sausalito, though we don't go so far. We turn at Highway 35 onto Highway 101 to Santa Rosa.

The traffic grows even heavier, if that can be believed. No end of city. Bulldozers sit amidst what remains of the wilderness. The striking hills are being flayed.

Matthew likes nuts. Cheryl bought pistachio nuts in Sacramento. Half the bag is gone. She thinks it was me. Erik was sitting on my lap for a short while, on Cheryl's lap for a long while, then falls asleep across the legs of his brothers. Matthew says Erik is cute when he's sleeping.

We find the Motel 6 in Santa Rosa easily enough, and go to Carrow's restaurant before checking in. We are served by a waitress who would have long been retired in Canada and by an

Hispanic named Lorenzo who could easily be confused with Manuel from Fawlty Towers. We eat well, the humour is good, but Erik won't sit. He must kneel or stand, step over Cheryl or me to get to Matthew, who we've discovered is a bad combination. After the meal we return to the motel. It is too chilly to use the pool. Cheryl and I arrange with Peter to babysit, and we go for a much-needed walk. We cross a busy road to townhouses with obsessively meticulous (redundant?) lawn-care, walk through its parking lot to different townhouses and more parking lots, and fencing, and shrubbery. It was our goal to find a proper sidewalk and maybe a park or residential areas where lives are less hidden. Then we realize that this might go on far longer than we have time for. Momentarily we come through the maze to where people are removing carpet from an apartment complex into a pickup truck. That's as good as it got. We returned by the same route and found the boys playing with Peter's handcuffs (a useful tool for babysitters) and Matthew's mini-Derringer. The television was playing a black-and-white movie about the British Navy and the Atlantic Convoy.

Peter has managed to get Matthew and Erik ready for bed, but they're restless. Too long cooped up in a vehicle. Erik cries when the hammer of the Derringer snaps and pinches the skin between his thumb and forefinger. Cheryl polishes off the rest of the Sacramento Bee. Peter changes and goes to bed with Erik. He embraces him, they toss and turn and eventually fall asleep. The snuffling noises Matthew makes when he sleeps is enough to wake up everyone but himself. The howl of traffic comes through the window we leave open to make up for the absence of A/C.

Saturday August 4

I wake first and read while the others sleep, then stir. Cheryl is awake by 7:20. While we get ready, Peter and Erik wrestle. We meet Cheryl's parents by 8:30. We are taken into a back room at Carrow's. Papa tells us they will begin the 5-day all-expenses gift today. Cheryl argue determinedly that the original plan had been to implement it at Crescent City, not Eureka. Her dad prevailed. The coffee is good.

We pulled out of Santa Rosa by 9:30. The weather was heavy and damp, just like last night. We admired the scenery, came back into vineyard country that covered all the available land, even over the hills. Winery estates sit on top of precipitous slopes. Peter wants a picture. Getting the van to the side involves me nearly causing a roll-over. Surrounded by the hills and orchards and stands of trees, he chooses instead a super-tight close-up of a ... tree trunk.

The 101 carries us through rapidly changing geography. From the rolling hills and mixed growth of oak and cottonwood, palm trees and blossoms to the more homogeneous coniferous forests. We pass through towns alternating wine-tasting outlets, motels, sidewalk flea-markets, fruit stalls and gas stations. We leave the congested 101 at Ukiah and follow the twisting Orr Springs Road past sprawling residences, dense commercial, gas stations (one, just before we leave Ukia, is carved out of a tree stump. Its sign over the breezeway reads: 'World's Largest Redwood Tree Service Station'), acreages, cattle, even llamas.

The California driving experience thus far has been unique. Very fast—prevailing traffic is at least 10 mph over the posted

speed—and winding, and slow, thanks to the intermittent road construction, and steep grades, sharp canyon drop-offs.

Lunch is eaten at the Cottage Inn in Mendocino, which serves breakfast and lunch only. It's a tidy place full of the work of local artists. We order French Onion soup and a roll. Erik begins the meal behaving peaceably with his brothers. Peter strains his ears trying to listen in on the adult conversations. Matthew draws. At breakfast it was a bank robbery. At lunch it is 'Midnight': cars jamming up an intersection. His canker sore hurts, so the bread must be broken into small bits. It is suggested that he gargle with salt water. I take him and a pinch of salt to the bathroom. It's not long before table decorum begins to unravel. Erik grows more restless and begins punching Peter. We try a game of eye-spy, but he won't say no matter how long we guess what is 'red with a statue'. When the soup is served he won't eat. He says his stomach and 'froast' hurt. He wants to go to the bathroom, so I take him, but nothing happens. It is soon obvious that Erik must be removed entirely. As soon as he's outside, he's happy. We poke around. He sits on the deck railing for a photograph. Families sit peacefully under umbrellas, eating everything on their plates.

We follow the #1 along the coastline, then inland to Leggett, where we merge onto the 101, and a succession of traffic jams. At one point a lane both north and south have been shut down. Once we sat for 15 minutes. Traffic heading both ways must take turns in convoys. Cheryl reads to Erik in the back. Peter and Matthew sit in the front with Papa and me, cleaning up what's left of the pistachios, cherries and grapes.

Just before the Avenue of the Giants at Meyers Flat, we come to the Grandfather Tree and Gift Shop. Miles of cars are pulled off

to the side, up and below the Eel River bank and basin. It's a Reggae concert. 12,000 have come in for the day. Many arrived with tents two days ahead. Getting out at the gift shop, with our jeans and not shorts, freshly washed bodies, short hair, we look like real Canadian squares. We sort through the heaps of goods, carvings, t-shirts. Outside, an endless line of people troop past, crossing the road, bringing traffic nearly to a halt. It is very warm. Cheryl and I find a knot-head carving, three t-shirts, and a bag of moss. Cheryl's mom buys us ice-cream cones.

Upon entering the Avenue of the Giants, we descend sharply into a forest so darkened one's eyes take a moment to adjust. The road winds past tree trunks ten feet across. Several times we stop for photos. Once where a tree had been felled. The boys climbed to the top and ran its length and back, causing Mama great concern that somewhere between the two ends they'd jump off. We saw two deer. Coming across roadkill, the van engaged in a sort of argument whether it was Bambi or a jackrabbit. We stopped again at a tree with a walking path right through it, again at the Grandfather tree, 950 years old and 250 ft tall, and for the last time at the (privately owned) Drive-Through tree that costs \$1/person. We didn't.

It was getting late by then, and we had a 6 pm check-in at the motel in Arcata. We returned to the 101 past the Pacific Lumber Company, with miles of stacked timber and mills billowing smoke into a wall of fog that hangs perpetually along the coastline. It's one turn into the wet cloud and the next turn into brilliant sunshine, the difference being the width of the highway. An odd experience.

The 101 runs through Eureka between Humboldt Bay and Arcata Bay. Historic refurbished Victorian model homes sit on both sides.

Once we've checked into the motel, Peter and Matthew insist on swimming, in spite of the chilly air. Cheryl sits with them and I take Erik to the Jr Burger, which, like McDonald's, has a play area. He meets two children his age and play Batman while I visit with the parents.

At the appointed time I return and we get ready for supper. Cheryl gets warmer clothes from the van. It's not until her father points it out that she discovers she has been poking in the keyhole of the wrong van. The giggling begins here. We went to Village Pies just down the street and forced a lone man to free up his table so we could move it together with another. We are served by an aged woman (though likely not as old as she looks) with long greying hair. We order large meals. Cheryl and I eat chicken stir-fry, salad, coffee and ice-cream. Peter gets his full order of chicken fingers. Matthew and Erik order a burger. Cheryl's parents get the senior rates.

Once done we drive 15 miles around the Bay to Eureka to see particular Victorian houses. The Carson House can't be accessed because it is a private club, and dogs and women are not allowed. We make the plan to return tomorrow. Papa wants to find the Samoan Cookhouse. Always planning future meals. It is left off 4th, over two bridges, through the fog, into a desolate marshy area straight out of Dickens Great Expectations. The Cookhouse is easy enough to find. Papa wants to explore a lumber museum—hanging on the walls are various items of self-erasure: hooks, saws, axes—and the gift shop. Big Band music plays in the parking lot. Instead

of dancing couples and strolling lovers, it's just us and one child being held or restrained from getting at shelves of Chinaware.

Back at the motel Erik and Matthew are put to bed in Cheryl's parents' room. Cheryl sticks a coin in the bed slot and reads a newspaper while it vibrates. She comments on feeling as if she's about to be ejected through the window. Peter for some reason is smiling to himself.

Sunday August 5

We're up by 7. Cheryl showers, I shave, Erik comes in to bid us good morning. He slept in Mama's bed. He told Cheryl, 'She took a little of your soft, but there is lots left,' proving it by lifting his shirt, exposing his stomach. As I write I'm aware of him prowling, being stealthy. In the corner of my eye he approaches. A tap on my shoulder. No-one is there. This is typical Erik. Peter gets up and fashions his hair for the day. Matthew is, as has become usual, the last to show up. All three watch cartoons while we wait for Cheryl's parents who, it turns out, were waiting that whole time for us. I think it's funny.

We ate breakfast at the Village Pantry, then returned to Eureka by way of the Samoa Blvd. This means coming through downtown Arcata along salt marshes, dilapidated and rusting homes faded by the salt air, small plots with Jersey cattle, more marshy desolation, across Humboldt Bay by means of three bridges, to the marina. We walk the docks, marveling at the rusting hulks still being used by tuna and salmon fishermen. We look through one window at stocks of overnight supplies, crochet needlework, Joy liquid detergent. We come to a couple hauling groceries down a ramp to their boat. They're heading 300 miles up the coast where the tuna are running. The plan is to be gone two to three weeks.

Across the final bridge, we turn into the historic old town, back to the forbidding Carson House, the Pink Lady, a couple of Bed-and-Breakfasts (\$75-\$185/night). We snap pictures of the exteriors. We read more about the rules governing the Carson House. Only those who pay \$1500 membership fees are permitted in. For no amount might a woman enter. A couple of weathered young men come by with their tiny pup. The boys play with it. It

crawled all over Erik, knocking him over, licking his face. Mama took a couple of pictures. Peter asked what kind of dog it was. One of the guys smiled and said, 'That dog is bred to defend. It's a Pit-bull.' The other said they had business to do. He gathered the dog in his arms. They walked up the hill then sat on a park bench. Maybe they've been hired as harbour lookouts. Later Papa said, 'If I had known it was a Pit-bull, I'd have told one of the boys to step on it.'

We gassed up, drove through the old downtown, headed north past McKinleyville on the 101 in low-lying cloud, then into a clear sky and beautiful coastal country with look-out points. We drove around Big Lagoon and Dry Lagoon to the Information Centre in Orick, picked up pamphlets about the Redwood National Park, and stopped for coffee, fresh baked pie, cookies, croissants and doughnuts.

From this point on we stop frequently. A fish hatchery where we look at the pools and talk to a worker while he feeds trout and salmon, cross a bridge over a shallow pool with large trout. Elk Prance where we study through binoculars elk sunning in tall grass. The Big Tree, with more pictures (Cheryl is hoping for the perfect photo for Christmas) and a walk along a cedar-chip path in the shade of the Redwoods. A Drive-Through tree where we cough up \$2 (a small scandal) for Peter to take a photo. Paul Bunyan and his ox, with many more photos while Papa and the three boys each ask Paul questions, and get answers. Which amazes the boys. It would have cost us \$20 to tour the Mystery Forest. We'll wait to take an equivalent walk in Canada for free. Then we are in Crescent City. We make a couple of photo stops, one above

Crescent City, overlooking the ocean, the white beaches, the bright surf.

We checked into the Pacific Inn Motor Hotel, a two-bedroom suite with a sauna and hot-tub. Erik was asleep, so we lay him in bed. Cheryl's parents stayed in the room. The rest of us drove back south along Endert Beach Rd to Endert Beach, long and crescent shaped with gleaming sand and rolling surf. We doffed our shoes, rolled up our pant legs and ran along the water line, chased the ebbing waves, watched three body-surfers, gulls cruising at water level, people on the driftwood near their campfires and tents and RVs. Cheryl took photos. The wind is strong. A thoroughly liberating moment. Everyone is feeling joy. An hour later we were back in the van, returning to the motel. Erik was just waking up. We went to the restaurant adjoining the motel office. Erik wouldn't eat. Cheryl told him that the food on the fork was meant as bait for a salmon hanging on the wall, which Erik intercepted, fork after fork until all the food was gone, the salad, the sole, the rice. Wise guy. What are we teaching him?

After supper we drove to the breakwater, Lighthouse Way, and began the long walk to the end. At the $\frac{3}{4}$ point we encountered large concrete anchor-like obstructions that blocked us from our destination. Things you see but can't reach have a way of transforming in one's mind from merely mundane to compelling. Peter and Matthew were busy noting all the things they were seeing for the first time. The waves rolling in and crashing on the rocks, crabs and starfish in the rocks below us, the circling gulls, Steamboat Rock a short distance off, bright lights on the horizon of an incoming ship, the small fishing vessels going in every direction, the blasting fog horn. The boys talked, Erik was quiet on

my shoulders. Cheryl was fetching in her black and white striped pants and a long blue coat. We returned to the van where her parents waited and drove to the harbour where one can engage a fishing vessel, then to the grocery store where we picked up a few small items, including a red puzzle watch for Erik which, once on his wrist, he ceaselessly shakes and rattles.

We returned to the motel. Matthew and Erik were dressed for bed. Matthew was tired and fell directly to sleep. Erik is a bad bet. We listen to him fuss until Cheryl gets him up. We sit in one of the bedrooms. Cheryl reads an information booklet and does cross-stitch. Peter serves us cups of grape pop and adds ice-cubes with his fingers. Mama reads Time magazine. Papa fishes for conversation and seems quite happy that Erik has joined the group.

Monday August 6

We were up at our new regular time, 7-ish, dressed, packed and ate breakfast at the Koffee Kup on 3rd. While eating we discussed the possible uses of the concrete object we found out on the breakwater. We brought this up again with a balding local in a wheelchair. He told us that they were used as breakwater for the occasional waves that brought enough power to destroy concrete. He told us about the damage caused by 1964 tidal wave. At that time he was a projectionist for the drive-in theatre. While he talked, Erik, full of pancake and syrup, could no longer be contained. We concluded the conversation, left, and joined Mama and Cheryl just returning from a Ben Franklin Craft store. We had heard of sea lions on Pebble Beach, and went to see for ourselves. Part way we stopped at a scenic view. As soon as we were out with our binoculars we discovered a long stairway to the beach. As if we had no control over our actions, our shoes were off, our pants were rolled to our knees, and we were in the sand looking for starfish. Peter was convinced the starfish on the sand must be stranded and dying and to save them he must throw them into the sea. We found a rock covered with barnacles, and seaweed piled on the sand. The most fascinating thing wasn't what was obvious, but what was hidden, what one found by digging at the water line. Erik and I found a tidal pool. He squatted on a large stone and watched a hermit crab. I plucked it out. It pulled into its shell. We waited until its legs eased into view, the shell moved, and lifted and edged towards the water. Erik was thrilled. 'Boy, I'm going to tell Mom about this.' Just then she appeared at the top of the cliff. We headed back. Crossing from rock to rock, I slipped, scarcely avoided plunging the two of us into the water, much to the

amusement of a family. My binoculars swung and struck Erik under the eye. By the time we reached the top of the stairway a small bruise had appeared. We resumed driving along Pebble Beach Road until we found the sea lions. They were far off, the fog had begun rolling in, so we decided to look for more up the coast. We stopped at a cheese factory on the way out of town, bought snacks, and left Crescent City.

Every mile of the road north gave a fresh, exciting view. At times it turned us into the forest. Then it climbed and brought us to a grand view of the ocean, green and blue and grey, the white surf crashing against ragged rocks, further out the large swells, and sand. At each turn we met a new view that seemed more perfect than the last. We couldn't resist stopping to take it in. Then we crossed into Oregon and discovered the epitome. Gold Beach. We parked the van and went onto the beach. The sand burned. I carried Erik. Matthew skipped and scampered. Peter and Cheryl followed in their shoes. We came across signs warning about the unpredictable surf. We stayed clear of the water, but were surprised by the number of people who had waded in with their children, playing tag in the crashing surf, some waves six feet high. The wind was stiff, the surf was deafening. We built a castle but the waves rolled in, soaking us, sending the boys screaming to higher ground, demolishing our work. Cheryl kept moving along the beach, picking up stones, studying the varying degrees of translucence. We found seaweed that looked like a bullwhip, moving in the water, which convinced Erik it was alive. We chased each other. Matthew expressed his feeling of liberation by wheeling in the sand, chasing the waves, squealing, screaming, yelling.

We lunch at Gold Beach. A football field with a sign advertising the Panthers separates our table and the ocean. Matthew ordered soup but only under duress. Cheryl paid him .25 to finish it. Once outside, he was laughing about it. He called it ‘easy money.’

We turned off the road at Cape Blanco. We drove four miles towards the coast, turned off that road onto a trail through a sheep pasture, and stopped at the Hughes home. This was a large house built in 1888 by Patrick and Jane Hughes, a sheep farmer and Irish immigrant. A woman was there to give us a tour. We spent an hour hearing her stories, looking through the partially-restored building. Though the wind blasted outside, inside this stone and cedar construction it was barely audible.

Coos Bay was next. We didn’t arrive at the North Bend motel until after 6. It didn’t matter if we were late. The suite was large, overlooking the courtyard. The boys were excited. They bounced on the queen beds. At supper we were served by a waiter with a bow-tie. We ate large meals. Erik and Matthew performed magic acts with a handkerchief and a brush. Erik went under the table, pretending it was water. The time came to go back to the motel. I battled to get the boys ready for bed. They went straight to sleep. The others walked to the mall across the street.

Tuesday August 7

We were up a bit earlier this morning. We have 109 miles to drive and a lot to see on the way.

The first stop was at the dunes just across Coos Bay and Haynes Inlet by way of the very lengthy steel Bay Bridge. We turned off the highway and went as far as the beach. The wind was stiff and wickedly cold, the fog was rolling in, and the surf was high and dangerous. We turned back, saw dunes through the trees, parked the van and headed over. It turned out to be much further than I thought. We threw off our shoes and climbed several times to the top—Cheryl stayed at the top, collecting pinecones and snapping photos—and racing down, leaping, skipping, howling all the way. Exhilarating, but hard work, dragging ourselves up the steep side. Peter took a real tumble and spent the rest of the day cleaning sand out of his ears and nose. Erik, in his red sweatshirt and black sweats, leapt down the descent, yelling up at Cheryl, ‘Watch me, Mom, I’m a runner,’ thumping his chest like Tarzan all the way to the bottom. By the end of an hour we had no steam left. We returned, laughing, to the van, drank water, shook out our clothing. Matthew stripped down to his underwear.

Next was a Myrtlewood factory in Hauser, the largest in Oregon. We strolled through the show room and picked out a cheese plate, a chip bowl, a pencil holder for Peter, small boxes for Matthew and Erik. Matthew found a game which requires the player to flip a ball from the cup at one end to the cup at the other. Erik was a natural—3 times in a row. Peter had his eye on a chessboard for \$110. We were given a short tour of the factory, saw the entire process from cutting rough wood, the kilns, lathes,

sanders, polishers. Beautiful wood, but it seems to me a dreadfully tedious sort of work.

We made driving straight to Reedsport, stopping there only for coffee and ice-cream. Bikers abound. The next stretch of highway was along the ocean, some up high, affording a spectacular view, but much of it level with the raging surf. We stopped for an hour at the Sea Lion Caves north of Florence. What a crowd! We found the gift shop. Papa purchased tickets for 5 of us take an elevator 200 feet to the caves. While in line we studied the sheer drop into the churning water, saw four seals floating together like a raft. We packed into the elevator, listened to the operator telling us how to behave while in the caves. We got out and a line of people began moving in. We found the screened area that looks onto the ledges and rocks and water. Our initial impression was that most of the sea lion must be elsewhere. As our eyes adjusted, we realized we were seeing not rock but crowds of animals on rock. Sea lions swam in from the open water, were battered against the rocks, got a fin-hold and clambered up, forcing the others to give a little room. We came to interpretive boards, two sea lion skeletons, a long stairway, a lookout with a view of the Heceta Head lighthouse. It is the most powerful lighthouse on the coast, visible to ships 24 miles offshore. The wind was chilly. Erik clung to my back to keep warm. Once we had returned to the gift shop, it was thought we couldn't consider the visit complete until photos had been taken of us posing next to bronze statues of sea lions. We picked up a couple of Oregon stickers for the car collection, then resumed the northward journey towards Devil's Churn/Cape Perpetua, and Newport.

We checked into a suite at the Moneysaver Motel, went to a fast-food seafood restaurant. Matthew and Erik were given coloured visors. Back at the motel we split up. Cheryl's parents drove somewhere. We walked to the beach by way of a series of staircases, through heavy vegetation, into small dunes, where the wind was cold and stiff, and the rollers were so fierce we kept a safe distance, making our way along the shore, around grassy bluffs, looking for a way up. We came to the Yaquina Bay lighthouse, built in 1871 but closed in 1874 (though remaining open to tourists from 12 pm to 5.) We returned to the motel by way of the park grounds and Yaquina Bay Bridge (stopping there for photographs, after fixing up the boys' clothing to help them stay warm; it's almost ear-ache cold). The boys watched a He-Man cartoon for half an hour. When Cheryl's parents returned we drove to the Port of Newport, parked, and strolled past gift shops, candy shops, the Undersea Gardens, Ripley's Wax Museum, bars, restaurants, grocery stores, fishing companies, marinas, fishing boat rental companies, (\$40/5 hours), Mo's Annex. We went to a pier, watched fishing boats come and go, watched two men and two women casting for seabass and herring and working crab traps. We chatted with them and photographed the boys holding samples of their catch, though Erik wanted nothing to do with that. We returned to the van. Cheryl's parents were eager for supper. We tried three places, including a restaurant/bookstore. We settled in the end for the Apple Peddler Restaurant next to the motel. While we ate, Erik sat at our feet tapping tunes on the table legs with someone's knives. We came out in pitch black, put down the boys, watched the news (Iraq has invaded Kuwait), bathed, went to bed.

Wednesday August 8

This was our last full day at the coast. We were up just after 7, pushed in the pull-out, packed, and were at the Apple Peddler restaurant by 8. We headed north with only one planned stop, Seaside, before ending up in Astoria—134 miles—by 4, to be sure we get our rooms. It's tough. There's far more to see and do than we have time for. Devil's Punch Bowl, Cape Foulweather, Haystack Rock, Cape Meares. We pass through tiny settlements like Oceanside, Cannon Beach and Tillamook, with interesting shops lining the highway. The road winds, speeds are often reduced to 30 mph. Jersey cow country. Valleys, lush slopes, green meadows, grey-shingle farm houses and barns. All the milk flows to Tillamook. We stopped there at 11, halfway to Astoria, for ice-cream. The place had a lot of sitting capacity, but far more were waiting for a table to become free. Even the parking lot was crowded. People standing with their cones, people in lines for deli-food, for take-out ice-cream, people taking self-guided tours of the cheese factory past empty tubs, sealed vats, a vacuum packaging machine. Too many people, too suddenly, after days of the openness, adventure, and ocean. We regrouped at the lobby. Mama thought she would like lunch here. But having just had ice-cream, no-one was hungry. We put the meal off until Seaside. We'd be there in an hour. We passed through Bayside where the expansive Nehalem Bay meets the Nehalem River. Fishing boats sitting everywhere in active pursuit of a catch. The highway from this point on was iffy, impatient drivers passing on sharp turns and narrow bridges, cyclists crowding the narrow shoulders. We were in Seaside by 1, found a road to the city centre, parked a block from the Promenade, watched a bi-bicycle with the two

riders sitting side by side, a bike seating four, a bike-buggy with a steering wheel, a bicycle with two seats projecting over a centre bar, which much have required special skills. We walked along the Promenade. Two miles of condos and historic homes fronting an expansive beach where post-hole equipment was busy preparing for volleyball posts, five in a row, at least a dozen rows, for an upcoming tournament. The breeze was fresh, the sun clouded over, yet people were on the beach in bathing suits and light shirts. Papa insisted on pictures being taken at the Turnaround. We visited a central mall, a mix of restaurants, kiosks, shopping stalls, arcades, where I spent my birthday money on a wind breaker. Peter saw it first, insisted on me buying it, and was quite pleased with himself when I left the store with it in the bag. We ate at a restaurant nearby. Erik found a toy-gadget store with toy kits, wind-up toys, yo-yos, water pistols. He played with everything, asked for everything he played with, and resisted when the time came to go. We waited for the others to join us, returned along the Promenade to the van, drove up and down a few streets. Lots of homes dating to the founding of the resort.

The drive to Astoria was short. Matthew read comics, showing snippets to Cheryl's mom while her father slept. Erik slept. Peter stretched out on the middle seat. We crossed the Youngs Bay bridge onto the narrow peninsula between the Youngs and Columbia Rivers, into Astoria. We left the road at the end of the bridge and turned into the lot of the Bayfront Hotel, backing onto Pier 3 with piles of lumber waiting to be shipped. After checking in we drove into town. We parked and split up. Peter went with Papa, 'Because', explained Peter, 'Papa and I like to look at the same things.' The rest of us walked to the harbour front, followed the riverwalk past a couple of tug boats to look and a Marina Supply

store to the Maritime Museum where the Columbia, a retired coastguard vessel, is moored. It is closed to sightseers. We paid quarters into binoculars to look ocean freighters anchored in the river. We spotted a lighthouse way up the hill behind us. We agreed to meet at the van by 6. We had twenty minutes. We climbed three steep blocks past historic homes, a couple of churches and lodges, a daycare, opera house, and were at the van before Peter and Papa. Erik and I went into Chris' Bookstore. It had nearly everything. Erik wanted nearly all of that. We didn't stay long. We returned to the van, drove to the Astoria Column at the highest point of land. This took us past some beautiful homes. The boys and I climbed the 168-step spiralling stairway—Peter counted, Erik more than kept pace—to an observation deck with a 360° view over hundreds of miles of ocean, river, mountain and forest. We saw Cheryl far below. We waved. She waved back. Peter photographed the bridge. By the time we were at bottom my thighs were aching. We drove back to the harbour and found the Dutch Cup restaurant. We weren't hungry but ordered anyway: sole, stacked sole, chicken strips, hamburgers, salad plate, oysters, clam chowder and fresh-ground coffee. All this while watching boats on the massive Columbia river. We stayed for two hours. Our last supper, so to speak, for this was the end of Papa's treat. From now on we're on our own.

We returned to the hotel. The laundry room was closing at 9. Cheryl and Mama wanted to wash a couple of loads. The boys were in bed by 8:45. They didn't go to sleep, making sudden wakeful movements, sounds, giggling, sitting up, in spite of desperate warnings from the parents.

Thursday August 9

After the dramatic scenery of the past few days, our drive to Vancouver was straightforward, non-descript. Passing through Olympia to Tacoma, we were delayed several times by roadwork. The worst delay was at Aberdeen. We stopped briefly for coffee and again for lunch in Olympia: Coco's, another pie house. Urban sprawl ran continuously along both sides of the freeway to the border. We stopped for the night in South Tacoma. Checked into a Motel 6.

The plan for the next two days was shopping. I trailed Matthew and Erik around the mall on Mall Blvd while Cheryl shopped for clothes. They played in a toy store. I supervised, but not effectively. Everyone met at 5:30, update the plan, then split up again. Cheryl had a few things to finish. The rest of us went to Elmer's Pancake House. Everyone but Erik knew of the plan to swim after supper. I told Erik that if he ate all his hamburger there would be a surprise. Once he was done, I whispered the secret. Erik said, 'Papa, guess what the surprise is.' Papa answered, 'Will you tell me what the surprise is when you're finished swimming?' Erik's mouth opened, his face changed several shades. He said, 'Papa, you guessed.' A moment home videos are made for.

We finished up, walked across the parking lot to our room. The boys and I changed in our swimsuits. In the pool Erik challenged several boys to a fight. A girl played with Peter, hinting at having a date. We never found out how the romantic dimension would play out because Peter had to excuse himself to intervene between Erik and those boys. He began a water fight with all three, while Matthew teased about his being in love. Peter seemed not to mind.

After a while we returned to the room. By 9:15 Cheryl and her parents had returned. The boys were sleeping. We read.

Friday August 10

We ate breakfast at Elmer's, took the short drive to Seattle: a huge city, no beginning or end, thick yellow air, crazy traffic, the Boeing factories looming by the freeway, the sky needle. We stopped at a mall. Patronized by obviously affluent people. We wandered from shop to shop. Cheryl bought a cardigan for herself and two pairs of running shoes for Matthew. Papa looked at trailers. I bought a biography of Philip Roth. We ate at a small restaurant, pizza and sausage rolls before heading out.

We followed the 99 nearly to Everett. Slow driving, congested traffic. We cut across to I-5 to Bellingham to the Bellis Fair Mall for more shopping. We wandered, bought a Washington State sticker. Cheryl sat awhile with Erik while he slept. We met at the food court for coffee and cinnamon rolls. The next stop was the border. After 10-15 minutes of questions, more time spent filling out customs declarations, we came into Canada, travelled through Vancouver, arrived at Lloyd's at 6:30. He was asleep.

At 7 we headed out for supper, to Milestones by English Bay. Mama and Papa, Lloyd and Matthew stood in line. Cheryl, Peter, Erik and I walked along the beach, watched a woman with a lariat, someone performing magic, a juggler, someone rolling hats up and down their arms. Erik perched on a post to watch. Eventually Lloyd got our attention. We returned and ordered hamburgers with curly fries. The restaurant (and presumably West Vancouver) was full of young people. We returned to Lloyds by way of Davies Street and Stanley Park. It was dark. Erik fell asleep. We made up our beds. It was hot and muggy. The house was stifling. While going to sleep we listened to the traffic on Nanaimo Street.

Saturday August 11

After breakfast we drove into Burnaby to see Lloyd's Business, Sierra Motors, then to Gastown. Papa dropped Peter, Cheryl, Matthew and me off. Erik happily bid us goodbye. We ventured into East Hastings and Chinatown. Most of Gastown was gift shops, and specialty shops, expensive clothing stores, cafes, sidewalk venders, three boys break dancing. The Gay Games are on. Obviously a huge success. We buy a BC sticker in a gift shop. The proprietor tries to sell Cheryl a t-shirt by knocking \$2 off. We head out of Gastown for uptown, passing through two malls in search of a fan for Lloyd's place and kid's cassette tapes to occupy Erik on the long drive home. We ride the Sky-Train to Nanaimo Street, walk the three blocks downhill to Lloyd's, eat roast beef and corn on the cob for supper on the patio. The boys play a game of human slingshot with Lloyd's hammock and throw tennis balls at each other. They bathe and go to bed. Cheryl and I walk to Kingsway where we buy baby oil and two carbonated drinks. Back at Lloyd's we watch fireworks, view the skyline, go inside where the fans are buzzing, read, then sleep.

Sunday August 12

Another hot day. Heavy smoke obscured the mountains north of the city the past few days has cleared some. We head to Stanley Park to walk (or in Erik's case, ride). We cross an avenue lined with artwork. Mama can't resist getting portraits of the boys. Each costs \$25. It takes from 11 am to 12:15 pm. I stay with Matthew, who goes last, and the others head to the zoo. Canada geese chase people with popcorn and peck furiously at the kernels in the grass. We see a polar bear, sea otter, a harbour seal, birds, snakes, monkeys. There are clowns, a sax player, and mobs of people. Lloyd and I retrieve the van, pick up the others, and we cross Lions Gate Bridge to a small café in West Vancouver. We linger over the meal after an iffy start when Erik was told to stop swatting the palm at the entrance. Cheryl and her mom leave early to check a couple of clothing stores. We are out soon after and drive along Marine Drive to ogle at the massive homes on sheer cliffs, all the way to Horseshoe Bay. Cheryl reads a Harper's Magazine while Erik sleeps. Peter and Matthew eat ice-cream cones. We walk to the marina and watch salmon being butchered, heads and tails being tossed to the gulls. Once we get to the van, we find out Lloyd has gotten his hands on a 28 foot boat. He wants to take the boys for a tour of the coastline. Obligatory pictures are snapped, then the boat casts off. We travel at 6.5 knots with a slipping clutch. Peter goes below deck and pops out of a hatch at the bow. After docking we drive along British Properties, up and up to the top for a great view, then down to Lloyd's. We eat a light supper, throw a nerf ball around until it goes onto Lloyd's roof. I hoist Erik up to get it. The boys watch Funniest Home Videos. Cheryl and her mother howled. The sun went down on the last day of our holiday.

Sunday September 9

Matthew and Erik went to bed at 8. Erik spilt a few tears. Matthew quietly pulled on his pjs, brushed his teeth, then said prayers while stroking Cheryl 'like mad', then asked for his night light and a tape, either Mr. Bach Comes to Call, Mozart's Magic Fantasy or Beethoven Lives Upstairs.

He spent the evening on his skateboard, playing with Kerry Wallace next door. He wears a handkerchief rolled up and tied across his forehead. He has asked me a lot lately to play chess. He's keen on learning more moves. He brought a chess book home from school last week. He takes his time between each move, then chatting during my turn.

Erik sometimes joins us. He moves for me (if I'm lucky he takes my suggestion), or he sits nearby with his toys waiting for our game to end so he can begin one of his own. Which is a hoot. His rules are that no-one can cross into his 'area'. Whoever trespasses loses that player. Not for the whole game. He returns the players as a conciliatory gesture once he has encircled the opposing pieces and declared victory. I would say his methods are Bismarckian. Matthew at his age had a more Stalinist style, cleaning the opponent's (usually Peter) players off the board with the sweep of one hand, his chin Kasparov-ishly in the other.

Peter was at Junior League from 4:30 to 7. It was a barefoot night with games and foot-long hotdogs. He told Cheryl, 'It's good to see my friends again.' He's back at band. He attended the Summer Band Workshop, along with five other saxophones and one flute. He tells us his class is good and he likes his teacher, Ms. Pidskalny. In short, Peter takes the most positive view of every

part of his life. If misfortune occurs, he is philosophical. Maybe he learns something. For sure he moves on.

The boys returned to Sunday School today. For Peter and Matthew, it's pretty much the same routine. Erik, however, is a lottery. While I was dressing this morning, he came into the room.

'Who is my Sunday School teacher?' he asked. 'Is it Boden?'

'No.'

'Is it Mrs Bakre?' (Elaine)

'No.'

'Is it Mrs Bergsma?' (Matthew's Grade 2 teacher)

No.

But he wasn't so cocky at church. He was even uneasy. When he saw me he smiled, which turned into a frown, then into quiet tears. He didn't want the tears. The effort to hold back was obvious. He did accept a long hug from Cheryl.

Sunday September 30

The weather continues to be wonderful, warm, bright, colorful. It permits us to be out anytime, though now that it gets dark by 7:00 we cut things short.

Matthew is 8. He had 2 birthday parties last weekend. His friends came on Saturday at 3:30. We went to Putt'n Bounce on 8th. Erik came along. He kicked up dirt in a flower bed. Peter oversaw the group with Travis Halldorson, Saul Dixon, Jason Boyko. I attended the other, with Matthew, Danny Jutras, Ben Wilson. We came home, ate hot dogs, chips, ice cream, hunted for goodie bags. Everyone went home. Matthew got a Black Cauldron computer game for the IBM we picked up 2 weeks ago from WMCI computer teacher Tom Shabbits. Plus a tennis racket and balls, a Roughrider football, Roughrider pullover coat, several toys, a sweater, cardigan. Both sets of grandparents came for the second party on Sunday pm. Supper was early. Ham, buns, coleslaw, etc.

On Friday Erik came down with stomach flu, fever and cramps. He wasn't very happy all morning, but ate a bit at noon and watched Bambi in the afternoon while playing on the floor with cars, talking in several voices.

Matthew was also home. It was an in-service day at school. He rode bikes with Ben most of the time.

Cheryl's parents are having their anniversary. We will take them for a meal. We were to have gone out with Cheryl's staff Friday evening, but Erik wasn't well enough to leave. Cheryl was tired. Peter was at basketball.

Peter's camp continued Saturday morning. He skipped Strings. After dropping Matthew off at Suzuki Strings—he sits with Michael Meier—we continued downtown to shop for family photos.

Michael and Cathy came Friday evening to stay for a few days.

Blue Jays are playing Boston to complete the season. Boston was ahead one game after today.

Erik played at our place with Toby Wilson. He decided he'd like to go to her place, and promised he'd be careful crossing the street. He offered to 'hold her hand'. Once Peter, Matthew and I had spent a bit of time at the tennis court, Ben came over to play with Matthew and Peter went to Jeff's.

We are thinking about moving. Maybe we'll look for a used home in the neighbourhood or get something new. Things have to be sorted out.

Erik races to the phone. He's always there first. He answers, 'Hello, this is Erik speaking.

Wednesday November 21

We had our first real snow last night. 5 cm. The new house is going up quickly. It is at the framing stage. The 2nd and 3rd levels are closed in, the 1st level floor is done, the front step is installed.

Erik is as happy as he's ever been. The ruling theme is Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles. He had his hood up at breakfast. He was Casey Jones, a good guy. He sings Sunday School songs. Especially one he was given at Pioneer Club Choir to practice. He identifies letters of the alphabet, speaks in terms of 2nd, 3rd, 4th.

Christmas has come earlier this year. Erik demanded we get a tree. Cheryl bought a miniature tree. He turns off all the lights, flicks on the Christmas lights, and sits alone to watch them. Want to read? Go somewhere else. Once in bed he insists on the blinds staying up so he can look out the window and count the bulbs on the eaves. This is after getting his evening reading: his favourites are Frog and Toad, Clifford, Nightmare in My Closet.

Matthew is on a 'Read To Me' campaign. Last book was Charlie and the Chocolate Factory. Now it is The Lion, the Witch and the Wardrobe. Cheryl and I feel badly that we haven't read to Matthew as much as we did to Peter. We're trying to make up the deficit. He continues sketching. He is working on becoming an illustrator for children's books.

Wednesday December 12

Peter is so busy we wonder what would have happened had he stayed with the gymnastics routine. Volleyball ended tonight. Parents of the Grade 7 and 8 boys played in a volleyball challenge. Afterwards we ate pizza. Peter demonstrated his skills. A hard overhand serve, a controlled bump. The evening was fun, though there were too many wanting to play. Erik played with Katy Jutras. She's a Pippi Longstocking look-alike if I ever saw one. Matthew chased around with Danny until his hair was dripping sweat. Pizza was brought to the library and we ate till there t'weren't no more.

Then we drove by the house. It's being built by Preston Homes. The 1st and 2nd levels are complete up to the electrical and plumbing stage. Gyproc has been delivered for the ceiling. Concrete for the 3rd and 4th levels has been poured. The boys are excited. Peter has picked out his room on the 3rd level. Erik will be across the hall from our room. Matthew is next to the fireplace chimney. Moving day is set for January 15.

Peter has joined the Saskatoon Youth Orchestra. Wayne phoned a while back and asked him to think about it. He went back and forth on the matter. He'd be the youngest. The orchestra played at Unifest during the day and again in the evening celebrity concert. They are rehearsing for the upcoming Christmas concert. He writes a theory exam Saturday morning. The boys are in the Sunday School program Sunday afternoon.

Monday December 17

We're about to be hit by the first real storm. Blizzard warnings are out.

The house has been taped on the 1st and 2nd levels. The 3rd is next.

Saturday night was Peter's SYO Christmas concert at Castle theatre. Katherine Akre babysat. She played monopoly with the boys. Erik was her banker. Matthew said Erik is a real good player. I asked why he said that. He said it's because they ended up with a lot of money. After Erik was put to bed Katherine told him they would be downstairs. If he wanted something he should stamp his foot. He stamped once just because. 'Two thousand times later' (by Matthew's count) Erik came up with a reason. He told Katherine he had a sore finger. She wrapped it with a Kleenex and he fell asleep almost immediately. The next morning after he came to our bed Cheryl asked how the evening had gone. 'I don't want to talk about it,' was all he said.

The boys were busy in the Sunday School program. Peter played Benjamin, a dreamy artist, son of the innkeeper. Matthew was a tax collector. Erik sang and recited with the preschool group, and squeezed his eyes really hard at Pastor Solstein's request.

The pre-Christmas plan at school is a trip to Venice's Pizza and caroling Tuesday evening. Parents are supposed to accompany them. Cheryl and I are scarcely hanging on. Will we make it to the end of the week?

1991

Sunday April 14

We've moved.

We were home by 2. Cheryl and I went for a long walk. The boys remained at home.

Matthew and Erik played swords. This involves a king the boys want to rub out. They take breaks from time to time to sit together on the sofa, with Matthew telling Erik everything that has happened since the fight began, and everything that is likely to happen from that point on. Then they've slipped away, playing somewhere else almost without a sound.

Peter practised cello. He's attempting to catch up on practises missed during his rather busy week.

This is the first real day of spring. The sun has been bright, the snow is going away in a hurry. The side streets are full of water, the main streets are dry and dusty. The yard front and back are mud holes. It takes real vigilance to keep the boys out of it.

Cheryl and I decided today would be Sunday School only for the boys. We dropped them off and went to Robins' for coffee and a double chocolate donut. We returned to the church a bit early and talked with other parents. We cancelled plans for brunch at the Saskatoon Inn in favour of getting Peter ready for his basketball game at Mount Royal. We picked up Taylor Dubiel on the way. Erik has the flu. He fell asleep in the front seat, the plastic sword in its scabbard strapped around his waist. We dropped the boys off, drove to the Robins' on 22nd for a muffin, then returned for the rest of the game. The uniform includes big black shorts that hang well below the knees. He played with hot intensity, scored a

few points, showed frustration with every point surrendered. The game ended in a loss, 58—24. The story of a long season.

Back at home, Peter walked to Jeff Cenaiko's. He has arranged to go back to Jeff's tomorrow night to watch the Tyson/Ruddock fight.

Matthew helped us carry the remaining boxes from the garage to the basement then went outside. Cheryl and I worked a while longer doing the last bits of tidying up after the move of over a month ago, then walked around the block with Matthew and Erik, Erik on his plastic tractor.

After Peter returned—exclaiming about the spring weather—we went to Sawyer's with Mama and Papa. Erik and Matthew were busy with the goldfish. Back at home Erik bathed, then Matthew. Cheryl sat with Erik in his bed. He moaned and stroked her arm and said how much he loved her and didn't want her to ever go to heaven because he'd be so lonely. After finishing theory, Peter turned on Temple of Doom. Matthew watched him before going to bed. Cheryl and I spent the rest of the night reading. (I've begun Schama's *Citizens*, the Father's Day gift Cheryl gave me last year.)

I have a four-day trip to Vancouver later this week that needs some preparing. The SYO plays with the Saskatoon Symphony, which I deeply regret missing because my plane does not return until 8 Sunday evening.

Sunday May 12

Peter returned yesterday from a three-day canoe trip between the Borden bridge and Wyngard ferry. He was hot and dirty in his shorts, tee-shirt, bandana, canoeing shoes. He had sand in his ears and his belly. 'I must have been very hungry,' he said, 'because sometimes the food would fall right into the dirt and I just picked it up and eat it.' Erik and Matthew were very happy to see him. They had been asking about him the entire time.

On the way home we went for a hamburger. He talked about canoeing with Mr Smythe, water fights, girls squabbling over who's tent would be closest to which boys, campfire discussions, Mr Farthing's anger at kids still talking at midnight, their big meals, Gabe Jutras jumping out of his boat and swimming after someone who had just hit him with water; about his tighter friendships, how hard they had worked, evidenced by the fact he had slept most of the way home in David Stearn's car. Things hadn't looked at all hopeful at the beginning. We woke up Thursday to pouring rain. Peter got his things together without saying a word, waited impatiently at the front door with one pack on his back and the other on his front for balance.

Matthew goes nowhere these days without a book. He just finished *My Teacher Is An Alien* and begun *Prince Caspian*. He says scarcely a word in the car, pulls it out wherever his is made to wait, reads us passages or tells us something that has just happened. He laughs more than ever. He practises intently at cello, drilling difficult passages without being told, and is so fixed on getting something his way that when someone tells him otherwise, huge tears fall all over the cello. He told about two boys from Grade 4 who had spent an entire recess jumping and sliding

in the mud behind the school. Ironic for someone who for as long as we've known him has strained against our grip to reach mud and water with his feet.

Four years of age is a good time to compare children. Peter and Matthew when they were 4, and now Erik. They are so different. Peter's incessant questions (recalling when he had been at Bingham's, asking Bill things until Bill had to lie on the couch), Matthew's dreaminess, and now Erik telling us what he knows, which is everything. He bosses. He jokes. His favourite kind: 'Why did the chicken cross the playground? To get to the other slide'. He not infrequently gets into trouble. Or he thinks he's in trouble. Or where justice reigns, expects there to be trouble. And has developed a rather pat (smug) response:

'Erik, where did you get that?'

'Mom, do you have to ask?'

Or: 'Erik, tell me happened last night when the babysitter was here.'

'Don't ask me. I don't want to talk about it.'

Or: When at the supper table the other day, and he had stalled over a half-plate of food:

'Erik, you have a lot of food there. Eat up.'

'I'm full.'

'You can't be full. You've eaten hardly a thing.'

'Actually my ghost is full.'

'How do you know your ghost is full?'

‘Because, I heard him burp.’

While Erik’s Cherub Choir performs, recently he has created a bit of a stir. By out-singing everyone, using bigger hand motions and a louder voice. Last week during the all-music service they sang two numbers. His performance in particular gave the congregation fits. Barney from the Bowling Alley told me afterwards, ‘Your son could have done Sask-Place without a mike today.’

At home he sings his own choir songs and everyone else’s, Matthew’s Junior choir, something Peter plays, even songs Cheryl and I sing in the shower. Every chance he gets, he sings the ‘Johnny Appleseed’ blessing. At the finish his voice drops an octave and his head shakes with a quaver: ‘Aaaaaaaa-men.’

The Stanley Cup Finals begin Wednesday: Pittsburgh vs Minnesota.

Rain has fallen steadily. The province seems in great shape ahead of seeding.

Mother’s Day is today.

The number one TV show in this house is three weeks old. Dinosaurs. Starring Earl, Francis, two teenagers, and a newly hatched baby. (‘This better be breakfast!’). All of us find it funny. Friday at 6:30.

The new local basketball team is the Storm. Its season just began. We almost went to their home opener on Friday.

Monday July 14

We spent the last three days at a family reunion in Outlook. Many arrived Friday afternoon, some just in time for supper at 6. While unloading the van, we discovered we had left Matthew's and Erik's suitcase at home. We ate supper and headed out. Peter and Matthew stayed behind with instructions to be in bed by 9. As soon as we were back, Mom found us with the disturbing news that Peter and Matthew were missing. The room had been checked. No-one could remember seeing them since 8. We did a quick circuit of the campus together, checked the most logical places, but no boys. Mom was almost desperate. Word got out and several others joined the search. I thought we should check the room again. I asked Mom, 'Did you know we have two rooms, 23 and 24?' She didn't. She knew only about Room 23. We went into 24, found the room dark, the blinds pulled down, both boys in bed. Peter smiled and apologized to Mom for not telling her they had gone to bed. She said, 'Your boys are too good. They deserve a medal.'

The weekend had been organized and run by Aunt Anne. There she was, manning the registration table, taking our \$220.64, putting out sign-up sheets for the horse-shoe tournament, golfing foursomes, swimming, tennis, bible study, and so on. At each meal she banged a serviette dispenser with a knife or spoon for attention while here and there conversations persisted. Once everyone was silenced she said, perhaps a bit ironically, a faint smile, maybe more serious than not, 'I will give the announcements as soon as Hugh (or Charles or Bob or Alan or Edward) stops talking.' Aside from this, the cafeteria-style meals were smooth affairs. Families sat around the tables. The children

especially were noisy. Food was good, the meals were varied. Lemonade and coffee were available through the day. Some ate and left. Others sat and talked, moved elsewhere, then sat and talked, going at it for 90 minutes or more, then moving outside the cafeteria, standing in the shade. Dad and his siblings were the most persistent at this. Almost anytime, anywhere, they'd be together with their coffee, at a table, on a bench.

Several were up early in the morning to walk. Who knows how far. After the first morning, a sort of competition began. The rules were never stated, only implicitly understood. Only couples were eligible. (It was about teamwork.) Get-up times were noted. Couple 1: 'We headed out at 6 this morning.' Couple 2: 'Lazybones. We were out by 5.' Couple 3: 'We walked into Outlook.' Couple 4: You know the pipe across the ravine? We crossed over that, followed the riverbank to the bridge, and came home through Outlook.' Couple 5: 'We left in the dark.' Couple 6: 'We didn't go to bed.' Couple 1: 'We're going to leg it to Dinsmore tomorrow, maybe Rosetown. Any takers?' Even though it was the most intensive competition—energy, time, sleep-deprivation—there were no prizes, not like in horseshoes, only gossip, word getting back to the leaders and laggards, humphing and jabbing partners with elbows, resolutions communicated through glances. As a matter of pride, Charles and Phyllis were in the lead on Saturday. There was confusion about Sunday am. Cheryl and I wondered what if the reunion had lasted seven days, or a hundred.

Cheryl and I played tennis after breakfast on Saturday. It was hot and buggy. Between the court and fencing was several feet of grass. Miss the ball and watch it bounce through the tall grass. Retrieve the ball only by stirring up clouds of mosquitoes and

bringing them back to the court. We didn't play long. Maybe ten misses long. When the gym opened and the lights were finally turned on, the children poured in and we followed. We started with some doubles badminton. I'm lousy. Cheryl did well. Murray was the best. Lee Ann—Joel's current squeeze and my playing partner—was rusty. We lost in record time. The others played basketball. Carl was in charge, Hugh arrived later, Joel and Peter and Matthew and the countless other baby rabbits ran back and forth across the floor, not keeping score, throwing the ball, not shooting, making a mockery of simple rules. Erik and others his age had taken off their shoes and were jumping from the collapsed risers onto a thick mat. Pictures were taken, thirty dollars was collected for the cost of turning on the lights.

Carol and Les showed up with Graeme and Cameron just before Saturday lunch. They had been Friday evening with Colin before he returned to northern BC to plant trees. After lunch, Joel and I played the first of three sets of tennis. Lee Ann sat on the other court and poked at a caterpillar. The sun was hotter, sweat stung the eyes. After the set, which Joel won 7-5, we joined the others who were arranging swimming and golf. Three golfing foursomes went one way. At least two loaded vans (ours being one) went to the pool. Mom and Carol talked in the shade. Cheryl sat on the pool edge Sara, Leslie's wife. That first plunge was exhilarating. Joel and I raced across the pool a couple of times. I bruised the tip of my fingers at the finish. Peter and Matthew played with Hugh's kids. Judy's daughter Amanda talked with Carl's stepson, Scott. Erik played in the shallow end until he got me to take him into deeper water. I threw him up and he sunk deep, swam to the top, floated on his back. In two weeks of Level One swimming he's become a real water baby. Matthew still wears

earplugs. He gets a slight buzzing in one ear after swimming. If that's the worst it gets, he may soon be out of them altogether. He can't wait. In fact he has been after us to get an appointment with Dr. Gore-Hickman to find out how things stand.

Once back on campus the kids disappeared. They have discovered the tunnel. Erik was torn between fascination with the idea of underground passageways and fear of the same. Supper was a hamburger barbeque. The mosquitoes are a pestilence, which several of us—Cheryl, Uncle Hugh, Judy, Karen, Sara and I—intend to brave for the sake of a summer evening in the courtyard, which lasts only so long before we're chased indoors, keeping up the conversation with lemonade and a slow cooling overhead fan.

After supper everyone began preparations for the Variety show. I MC-ed off a list of 14 participants Aunt Anne gave me, which became 17. Carol rehearsed with Peter and Matthew in a room by the gym, then with Graeme. The boys prepared Gavotte (Matthew), The Elephant's Waltz (a duet), The Swan (Peter). Carl sang a song, gave a reading of W.C. Fields, performed a skit with Scott. Several women did a fashion show with Judy narrating. Aunt Anne did a shadow play. Uncle Ed's girls sang. Roger's daughter Nicole read a poem. Several men sang 'Reunion '91'. The words were written by Dad, the melody was She'll Be Coming 'Round the Mountain. Murray called on 18 volunteers to play a game. Diane's girls played two piano numbers and sang a song. Two of Hugh's kids sang a duet, and each sang a solo. Graeme played two numbers on the violin, Carl's wife played a solo, Carl's second step-son Damien played a solo.

Once the show ended we broke up into small groups. Once the children were down, we'd go into Outlook. Erik was the first in bed. We waited outside. Before long we heard him crying. I went in to see what was the matter. I found him in his sleeping bag, sticky and red, crying at the window. I asked if there was a problem. He asked if there were such things as monsters and nightmares. I said no. He wasn't sure. He lay down anyway and I sat with him while his eyes slowly closed and opened.

Peter and Matthew came after awhile. Peter lay in my bed to keep Erik company. Matthew slept in the top bunk of Room 24. Joel, Lee-Ann, Les, Carol, Cheryl and I went looking for a café that served cold drinks. Nothing open. We found the café at the Esso station, amused ourselves at the expense of waitresses, who might have preferred a quieter evening, amused ourselves at the greater expense of each other, particularly Carol, whose inability to follow jokes hasn't changed since her childhood (the best we can remember). Returning by 11, but not ready to sleep, we hunted down others and found Roger, Karen and Carl in the Lounge. We sat with them until after 12. Carl left first with his empty ice-cube bag, Roger told us stories about the 'Screaming Eagles', his aging all-purpose Watrous gang, and one of the town oddballs who operated a driving range and cleaned the pool.

I was awake by 7. I dressed, woke Joel, and we went out to settle scores on the tennis court. I beat him in two sets, 6-1 and 6-4 to take the three-set competition 2-1. To be honest Joel is kind. He doesn't play as much as I do, but is game, doesn't make excuses, has a wry sense of humour. We ended up being late for breakfast. I had to shower first. Les and Carol joined Cheryl and me. Judy came a bit later. We talked until 10:30. Mostly, jokingly, about

marriage. Everyone else was long gone. It was Sunday and the family has more than its share of ministers. Each one was preparing for the role he had agreed to play in the service. Peter returned just after 10 to remind us that he needed to get ready. We had forgotten his solo. He had brought his cello down to the chapel. We remained at the table until scant minutes before the service began.

Dennis Hendriksen led the service. The children were to be taken to Sunday School just before the sermon. A terrible noise was coming from the balcony. We turned to see what it was. The top of a head could be seen above the balcony wall travelling back and forth at a good clip. Dennis went to investigate. He found his son on a tricycle crashing into stacks of chairs. Just like that, it was quiet.

Carl gave the sermon. (It should be noted that Carl is one of our favourite subjects of humour: at 6'7" and 270 pounds, he's one of the gentlest people on earth. We have been amazed by the quantities of food he consumes in a meal, plates and plates of it). The sermon was a story about Winnie-the-Pooh. One day Pooh wanted to visit a friend. He thought of Owl, but Owl used words that were too long. He thought about Tigger, but Tigger was moody. Then he thought about Rabbit. Rabbit uses such encouraging words like 'Why not stay for dinner', and 'Have some more'. Carl said he was a lot like Pooh. Cheryl and I could hardly contain ourselves. Carl, we were thinking, you are more like Pooh than you imagine. There isn't a storybook character out there more like you than Pooh. Peter played a portion of the Bach Suites. An offering was taken. Ed's daughters sang a song. We sang hymns. We dispersed.

The children went to the gym for one last crack. The floor was littered with plastic hockey sticks, balls, nets, badminton rackets. Erik spent time with Uncle Hugh. They went into the tunnel. As one goes further, the tunnel grows darker. Erik hardly dared to go to the end. But Uncle Hugh encouraged him. And doing it once, he had to do it over and over. He had discovered that the stories Matthew had been feeding him were not true. Of monsters and death and things that grow where it's too dark to see. He and Uncle Hugh planted a banana tree. The banana (a Caragana pod) wasn't even bruised. He was excited. He made us promise that at the next reunion in two years' time we'd check on how high it had grown.

The noon meal was big, featuring chicken and salads. Aunt Anne's last round of announcements included the Horse-shoe Trophy, presented to Murray and Aunt Clara. Uncle Alan offered to engrave the names of last year's and this year's winners. She acknowledged Charles and Phyllis' 40th Anniversary. Glasses tinkled. They kissed. Mom blamed me for bringing it up. Cheryl noted that Katherine's husband Graham had kept to himself for the entire weekend, seeming to go in the opposite direction to everyone else. She visited with Katherine while Carol, Mom and I reviewed the weekend. Carol said that after Les, Murray, Leslie and Roger were finished their golf game they'd be going straight back to Calgary. Cheryl has said she wants to get started on golf this summer. This summer is too soon for me.

Everyone milled about outside, wrapping up the conversation saga, Hugh, Jody, Katherine, Aunt Audrey and Uncle Ed on the walk by the girl's dorm, the rest in the chapel looking at Aunt Anne's pictures of her trip to Egypt and Aunt Isabelle's pictures of

Zimbabwe. Then we packed. I left Matthew's cello with Dad so we could hunt down the boys. Janet stood by our van talking with Ed and Audrey. They don't see much of each other. Janet caught a ride with us. Her car was left at Karen's. She planned to return to Edmonton today. Ed and Audrey watched while we pulled away. It was 3.

Monday August 12

The summer is passing quickly. Cheryl's classes are over. She wrote her last final on Friday, a three hour open-book. The last two weeks have been long for her. She has worked hard and is anxious to begin her holiday.

But we have had a memorable summer. The boys have been busy with activities. Matthew took a week of soccer camp. Cheryl drove him, parked in Harvey's stall by the Phys-Ed building, left him with his instructors, and walked to the Biology building where her class is held. Peter is completing his White badge at the Lakewood civic centre. He likes his instructor. She is young but demanding. She told me that Peter's only area needing improvement is to reach farther ahead on his front crawl and he bring his hand up nearer his on his back crawl. The rest, his stride entry, head-up crawl, safety procedures, endurance are all very good. He did pass and is now ready to work on his Bronze Medallion. Matthew and Erik participated in the Olympic Way swim program at the university. Matthew went for six weeks, Erik for four. Matthew was bumped up to Level 2 even though three years ago he didn't get his Level 1 because of ear infections. The instructor felt he would be out of place with four year olds. He did well in Level 2, was moved into Level 3, passed that in two weeks, moved into Level 4, and passed that in two weeks. He has a strong quick stroke. He has completed as much as Peter by the end of his Level 4, except for the butterfly, which they seem not to be teaching. He loves swimming, but he wants to get rid of the ear plugs that make it difficult to hear the instructor. His hair has that chlorine sheen. Erik began in Level 1. He too loves the water, but is careless because he doesn't know enough to fear it. Most of the

time he wears a life jacket, but he wants to put his head under the water. His best 'stroke' is the bob-and-breathe, which involves letting go of the side of the pool, sinking and then recovering to grab the side again. He looks over at Cheryl and me and smiles. But he makes Cheryl nervous. He goes about with a kick-board in depths well over his head. He is smaller than the others and falls behind. He seems not to care that the others are ahead, and twists and turns according to the patterns in his mind. He jump into the water and dogpaddles the four feet back to the side, though there is the danger that someone will get in the way. We aren't sure how he'd react if that happened. Cheryl knows what I would do. I'd jump up and save him. After four weeks he is much improved in a lot of areas. He nearly passed the first level. We'll wait to put him back in Olympic Way for a couple of years until he is bigger and ready to do the lengths that kids in Level 2 are required to do.

Friday August 16

Today is our sixteenth anniversary. At 9 am Erik was playing Sega Genesis, Tommy Lasorda's Baseball and Matthew was sleeping. He cleaned tables at Folkfest until 10 last night. We said it was time to go home. He said he wanted to stay. Peter, with huge plastic gloves, was working at a drink machine. He saw me coming, and before I could say a word he said that they are desperately short of help. We arranged for Mama and Papa to take him to their place for the night.

Cheryl worked a couple of hours before the pavilion opened, helping her mother cut and prepare cakes. When I arrived to pick her up at 6 she said that they were barely able to keep up with demand. Someone had shut off the air-conditioning and the small kitchen was unbearable. We left with Erik, who was more than a little disappointed to learn that the gnomes he had been waiting to see were only plaster statues. He was heartened slightly when Mama told him that live gnomes were coming later on in the evening, but disappointed again when I told him they weren't real gnomes, which were only a few inches tall and hundreds of years old, only ordinary people dressed up as gnomes. Eventually he dropped the subject.

We went to Granada restaurant for the BBQ ribs special and half order of spaghetti, split three ways. Cheryl had a headache. Erik had a Ninja Turtle character. After eating we went home, changed, loaded Matthew's skateboard with the handle into the trunk, and drove to the University area for a walk. Erik took off ahead of us, bouncing the board off upturned concrete sections, barely keeping control. We were a little nervous, but he would turn around and come tearing back to us all smiles. We walked along

Elliot to Clarence, south a block and back to Cumberland. We hadn't gone very far from Clarence before he had us pull him. It had rained quite heavily earlier in the day and a sodden lake smell was in the air; reminded me of our times in Waskesieu. By the time we got back to the car it was nearly dark. We drove this way and that until we arrived at Marion Graham to get Matthew.

Folkfest is something that the two older boys look forward to. They have had times this summer when they didn't have enough to do. Their good friends were out of town. Matthew has phoned Danny Jutras every day, knowing that he is either at Emma Lake in July or in Oregon, where his father is finishing up a Masters. Peter has played with Taylor but would prefer Gabe Jutras. He didn't phone Gabe – Matthew was being silly with his persistence – but kept his ears wide open to hear if Matthew got any results. Peter and Taylor went to Bill and Ted's Bogus Journey at the Odeon on Tuesday and quoted pieces of dialogue and laughed all the way home. Cheryl and I rented Awakenings with Robin Williams and Robert DeNiro. We have arranged for tickets to As You Like It, a 'Shakespeare on the Saskatchewan' production.

We have arranged for Erik's piano lessons. He is excited. He goes to the piano nearly every day. He hasn't said a word about wanting to play the violin. Cheryl and I are happy about the piano. A third string instrument would be too much the same.

We spent several days this summer at the Fringe Festival. The boys loved the outdoor theatre, "Flying Bob Debris and his trick with the celery ('Oh I love my job'), Charlie Brown from San Francisco, Motion Sickness, Easy-T's (an a cappella group); and everyone's favourite, Sak Theatre from Florida, a group of three with rewritten Shakespeare and fairy tales that narrated the

happenings while members of the audience played the leading roles. Cheryl and I saw two indoor performances, Dr. Bossins and Mr. Cairns (Cheryl's friend from Walter Murray), and Animal Farm, a performance by a touring company made up of Russian students. We saw the second performance with Peter and Louise. We went to Calories before the performance, talked about Louise's job at the Psychiatric Penitentiary, about adolescents (given some interesting experiences they have had with Usine), about writing. Peter babysat. Omeasoo came over with Scooter to keep him company. We were home by a little after one. Cheryl and I would attend one other dramatic performance before summer ended. To celebrate our anniversary we bought tickets to 'Shakespeare on the Saskatchewan's' presentation of As We Like It set in the late-'60s. Hilarious. We sat in the front row of the natural turf stage. A full house.

Sunday August 25

Peter, Matthew, Papa and I went to the driving range at Greenbrier Golf Course. It was Peter's idea, although Cheryl and I had talked all summer about doing some golfing. Peter had actually wanted me to join him on the course, but I thought it better to limit my first experience to the driving range. Four events proved me right. First, after purchasing tokens for several buckets of balls I put one into the machine and watched the balls drop and bounce all over the concrete pad. Only then did I discover the empty buckets I was supposed to set in place to catch them. Second was the driver I used. It was Dad's. The head was secured to the shaft with masking tape. Third was my first drive. The ball I struck went sideways, clearing the noses, just, of the men and women to my right. The fourth would wait for half an hour. In the meantime Matthew did well for his first time. Peter knows what he's doing. His drives rise high, straight, and depending on the club travel between 75 and 150 yards. The four of us kept hitting until the first load of balls was exhausted. Papa went to get more but the machine was empty. A worker had gone onto the range to collect more so we assumed he'd take a while. Since everyone was wanting more, to kill time we went into the clubhouse, ordered coffee and ice-cream for the boys, sat on the deck, enjoyed the sun, talked about winter travel plans, and waited for the machine to be filled. A half-hour later we were back out. The fourth event was a grande finale: I took a full backswing, over-swung going forward, missed the ball, went off my feet and landed on my back. Some may have gotten a good laugh, but I didn't look around to see. Even if the boys had kept quiet about it, the grass stains on my back were all Cheryl needed to know how things went. I will never

again sit in the Willow's restaurant and laugh at the first-timers. Comical as their swings may be, not one I've seen has ended up on his back.

We were invited to Mama's for supper. Her sister Judy was to be there. She had just come from the hospital where her husband Ronnie is just out of intensive care, being treated for severe burns for reasons no-one is quite clear about, but we assume was his 'still' exploding in his basement. We ate on the patio: barbecue roast, corn on the cob, carrot sticks, french bread and juice. We watched the 6 o'clock news to see that the Blue Jays had come from 6-2 behind to beat the Yankees. I had turned it off in the fifth inning. I'm quite sure that me watching my teams has a unconsoling effect on the athletes.

Peter and Matthew register at Lakeridge tomorrow. Matthew is clapping his hands with excitement. Peter is feeling more cautious. He won't know until Tuesday what he is in for. Erik wanted to go to bed early tonight to bring tomorrow more quickly, because he's going to Shirley's in the morning and kindergarten at Buena Vista in the afternoon.

Last night we had joined Mom, Dad, Matthew, Cheryl, Diane and Ernie at Kinsmen Park for a picnic. Matthew and Cheryl go to Texas today. We may not see them for years if their visas to Nepal come through. The children were noisy and had a lot of fun. Every one of them went to the play village for a while, then returned to go on the train. When it turned out that its wheels had fallen off in the tunnel, they went on the merry-go-round. We left when it got dark and the mosquitoes were unmanageable. Better I suppose than the wasps hovering inside our glasses of orange juice earlier in the evening.

Tuesday November 5

Cheryl and I have just finished with student reporting. We have no assignments left to mark. We're looking forward to having nothing much to do over the Remembrance Day Long Weekend. In fact, our leisure began this evening. After Matthew's cello lesson we ate a hamburger supper, sat at the table, discussed Peter's volleyball game against College Park, Matthew's first soccer practise last night, Erik's school work (he drew the number '6' today). Then we cleaned the kitchen, lit our first fire of the winter, took photos of the boys (it's Cheryl's hope we might get something for Christmas cards), watched the season's new sitcom, Home Improvement, put Erik to bed, sat in the family room and read while Peter blew on the logs to make better flames, put Matthew to bed, watched Peter fall nearly to sleep on the rug, put him to bed, watched Cheryl doze on the love seat, and so on.

Cheryl has a 'dream class' this year. She said she would miss Buena Vista if she left it. She has been cooking up plans for an Education Leave but can't decide if she's ready for it to be next year (with so few classes completed by this point, she would have to work very hard) or the year after. She has only two difficult students. The rest are high-achieving and wonderfully easy to get along with. It's obvious they appreciate everything she's doing. Some can't get enough. She looks for Erik every noon hour and afternoon recess. It has turned the dull and tiring exercise of playground supervision into something else. When he sees her, he comes running. He walks with her and holds her hand. This has caused a bit of a problem for other kids who can't understand why this particular one is permitted to hug and kiss a teacher and they are not. Erik enjoys school. He loves his teacher. She, Sandy

Byneshewsky, she finds him very sweet and funny. He plays jokes on her, sitting at her desk and not noticing that she has sat on his knee. After school he goes back to Shirley's to play, and doesn't like Cheryl to come too early.

Matthew has spent six weeks taking art lessons downtown at the old James Art Studio. His sketches and paintings are placed around the house. His favourite is the cougar he copied from a card. He works hard at school. He wants to do well. He never has to be told to get his homework done. His teacher admitted amazement at a lot of the artwork he turns in; our one concern is that working with such minute detail makes it hard for him to get anything finished by the deadline). He has made some good friends at school. Every day, until the snow fell last week, they've spend every break playing soccer. Several are on the same team. At supper he demonstrated the slo-motion boxing he was doing with one of the boys. He is swimming now, Red Cross Blue. They had to tread water for four minutes. He loves it enough to get out of bed at 7 (otherwise he won't be up before he absolutely has to) and dressed before I am out of the shower. He comes down to the kitchen, sets out the cereal and bowls (formerly Peter's job, who is now showing the signs of being a teenager by letting—though even this seems calculated—his superhuman punctuality slip a bit, and is often the third person into the kitchen now).

Friday November 29

Payday was yesterday so we went for supper tonight. Cheryl phoned her father and we met him at the Cave. (Mama is working at Sears until 10). Peter ordered in advance because he was leaving early with Taylor to attend a play at Holy Cross High School. We spent two hours eating. Matthew wandered around with a map. Places like this end up in his sketches, done on a very small scale. Erik drew arrows and Christmas trees on the back of a place mat.

Peter and Matthew got report cards a week ago. Their work is either a grade ahead or exceptional (Peter's math; Matthew's art and handwriting). Peter is at school at all hours. He is President of the student government which plans special days like Gym Blast. He plays on the volleyball team (the summer camp helped him develop a hard serve; at 5 feet tall, he needs all the help he can get). Matthew practises with his soccer team on Monday nights, 7:30 - 8:30. Cheryl and I attend choir practise at 7 and leave in time to pick him up and drive him home. Peter practises basketball every Wednesday between 8:30 and 10. Games are usually on Saturday afternoons. He missed most of them last year because of Saskatoon Youth Orchestra. He performs at the Sundog Fair tomorrow at 2. While I'm working the door, Cheryl will be with Matthew and Erik. When I'm done, we'll go to the Festival of the Trees at the Ramada. Peter is raising money for the Easter trip to Banff with the SYO by selling Drake sausages. Several days after school or in the evening he has canvassed our neighbourhood. We figure he is bringing in over \$13 per hour. He seems happy to do it. He never complains.

Erik's school is going well. Almost every day Sandy has some story to tell Cheryl about what he has said or done. Most is funny. He knows that his comedy rarely fails.

We're busy with Matthew, helping him adapt the qualities that serve his art so well to other areas that suffer somewhat. He is dreamy. The classroom instructions he does not follow: is that because they don't penetrate to the command centre of his brain, or he is actively ignoring them? On the way to doing a task are several diversion points. He usually takes them all. We want to preserve these qualities, but we want him to succeed elsewhere too. He works hard. He wants to do well. He follows our suggestions. One quality we admire is that he tells us exactly what he is thinking. 'Can this be a short practise?' or 'Wait a minute, I want to work on this before I go on.' He played Humoresque last Thursday on Solo day. He has come so far. It's a difficult piece. He loves the cello and practises hard and willingly.

Peter's cello lessons with Bernadette have become chat-fests. When I pick him up at 9:30 pm, I find him leaning back in his chair, cello upright, talking with Bernadette, often both of them are laughing; or he's talking quietly while Bernadette writes notes in his instruction book.

Sunday December 22

This is the second day of our holidays. Erik and Matthew have spent the past week counting the days until Christmas. One starts a new round of chanting and is immediately joined by the other: 'After tonight there are seven days till Christmas, then six days till Christmas, then five days till Christmas . . .'

We've been through a steady stream of Christmas concerts. The SYO performed on the 18th. Michael and Catherine, who were here at the time, attended with us and came home afterwards. We discovered the tree, which we had put up that afternoon, tipped over and pieces of glass balls scattered across the floor. Matthew's Suzuki players played the following Thursday. Matthew has a new haircut. We left there to hear Peter's Zone Band at the Market Mall. Matthew stayed behind for a snack and to see Santa Claus. Peter played a sax duet with Mr. 'B'. Both Peter and Matthew had their school concert last Wednesday, which finished with the entire school body on stage singing Christmas Rock. The place was full. Erik sat most of the evening on Cheryl's lap. The next night, Thursday, Erik's school had its concert. He was dressed as a snowman: a hat, a white garbage bag with buttons down the front, and a carrot (construction paper rolled into a cone) held to his nose by a rubber band. Peter, Matthew and I sat in the front row and got several pictures. Cheryl led her class in a rap song about hockey.

Friday night we were invited to Mama's and Papa's for supper. Lloyd had come in the previous evening. Shirley Bondy was also there. Peter was at a classmate's house for a party. Supper was peppercorn roast beef, lefse, 'broccoflower', ice-cream. Matthew and Erik opened their gifts from Shirley, a sport watch and Hardy

Boy's book for Matthew, a video with three old Christmas cartoons (dating late '40's) for Erik.

Saturday morning we met Mom and Dad at the Saskatoon Inn. We visited until nearly eleven. Cheryl and I shopped for the last Christmas things while the boys did some cleaning and playing at home. At home the boys and I went to the new rink behind St. Luke's and played shinny, separately from the others to begin with, then with everyone to finish. Erik and I were Los Angeles Kings. Peter and Matthew were the Boston Bruins. The Kings won. Erik and I left before the others. He held my hand back to the house. He said, 'That was the absolute funnest.' Peter and Matthew were home within a half hour.

Cheryl and I put the finishing touches on a supper for Mama and Papa and Lloyd. Lloyd was on his cell phone a couple of times during the meal. After he left we made a fire. I had some trouble getting it started. When the flames had consumed the paper kindling and were dying down, Erik stood over my shoulder and said, 'Dad, that doesn't look like a fire.' In time it did. Then we watched Princess Bride. It lasted until 11. The boys went straight to bed.

Sunday morning everyone slept in. I was up first, reading To Serve Them All My Days - Part II on the sofa. Erik and Cheryl came down shortly after. He had been in our bed. He had sung The 12 Days of Christmas to Cheryl, with a kiss for each day. Cheryl read the paper. Erik read Gnomes aloud.

Tuesday December 31

We're just back from Calgary. We left last Friday. After packing the car at 7 am, we drove to the airport to see Lloyd off, had coffee at the Saskatoon Inn with Cheryl's parents, went by Joel's, and were on the highway by 9:30. We drove the Taurus (our vehicles are no longer reliable for long trips in the winter) Cheryl's Dad had rented for Lloyd while he was here. We stopped once on the way, in Hanna. When we arrived at 3:30, Mom and Dad were already there. Michael and Catherine arrived soon after. We took Mom and Dad to Milano's on Signal Hill to celebrate their 40th anniversary. Les, Michael and I went to Blockbuster Video to rent three movies, Clarence the Cross-Eyed Lion, From the Hip and Robin Hood: Prince of Thieves. We picked up two pizzas from Little Caesar's. Michael and Cathy went by their place to change. We met them at the restaurant. We sat at a table with a good view of Calgary's downtown. Afterwards we went to Les' and watched From the Hip. Not very good. Partway through, Mom and Dad got tired and decided to leave, Carol and Cheryl began making sandwiches for tomorrow's ski trip, and Les and I packed the car with ski things. The movie was playing to an empty room.

Les woke us shortly after seven. We ate breakfast, dressed, packed the car, dropped first by Michael's and then the Ski Barn for rentals. On the drive to Sunshine, Michael made a call on Les' cellular and Graeme peed in a ditch outside Canmore. The temperature was well above zero and we wondered what snow conditions would be like.

We parked the car some distance from the gondolas, loaded ourselves with skis and packs, purchased tickets, and rode up. The heights made Matthew quietly apprehensive and Erik chattily

apprehensive. Peter was ahead with Cameron, Michael donned a hat with ear flaps and sun glasses. The zipper of Les' ski pants gave out, which couldn't be hidden no matter how Les arranged his jacket. I wore bright green Roughrider sweats.

After getting off the gondola, we got into our skis and worked sweatily up the last slope to the Strawberry chairlift. I was nervous. I haven't skied since 1982 when Lloyd and I were at Whistler-Blackcomb. Now, not only was I to get on and off a chairlift and down the hill, but I had to do it with Erik between my legs. We didn't do very well the first time. An assistant helped by carrying Erik to the bottom of the ski-off. From that point on we were alone. Michael and Matthew were together, Peter and Cameron headed off somewhere, Les and Graeme skied separately. With Erik tucked between my legs, I snowplowed all the way. As Erik grew more used to his skis, he undertook the flatter parts on his own, and gripped my ski pole where the slope increased a bit, and the rest of the way was directly in front of me, or between my legs, or gripping me from behind. It wasn't until the days after when he complained about having sore arms and legs that I realized how tough it was for him too.

We stopped skiing at 1 to eat. We sat at a picnic table outside the lodge. The sun was bright, the snow and trees were beautiful. The crowds were not too heavy. At times we were able to ski directly onto the chairlift. On one trip, when Michael and I skied together and Matthew was sitting out because he was tired, Les took Erik. The rest of the time Erik and I were together and it wasn't long before my thighs were screaming for mercy. By three Graeme, Erik and Matthew had had enough. I stayed at the lodge with them while the others rode the Angel lifts near to the top.

Peter navigated the black diamond runs on his behind and it wasn't much more dignifying for Michael. At the end of the day we got our things together. The smaller boys and I took the gondola to the parking lot with a Japanese snow host named Mika. Each time the gondola reached a terminal point, the others who were skiing out were directly below. We were all tired and wet, and shivered while packing up the cars. We were on the highway by 5:30. Michael phoned Cathy to see how the meal preparations were coming. The kids slept.

We were at Carol's by 7. Michael went ahead to his place with Joel and Colin. By the time we arrived, the duplex was full, the basement was noisy with kids. We were humoured by Michael's neighbour who shouted through the walls at the noise Margot was making, and when that didn't stop her, started banging. King's College Choir sang Christmas music on Michael's new speakers. Supper was a vat of spaghetti and meat sauce and ice cream for dessert. We watched Robin Hood. In spite of the assist of Michael's 'surround-sound' system, the audio was so poor early on that the kids stopped paying attention. The movie ended after 11, and we packed up our belongings, stowed the chairs, and returned to Carol's.

Sunday morning Cheryl and I left the kids in bed and went to church. Carol was tense ahead of playing the organ. After the service, Cheryl and I headed back to Carol's to prepare brunch. We were expecting Michael and Cathy any time after 10:30. The egg was slow to cook, so we didn't begin eating until noon. With so much food being consumed before this, no-one minded. After, we moved to the living room and chatted. The idea of walking in Fish Creek Park came up. The turkey was put in the oven, everyone but

the kids got into two cars. After parking in Evergreen we navigated the steep slope to the bottom, slipping and falling and tossing back and forth Joel's deflated football. Cheryl and Carol walked ahead of the rest of us. Snow and ice covered the path. There were a lot of laughs. Back at home, we prepared supper. Michael and I played 'Ultimate Noball' while Dad sat in another corner and laughed. The kids played with Nintendo, then ate in the kitchen. Erik was full before his food was half eaten. The rest of us ate turkey, dressing, sweet potatoes, potatoes and salad in the dining room.

Monday was a free day. Mom and Dad were over before 8 to finish cleaning up. We were up after 9. They left with Joel after coffee. Peter and I went for a walk in the valley, during which he asked about Robin Hood, and how the real legend, which he read a fair bit about when he was younger, differed from the movie we had just seen. After returning to the house Les arrived, and we arranged to go to the Elbow Falls and Bragg Creek, both southwest of the city. We took Graeme with us in the Taurus. The falls are inside Kananaskis Park. We found a parking lot, walked through a parking lot to a picnic area near the river. Several families were eating at fire-pits. We walked to the top of a path where fences kept us from climbing out too far onto the rocks overlooking the Falls. The water was clear. Les and I bypassed a 'closed' sign, crawled along a narrow path to a high point, and sighted four people down below in the river. We drove to Bragg Creek, had coffee in a Grandma Lees restaurant, wandered in a pottery shop, returned to Calgary, stopped at the Safeway for a few groceries, then had a supper of fettuccine alfredo and caesar's salad. Michael and Cathy showed up later and we played Monopoly for the rest of the night.

We were packed up the next morning, Tuesday, by 9. We had eaten breakfast, loaded the car, said our goodbyes, and were on the road by 10. We stopped at the Tyrrell Museum in Drumheller and found out that Tuesdays are free. Erik was very excited and ran from one television with a taped program to computers with games to fully dressed displays and stripped skeletons, and underwater scenarios. We gave up asking him to stay put at any display. Despite making an effort, within a minute he had disappeared. At one point on the upper level, there was a moment of excitement when we realized that Erik hadn't been with us and with a flurry of searching, he was sighted below us and far off on the main level. We called. He saw us and happily waved. Erik's favourite dinosaur was the Triceratops. At the Tyrannosaurus Rex display, Peter gave us a full commentary. Matthew was often apart from us, studying the plaques by himself or sitting at a computer. We ate lunch in the cafeteria. (Cheryl bumped Matthew's coke onto the floor), Peter had a cheeseburger, Erik a hot dog, and pizza for Cheryl, Matthew and me. We started off at 1. The countryside was beautified by hoarfrost and the heavy snowfall after Kindersley, all the way to Saskatoon. A real contrast to Calgary's early spring.

Once home, Cheryl's parents dropped. By on their way to Rose's. Matthew and I dropped Dad's jacket by, visited them for a while, picked up the game of 'Stockticker' from Cheryl's parent's, were foiled in our effort to buy hamburgers when we found Mcdonald's was closed for the evening, and went home. Matthew, Peter, Erik and I played for an hour. Erik drifted in and out with the dinosaur we had purchased at the Tyrell museum gift shop. He was tired and went early to bed. He wore long red socks. Matthew won the game and he and Peter went to bed. Cheryl wasn't feeling

well. We decided it was the Beijing flu, so we went to bed. I read until 11:40. We were asleep before midnight, leaving it to the rest of the world to see in the New Year.

1992

Sunday, January 5

Last day of holidays. The boys spent last night at Cheryl's parents. We took them over during an NFL Bronco-Oilers playoff game. Cheryl's parents invited us for supper, but we preferred to return home. By the time we left the boys had disappeared. Erik had hauled Papa into the basement and called his goodbyes from down there. Peter and Matthew watched a few minutes of the game with me in the living room.

With the night to ourselves, Cheryl and I went for salad at Delphi's and picked up City-Slickers for afterwards. I lit a fire, the fifth in five days. The movie gave us a few laughs. Once the movie was over it dawned on us how quiet it is without the boys. Cheryl suddenly wanted to bring the boys home. I remember when news of a sleep-over excited us even more than it did the boys. With a clearer sense of how quickly time is passing, we don't feel that way anymore. Cheryl's mom phoned about 10 to say that Matthew's arm was hurting him.

We were at church by 9 ahead of her parents and the boys. Matthew came in first with a tie and big smile. The boys smelt of oil from their breakfast of Swedish pancakes. Erik sat happily enough on Cheryl's lap but he made it clear he was going back to Mama's after church. He was restless, pulling on the sleeves of his black sweater.

'What is the matter?' Cheryl asked.

'My sweater's on backwards.'

'Your sweater's not on backwards. If it was the tag would be on the front.' She pulled the neck out so that he could see.

‘Maybe, then, it’s on sideways.’

On the way to the Saskatoon Inn, Peter said that Erik had not wanted to come to church. He told them, ‘It is boring, and we have to do work in Sunday school.’ Sounding a bit worried, Peter said, ‘I wonder if he is going to be like that in school.’

Matthew told me that Papa helped him with the tie. First he tied it around his own neck, then he slipped it over Matthew’s head. Something about this Matthew finds funny.

Peter, Matthew and Erik walked throughout the gardens of the Saskatoon Inn while we visited. They don’t even try to be part of our conversations anymore. For a while Erik stayed behind on his knees by the stone wall, placing mini-cars on ledges and talking to himself.

Peter and Taylor went to Father of the Bride with Steve Martin. Matthew and Erik walked to the park and tobogganed until nearly dark. We watched them from the back window. When the time came I went and called. Erik came first, black toque bobbing, and Matthew lagged as usual, pulling the sled with the retractable rope that hasn’t retracted since Erik jumped on the sled while Peter was hauling it up the hill earlier this week.

Peter likes being 13. He knows it is a source of humour and joins in the jokes whenever he can. He smiles wide to show his braces, styles his hair, had fashion preferences, like ‘European-fit’ (large) jeans, Vuarnet shirts, Vans tennis shoes.

John and Irma Peltier were over on Friday evening. Erik and Matthew were put to bed by 10, and Peter and Sara sat with us by the fire in the dark family room and talked. This is the first for

him. He was quietly listening, and when asked to join in on a discussion about male-female conflict he said, with a laugh, that he'd rather stay out of it.

The boys seem happy to be back at school. Erik maybe has some doubts. After I heard his prayers in bed I asked him what he thought about Mustard, the cat that died in a story I had finished reading moments earlier. He said that it was sort of sad. He was quiet a moment, then said: 'I don't want Mommy to die.'

Thursday, February 27

We have been off from school for the past week. We attended meetings on Monday and Tuesday. Wednesday, Thursday and Friday were free. A happy coinciding with warm weather. Temperatures are over 8+ by noon. Peter leads the rush to the rink in the morning before pools of water have formed on the ice. I joined them this morning. Erik wore his snow pants, a blue helmet, and a headband that fell down over his mouth. Peter and Matthew wore light clothing, wind pants and spring jackets. The 'good guys', Erik and me, played against the 'bad guys', Peter and Matthew. The game was two-on-two with a board used as the goal. We steered clear of the water at the west end. Erik scored a couple of goals. All three have improved their skating. They are working on their stick-handling. A few days ago Matthew was in tears when I told him that we would not buy a hockey stick with a curved blade to replace the perfectly good one with a straight blade, not even if his friends laughed at him at school. I noticed today, however, that the blade was wearing down and the white tape is curling up from the bottom. So...

Erik has used this holiday as an excuse to come to bed with us. It began when Peter, Matthew and I were away at Camp Kinasao for a ski-weekend. By 7:30 one hears his feet on the carpet in our room, and see the top of his head pass the silhouette of Cheryl's body. He climbs up on her side, lies on his back, holds his hands up and makes shapes with his fingers, and whispers to Cheryl.

Conditions at Christopher Lake were perfect for skiing. Temperatures sat around 10 below. Matthew and I took the 5.1 km 'red' trail along the shore of the lake. It was longer than he had expected, but he did not complain. His skiing improved over that

distance and he became adept at climbing hills. Peter and Greg Millar found a steep slope and built a jump which they used for hours over the two days. I set out on my own Sunday morning, left the trail when I saw (or thought I saw) the lake to the north through the trees, thinking I would like to ski the rest of the way along the shore. But north turned out to be east, the lake was a beaver pond that angled northwards, not westward. I crossed a clearing through thick trees along a rabbit track in a cut line that took me deeper into the woods. After about an hour I concluded that I had made a mistake. In theory I should have backtracked. In practise, such admissions are impossible for me. I looked for the sun (which at this time of year and to one as inexperienced as me is misleading) to reorient myself along a westerly line. I came to a logging trail, followed it into a clearing where two bulldozers sat idle, went into thick woods on the other side, and kept on until I came across an old skidoo trail. By then I was entirely confused about my direction. Turn left or turn right was a 50/50 proposition. I turned right and got it wrong again. I followed this path, going faster down a long slope, thinking that if I am going in the wrong direction I'll get there sooner. Then I made a sharp turn and saw an idle skidoo pulling a long sled. A minute later I came across two more skidoos pulled into the trees where someone was loading firewood. I called to him and asked him where I was. He answered but I couldn't understand. I thanked him anyway and started off. By luck I caught up to two others and asked them. They told me the lake is a kilometre to my left, which means that I had been travelling due north the entire time, at a right angle to my intended direction. I did think later that if one is ever able to choose how to die, being in woods on cross-country skis on such a beautiful day is a great option. I returned to the camp by noon and

found Peter walking to the lodge from our cabin. He had just finished packing all our suitcases and rolling (not very well) the sleeping bags. I found Matthew in the lower level playing ping pong.

Cheryl was cheery when we returned home. The house was quiet. Three of us piling through the door and heaping our dirty things in the living room had a way of putting the starch in her smile. She insisted (overly) that she was happy to see us.

Erik had been good company. He is as happy as a five year old could be, which is a trait everyone notices and comments on. Cheryl's parents had been by a couple of times to take them for breakfast or supper. Saturday night they had been to Saigon Restaurant. The food hadn't been very good but Erik eating with chopsticks kept them laughing. Cheryl had invited Avery and Caitlan, who Erik knows from his babysitter, Shirley. They had a tea-party on a little fold-up table in the kitchen. Sandra Cochlin visited while the kids played around in the house.

This evening we went with Cheryl's parents to the Granada restaurant. I'm not sure if this was marking any occasion, but as we ate we talked about the new Conservative budget and social assistance while the boys slipped deeper and deeper into their zipped up coats until their heads had disappeared from view.

Matthew got his haircut today, short on the sides, somewhat longer on top, but combed to make it stand up along the part. Erik said something about him being a 'pretty girl. Matthew's friend, Curtis Guenther, asked him the address of his 'hair stylist'.

Thursday, July 9

Summertime. Matthew is having his last full day at Camp Kinasao. Peter has two days left in his Lifesaving III. Erik being Erik is prowling the neighbourhood in search of someone to play with, practising a little piano for his lesson on Monday, playing with Lego and the Sega Racecar game Peter brought home from our trip to Minot. Cheryl is listening to Dvorak's String Quartets and baking Peter's birthday cake. The exhibition is on but I think we won't go this year. We have had two days of rain, and water is building up at the back of the backyard.

I returned from Japan on the 1st . Cheryl brought the boys to the airport. I was struck by how much taller they were than my memory of them two weeks previously. Both sets of parents were there. Everyone came over and we visited until 10:30 pm. The days that followed, I scarcely remember. I was tired from the combined effects of two weeks of constant travel and jet lag. I slept compulsively, reminding me of the lingering effects of anaesthetic after two bouts of surgery years earlier.

Peter and Cheryl went to Minot on Saturday afternoon and are due to return on Tuesday. Saturday evening, Matthew, Erik and I went to Kinsmen Park, did all the rides, played soccer in the park, went for ice-cream where Erik and I shared a Blizzard (Erik was insisting that I eat the last part, while saying, 'Are you sure, dad?') and Matthew ate a medium dipped cone. Sunday morning I watched the Wimbledon finals, bathed both boys and got Matthew's suitcase ready for his week at camp. I had been duly warned to remember Matthew's earplugs: 'David, I know you're going to forget Matthew's earplugs and then he won't be able to go into the water'. We drove with both Erik and Matthew in the front

seat to keep me awake. Matthew talked the whole way about what he was expecting at Christopher Lake. After arriving, we registered in the Camp Center, moved Matthew's bags to Cabin 9, met his counsellor Lee, then headed down to the lake. Matthew was a little worried that he would miss the opening event, so after a few minutes of distracted play on the beach he told me he should head up. He went with barely a look over his shoulder. Erik took off his shoes and socks and threw stones in the water. Ione and Crystal were returning from a birthday party for Dawn at Ed's and Shirley's. We were invited for coffee. Erik stayed outside to throw more stones. Ione told me about the plans to raise the cabin and add a living room. On our way out of Kinasao I spotted Matthew in the chain of campers, the front end pulling the rest around its own centre. Matthew didn't see us. We waved anyway.

For the rest of the weekend, Erik and I kept busy. I woke up at 9:30 thinking there was plenty of time before the Travellers' Day parade began, until I discovered it was beginning just then. Erik had been playing on his bed quietly to let me sleep. When he saw I was up, he hurried to get ready. We parked on University Drive and walked down the bridge. We hadn't missed a thing. The sun was strong when the parade began, but heavy clouds passed over and rain fell on the column of people on the bridge. Erik said he hated being on the bridge. He was afraid it would break apart. After breakfast, we were called by Aunt Margaret Fredeen who asked if Erik would play with Tara, her lively, lonely granddaughter. Erik thought he would be shy, but I was hardly out of the car and he was in the first branch of the tree, talking to his new friend. I played tennis with Jack Nepjuk. Scott Farmer came by and invited us over for coke. We talked about holidays and Japan. When Jack left we talked a few minutes more, but Scott

became quiet. I said they were probably going to have supper soon and I should go. He said yes they were, but only tomato sandwiches. I ate a bun for supper and sat down to read *Nicholas Nickelby*. Erik was dropped off in a heavy thundershower. He raced indoors and watched lightning through the front window. He had had a great time with Tara. They had gotten into some trouble with Uncle Hartley. They were jumping on the bed when Tara fell and bumped her forehead. Uncle Hartley scolded them. Erik said, 'I think he was correct.'

He plays quietly by himself. He came downstairs in a jean jacket with a rifle under one arm, both barrels cocked, and a fat play-dough knife in an inside pocket.

We watched *Rescuers Down Under* and ate a large bowl of popcorn. Erik had seen it at Shirley's but enjoyed it the second time. He talked throughout. It was over at 9:30. I flossed his teeth—he has a large cavity in a lower molar—and he went to bed.

Tuesday, Erik spent much of the day watching for Cheryl and Peter to arrive. I took him to Delphi's for pizza. He ate slowly, every bite had to be prompted. I said he had two slices, but he ate only one. I cut the second in small pieces, and he ate two. I chatted briefly with Leanne Golding, a former student. Erik asked me about her afterwards. We got milk from Safeway, played baseball in front of St. Lukes (with new rules about hitting singles, triples, fouls, home runs), and finished off watching *Sylvester and Tweety Bird* cartoons. I spent part of this time transcribing minutes from the last SYO executive meeting.

Cheryl and Peter were home by 9:30. They hauled in more than they had gone with. Papa bought Peter a gel bicycle seat as a

souvenir. Cheryl seemed rested. They had found some good places to eat. Peter had spent a lot of time in the pool showing Papa his lifesaving techniques.

While I was away, Erik wrapped up his first season of outdoor soccer. The players received small trophies which Erik is keeping on the piano. Matthew had been playing goal in some tournament games and was strongly complimented by an opposing coach who also plays soccer. I had learned this on a phone call I made from Kyoto. Once home, I learned that Peter has been pitching for his baseball team. He was surprised by how well the game had gone. He hasn't had any coaching. He has a strong arm.

Monday, July 27

This week we will be driving to San Francisco. Cheryl hasn't let herself think about it. She was concerned that too much excitement about something happening days ahead will steal from her enjoyment of the present. She doesn't trust plans for the future. She had learned growing up that her parents had done a lot of talking about doing things in the future, which had raised Cheryl's hopes, only for those plans to vanish without a word.

Carol and Les and family came to town late Friday night. We went to Mom's and Dad's Saturday morning for a pancake breakfast on the deck. We stayed until the early afternoon. After planning supper for supper at our place, we headed home with the boys. We picked up deck furniture at Canadian Tire and The Bay. Everyone, including Cheryl's parents and Joel and Leanne, were invited for the barbecue. We ate on the deck, hamburgers, smokies, chicken souvlaki, chips, garden salad, cherry lemonade. Dad took pictures.

Cameron and Graham slept here for the next two nights, Graham and Erik in the upstairs bedroom, Matthew and Cameron in sleeping bags on the hide-a-bed. They spent hours on Sega, roller-bladed, and knocked tennis balls over St. Luke's roof. Erik made several trips around to the back of the school on his tricycle. His bike tires aren't holding air, and he's still not that eager to use it. They left the city today.

Erik has a way to mix up names. Once day after school he told me he had a substitute named Mrs. Lunch, 'but we can call her Mrs. R.' Cheryl clarified that her name is Mrs Rusnack, but he heard only the last syllable. He thinks Pastor Hugh's name is

Pastor Few. Kerimee, a girl who lives two doors down, is Kerry, Kirsten and Kelly.

Peter and I played tennis for an hour and a half last night. He was gotten a backhand chip under control. We have planned to play for an hour each day until Friday, more tennis for me than ever.

Cheryl is reading Sarum, a Michener-type novel about England. I am reading Nicholas Nickleby. Matthew has been reading a book he finds so mysterious he can barely breathe. Peter hasn't been reading much. He is in a steady state of being unsettled, and can't sit anywhere for more than a few minutes.

Saturday, August 1

This is the evening of our second day away from home. We are in a Motel 6. Cheryl is sitting in the light by the front door reading Amy Tan. This is after an hour of Olympics and putting the boys to bed. Peter and Erik are in bed in our room. Matthew is in Mama and Papa's room.

We hadn't planned to travel from Great Falls to Wells in one day, but the original destination, Jackpot, was full with waiting lists. We drove through the dusk, watching the lightning flashing in the hills. It is 106+. The boys are writing their own journals.

Erik coughs in his sleep. We thought on Wednesday that his cold might spoiled our trip plans. It hasn't affected his humour. In a restaurant in Twin Falls he was colouring a cartoon placemat: 'I think I've become an artist. Look at those eggs.'

Our room vibrates from the rumbling of the army of semi-truck refrigeration units lined up across a parking lot, filling a long block, a constellation of dull orange light.

Matthew says that he remembers Butte Montana from our last trip here. 'I don't know why, but it just jumps (his palms are open, in front of his face) out of my mind.'

Peter had the back seat to himself until noon. He slept most of the morning. Papa wears his headphones and is unaware that Mama is calling him with increasing emphasis. We ate lunch in the van (bananas, cheese, Triscuits, juice) prior to arriving in Idaho Falls. We had coffee at Cedric's where everyone used the bathroom. The boys were restless by this time. We detoured to the falls, which consists of a weir with a turbine beneath the water. We

walked along the grassy border to a place with many ducks and geese crowding around a down-syndrome boy who was feeding them bits of bread. He offered our boys a loaf. Matthew wandered off with bread and tossed some at the birds. 'This was the very best part of my holiday,' he said.

Sunday, August 2

Matthew sat between the front seats. Erik played with two hangers. First they are bows and arrow ('tchew-tchew' he says as he fires through the windshield), then they are fishing rod and fish. He doesn't sit still. His bony little body slides off laps, he rubs Cheryl's leg and Matthew's cheeks. Peter lies in the backseat with Papa's headphones, saying out loud that a \$99 for a disc-man would be a great deal. The countryside is dry, pale green, a powdery shredded wheat shade covering the flats and up the sides of the rocky slopes. Dusty roads wind through the sage.

We took rooms on the 14th floor of the Sundowner, a huge room with two king-size beds.

After breakfast in a casino cafe, the boys swam in the pool. At 10 am the heat outdoors is intense. We sat in the shade. Erik, who is still coughing, sits on the steps in the shallow end.

We ate supper in Circus Circus, then watched the acts. In between we toured the arcade, flying rubber chickens, mortar shots fired into rings, and the boys firing rifles at the shooting gallery. We walked in the cooler night air along Virginia Avenue. More Mexicans than two years ago.

We watched the Olympics from 10 to midnight.

Monday August 3

We spent the morning in a shopping centre in South Reno. Cheryl found a pair of saddle shoes. We drove for lunch to a restaurant on Virginia Avenue. Papa punched a hole in his finger while closing the heavy panel van door.

We took the I-80 to Auburn, climbing to 7400 ft, passed Tahoe's north shore, left the interstate and crept along the narrow winding Highway #49 through tiny settlements in valleys between steep sloped hills covered with long brown grass topped with deep green oak trees. We took the 88 and 104 into Stockton.

Motel 6 is in the south end, next to the I-5. After supper at McDonald's and an aborted shopping trip in a local grocery store, the boys swam while Cheryl and her parents went somewhere. The sun had set, the pool was empty, the boys inched into the cold water. Erik finds it uncomfortable and sits with me, watching his brothers, then suddenly stands and says, 'No, tonight I'm going to be brave.' He dove in directly and stayed in for the 20 minutes before it is time for bed.

Cheryl's parents switch to another room after deciding theirs smells like fish.

Tuesday August 4

We ate breakfast at Carrow's. 'It's either that or Denny's,' Papa says when Mama complains that nothing in this area is any good to eat in.

1-5 to 580 through a wind-energy field outside Oakland. The highway becomes 5 lanes each way. We cross the Bay Bridge into San Francisco, exit at the Civic Centre, have trouble getting onto Powell, and discover once we've arrived at the Days' Inn that the reservations are for the Day's Inn in Oakland. We look elsewhere and discover a penthouse for \$250 at the Wharf Inn one block from Fisherman's Wharf.

While waiting for housecleaning to get the room ready, we wandered along the sea front, ate lunch at a sourdough restaurant, sat on planters by the road drinking coffee and watching others stroll by.

After putting the luggage in our room, Cheryl, Papa, Peter and I walked to Telegraph Hill past interesting apartments on steep hills. We were disappointed to discover it costs \$3 each to take the elevator to the top of Coit Tower. We headed back by way of Washington Square Park and St. Peters & Paul RC Church. Papa gets drawn into a long conversation with Salazar, a fellow who told us that Joe DiMaggio went to school around the corner. We stopped at a couple of stores for shampoo and food for supper. After a lunch of bread, havarai cheese, peanut butter and jam, we headed out on the Wharf to Ghiradelli Chocolate Marketplace to see the shops. I took Peter and Matthew, Cheryl took Erik and her parents. There are four levels, only two with stores. The boys visit every sports store and look at the hats, jerseys, running shoes.

Wednesday August 5

We ate breakfast in shifts, coffee, cereal and milk, while everyone showered—Erik bathed last evening—or watched the Olympics. We took photos of the boys at the table with the city skyline as backdrop, and others with the bay as backdrop. Then we packed our things to move to tonight's rooms, 209 and 309 with their Kingsize bed with Queen-size hide-a-beds. We made several trips to the van. Peter and Matthew raced to the elevators. We listened to their feet thumping along the outside corridor. Then Peter's voice from outside the door: 'Pennies? Nickels? Help a homeless man?'

We discovered that the Exploratorium is free on Wednesdays. First we dropped off Cheryl and her mom downtown before making the sort of trip one can only experience in the centre of a big American city: following the South Bay road, entering the 4-lane Highway 1 that crosses the Golden Gate bridge, merging on the 101 with traffic coming off El Camino Real, passing the Presidio and Fort Mason, then feeling our way along side streets towards the Exploratorium (now the Palace of Fine Arts). Huge grounds with trees, a pond, massive Greek pillars dating to the 1915 Panama-North American Exposition. We explored among the hundreds of displays demonstrations of light, electricity, sound, mechanical things, geography. Each was worth an hour's time. One was of honeybees crawling from their glass hive through a mesh tube to a hole in the outside door. The boys moved quickly. After 2 hours we were back in the bright gardens where children are being hoisted onto the pillars, in spite of signs everywhere saying, 'Do Not Climb On the Structure.' Others lie on the grass,

one man chases a girl into the bushes, laughing. After awhile, everyone was hungry, so we headed back to the van.

We found a parking spot in front of Baker's Square Restaurant with a great children's menu. Erik and Matthew ordered a 'Cheesy Moon Burger', Peter had a loaded burger. The policy is that if the order doesn't arrive within 10 minutes he gets free pie. He set his alarm as soon as the order was taken. I asked the waiter about a Giants game, but they're on the road.

We drove up the switch-back of Lombard, past a van stopped by a steaming radiator, to the Hyde St. Pier, SF's maritime museum, with its feature exhibit, the 19th C (1886) cargo ship is moored, Balclutha and the paddlewheel steamboat Eureka. The boys ran from end to end, down in the hold, up on the deck, onto the foci's, into the Captain's galley. We paid 25 cents to see still photos in a view box on the Eureka. After, we walked along the beach, passed a fellow playing the hammer dulcimer, one playing the Caribbean steel drum, a small boy accompanying his sister's vocals with the electronic keyboard. Cheryl and her mom were in the motel office when we got back.

We had pizza and calzone for supper. After Papa and Mama went to their room, tired from the day, we walked to the Wharf. Peter, Matthew and I went through the medieval dungeon for \$15. We walked to Pier 39, walked along both levels, watched some 'fringe' theatre, returned to the motel. The boys went to bed on the pull-out. Cheryl and I went to TGIF's for a beer and sundae.

Thursday August 6

I walked to Safeway in the mist for milk and croissants for breakfast. After we ate we all walked to the Bay and caught the cablecar to the far end of the line, Market and Powell. There, we walked to Nordstrom's for coffee and danish and cookies. Mama and Papa split off with the plan to meet in 2 hours, 1:30. We rode the curving escalators to the 8th floor past the piano player, then down by elevator and outside onto Market, where a South American music group was set up at the cable car turn-around. They played and danced and sang; beautiful harmonies. We walked to Macy's where Cheryl bought a dress. The boys and I walked to FAO Schwartz and its three floors of noise, crowds and toys. Matthew and Erik bought Porsche and Ferrari model cars. Outdoors, we strolled past immense hotels, small shops, parks, buskers—one who sang opera—to a discount book store, bought New Yorkers for \$3.88, then back to Nordstroms, and met Mama and Papa. Cheryl was quite late in returning. She held a package behind her, smiling. A second dress. We went to the top floor again to the cafe for soup, sandwiches, hotdogs. We split up again. Cheryl, the boys and I crossed Market, found more homeless. We stood in line to buy cable car tickets behind an Asian man who was fumbling the unfamiliar dollar bills into the slot of the ticket machine, but they were being rejected and he didn't know why. A woman with a red swollen face and a very insistent voice, standing yards distant, was trying to instruct him. 'Turn it over! Push the button first!...' Which only made it worse. Clearly he wasn't understanding. I stepped in to assist, pointing to the money, which he was putting in upside down, then to the button. It went smoothly. He bought 4 tickets. 'Hey,' the woman said,

'You're taking my job. How am I supposed to make any money.' Then she smiled. Then she held out a styrofoam cup. I gave her 50 cents. We got into a long line, caught the Beach & Hyde trolley, paused at the midpoint for a change of drivers.

Back at the hotel the boys settled in to play. Cheryl and I went out again, walked to Union, down to Van Ness, back as far as Lombard, followed the sidewalk along the switchback past hydrangea bushes, then down a street so steep our feet pushed into the toes of our shoes, and took a zig-zagging route back to the motel.

Shortly after, Mama and Papa returned. We went for supper to TGI Friday. Hamburgers, grilled chicken, chicken strips, potato skins, Thai chicken with a sauce, served by a 6'9" waiter. Music was loud, the place was full, a voice at the front door calling names of people in line. As we were finishing, the waiter came by and asked if that was everything. We said yes. Erik said to Cheryl, 'How come they ask the dads about things like dessert and never the kids.'

We headed back to the motel to get the boys ready for bed. Mama and Papa arrived with chocolate for the boys. We decided that Cheryl, Papa and I would take a last ride on the cable cars. From Bay & Beach to Nob Hill, off onto the Nob Hill trolley to the end and back, walked around the Flood Mansion, past huge hotels, through a park with a Roman fountain, back on a trolley, down California to the Financial District, back to Powell and to Market, off again at the turnaround where a tall black man in orange hum suit wandered along the empty line, singing, thrusting out his hand for emphasis, in a deep voice that resonated off walls, with no-one there to give him money. Papa asked, 'What do you think is

wrong with him?' We caught the last car to the Bay and returned to the motel to bed.

Friday August 7

We went to Pier 39 for coffee and danishes, then checked out of the motel. We drove to Sausalito. The fog was so thick the Golden Gate bridge and the water passed unseen.

In Sausalito, Cheryl, Mama and Papa walked through the shops. Peter, Erik, Matthew and I followed the shore to the end, studying crabs on rocks, past restaurants sitting on piles, then back to look at the docked boats. A Chinese junk sailed into the harbour. I pointed it out to the boys and took a picture. Erik thought the name was funny. Coming off the dock we passed a pile of chopped wood. He said, 'Now there's Chinese junk.'

We joined up with the others, ate lunch at a hamburger cafe, sat awhile as a long line of people built up on the sidewalk, then returned to the van. We returned along the Golden Gate bridge but missed our intended target, a children's playground, and headed instead directly to Oakland to get our hotel room. The Days' Inn was overbooked. They transferred us to the Clarion. We swam in the large pool, at its new coffee shop, caught the shuttle to the Coliseum for the game between the A's and Royals. We sat by 3rd base foul pole. Tickets were \$12 each. Ricky Henderson stood very near. He turned, looked the crowd over, waved a couple of times, made plays to back up the centre fielder, caught someone out. Jose Canseco was ejected. Carney Lansford hit a grand slam, the ball landing 5 meters from us. The boys ate malts. While waiting for our hotel shuttle a scuffle broke out in the parking lot. Security arrived. We passed a car with 4 or 5 guys with their hands on a van, getting frisked.

Saturday August 8

We drove to Haywood across the San Raphael bridge to Half Moon Bay, along the coast on the #1, with some spectacular views of the surf. We stopped at Santa Cruz for coffee. A clerk said something about Canadians and the US being 'practically neighbours'. Canada being 'up there somewhere'. We continued around the Bay to Monterey.

Most of the day was spent running after elusive motel space, 2 rooms at the San Dunes motel, or at the Motel 8 in Seaside, being reasonably priced (\$65 - \$80), but when we learned during lunch that the north end of Fremont Street had a problem with crack users, we decided to do more looking. The boys went with me to the beach, Mama and Cheryl went to Macy's, Papa sat it out at the Motel 6, got 2 room. We ate supper at Gold West restaurant near a motel, Casa Munras, that charged \$350 for the suite (the horse races are on). We drove to Monterey and walked around, then returned to the motel.

Matthew was exploring something. I questioned him on several points. Finally he laughed and pushed me. He said, 'That's why I don't like you. You antagonize people.' I laughed. We walked awhile in silence. Then he said, 'Dad, did I use the right word?'

Erik gallops in the Monty Python style while Peter slaps his thighs for effect. Erik walks. Peter begins slapping. Erik breaks into a gallop. The toes of his shoes has worn through.

Sunday August 9

We ate breakfast in a cafe on Lighthouse Avenue, drove the 17 mile road to Carmel past golf courses, beaches with crashing surf, gulls harping at tourists, deer in the preserves, cypress shaped by the winds, seaside mansions. Arriving in Carmel, we parked on Dolores Avenue near Ocean Drive, walked from shop to shop, Cheryl bought a sweatshirt. We strolled in an area of residences/cottages that looked fitting as postcards. We met Mama and Papa at 3:30, drove to the beach area, returned to the highway, then travelled the 101 through San Jose. It's a clear day. Our best view so far of sprawling San Francisco. Wind surfers are under the Golden Gate bridge. Driving into the city, all four lanes are jammed, sitting for two miles all the way to Sausalito. We arrive in Santa Rosa for the night.

Monday August 10

We recognize this part of the 101 from our 1990 trip. We eat breakfast at Carrow's, lunch in Eureka. Traffic is stopped time and again by construction crews. We have supper in Crescent City and check into the Pacific Motor Inn.

Once it's dark, Cheryl, the boys and I went into the hot tub. Cheryl sat awhile in the sauna. Peter didn't like the heat and stood several times under the cold shower. Erik danced in the water. I tried and failed to keep his mouth out of the water. After putting them to bed, Cheryl and I walked to Pizza Hut for a slice.

Tuesday August 11

Our original plan to stay 2 nights changed. After cereal in the room and coffee in a cafe we formed two groups. We went to the beach, stationed ourselves near the lighthouse. Cheryl gathered stones. Peter, Matthew and Erik soaked themselves in the waves while throwing stones, pushing a log, flinging muddy sand. I snapped a few black and white pictures to finish off the film.

We met Mama and Papa for lunch, triscuits, gouda and string cheese, apple fritters. Then we relocated from the lighthouse to a place on the beach where bigger waves were rolling in. Cheryl read a newspaper near the parking lot. The boys and I played a game of football. Peter runs, gritting his teeth, showing only braces, makes a couple of great catches. Matthew and Erik are opposing quarterbacks. We draw our plays on the sand. Erik's play was: I run, fake left, fake right, go straight. Peter and Matthew win 21 - 7. Erik counts this as our second loss, but doesn't know why this has happened. We take the ball back to Cheryl, then play tag with the surf, holding hands, running out, not letting the foam catch our toes, assigning marks for style. Peter and Matthew do handstands in the rushing surf. 'Ho,' says Peter, once he's back on his feet, 'is that disorienting.' They do roundoff back handsprings. Sand and water splashing. Erik's shorts were rolled up, but they unrolled and the cuffs filled with water. Matthew's hair hangs in his eyes, but short around the ears.

We leave Crescent City by 2:30, follow the coast, plan to stop for the night at Coos Bay. However, every motel is full. We drive to Reedsport and find the same thing. We phone for a motel in Eugene. (I end up talking with a girl at the central dealing agency

to book two rooms at the Econolodge, but she is (she must be) tired and asks which state Oregon is in.)

We follow the Siuslaw river past elk-sighting spots. In the dying light we see them hunkering down in the grass. We arrive in Springfield north of Eugene. Erik is asleep and needs to be carried to the room. Next morning he says, 'I don't remember coming to this hotel.'

Wednesday August 12

We returned to the coast after stopping at Denny's for breakfast. The waitress handed out a seniors menu to Mama and Papa, a regular (adult) menu to Cheryl and me, and paper menu for children 10 and under to the boys. Peter, 14, doesn't understand how anyone could be confused about his age. This is now a running joke. We went to the mall. Matthew spent his birthday money on a Sony Walkman and the Beatles' Hard Day's Night album. Erik spent his money on two Lego sets. Cheryl bought Peter a pair of gym shoes.

North of Florence, we pulled off at the sea lions cave. We took an asphalt path wide enough for one vehicle to a parking lot, took the footpath to a difficult descent to the beach. Mama and Papa tried it later, but turned back. Once on the beach, the boys ran free. Cheryl followed in her pink top with a camera. The batteries failed and she had to return to the van for more. The boys and I had a football rematch. This time, Erik and I emerged as clear winners. At one point, when he and I were on his knees to study the complicated play he was sketching in the sand, he stopped and said, 'Dad, I really have to go to the bathroom.' We excused ourselves and disappeared behind a recess in the cliff wall for privacy. The sand there had a hard crust. It chirped underfoot. The beach is covered with tiny shellfish. The boys were grossed out by the jelly fish. Peter thinks one looks like mucus and covers it with sand. The surf is wonderful, huge waves rolling in the shape of cones.

We ran to a distant rock along the wet sand, and arrived puffing at the van. We stopped at Yachts for lunch, Tilamook for

ice-cream. Pulling away, Erik said, 'Mama, you are going to be in the news.'

'Why is that?'

'Because you buy so much ice-cream.'

We arrived in Astoria in pitch black to check into the Red Lion Inn. Our balcony looks out over the marina. We had coffee at Pig'n Pancake. Eriks makes himself the centre of attention, tugging his face out of shape with imaginary strings, making synthetic instrument sounds, syncopated patterns, to go with the McFaren/Yo Yo Ma tape. He called himself Yo Yo Yashuma. His head would bounce, his fingers snap, then he'd laugh aloud and ask why Mama and Papa were crying.

While driving, the boys are in the back seat playing with Lego, listening to their Walkmans, whispering,. Every once in a while there is an outcry and someone says, 'Can Erik sit up there?' Erik tearfully resists.

Thursday August 13

We turn inland at Seaside. The boys play quietly. We arrive in Portland by the mid afternoon. After looking around for hotels in the south end, we settled on the Shilo Inn. It has a pool and queen beds. Mama and Papa have switched away from Motel 6 after they've judged the last several to be suspect.

Most are shopping after the late lunch at the Village Inn. Erik, Matthew and I go to the hotel. The boys lie down to sleep. While I read Updike's *Rabbit Redux*, Erik tossed and turned, yawning, but not letting himself settle. I lay with him to keep him in one place. Half an hour later, myself feeling groggy, I realized he had fallen sound asleep. Then we went swimming. Matthew did some shallow diving and Erik churned up the water, his head submerged, going short distances. When the others returned we went to the Millar's Log Cabin restaurant. Matthew likened to the Beatles. At the motel, we swam with the lights around the pool turned off. Peter, feeling 14, was wanting to throw Matthew around, grabbing him, pulling him under, and every time he sensed a look, he got very innocent.

Tuesday August 25

We're on the second last day of holiday. It's the typical last-minute rush. Cheryl and I have made two trips downtown for fall clothing, two trips to the grocery store for food and school supplies. We've taken the boys to the doctor. Peter is 5' 2", the 48th percentile; Matthew is 4' 5", the 75th percentile.

'The 48th percentile,' Peter complains. 'Big deal. Matthew's in the 75th.'

I said, 'He's just had a growth spurt.'

'I've never been close, and I've had growth spurts.'

'Sort of,' Matthew says. He laughs

Everyone has gotten haircuts, we've reorganized the basement, taken a trip to the dump with an old mattress, and so on. It's easier now that Peter is old enough to leave him with his brothers. Three in the back seat means laughter, complaints, teasing.

Besides this, however, we've got time to enjoy things. The boys are with their friends. Peter and Taylor rode bikes to the Meewasin trail, toured the campus and stopped at the Diefenbaker Centre for a bathroom break. He and Gabe went riding, sort of. In spite of our pressure to get him to exercise, what they claim is riding 'around Lakeview' means taking a bee-line through the park directly to Gabe's. 'What did you do there, play Nintendo?'

'A bit.' Which we interpret as most of the afternoon. Just now Peter and Greg took off to, in Greg's words, 'shoot rabbits in the prairie'.

Matthew has played fervently with Josh Rosvold, Joel Dei (whose father has been made ill by medication and is suing somebody from his bed), and Curtis. He slept over at Josh's last night and talks with so little energy today his lips don't move.

Erik is scampering around the neighbourhood with with Janie and Karamee. They leave toys everywhere. They run with plastic swords. They negotiate rules. They've set up headquarters—a light play-tent—on our front yard. His birthday is imminent and he is excited. 'The day after tomorrow and the day after that.' After dropping Peter and Matthew off at the Norwegian pavilion to work the food line, we took Erik for supper to plan his birthday. His entire guest list, which he put together, is girls. 'Don't you have any boys to invite?' 'Not really.' After some prompting he named two, but they're fourteen. Shortly after, he fell asleep with his head on Cheryl's lap.

Cheryl and I too have been busy, me writing, Cheryl organizing, us walking and reading. We went to The Player at the Broadway Theatre, then had coffee at Calories.

The weather has been cold, with some freakish results. Temperatures fell below freezing a couple of nights. Areas nearby have had up to 2 feet of snow. Campers in Cypress Hills were trapped, power lines were knocked down, standing wheat fields covered over.

Erik was telling us he had seen a 'limousine dog with short legs'. His word for dachshund. He reprises that facial trick with a string, and his frozen face trick, and his vocal acoustics. He strips down to just sweats, pulls the legs to his knees, and does karate.

Tuesday December 29

Christmas holidays. Typically, this is when the holiday relaxation truly begins. By now Cheryl has made supper for three sets of guests, Danny and Joan Isaachsen, her Mom and Dad, and my family. Nothing can be simple.

The boys have been busy all fall. Peter enjoys high school very much, has learned a lot, and works very hard. He has come from having scattered procedures and premature sense of completion to having a solid sense of good work. He has friends now, many who are high achievers, and demonstrate real effort: he is often getting phone-calls at 10 pm from someone still busy working on an assignment. At first he resented the pressure, but one Sunday evening it clicked, his frown was gone, his work was spread out on the dining room table, and his marks have gone up from low 80's to mid or high 90's. Cheryl is concerned now that he is now working too hard. She thinks some of his teachers are selfish, self-important boobs with no appreciation for life beyond books in their subject area. I don't escape the accusations. She has always thought I do too much marking, but has always expressed some sympathy. Now that she is seeing the student side, that my marking represents their labours, she is no longer pretending to take my side. She gives me accusing looks. Fittingly my briefcase is 'undertaker black.'

Peter has made some good friends at school. Gabe Jutras remains close, though he has gotten 'girl happy', in Peter's words. He has spent some noon hours following Gabe while Gabe follows a girl. In time he laughs Gabe off and finds something else to do. Peter is not girl happy yet. He went to the first school dance, but has not interest in attending more. Girls phone him, but he thinks

talking on the phone is a waste of time. Girls from the SYO drop by. Two came with Alan Harrington one evening last week to watch movies. Nothing more was said about it in the days that followed. We tease him, he smiles. He thinks our words are like bait on a hook, but he bumps it aside on his way to something more interesting. More than anything, he is caring about his physical appearance. Cheryl bought two or three fashionable pairs of jeans, t-shirts with Mondetta stitched on the front and button-up long-sleeve shirts with button-down collars, Vans shoes, leather belts, and so on. Adolescent conceits aside, Peter spends most of his social time arranging with Stuart Gander and Max Lingard (two French-immersion students from College Park), Alan Harrington (from SYO), to go tobogganing, paint-balling, playing Sega, watching movies.

Music is a bigger thing to him than ever. Since picking up the bassoon Peter's beginning in the Grade 9 band has expanded to the Grade 10 and the Senior bands. He is taking lessons from David Steer, a young university student who plays in the Saskatoon Symphony. He gives Peter lots of encouragement. His cello lessons with Terry Sturge are also going well. Peter has taken these things on as his own. He has built up a solid practise system. Terry held a pre-Christmas recital. Peter played Allegro Appassionato by Saint-Seans. Pat Deibert accompanied. They practised three times, the first with Terry Sturge for an hour and a half, the second just the two of them, the third at the church. After warming up just before the performance, Peter came to sit with us, shaking his head, thinking it hadn't gone well. But when the time came to perform, he had lost his nervousness, the timing and dynamics were great, and Peter was totally absorbed. He was

thrilled. We were too. That includes his brothers, who were perfectly still during the two hours, and his grandparents.

Matthew is a large boy, broad across the back, rounded and full. He is growing into clothes Peter stopped wearing only two years ago. He's working hard at school. He is taking accelerated math and enriched work in other areas. He works at everything with care and at his own pace. At the start of the year Matthew had problems concentrating in the classroom. His desk was next to the computer and the teacher's desk. He's like the guy (Rob Schneider) on Saturday Night Live whose desk is in the copy room, talking up whoever comes in: 'Ronnieeeee, Ronny to make some copieeeeees.' He has been relocated near a couple of girls who are working on the same programs. He brings home interesting stories. The girls shift their desks close behind his, touch him with their pencils or rulers, pretend they haven't done anything, say things that are almost inaudible, and ignore him when he turns to see what they are wanting. His work has improved, he has less homework, he is happier.

He has been to the orthodontist several times this fall. He is outfitted with head gear and has to wear it up to ten hours a day. He has tried wearing it at night, but he can't sleep. The gear is designed like a football helmet face guard. Sleeping on his side pushes it off its required line. He doesn't sleep well on his back. He puts his hands under his head, or lies on his side facing up. That doesn't work. Now before we go to bed, we come in and take the gear off, which gives him some hours with it, but allows him to sleep the rest of the night. He spends as much time as possible wearing it in the day, not minding the appearance, or that he talks with a slur.

He is attending a soccer clinic at the Wheatland B building. A new floor has been laid onto the concrete floor, green plastic 6" squares, that provides must better traction. Before, the only way to keep grip on concrete was to apply hairspray to the soles of their shoes. He plays forward with a Division 2 Under-12 Lakeridge team. I am assisting, and learn things about the character of 10 and 11-year old boys as well as myself. The cost of discovery, Fridays at 7:30, is greater than the value.

Matthew is loving cello. He is in Book 4, learning Chanson Triste by Tchaikovsky. Bernadette has planned a recital late in January. He is looking ahead to which instrument he'll play in the Grade 6 band. He talks most often about the French Horn.

Above all else, he is a dreamy boy. He intensely dislikes tough demanding schedules. He's out of bed later than everyone. He dislikes fixed sequences, mixing dull routines like dressing with more interesting things, like reading or finding forgotten things under his bed. He spends a lot of time in the bathroom, escaping from something he knows is about to be laid on. I helped him get his room in order. We went through his desk drawers, his chest of drawers. We pulled things out from under his bed and from his closet. We assigned places for things, his art supplies, school books, little artifacts (teeth for instance, and shells and small stones). We assigned drawers for school jeans, school shirts, play clothes, summer clothes, socks and underwear. We put his Lego into containers. Once we set up a pattern, I tried to give him the freedom to do the rest. He is stumped. I put something in his hand, he looks at it, puts it in his other hand, and stalls. I give him a pencil. It should be a half-second decision. When he hesitates, I say, 'Where should it go?' He says, 'I don't know. Do I put it with

my art supplies or with my pens? I use it for school but I draw with it too. Sometimes Erik uses it, and sometimes I use it for cello.'

1993

Saturday July 24 1993

We're nearly half-way through summer holidays. We spent the afternoon on the riverbank watching Formula 1 and SST speedboat races. It was hot. The race preparations were interminable. The river is high and fast, which demands that extra precautions be taken: guard boats and ambulances are set in place, buoys are fixed, damaged boats are hauled to shore, cranes lower fresh boats into the water. The crowd is in constant motion, everyone trying to improve their view, or going to the concession stand or the bathroom, crawling up the steep bank with two beers in one hand, people in lawn chairs calling their kids out of the bushes.

The boys are changing, quickly. Erik is almost seven. He has stretched out. He has a gap in his smile, with the two permanent teeth starting to show. He has spent most of summer with Jordy Trifa playing soccer in the park, biking around the block, shooting guns, playing Sega, arguing, telling stories meant to test each other's credulity, helping Jordy's dad, Avram, build a fence. Jordy is just now in Edmonton to watch Canada's team play Australia in a World Cup qualifying match. (I hope it's on television.) Now he spends time alone or with his brothers. He finds some place to lie on the floor, singing, whispering in different voices, playing with cars or drawing Mutant turtles. He still touches his Mom, and praises her beauty. Cheryl knows this stage is just about over, and has sad eyes and longing smiles while he caresses her arm or leg. At the family reunion in Outlook he was with Graeme playing basketball. He bounces the ball two steps out of every five, and when he crosses the foul line he takes it in hand, runs six or seven steps ahead of the layup. As Matthew puts it, Erik is 'restless'.

When his fits of energy strike, he runs up and down the stairs, races his bike up and down the street, gets on his cleats and kicks his ball against the school, and finds ways to annoy his brothers.

We went to Calgary to attend Eric's baptism. While there we went hiking in the Valley of the Ten Peaks, near Lake Marmaine. Carol and Cheryl walked part of the way. The rest of us, Cameron, Peter, Matthew, Les, Graham, Michael, Erik and I, carried on to Sentinel Pass. We crossed a mountain meadow before climbing to the snow at the top. I began having serious misgivings about having brought Erik. He was tired, the switchbacking path was narrow. I told myself we'd turn back as soon as the hike became too dangerous. Hikers on their way down said, 'It's slippery but worth it.' We carried on. I kept Erik on the slope-side, and switched hands at every turn. Had he slipped from my grip, he wouldn't have stopped for several hundred meters of large rocks. Once we gained the top, a heavy wind coming up from the Paradise Valley side threatened to make Erik into a kite. We debated whether to go on or return to the bottom. Since the first 50 meters of the path ahead an almost sheer drop, Michael went alone. On the way back I asked Erik how he felt about having done this. He said that this hike was better than sleeping in, better than a movie, better even than having girlfriends.

Matthew is as happy by himself as he is with friends. He is excited when someone calls, Ben, Josh, Matt Johnson, to play soccer or tennis or drive golfballs or run in the field across the street. Most of the time he is alone. When he is on detective cases, he wears a suit jacket laden with detective tools: handcuffs, notepaper, ID card, gun, microphone. He finds clues, types down information. He is stealthy. Sometimes the work takes him to the

basement. Sometimes he is in his bedroom. Or he goes through his stock of toys for things that might be transformed into something else. He practises cello 15 minutes a day, getting ready for the Grambo reunion next weekend.

Peter has shot up to nearly 5'6". Most of the growth has been in his legs. But one sees gains in the torso, especially as it turns through his golf swing, his elbows high, his back bent, a foot tipped onto the toe. He is fifteen, self-absorbed, aloof. He spends a lot of time in his bedroom reading *Elfstone of Shinarra* or listening to his new \$252 Sony Discman (this he argued long and hard for after he listened to Taylor's, and no amount of talking by us made a difference. He himself was in long agonized silences, arguing the pros and cons. I think that was partly an attempt to reveal a tortured soul, gain our sympathy, have us pack up our resistance, and tell him, urge him, that if he buys it, it's okay with us. It was only a matter of time before he pulled together his money and did the deed. He is golfing almost every day. We bought him a 5-wood which he uses on all his tee-shots and most of the longer fairway drives. His best drives are up, straight and long. He is looking for more consistency on the shorter lengths and the green. But who am I to criticize or praise? I'd be better off playing marbles than swinging a club. Peter's voice is changing. He is anticipating how low it will get, and that's where he spends most of his time. He mows the lawn for us and a neighbour. Idle time sits heavy on his hands. He is much happier when things are structured. Give him something to do, say what his timeline is, and he's never happier. One task keeping him busy for hours is helping Papa on the computer writing the Grambo family history.

Cheryl and I are reading more this summer. Cheryl has read Billy Bathgate, Norma-Jean, Norman Mailer, Skin of the Lion by Michael Ondaatje. I read Amis' Lucky Jim, Showdown by Jorge Amado, Dickens, Porter's Pale Horse, Pale Rider. Cheryl has finalized arrangements for her transfer from the Admin Masters to the Ed Psych Masters. She is elated ever since her conversation with the head of the department. She will take a class this winter in Stats and apply for an Ed Leave for next year. The head is very happy with her transfer. Very few women enter this field. He asked her to consider a Phd, with the aim of getting on faculty at some point.

I write some, more than I have been. I put off working on the fence. It has remained in its skeletal form ever since Harley Johnson dug the holes and dropped in the poles. His fence is complete on all sides but ours. I am busy putting in grass and exposed-aggregate paving stones along the north side of the house. I would like to be playing more tennis. I am golfing more than I'd have ever dreamed. Matthew and I rode bikes to the river and returned in a downpour. Cheryl was horrified by the mud on our clothes and told us that we had a lot of scrubbing to do if we ever wanted to get the shirts clean.

Cheryl and I are noticing that people our age are beginning to look older than us.

1994

Monday, April 21, 1994

Peter has been attending triathlon training Sunday evenings. He rides his bike to the Field House. Everyone does circuits on the track on bike and on foot, wind sprints, time trials, warm-down games. Some have spent as much as \$1400 on bikes, with pedals that lock-in, shocks on the front frame, special metal-alloy frames, high-end gear-changers, and so on. Peter is sticking with the bike he bought three years ago.

Matthew has taken an interest in running. Most mornings he is up at 7:40, eats his breakfast, and goes out, sometimes with Matt Johnson next door and his dog Finnegan, sometimes alone, running for 30 to 40 minutes. Yesterday, at Peter's suggestion, he attended triathlon training. They were off by 6:35 to meet Joe Woolley at the Lakeview confectionary. By the time they returned we were barbecuing hamburgers on the deck. Mama and Papa had just dropped off several dozen Arizona oranges, and the sun was beginning to set.

Erik has been on his own since Geordie went away. He's recovering from the scrapes and strains from playing in recent days, mostly from falling off his bike. Not playing is hard for him. When Cheryl and I had arrived home after a walk in the University area and getting groceries, Peter and Matthew were ready to leave.

Erik was outside, squatting near the poplars on the north side of the driveway, motioning to me to watch, pointing at Cyrus, Johnson's cat.

'Come here Cyrus,' he said, motioning with one finger. It came and lay between his legs. He asked me, 'Do you want to do something?' 'Let's shoot some baskets.' We pumped up the big

basketball and played '21' until Erik's hand was hurting. He sat by the fence and waited for me to finish. Back at home I did some marking, Cheryl read Chaim Potoks *The Chosen*, and Erik had a bath.

Peter has several music competitions in the next month. He has prepared two pieces, Schumann Fantasy Pieces and one by Telemann. He will play a Bach suite and a quartet piece at the festival at the end of this month, then again at the Canadian Music Competitions later in May. He has practised somewhat more intently than usual. The SYO just returned from Banff. His school band will be going there for a festival April 30. His quartet played to good reviews at the SYO Banff concert and is being asked to perform at social functions. Peter and Matthew will play a duet at Redeemer's youth service next Sunday and at Joel's wedding. We picked up music during our Easter trip to Calgary.

Matthew is about to get braces. He is sarcastically thrilled. He has worn a hidden brace on his upper teeth that hooks onto night-gear. In a couple of months he'll replace that with the real thing. The night-brace was supposed to save us time and money.

His string group played Mozart's 29th Symphony at the SYO Spring concert on Saturday at Knox. This made up somewhat for his having forgotten and missed the group's school tour on March 25. Saturday morning, during a break in practise, he went with a few kids to the Milroy apartments confectionary, but broke off on his own to wander in the downtown area and hurdle fences. I asked him about going off by himself.

He said, 'I guess I'm a loner.'

I said, 'Your mother and I were sort of loners too.'

He laughed. 'That doesn't surprise me at all.'

He enjoys being with other kids, but he expects more loyalty than they seem able to give. They are off the cuff, transitional, transactional, sunny with the chance of afternoon thundershowers.

Erik and Geordie are not in the same class this year. This isn't much of a problem for Erik. Their friendship is no longer exclusive. When together they race their bikes on the street or in the field, white helmets high on their heads, they play hockey in the house or Sega, or they talk, and when they talk they argue.

Tuesday July 19

We spent yesterday at the farm. We went up in the morning, mowed the grass, and headed home after six. Cheryl's parents had been up over Sunday night. Matthew rode the grass mower, Peter and I used the push mowers. Erik joined Cheryl when she took over the tractor from Matthew. Cheryl let him drive, but he veered off course whenever he leaned back to kiss her or rub her arm. He rode a while with me until the tractor ran out of gas up at the road. While Erik steered I pushed the mower to the barn as fast as I could run, rattling us over the bumps. At the turn Erik pulled so hard on the wheel the tractor tipped onto two wheels. Once filled we went back to finish the job. Erik asked the meaning of the 'rabbit' diagram by the throttle. I told him it meant rabbit speed. He said rabbits aren't very fast, that he could run faster. I said I don't think so. He insisted we have a race. He took off running before I was ready. I rode in 6th gear. He went like a rabbit, but faster.

Peter is taking the National Lifeguarding Course at the University. It is two intensive weekends. He came home on Sunday with a short deep gash on his kneecap. We took him to the Medi Clinic either for a good strong bandage or a couple of stitches. Matthew wanted to come along. While waiting, Matthew said he wanted to watch the stitching. They were gone quite a while. When they came Peter had a heavy bandage patch on his knee and no stitches. Matthew was disappointed. A strange attitude for a boy whose dislike of needles rivals a holy man's dislike of sin.

Peter got a new bike, a Kona Lavadome. He used birthday money and money Matthew paid him for his bike. They've gone to

ride on the Kona trails along the river north of the 42nd Street bridge. Though Peter is happy enough to accept that the bike will be his main mode of transportation, the driver's licence in his back pocket poses an irresistible temptation to drive sometimes when he could bike.

Matthew and Erik finished their soccer seasons. Erik's team, the Cardinals, went undefeated. Matthew's team, United, lost only twice, both times to the eventual pool winner. Both teams qualified for playoffs. World Cup soccer coverage has done a lot to inspire them to hone their skills. Their games have opened up. Erik has learned the mentality of kids his age. Wherever the ball is, they run in a pack. If he can dribble through the crowd it is open field all the way to the goal. He told us he knows how fast he runs by how 'the wind blows in my hair'. His coach, having failed to get players to pass, told the team he would sub off every player who scored, to give the others a chance to score. Surely he could have foreseen what the hogging players would do. Most of the balls got fired just wide of the post.

Matthew is working on juggling — he has counted to 50 — chesting, heading the ball, though he does worry sometimes about getting brain damage. Ahead of each game he gets quietly keyed up. His favourite position is midfield.

All three boys finished the school year with excellent report cards. Peter's overall average is 90%. Matthew and Erik were both highly commended. The main criticism levelled against Erik is his occasional loss of self-control. Peter told Matthew that he is enjoying school too much to be looking forward to graduating.

I watched the World Cup final with Matthew, Erik and Geordie. It wasn't long before Erik and Geordie got so they couldn't sit any longer. Erik asked me to blow up two balloons. He and Geordie juggled them in the living room. I listened to them counting: 198 ... 199 ... 200 ... 201 It was slow, but that's balloons. As the number rose they got wilder. I ordered them outside. It wasn't more than a few minutes before Geordie and Erik were back, Erik in angry tears. I asked happened. He said, 'My balloon burst and Geordie's blew away.' (That too is balloons.) He continued complaining, disturbing my enjoyment of the game. I sent him to the bedroom. The rest of us watched in peace and Matthew picked out tunes on the ukulele. Brazil beat Italy 3-2 (the great Roberto Baggio kicked his try over the net) in the shootout after 120 scoreless minutes.

Mama and Papa have purchased a 31' 1978 Airstream Excella. Papa had several renovations done. He's now waiting for the seller to haul it to the space he has rented at Camp Kinasao. We will go up as soon as Erik is finished his swimming lessons. We will take the bikes, tennis rackets, golf clubs, books, computer, and so on. Mama and Papa will stay at the Peters' cabin.

Joel's wedding took place last Saturday, July 9. Michael, Cathy, Margot and Eric stayed several days with us. Carol, Les, Graham and Cameron stayed at Mom and Dad's. We golfed at Wildwood, Holiday Park and The Willows. 19 people showed up for breakfast at The Willows. Michael and I played tennis. The boys had fun with their cousins. Matthew played mostly with Eric. He endured Eric's standard abuses. Erik read books to Margot. They played in the park. Peter and Matthew prepared a cello duet they'll play while Joel signs the register. Erik was ringbearer. He wears his tux

(\$100 rental) with military bearing. He was nervous until he had gone through the first rehearsal on Wednesday.

The ceremony went quickly. Erik's role was to carry the pillow with rings and hold the hand of the 2-year-old flower girl. When the time came, he offered up the pillow to Colin, the best man. Colin removed the first ring. Pastor Borsch brought the service to the point when the second ring was to be presented. It was evident to everyone that Colin was having trouble untying the ribbon. Borsch waited, Colin wrestled, Borsch stopped waiting and called for the ring. In that instant Colin's arm jerked. He had snapped the ribbon. He handed the ring over, trailing bits of ribbon. The crowd broke up. Erik didn't smile. He said afterwards that it had somehow been his fault. The reception followed at the Top of the Inn. 51 people attended. After the meal came the dance. Attendance had swelled to over 100, many of them Joel's friends, some from his Rec-Tech program Fuzzy Ducks slow-pitch team, some from Aden Bowman Collegiate, some from the Saskatoon Video store. Hedlins didn't (don't) dance much. Joel's friends did, a lot.

The younger kids left to tour the hotel. They returned, dismayed by what they had found in the washroom on the main floor. Men dressed as women. When Matthew went in to wash his hands, a woman in long blonde hair who must have been six and a half feet tall was at the mirror applying mascara. When she turned he saw her whiskers. She spoke to him in a deep voice. It was all part of an Aids Benefit event in one of the ballrooms.

A terrible storm blew through town just as we headed home. Blinding rain, fierce winds, power failure. The streets were pitch

black, trees and branches lay everywhere. Peter drove. Cheryl thinks that he has gained undue confidence.

Tuesday July 26

Peter is waiting for a phone-call from the Y for a job as a casual shadow lifeguard. He plans to join the Lifeguard Club and register in a fall instructor's course. He went with Alan Harrington to see Schindler's List for free at the Place Riel theatre. He was home at 12:30.

Matthew will be spending the next three afternoons at Lakewood Civic Complex learning volleyball. He is digging into the Calvin and Hobbes treasury.

Erik and Geordie played Junior Trivial Pursuit last night while Cheryl read and I watched an Expos-Braves game.

Erik asked Geordie the name of the rabbit in Care Bears.

Geordie said, 'I don't watch that show.'

'Yeah,' Erik said.

Geordie asked Erik the name of the seventh dwarf in Snow White and the Seven Dwarves.

Erik said, 'Oh, I haven't seen that.'

They laughed.

Erik asked Geordie the name of the owl in Winnie the Pooh.

Geordie said, 'Uh, I haven't seen that.'

When they were told the owl's name was Owl they laughed again.

Tuesday August 9

We spent the last week at Christopher Lake. Papa, Mama and Peter stayed overnight on Sunday and left Monday early afternoon. A neighbour from the neighbouring trailer dropped in. He is 75. He must be the victim of a dental prank. When he smiles his dentures drop and his upper lip slips underneath. He stops smiling but the lip remains stuck under the dentures. He has a sad appearance.

We spent most of our time answering Erik's questions. 'If you were to die, would you want it to be slow or fast.' 'If you were going to pick one trophy, which would it be?'

By the weekend we were in Moose Jaw for Andrew Skarsgard's marriage to Krista. I drove up to Kinasao Friday morning to get Matthew from camp, returned to the city, packed, then drove together with Mama and Papa to Moose Jaw. We stayed at the Super 8 north on Main Street. Cheryl, the boys and I stayed in a suite with a king-size bed in an enclosed bedroom, a hide-a-bed, and space for someone on the floor. We brought the cellos. The boys are playing a Romburg duet.

The rehearsal party was held at the Prairie Oasis campground, suite 44. An Italian meal. 40 attended. Cheryl and I visited with David Skarsgard and Heather. Matthew and Erik sat outside at a picnic table. Peter talked mostly with Papa.

We had a continental breakfast in the motel lounge. We met briefly with other family members and studied maps of Moose Jaw and Super 8 locations across North America.

Cheryl, the boys and I toured Moose Jaw. Most houses even in the newer areas are in need of refurbishment. We were somewhat surprised that a strip of seemingly valuable residential property, because it is overlooking the Thunder Creek valley, was nothing but an alleyway behind small homes. We agreed to meet David and Ben at the St. John Anglican church at 11. They will xerox programs while we decide on the best place for the boys to set up. The boys roamed through the building, looking at plaques and corner stones, finding narrow staircases and mysterious doors. They would appear, then vanish, time and again.

We ate lunch with Mama and Papa in the basement of the Co-op. Enough said about that.

We went to the Prairie Oasis campground to waterslide. Cheryl and I walked in the downtown area, from Memorial Park to the 'natatorium', where the boys may swim on Sunday, weather permitting. We arrived at two baseball stadiums. I asked Cheryl to join me in climbing the wall to see what was causing the crowd noise on the other side. She couldn't be bothered. We went through the library, were nearly struck by a car being driven by Harvey and Anne on Main Street, and returned to the hotel.

The wedding was brief. The boys played well. There were lots of compliments. We went to Robins for coffee before heading to the reception at Buffalo Pound Lake where Krista's parents have property. The cabin was at the top of a hill, 75 metres from the road by the lake shore. Near the road was a large tent, erected the day before, with two aluminum poles in the centre. People stood around drinking punch, listening to the Playboys in their red jackets playing jazz from the 40's and 50's. Plenty of oily smoke poured up from the six barbecues: prime rib, corn on the cob,

potatoes and vegetables. People were forced inside the tent by rain. Shortly after there was heavy wind. Several men rushed about to install tent walls. Then the weather really happened. A deluge with high winds tested the tent structure. It began sagging, the centre poles were shifting, the entire tent was bouncing. The corner where the Playboys were stationed gave in. Krista's and a couple of others secured the pegs. The music continued while lighting popped on and off, people in soaking clothing went in and out, everyone watched the tent roof, some joking, others fearing a total collapse.

That's when Erik said he had to go to the bathroom. The bathroom is in the cabin.

By the time the rain stopped and wind had calmed (the tent is still still standing) the reception was nearing its end. A local photographer organized family groupings. As a group of five older women, Krista's great-aunts, stood to leave, the photographer moved in to set them up for a picture. One was having trouble standing. She teetered, looked about to fall on her face. I happened to be standing within arm's reach. I was ready to grab her arm. The photographer looked up from the camera and said to me, 'Who are you, their sister?' I crouched down. The photographer stood on her toes and said, 'I can still see you.' I left the tottering woman to her fate.

The boys were tired. Cheryl remained in conversation with Karen to the very end. We gathered everyone, pulled out along slogging roads at 11 pm. The sky was dark and clear. We arrived at the motel 30 minutes later.

Next morning we ate breakfast at the Prairie Oasis restaurant, then drove to the Krista's family home for the opening of presents. We ate lunch with 40 others and left by 1. Drizzle started up. We cancelled plans for the boys to swim at the Natatorium and headed straight home. Peter drove Papa's car.

Tuesday August 23

We have just returned from several days at the lake. We went up Saturday August 13, came home on Wednesday, then returned Friday afternoon. We are learning the secret to lake living: mooch mooch mooch. We graded and seeded the trailer lot, Cheryl clipped away bush along the edges, we set patio stones around the deck. None of it was possible without Adolph's tools. Nor could we play on the water without Adolph's canoe, paddles, lifejackets, Ed's sailboat and Adolph's paddleboat, Adolph's windsurfer. We skied behind Ed's badly underpowered motor boat. Matthew skied for the first time. He made a circle in front of Adolph's cabin, fell, and couldn't get up again. He knee-boarded the rest of the time. Peter tried a couple of times to ski, but the lifejacket was aggravating a bad sunburn on his back, and his heart wasn't in it. Erik was dying to ski. It wasn't until Terry Ardell came by with his big boat that Erik learned to knee-board. He was up, gave thumbs up for more speed, turned himself hard into the wake to jump it and get outside, then cut back across both wakes. He struggle to get the nose of the board pointed the right way and began losing control, a expression of hilarious fear on his face before going under. With every tumble after, he popped up spitting water and grinning. Peter knee-boarded also. Dale took him for a long run. When Peter indicated that he was ready to go back to the dock, Dale circled a couple of times to take him through the choppy wake. He thought afterwards that I had put Dale up to it. Which was only half true.

The boys have made great friends with Dale's girls. Each girl has latched onto one of the boys, Kristen onto Erik, Bree onto Matthew, Kim onto Peter. They played a night-time game of Red

Light Green Light with Peter carrying Stephanie on his shoulders. At the end, each girl whispered a plan to meet the boys in a hiding spot early the next morning. We were packing up late Sunday and Matthew was letting the air out of the dinghy when one of the girls came by to say goodbye. She went into the trailer. Bree came next. She said bye to Matthew with a sad tone, bending Matthew over with one arm around his neck, one across his back. They rejoined the girls at the beach. They swam back and forth to the floating dock. The dinghy became a ferry. Peter pumped air all day long because of a pin-prick hole. On the way back with a boatload of kids, Peter opened a valve, then thrilled the girls with warnings as the boat shrank and sunk. Back on shore they screamed and ran to their mother telling them what fun it was.

We went home on Wednesday by way of St. Louis. Peter showed us where he had seen the light of the ghost on Sunday evening with Crystal Peters. (We passed on Peter's experience to my parents. This coming Friday we'll have supper at their place before driving to St. Louis. Cheryl's parents may come too.)

Matthew and I worked on a plan to install the basketball hoop. Usually when doing things with tools, I end up with an injury. This time it was only a bleeding bump on the bridge of my nose and a scar that will likely last a lifetime, and a broken fingernail on my right index (guitar) finger. Cheryl studied it and made a thorough pretence of sympathy, trying not hard enough not to grin. Matthew's involvement with YAS has got him hepped up on basketball. He is in a five-day session. His vertical jump was the best of all, beating second-best by five inches. He also won a speed dribbling contest. It seems odd, all this physical vigor in a boy that spends the rest of his time loping, hunching, easing.

Erik has a growing list of misheard terms, the most recent being 'breathstroke' and 'snores' (smores).

Peter is getting more time lifeguarding at the Y than he expected. He is filling in for others who are sick. He feels lucky to get this job. Several had applied ahead of him, guards from the striking city pools. He worked several hours last week at \$5.35/hour. A one-hour stint yesterday turned into 4 1/2 hours when a guard phoned sick.

He went with Alan to The Client last night as soon as he was home from work. Matthew makes the point that while Peter comes and goes, gets a phone-call, tells us he's going to a movie that is nearly Restricted, Matthew has to spend his evening reading. He teases Alan about his changing voice, just as we have made fun of Matthew's efforts to artificially lower his own.

To which he answered, in that artificial voice: 'See what a man I am. I have whiskers on my chin. Hair is bursting from my nose. I have so much chest hair I can't put on a shirt.'

I gave in at that moment and said he could watch a bit of David Letterman with us.

He said, 'See, it worked.'

We have gone through a small library this summer. Cheryl is reading Michener's Mexico, McMurtry's The Last Picture Show, Victorian Wives. I just completed The Last Picture Show and Kundera's The Joke, and am now reading Fear by Rybakov. Peter and Matthew are reading Shannara books and spend more time sharing what they've read than they spend reading. Erik reads under duress. He lies on the love-seat, holding up the book but

scarcely looking at it. He checks over the front and back covers, sets the book down on his chest, reads for a couple of minutes, asks what a word means, lays the book down. He reads only because the alternative thing, playing with Geordie, is not on the table.

Erik's birthday is coming up. He's giving us the daily countdown. His knows for sure that Geordie will be invited. Other names are in the pool of discussion. Maybe we'll include the Ghost of St Louis trip with a sleep-over. No idea yet what to buy him. Everything he needs has come as nearly new hand-me-downs from his brothers. We're thinking of a watch. His last watch he had taken off and put on the goal net in the backyard while kicking the ball around and Peter ran it over with the lawnmower. Erik has asked for a super-soaker. He also has ideas from the toys he plays with at Geordies. One toy he suggests is a corpse. What a gruesome toy, we say. It turns out that Geordie has a set of army toys called Corps. We're also thinking maybe a remote control, which strikes us as a pretty passive activity, unless Geordie gets one too. It's hard being a kid in the '90s.

Peter is officially the same height as me, 5' 9 3/4". He is 140 pounds, which is a jump of 10 pounds from his last weigh-in. The joke now is that people who phone confuse Peter with me and Matthew with Cheryl.

Matthew cut his own hair a couple of weeks ago. Not liking his 'sideburns', one day they disappeared. It seemed harmless, so we said nothing. The next day he noticed a bit of hair coming over his ears. While we were out for a walk, he arranged his barber tools and went to work. He clipped too much off above the ear, trimmed further to get rid of the 'chopped' look, then began panicking, and

cutting. We were home for a while before Matthew turned up with his red baseball cap. I noticed no hair. I lifted his cap off. An inch above both ears from the temple to the back was gone. He had gone to Peter, said 'ta-da!', lifted his cap, and began to cry. 'Mom and Dad are going to kill me.' Our shock wore off after a few minutes, and the whole thing seemed funny. Another of Matthew's typical things. He disliked our mirth more than he expected to dislike our anger. Then he got angry. Cheryl simply called Karen for a haircut for the next day. On the way there he said he'd never do it again. After Karen had some fun, he said, 'This is the last I want to hear about it.'

1995

Friday June 7

We arrived in Salt Lake City by 10:30. We ventured into Temple Square. We began a guided tour with Sister Diana, but backed out after we were invited to give a testimonial in the Universe room in response to the prompt: 'What did you like best about what you heard?' We saw the Temple, Assembly Hall, the Tabernacle.

We crossed W South Temple street for a snack at JB's. We ordered lunch instead. We were humoured by a very large woman sitting alone at a table. She had ordered 'two of the large cookies with the really big chunks'. The waitress asked if there was anything else. She said, 'And a diet Coke.'

We drove up a very steep grade to the legislative buildings. We were surprised to learn that Utah is 77% Mormon.

As we drove southward the heat intensified. The boys have been sleeping too much during the day, so we have ruled one nap a day. We are enjoying the view. Erik said he'd rather do this than play with Geordie.

We came to Cedar City to set up camp. The KOA is a poor choice. The RVs with their droning air conditioners had prime spots. Tents were assigned to concrete patches next to the highway. We carried on to Kanarrville. Not much there except for a pleasant campground. Houses on a grid, a Mormon Church, a playground with sprinklers always on, tall thin men with sun burned skin and cowboy hats. The boys find someone with a basketball and play 2 on 2 in the near dark. Erik wants to play on a play-contraption in amidst water and mud. Cheryl said no. We walk instead. The boys tell us afterward about a boy on a dirt bike who planned to go to the dance because the cops would be there

and since he had ditched them once he would ditch them again. Erik stood nearby and watched them play.

Sure enough, just as we were getting ready for bed a dance band began tuning up nearby. We watch the town population migrate in that direction. Two women set up a table and take money. Three police stand near the gate, chatting. Once the music starts, people not at the dance sit on their front stoops to listen. The female camp proprietor came by to inform us that she didn't know if the office would be open before 8:30 am, since she was going to the dance.

Early in the morning a rooster crowed for an hour. There must be a recipe for rooster stew.

Wednesday July 5

We spent a long day driving through familiar territory. We ate lunch at the Swift Current Pizza Hut, walked a few square blocks in a residential area to help the boys burn off energy. But Erik fell behind. Matthew and Peter are excited about the trip to come.

We stopped at the Chamber of Commerce in Havre to get an idea about the location of campgrounds in the Great Falls area. The staff there were of no help. The information we got from one cast doubt on whether she knows of any such place as Great Falls. One used a book that didn't say much, shrugged, passed it to a higher-up, who said just as little. There is a campground in Dillon, but they can't say where Dillon is. Can't say where places are within the state. But they smiled nicely and received cool thanks.

We continued to Great Falls, our eyes peeled for signs of campgrounds. Found nothing before arriving there. We did come to a KOA Campground on 10th Avenue. \$20 USD/day. We set up in the middle of a large circle, with sites marked by low fencing, each with a bit of grass, picnic table, electric outlet. We ate supper at JBs, took a long walk around the large campground, found a nature trail. B-52s were landing at the air base every 15 minutes. Kids on a hill are setting off fireworks. As many rabbits as gophers.

We were in bed by 10:20. Boys in the next camp site tossed their fireworks into the campfire, which bang off at irregular intervals. Add to that planes thundering overhead, a family with whining children arriving in the dark, turning to bawling as the night went on, a barking dog, a nearby train roaring past.

Thursday July 6

The day started early with a dead van battery. I found a worker cutting plastic pipe. I asked if he could give me a boost. He looked puzzled.

He said, 'Don't say boost to us out here. Sounds like you're from San Francisco. We're likely to turn you down. The term we use is jump'

Does 'would you jump me' or 'would you give me a jump' or 'can you jump my truck' sound any better than 'can you boost me' to people whose thoughts float on a current of homophobia? In the end he brought his truck around and got the job done.

We stopped in Butte for toast and coffee, gas, groceries. We ate at Perkins. All the women here wear their hair long and blonde. I filled my thermos. Erik, we discovered far down the highway, forgot his jacket.

Peter took the wheel for the first time on the trip. He finds the I-15 easy with its four lanes. He is a bit slow on the curving parts. Cheryl and I keep our overall unease to ourselves. His neck gets sore. He's tense.

We ate lunch at a rest-stop, peanut butter and cheese, amidst a vast lava field. Our first photos.

We found the Lava Springs Campground off the highway, next to the small Portneuf river. We picked a river-front site behind a motel. We count the emergent fins of carp feeding on water plants. A heavy storm passed overhead. No rain but the rumble of thunder and a double rainbow, one of them ending at the picnic table one site over. We might have selected a campground upstream at the

end of a tube-run, but Cheryl didn't like the look of the mobile home community, in utter disrepair, empty Budweiser boxes everywhere.

We took a stroll in the town. Steep hills rise away from the river. The town feels like an old gold mine settlement. We've been through a few of those in the past five years. A three foot snake lay by the curb, flattened by some parking car.

We had supper at Virginia Crossing. We skipped a swim at the Olympic size pool after learning the family rate was \$20. Tubing costs \$2/hour.

We had ice-cream after supper. We took a short walk, a short drive back to the campsite. The river makes sucking noises. Lowing cows are the first sounds in the morning. Cheryl cancelled her plan to shower when she discovered silverfish on the walls. I waited outside the men's shower room at 6:30 and watched the sunlight appear on the mountain, and birds swooping around for insects and settling in nests where the babies are just visible. The boys played aero-ball — basketball in an enclosed trampoline, a perfect way to break one's back — and felt queasy afterwards.

I chatted briefly with someone from Washington who slept with his wife in their van. Every winter they drive to Mexico City.

Saturday July 8

Since we were up early we head towards Zion National Park. We ate breakfast in a park in La Verkin. Horses with hoods wandered by. One tried to eat Matthew's hair. They were joined by a cow, a rooster and a goat.

We drove to Springdale, the gate to Zion. We thought briefly about watching a big screen presentation about the history of the park, but the price of \$35 seemed awfully steep for 35 minutes. We drove into the Park, passed a campground, followed the narrow valley road along the Virgin River.

We parked at a hiking spot. A half-hour to the Weeping Rock, says a sign. We climbed the steep path. We read botanical signs along the way. Lizards with purple tails were everywhere. The cawing crows resound among the rocks that Erik imagined 'sounds like a tourist falling off the cliff.' Weeping Rock is a strange thing. We stand inside a deep depression in the wall where water rains down from pores in the stone, originating from some unknown place. The cliff face is dry.

Once we return to the parking lot, the boys are eager to hike more. We choose a trail to Hidden Canyon. The sign says it's a three hour hike across a steep vertical. We climb the switch-back paths, which turn narrow at the cliff face. Matthew goes ahead. Cheryl is nervous about Erik. Peter snaps pictures. The heat has turned Cheryl's face strawberry red. She doesn't like the height. She warns us she might faint. And she has fainted before. After passing through a break in the rock we find ourselves nearly at the top, hundreds of feet above the valley floor. A couple ahead of us goes through a crevice. We think briefly of following. But the path

gets even more narrow and there is no barrier to falling. We take pictures and turn back.

We drive through South Utah, cut across a corner of Arizona, and descend sharply into Nevada. The windows are hot to touch. We arrive in Mesquite for lunch. We drive in a wide circle through town in search of a picnic area. We find one next to a cemetery hard against the highway. A couple from Alberta are having their meal. It is 105 degrees. Everything we are eating has melted. We discover that a rear tire has gone flat. Removing the tire and accessing the spare underneath means kneeling on the baking asphalt. That done, we take the tire for repair to Mesquite Tire. The old guy in the broiling shop charges \$10. He says people drive too fast on the highway. If the air is 105°F/41°C, the asphalt is 140°F/60°C. Tires get hot and blow. We refreshed ourselves afterwards with the largest drinks on Macdonald's menu.

We reach Las Vegas by 4:30. We locate the Circus Circus casino, find a place to park, wander into the din of the front lobby, find registration, stand behind two moms and two daughters who had driven 19 straight hours from Michigan. Also in line are bridal couples. An old woman is playing several slot machines at once, pulling on a long cigarette. She wins something and accepts congratulations from strangers. We eat at the Pink Pony, then find our room, 27734.

Monday July 10

We were up at the sound of my watch alarm. 6 am. We're getting an early start across the desert to beat intolerable heat and heat-related mechanical failure. While the others were getting up I went in search of a Macdonald's outlet near the Midway. The slots and poker tables are as busy at any other time of the day. A guy sitting at a slot machine ordered liquor from a passing waitress. Men are in the bathroom loudly clearing phlegm (Vegas' idea of brushing one's teeth or combing one's hair) before heading back to the tables. I find a Mac's by 6:15, but it was closed. I asked someone washing its floor why? He said it's because it's only 5:15. We hadn't seen any clocks since arriving in Vegas. Somewhere between St. George and Las Vegas we had gone from Mountain Standard to Pacific Standard, gaining an hour.

We packed and headed down Sahara past the I-15 to a Macdonald's that is open. Then we drove without stopping deep into the desert past Baker—94°F/34°C at 8:30—and Barstow, climbing to over 5000 ft through a desert of mesquite and sand.

Our first real California experience comes while passing through the San Gabriel mountains into the LA basin. The smog covers mountains and smells like wet garbage. Four lanes of traffic. Even at 75 mph I'm obstructing vehicles travelling 85 while weaving across all four lanes seeking spaces just being enough for their vehicles. I feel not quite in control. The cab of semi-truck that ran up against a barrier is dangling over the precipice.

The smog lifts as we pass by the Cleveland National Forest. We leave the interstate at Escondido and look for a public park. We travel several miles through richly landscaped residences, turn at a

school, stop at a convenience store/garage, buy more food, and have sandwiches on the road into San Diego.

We miss a couple of turns, carry on too far along the 52, turn onto I-5 to La Jolla village to Genesee and so on, ending up finally at Michael's. Michael is at work. We walk to a park south of their place, then drive to TGI Friday's for burgers and nacho chips. I phone Michael and he gives us the directions to Scripps. We find it, find him, find Cathy. He gives a brief tour.

Tuesday July 11

Michael took Cathy to the airport. She is travelling to Boulder for a conference.

His kids were late getting to daycare. Cheryl and I took Erik to a mall on Genesee. We were early. We bided time with coffee at a shop owned by an Israeli family. Erik ordered a cranberry juice but didn't drink much. We bought him shoes at Nordstroms from a woman from Chicago and a jacket to replace the one left in Butte at Sears from a Croatian refugee.

We returned to Michael's to prepare for the beach. We arrived in the parking lot by noon, but it was full. We found a meter close to the water and set up just north of Scripps pier. Michael is with colleagues playing ultimate frisbee.

Cheryl stays by the umbrella. Peter and Matthew head into the surf. Erik, Michael and I walk north to the tidal pools, with anemones, crabs, barnacles, abalone.

Back at the umbrella, Michael, Peter and I begin a swim around the pier. I fall behind in big waves, have doubts about my swimming fitness, and turn back. Peter and Michael return on the other side of the pier in half an hour. The seven foot waves crest land with crushing force. Awesome.

Michael returns to work. The boys and I play a short game of football, but the sand is as hard as concrete. Peter and Matthew win by a touchdown. Erik and I failed to complete even one pass.

After enjoying the best San Diego has to offer, we then experienced a bit of the worst. A semi had overturned on Ardath Drive. Traffic was backed up a mile, all the way to La Jolla Shores

Drive. We turned onto Torrey Pines Drive to La Jolla Village Drive where traffic in my lane stood stock still. A 10 minute drive turned into 70 minutes. Traffic from the other lanes merged/jammed into spaces in our lane. An Audi 5000 lost its coolant and had to be pushed across the outside lane up a hill and over a curb. Michael said this never happens. Just a bit of bad luck.

By the time we were home, Michael had supper on the go. Tacos with avocado. We ate, then headed back to the public beach where campfires burn here and there. Erik ran ahead, passed near two girls, and slapped one on the rear.

She looked up with shock: 'What did I do?' She asked.

Erik explained to us later that she had been saying rude things to Margot. Matthew reported that a couple of young men in a blue VW bus with a blue roof wearing hoodies were asking a couple of very young females if they could sleep at their house in their bedroom.

Wednesday July 12

The day began normally. Michael was up with the two children, dressing, feeding, taking them to daycare and school.

Margot showed us her loose tooth. I asked what happens when it comes out.

She said, 'I put it under my pillow and...you know.'

I said, 'I don't know.'

She said, 'You know.'

Michael took his bike. The plan was to meet us at the Cabrillo monument on Point Loma. Cheryl did two loads of laundry.

We drove along Torre Pines to Mission Beach. We walked past the Crystal Hotel and Pier Cottages (\$140-\$200/night) to the end. Surfers were lined up in the water waiting for a wave. Those on a wave are interfering with each other. Men are fishing at the end of the pier.

The beach was dotted with sea weed and sun-tanners. Some are as dark as ebony, some look like old shoes. After walking a ways, being dodged by bikers and skateboarders, we returned to Thomas Street and headed south to Palm Avenue, then north on Silver Strand Blvd (a narrow causeway) to Coronado. We parked, toured the darkly luxurious Hotel del Coronado, ate lunch at Mary Calendars where we sent back undercooked hamburgers and received three pieces of pie free for our troubles.

We headed across the Coronado Bay Bridge where Cheryl nearly panicked at the 200 foot elevation. We didn't find out until later that a newly married couple crossing the bridge for their 1st

night at the Del Coronado had had a mechanical failure, got out of their car, and were struck fatally. We travelled along Harbour Drive past Lindbergh field to the US Naval Air Station, then to Cabrillo National Monument where Michael was waiting. We removed the wheels of his bike and stashed it in the back.

We spent some time looking over the Navy yards at the yachts, incoming naval vessels, an outgoing nuclear attack sub, incoming Hueys and F-14s. We walked to an historic light house operated by a man named Israel and his wife, then drove to tidal pools, found some caves, talked Cheryl into coming down with us, although she claimed she was quite happy just watching the ocean. We found huge crabs in the cave. We watched the waves dash against the rock. I wondered what it would be like to get caught there in a rising tide.

We returned home by Sunset Blvd, stopped for groceries at Ocean Beach, cooked chicken fettuccini for supper. The kids ate at the table. We ate in the living room.

Thursday July 13

We split the day into two. The morning was spent on the beach. We headed there just after 10. We parked at La Jolla Shores beach, set up an umbrella. The wind was chilly. The surf is high. Everyone has been warned about a strong current. Surfers to the north, swimmers and boogie boarders to the south.

The boys ventured into the surf. Peter was cold and came back. I bought coffee and newspaper from a cafe near the beach. Cheryl and I read. Our umbrella blew into the party several yards away. They didn't know where it had come from and took it apart. I went over and claimed it.

The boys search in vain for a place to rent boogie boards. They had seen such a place down on Mission Beach. Nothing like that here.

Kids are dragging armloads of seaweed from the water. Boys in wetsuits and long hair threw flat boards onto the wet sand and jumped on for a short ride. The beach was quickly filling up. Cars eased through the parking lot looking for a space.

We ate lunch. The boys returned to the water. Matthew and Erik tried body surfing. They were drifting down-shore. Peter stood with me, ankle deep in the water, watching the boys and talking.

We left at 2. We followed Michael's instructions to the Torrey Pines hiking trails inside the State Park. Entry was \$4. We walked through the thorny growth on broad sandy paths along cliffs to lookout points. To the north was a long parking lot and miles of white breakers. Southward past Black's Beach towards Scripps

pier are hang gliders. We spotted schools of dolphins just offshore. Jets from Miramar fly by in formation. Navy boats and private power boats cross by. A few people are on the beach below.

On the way back home we stopped at Torrey Pines Municipal Golf Course: we see the entire gamut of golfers, from the best to guys on the practise greens in sandals and toes sticking through sock holes. \$42 for 18 holes.

For supper we ate hotdogs and leftover fettuccine.

Michael returned to the airport to get Cathy. We watched the Simpsons. It has become a bit of a nightly ritual. The kids sit on our airbed. Eric slips under the covers. Margot shrieks with laughter. We hear about Cathy's trip. I drift off to sleep. Long days in the sun take a toll.

Friday July 14

Cheryl and I listen to the sounds as others were getting up while we stayed in bed to read. The boys think there is a lot to do. Matthew even showered.

After breakfast, we polished off an Andy Griffiths show on Fox, then went to the UTC Mall to shop. The boys looked in sport stores. Peter bought biking/hiking boots, Matthew Nike Air running shoes, two shirts for me, and for Erik a spring-propelled plane. Cheryl stayed after we left and shopped at leisure. She had two dresses, towels and a table cloth by the time I returned. In the mean time the boys and I walked to Marcy Park near Michael's house, the boys in their new footwear, to test Erik's plane. Two boys, Kevin and Gregory, wandered over and took their turns with the plane.

We returned to the house by 2:10 in time to get to UTC to pick up Cheryl. I had coffee while Cheryl ate lunch. We were back by 3. Michael was a few minutes late, returning from work on bike. We picked up Margot from school and got to Jack Murphy baseball stadium by 3:30 to buy tickets. We sat in Plaza level #30, Row 17, Seats 1 - 7. This put us above first base. If we were watching a football game, we'd have been at the 50 yard line. We were able to see most of the pitchers and the Padres' bench. The game began with cheers for the Braves being easily as loud as cheers for the Padres. At times while the crowd was clapping a wave would start. Sputtering at the beginning, then catching momentum and circling the stadium, at times seemingly distracting players and slowing down their play. The chicken mascot was the best part. It ran through a balloon to the sound of MC Hammer's Can't Touch This. Though the Padres were rallying in the 8th and 9th innings, many

spectators sensed — possibly they were conditioned to think this way by past Padres play — that it would not be enough and began vacating in the 8th.

We took Friars to 263, the same freeway where a runaway tank was recently stopped in its tracks (we had watched the film of it being caught up on the boulevard and police opening the hatch and firing their weapons inside and pulling the slack body out). Cheryl, Matthew and I went to the UTC for more towels. Cheryl was delayed by a conversation with a male sales clerk about Canada.

Michael made his macaroni and cheese ‘special’. The broccoli was overcooked and stayed behind on most of the kids’ plates. Michael and Peter took off for yogurt. Erik and Matthew shepherded Eric. He is in one of his slap-dash moods, throwing toys into the tub and against the wall, screaming in between sweet smiles, a peaceful interval with his toys, then perverse attacks, slamming doors, breaking train tracks.

Matthew wears a miner’s/hiker’s headlamp in the tent. He examines his new runners. He will run with Michael on Monday.

Saturday and Sunday, July 15 - 16: Mexico

Our trail went from San Diego on 94 through East County (Spring Valley) to Tecate on the border to Ensenada on the Baja peninsula to the La Bufadora blow-holes to Tijuana and back to San Diego.

The first impression at Tecate didn’t change much during our travels to the peninsula. Dry rocky hills, homes lodged helter-skelter against the slope, like bird nests. They are flat-roofed,

made of wood construction or unpainted cindercrete blocks or clay brick. Eroded, graffitied, sluggish. Belongings are piled at the door, cars badly damaged or burned out at the curbs, empty buses, small round trailers attached to lean-to structures, winding dirt and cobbled roads so steep that at one point I was forced to shift to 1st gear, spinning the rear tires, reaching the end of the road and nowhere to turn. In the middle making of a multi-point 180 turn I was thinking there's a chance the van might roll over. We saw in the window of one house a a man on a hospital bed, his leg suspended. We passed a hospital and the sign, 'Consulta y emergencias'.

Plenty of evidence of wealthy Mexicans, paler-skinned than the poor, sleek black hair (the girls were adorned with bows), stereotypically tough looking young men in their shades, their girlfriends dressed 'for the street'. Waiters in high-design restaurants with moustaches, the tables with linen cloths, the interior dark and swank. Impressive churches. They're all living as much off the avails of the poor as us tourists. A California kid passes by in a VW bus with the stub of a cigar in his mouth.

Kiosks crowded with handcrafts and junk served by tiny dark Indians. Boys are everywhere, hundreds of them selling chiclet gum and little handheld drums with tethered balls that beat while being flipped. Indian women in dirty clothing, barefoot, looking up but barely seeing, holding dirty styrofoam cups for money. Little boys chasing Cheryl, gripping her hand. Others approaching cars paused at intersections, pulling at the door handles.

At La Bufadora where we were sitting at a table, a man in a green suit, silver clasps down the side of the trousers, in a big sombrero, is playing a guitar and songs that include Happy

Birthday and Mexico's national anthem, altering the lyrics for our benefit — 'Yiba (Viva) Mehico' Yiba Caaanada — for a dollar that he drops into the sound hole. He opens every song with a series of 2-note chords that rhythmically or melodically have no relation to the actual song, and stringing the whole thing out until someone comes up with a donation. He turns to us as he plays. We attempt to avoid looking at him and applaud obliquely after each song. He moves to the other tables. Wherever Mexicans are sitting he is brusquely waved off. He goes into a restaurant and sits at the bar. Later he comes out with guitar trailing in the dust, and wanders to the highway. We sit beneath a reed canopy with a view of the ocean and the hills where the poorest people are lodged. We are served by a waiter in white jacket. We ordered hamburgers well—we ask that they be very well—done. Cathy ordered seafood 'surprise' soup for \$8, tacos, enchiladas, pop in bottles. Then we waited and waited.

Eric is difficult. He is on a leash. We take turns following him. He leads me to some flowers where bees swarm in the foliage. He swats these even as I'm pulling him away. He high-fives big ants. Just then a very dark Indian smelling of tequila asks for a dollar. I shake my head and rub my stomach.

'I'm going to eat,' I tell him.

'Why', he asked.

'I don't speak Spanish,' I say.

I tug harder on the leash, pulling Eric backwards.

He follows me to our table. The girls are a bit apprehensive. He stands in the shade of our canopy.

‘Why?’ He asks again.

Cathy without looking at him, forcefully (and querulously) says, ‘We want to eat and don’t want to be arguing right now.’

He’s not deterred in the slightest. Finally we ask a passing waiter to tell him to leave. Maybe this is the one order the water is actually able to fulfill. He uses rough terms, crude gestures, and uses one word that has a magical effect. He turns away. I was wishing then I understood Spanish.

We’re still waiting for our meal. We catch the eye of our waiter with his white ‘dentist’ jacket and tattoos up his arm and ask how soon.

He speaks while hurrying plates to other tables. ‘The potatoes take a long time. They must cut them. Then they must fry them.’ Later he says, ‘The food will be very soon now.’

An hour later we ask, ‘How it can be that those people and those (we’re actively pointing now at two tables occupied by a two families from California) who came after we had given our order have gotten their food and are nearly finished.’

His answer strikes us not so much as the height of obviousness as it is a glimpse into the Mexican soul. ‘Theirs were easier.’

Peter’s burger arrived well before the rest. He took a bite, then said, ‘If we had been willing to wait longer, the chef wouldn’t have just put the meat on the bun, he would have cooked it too.’

It was literally bleeding into the bread. He left most of that, and the fries, which were cold and tasted, he said, like fish. As Cathy lifted her spoon from the bottom of her soup bowl, the

surface was disturbed by the black tips of tentacles. It was like watching a monster rising in a Jules Verne movie.

Eventually we were done. Miles later we caught sight of the 2-chord guitar player eating a meal.

How does one explain the roughshod consistency of the physical engineering here, the casual workmanship and seeming permanence of unfinished projects, paved roads suddenly turning to gravel, and 8" speed bumps topped with steel balls here and tips of rebar looking like punji sticks (which North Vietnamese forces buried in pits to impale American soldiers) to warn that a village is ahead, so slow down.

Then there is La Bufadora, a spectacular phenomenon of ocean waves striking the peculiar arrangement of the cliff face with a cauldron at the bottom and chutes of stone that every fifth wave or so explodes upwards, far overhead. The best view of it is from the top of the cliff. One gets there along a slope so steep, with stones for steps set randomly and of differing heights, that children must here and there be dragged. There is no retaining wall along the lip of the cliff, and to lose the grip of a child is a nightmare prospect. There is a wall at the top where tourists stand to watch the geysers and if the wind is right, get drenched. But the wall seems more of a problem than a solution. It is at best only knee height, and seems likelier to cause one to trip than not. Pitching to one's doom seemed a likely occurrence. There were no sign boards with notches counting the bodies like Cheryl and I came across in 1976 in the Colorado mountains on the steeply descending switchback highway where, at one turn with a vista view to die for there was a billboard that kept count of the trucks that had lost their brakes. I was wondering if the locals were here not for the water but for the

chance of seeing someone fall and enjoying whatever soap opera might follow. Maybe there was a betting pool. Otherwise, with each eruption of water there was laughter and cheers. One spectator wore a blue baseball jacket. Another was upset when the water doused his cigarette.

Beat poets had always been connected to the Mexicans who were the spirit of the Beat Movement. We see it here. The poverty, simplicity. A spirited people, trammelled but unasking. Sadly festive, their brown eyes scarcely looking, their beaten cars rattling and rumbling, sagging with human cargo, some stalled and pushed to the roadside. A Camaro, its lights flashing, sits askew on broken suspension. Its left rear wheel is smaller than the others, and flat on its rim. Loud music plays. A young man dressed in soccer gear, just stepped off the bus, kneeling to tie his brown Diadoras. While driving between cliff faces south of Tijuana we see kids peering down from the top, some dropping big rocks onto the highway. We drive through neighbourhoods where weeds grow through the asphalt and cover the curbs. We see apartment blocks, rose-shaded, walls begrimed and graffitied, their windows showing black interiors. We see barefoot kids kicking a plastic soccer ball, men standing in ditches with white straw cowboy hats, tethering their cows to steel posts. We see fields of corn, peppers, and nuts, and roadside vendors, 20 or thirty in a row, selling canned jalapeños. We visit a fish market with dozens of varieties, huge fish whole or crosscut, and octopus, and species none of us can identify. Men inside are chopping the meat. Flies buzz over platters of seafood, carrots and peppers, ready for the oven.

The next morning Michael and I were hungover from last night's margaritas on the pool deck. Our drinks had been served in

oversized margarita glasses. By the time Peter came to report that Eric was out of control, I was in no condition to offer more than a useless smile. Once up I went outside to walk off my headache. I crossed a bridge where the water below was clogged with car tires and garbage.

We went to Denny's for breakfast. The orange juice is \$1.25. We ask why so expensive. The waiter says, 'The oranges are freshly squished.'

While waiting, we sipped our drinks through short straws that don't reach the bottom. I opened my napkin and found in the fold someone's used chewing gum. The bathroom had a dropped ceiling just inside the door. To protect heads, it was covered with a bumper pad.

Monday July 17

The boys stayed at home while Cheryl and I went to the UTC Mall. Cheryl is on the hunt for whatever clothing and shoes will fill her wardrobe gaps. We buy coffee at Starbucks. Classical music is piped through the mall. Other couples are seated under the green canvas umbrellas, reading or chatting. Cheryl buys a San Diego paper. After she resumed shopping, I stayed behind to read. Back at the house the boys are busy. I wrote a few Mexican impressions.

In the afternoon we went to the Wild Animal Park. It is near Escondido past the Miramar grass fire. Then I discovered my Visa card is missing. We attended a bird show: Emus, a diving hawk, talking and singing parrots, an eagle. We visit the gorilla family. We are instructed not to stare at them, only sit patiently to wait for things to happen. The lagoon is crowded with ducks, storks, egrets, shoebills. Lemurs have conked out by mid afternoon, but are lively by 7, their tails straight up, sitting in a row, their red eyes watching. Warthogs lying in the dirt, seemingly struggling in the heat, had disappeared by 7. The monorail ride took us passed a family of rhinos. The adult was missing. Our guide said that he was being kept in a containment cell until the baby son rhino is one month older. One male, a huge albino, was confused for a boulder. There are bison, gnus, giraffes, and the trees they have destroyed that the park people have done everything to save.

The boys are hot, and look for water fountains. At Dinosaur Mountain we see a T Rex gripping a brontosaurus by the bloody neck in its jaws. There are African and Indian elephants. Again, males have been kept apart for the sake of the offspring. Turkey buzzards — I count 19 — circle above the hills. We see antelope, donkeys, sheep, deer of all sorts from Africa and EuroAsia and

India. Children ride in strollers designed like safari vehicles. A truck with photo takers rides through the middle of the safari territory. A rhino female and her son are up against fence slats eating apples. Juvenile male deer, antelope and goats are butting, tangling their horns.

Michael and Cathy arrive at 5:40. We've eaten (\$31 for a snack). Birds come by looking for crumbs. Fake throwing crumbs and they'll stand in rows and wait. Margot and Eric go helter-skelter. Eric is in his halter, carrying his own leash. We take the Kilimanjaro Walk to a viewpoint where animals are clustered on the slopes and around a watering hole making a racket.

The Park sends repeated announcements about closing time. We start moving towards the exit, past a hidden jungle (roaches, spiders, ants, snakes, hummingbirds, butterflies). Once in the cars we head by Rancho del Rey where Kroc, the founder of McDonald's, lives. Walls and trees serve as barriers to these vast properties. We end up at the beach at Del Mar and walk along the surf as the sun sets. Plenty of waders, couples on the beach. Homes new and old, big and modest, behind a long wall. Sailboats, curling waves, the kids going out further than they should, body surfers, lone surfers far out waiting for the last wave to bring them home. A long-haired man carries his guitar towards his all-terrain vehicle. We are sticky from the salt spray.

At home Cathy goes for groceries, then eats her supper. She reads *Secret Garden* to Margot. Eric rides his tractor nearly over Cheryl's feet. He stops, looks at them, and says, 'Look at the toes. Yiketh.' (Her toenails have just been painted red.) He sits with me to look at road maps. I show him Chicago. I tell him it's the home of the Bears. He says, 'Go Bears.' I show him cities with

reputations for being dangerous. He touches Detroit and pulls his finger back as if it is burnt. His finger traces highways, chasing my finger, avoiding my finger. Michael puts him in bed. Waiting for sleep, he says, 'No bears, no bears.' Margot combs her hair to 'make it fluffy for the people'.

Tuesday July 18

First thing that morning, after dealing with my lost Visa card, we head to the Cove and underwater park. Matthew goes with Michael and Cathy to run from from Scripps to the bay. We find a place to park overlooking the rocks. After settling in, while Erik and Peter were swimming with snorkels and fins, Michael and Matthew arrived. They had stopped a few times because Matthew had a stitch in his side. The water is icy and calm, just an occasional swell channeling through the rocks, pushing waders off their feet. Cheryl and I take our turns with snorkels. We kick further from the shore where the rock face turns and the Cove becomes the ocean. There we find seaweed gardens, eel grass, and a plethora of fish varieties: Garibaldi, Anchovies, Kelp Bass, Treefish, Urchins, Anenomes, and so on. One comes to where the shelf falls away to 30 foot depths. It is a spectacular experience, being weight free and dwelling in the Now, feeling detached from passing time (except that we're aware that for as long as we are doing this others are waiting on the beach for another turn with the equipment). Peter was to declare for the rest of the trip that this had been his finest moment.

We met Cathy for lunch. It was a short walk to the van. We drove to the Star of India for the buffet. The route took us through vintage La Jolla. High priced autos parked on steep roads, fine fashion, neighbourhoods washed down and clean, all the vegetation manicured, always with the sea visible beyond the white walls.

The buffet provides a wide variety of food. The restaurant gradually fills mostly with well-heeled people, a few Indians, most not. We discussed our time in San Diego. Michael said he was

depressed we were leaving. We stood outside the restaurant for awhile, then hugged and said goodbye.

We followed the I-5 to Anaheim. The highway was mostly clear until we arrived. All along are posted signs, the sort one sees at homes warning of crossing deer, but these with images of families, holding hands, in flight. Traffic builds and slows. We discover the pattern. Cars collectively travelling in accordion fashion, distancing with speed, then compressing at a crawl. Anaheim and Disneyland are easy to find. Hotels and motels—Candy Cane Lane, Jolly Roger—are full. Some are \$150 - \$200. We question our next move. We keep driving along Harbour until we arrive at Hacienda. We take Room 201. The bathroom basin is cracked, no amenities. A cleaning lady with not a word of English fixes the air-conditioning by plugging it in.

I walk alone down Harbour through throbbing life to make reservations at a Motel 6 in Barstow. A gypsy is dancing in the parking lot by Toys R Us as her strong man sits nearby on a bicycle. Two Latinos car creep by eyeing her. I pass an angry woman on a public phone and some guy whacking the wheel of a souped-up VW with a hammer while a family watches.

I return to find that Cheryl has been worrying I might be injured and she'd have to drive through the LA freeways and all the way home.

Wednesday July 19

Not sure how we're going to do Disneyland. We were told that the earlier we were there the better. So we were up at 5:50 and through the gates at 8. We had a short conversation while standing in line for tickets (the first of many over the next two days) with a local who had moved from New York who told us he had travelled to Alberta and BC, had loved it, and thought of moving to Calgary: no graffiti.

Our first lineup is the longest of all: Indiana Jones. The 'vehicle' needed to be 'driven'. I sat behind the wheel. All the ups and downs, side to side, breaking, accelerating to evade rolling boulders and other extreme hazards, taking sharp turns in the pitch dark, and Erik is still young enough to believe I was the one in control. I was heroic. All the rest of the day were lines. Disney knows how to move many people quickly. This is our first experience following the system of folding the line on itself, back and forth, to create the illusion of swift motion towards the ticket booths. We saw movies in circular theatre, rode trams, railways, and roller coasters. Matthew is ill. He missed out on Space Mountain. The motion in the dark seemed too much for his disturbed GI. Sudden urgencies remove him and me from our place in lines, heading for the nearest bathroom, returning quickly enough to rejoin Cheryl, Peter and Erik before they've disappeared through the gate. We suspect he was infected with a bug in the water in Mexico while brushing his teeth. The entire Disneyland is a series of themes of an idealized, imagined, America. Critter Country, Frontierland, Tomorrowland. Parents show increasing fatigue over the day as the children get worn down by the energy and excitement: tears, children sleeping, anger. Erik does well but

begins to fall behind by mid-afternoon. We are in and out of countless Disney stores. We stay for the fireworks and a fantastic light and water show, witnessing things as Mickey Mouse imagines them.

Thursday July 20

We missed the exit sign to Universal Studios. Our speed along the I-5 was crazy ranged between 15 mph and 0 for over an hour. The freeway and the route it follows is a sequence of broken pavements, all lanes bumper to bumper. On both sides are trailer parks, warehouses, dusty anemic trees, flowering shrubs, billboards, the backsides of cheap neighbourhoods, all the way into downtown LA. By the time we get to Universal Studios we're worn out, our morning fresh anticipations ebbing. In Hollywood, the surroundings spruce up a bit. From here we can see the rolling hills. Like everywhere else, the smog is as thick as a pastel wall.

Once inside Universal Studios, we watch an animal show and a Wild West show. We spend 45 minutes in line to Back to the Future. The boys agreed it was the best ride of both days. Cheryl covers her eyes through most of it. We take a tram through the back lot. Four girls flirt with Peter ('she likes you,' one of them says to him). We ride 4 escalators down the hill into San Fernando Valley past Jurassic Park to an exhibit about movie-making. The examples today are Backdraft and Hendersons. (Erik is picked out from the crowd to come to the stage. The light on his mic doesn't go on to cue his growl.) We see the buildings from Psycho and Saboteur, a Hitchcock's movie about someone falling off the Statue of Liberty. We eat at Mel's Diner for \$32. It's a hot day. Our thirst builds. By 4 we have all had enough of the noise, hype, excitement, crowds, lineups, money spent. We find the car and head for Barstow.

The I-10 all the way to the I-15 is a traffic jam. 70 minutes to get from Hollywood to the I-5. About 6 miles. After that we use the HOV lane and make good time. \$250 fine for breaking that law.

Motorcycles weave in and out. The boys sleep. Cheryl traces with her finger on the map our progress along the I-10 until her body begins to ache. We're not sure why the freeway speeds surge then suddenly brake and slow to a near stop, time and again. Once we've gotten onto the I-15, the traffic thins and speeds reach a steady normal. We climb into the desert to Barstow. The entire way 80% of the cars have only one person.

We have supper at a good local restaurant near Motel 6. The bridge of my glasses snap. The boys swim, dive, play keep-away with a rubber ball that belongs to a paddle game Erik got at Mel's. We watch 3 episodes of I Dream of Jeannie.

Friday July 21

Our start is delayed by my search for a glass lab. Meanwhile the boys swim. The heat is up early. We find an optical shop, a small shack of a place. The optician is a little man in a burgundy jacket and long hair. He excuses the dust but it's something, he says, that's always around. My frames can't be fixed.

We leave town by 12, heading for Needles. The boys sleep. The desert slides by. We go for ice-cream to the Baskin Robins in Kingman. Matthew has to go to the bathroom, badly. (Still dreaming of Mexico.) We skip the line and go to the Dairy Queen for ice-cream and facilities.

On the way to Williams we climb until we've left the desert and are in the trees. We're not sure about the time zone. We can't find a campsite. A state campground charges \$6, but all its facilities are closed. Hotels in Williams are expensive.

We try our luck at one motel. I ask the manager if he honours CAA.

He says, 'Sure, I've taken \$4 off my price. You say how much more. I have no idea what CAA means. So many have come in asking that it makes me sick.'

'CAA is affiliated with AAA.'

'It doesn't mean anything. Quality means nothing. You can stay here where it's clean, or you can go next door where it's dirty, or down the way to the Pakistani Inn where I wouldn't let my dog sleep. Price is the bottom line.'

'I stayed at the Motel 6 at Barstow for \$26.'

‘This isn’t the Motel 6.’

‘I see that. Well, I’m just looking now.’

‘Find something if you can. I’d drop my price but I have only 3 rooms and am confident of renting out. You’ll be back.’

Instead we camped at the KOA north of Williams. The ground was too hard for our pegs. I bought 3 sakes to do the job. We watched the brilliant stars, the mobile homes, the families sitting outside, someone on a guitar singing ‘Put your left hand in, take your...’. This was a moment of genuine American West. The wind is blowing. It will be cold tonight.

Saturday July 22

We were up at 6. Or is it 6? Which time zone are we in? Cheryl is certain we are packing more poorly as we go. We drive up the road to a Days' Inn restaurant for breakfast, across from the Flintstone's Bedrock campground. We're the first in. It's crowded when we leave.

The Grand Canyon: I can't fathom the act of chewing out a ditch this big. We take pictures. How can you not, when you're at the Grand Canyon. We walk along a trail that follows canyon rim, smile at tourists we encounter. Erik falls behind. Being at this altitude, 8000 feet, makes the legs heavy. After a bit of time at a museum of canyon artefacts, and a quick drink of turbid water in the visitor centre, we leave. By now the area is crawling with visitors.

We pass through Cameron and Tuba City, and eat lunch at a local diner off the path near a Navajo school. The boys notice strongly worded racism on the bathroom wall, aiming both ways. Soup (broccoli, cheese, rice), toast, and cottage cheese off the buffet.

We drive through vacant land. Long ridges of land to the north, white to the south. Utah and Four Corners lie ahead. The boys read. Peter is finishing a Shannara book, Matthew is in the middle of Elfstone. Neither talks. Peter goes nearly the whole day without saying a word. Our curiosity to visit Four Corners is cured by an entry fee of \$1.50 per person. It doesn't mean enough to us.

Cortez Colorado is a sharp contrast to the desert. We climbed to 7000 feet. We had been here 19 years ago. It is much more modern now. We check out a campsite, a crusty little spot behind a

broken fence of a single house, just off the highway. We drive into Mesa Verde National Park. I'll give Cheryl another taste of climbing on winding roads to 8000 feet. The Morefield campground has 500 spots. It is pristine. Picking our own feels like a luxury. Cheryl and I walk to locate an amphitheatre, but path is steep, the going is tough. The boys stay behind in the tent to read. By the time we return, the campsite is nearly full. Campers go around busy with camping business. We fill up the air mattresses and sit in the shade.

We eat supper at the Knife Edge Cafe where the camp complex is headquartered. Showers, firewood, a store, gas station, and three visual panels showing the stages of cliff-dwellings.

[Mesa Verde to Santa Fe, to east of Colorado Spring, to Pierre, to Saskatoon: July 23- 26: an inexplicable absence of comment about a fascinating finish to our trip. Belated —September 21, 2020 —apologies.]

Sunday August 13

Another summer is nearly over.

We spent the first part on a trip to San Diego and Mexico, with stops at Disneyland, Universal Studios, Grand Canyon, Mesa Verde, Santa Fe, Taos, Boulder Colorado and Pierre South Dakota. The boys are wonderful travellers. Having a van helped. Peter's place was in the back seat. His time was spent Shannara, sleeping, listening to tapes. On occasion, he drove. But the Interstate highways are sometimes crazy and his neck gets sore from the tension. Matthew and Erik had their places in the middle seat. Matthew read Elfstones, listened to Weird Al Yankovic, slept, watched scenery. Erik sang along with Weird Al, slept, played with a car, making hissing sounds, jiggled his foot on my armrest. No real conflict. Mostly only the anticipation of our next stop, or conversations about what we'd just done.

Peter has grown taller than me. He is lean. His glasses are gone. His hair is a mop. Somedays there are hours of him being neither seen nor heard. He reads on his bed, or plays music on his stereo. Cello is a fixture in his life. He worried early on in the trip about falling behind the others in his quartet: Sara was playing with the National Youth Orchestra, Elation was at a workshop in Montreal. As soon as we were back he resumed practising his studies and quartet pieces. They will play for a wedding in Prince Albert on the 19th and at the National Quartet Competitions in Calgary on the 21st. He's excited about both. He'll take the van to PA. The quartet will fly to Calgary. Their tickets are paid for by the National Association. That includes a seat for his cello. They'll be gone until the following Tuesday. They have rooms at the Olympic Village. He's pretty self-contained about his thoughts. The more he

thinks, the quieter he gets. We have to watch rather than ask if we're going to learn anything meaningful. He has had a very busy year. The quartet is taking more of his time. It practises frequently now with Mark Rudoff as their coach. He was also in a drama class. They put a performance with Peter as lead. The play is about a boy who trying to write a test, but with all the distractions real and imagined, he gets nothing done. The grandparents were there. We laughed throughout. All his subjects went very well, except for French. He wishes now that he joined the SRC. He also wished he had wrestled. That would have cut into his work. He spent two hours every Wednesday after school at the Y as a guard, and got additional hours guarding or teaching. He drives himself everywhere, easing our schedule. He spends a lot of evenings away with his friends: mostly with the SYO kids, Sara, Elation, Alan, Michael Barth, sometimes Andrew Agrey; sometimes with school friends, Raghu, Stuart, Derek, Joe Woolley. They watch movies, go wall-climbing, play pool, attend string performances at Mayfair United Church or the Centennial Auditorium or Convocation Hall, and bike. Peter has the same sense of humour. He is a great mimic, he has quips, he tells stories about his friends. For example: Just after visiting Cheryl's grandmother at the Circle Drive Old Folks home, we were departing from the parking lot behind car with a license plate with handicap markings. Thinking aloud of the advantages that designation would bring, I wondered aloud what it would cost. Peter said, 'An arm and a leg.' When he's with us he's quiet. But he listens carefully to conversations. As soon as our voices are lowered to confidential tones, he positively hones in. His ears have the power of radar dishes. If he's in another part of the room, we'll watch his head pivot, his ear train in. About his own affairs, he lets us know only what he wants us to

know. If he were to say too much, we'd use it somewhere to embarrass him. He is active in some conversations with his friends or select adults. He says what he has experiences, or he makes jokes. His talking is full of head nodding and smiling. His eight year old swimming students call him Petey. He arrives at class not a moment before it's supposed to begin in order to escape their clinging on. He told about a 15 year old in his Masters class who has failed twice already, who is very cool while he swims, keeping his head out of the water just so, never straining, well short of a full effort. Peter calls him Chachi after the 'very cool' character from Happy Days. Peter's a recognized asset on Life Guard competition teams, both as a powerful swimmer and quick responses in guarding scenarios. Had he not been away through July, he could have had a full time job with the city.

Matthew has taken on many interests. He still loves both indoor and outdoor soccer. He has settled into the fullback position. He's fast. He always wants to situate behind the ball, not trusting others to keep it out of the net. His instinct is not to attack upfield. He talks a lot to the other players, helps keep order on the field, is trusted by the others. He is on the Century track club relay team, that includes Joel Dei, Matt Johnson and Garret Separlo. The team is always at or near the best times in the city. Matthew and Garret were offered complementary 1-year memberships. He likes running longer distances too with both the track club and at school: he finished 11th out of all the 13-and-under boys in the city. He attended basketball camp last summer and played both on the school basketball team and the volleyball team. He played hockey through the winter and got a much-prized jersey for Christmas with Norge and the Norwegian flag printed on the front. He also played in the Saskatoon Strings again with Terry Sturge.

This year he didn't miss the city-tour. He played a Popper piece in his very first festival appearance and was highly praised by the adjudicator and Terry and Bernadette. He has developed a comfortable practise regimen. He is therefore very easy to work with. He learns quickly. He now plays a full-size cello. We're testing a \$525 German factory-made bow. Bernadette had kept him at the 3/4 size longer than she kept Peter after learning the technical dangers of playing an instrument that is too large. Matthew on the cello is Matthew with everything he does: deliberate, slow, thoughtful, confident, self-knowing, detailed, purposeful, always enjoying. His work is careworn. He insists on perfection first time, which gives him problems with deadlines or incompleteness. This is often frustrating for us because his work always shows such promise. When Peter expressed interest in participating in the Kinasao Father's Day Bikeathon, Matthew wanted to join. 185 km. Matt Johnson said he'd go too. When Peter discovered he's booked up that weekend, and Matt Johnson found that his bike is not roadworthy (his money goes into running shoes), Matthew wasn't deterred. He'd go alone. He got everything together, checked over and over the list of things to bring, hounded us for the things he didn't have, and raised \$400. The day came and off he and the group went. We had planned to drive up the next day. We discovered Matthew just short of PA. He was all alone in a no-man's-land between the leading cyclists, who were too far ahead to be seen, and the trailing cyclists who we had passed some miles back, riding into a stiff wind, his lips dry, wearing biking gloves and a red bandanna under his helmet. It bothered us that he was unsupervised by any support vehicles on this very busy and at times chaotic highway. We were at Kinasao when he eventually rolled in. We applauded. Erik ran beside. He

said that even though he was alone most of the time, he enjoyed the entire ride and would do it again. The following Sunday at Redeemer Pastor Randy, who had also ridden, asked him to stand and receive recognition for being much younger than anyone else who travelled the entire distance. Matthew's other big achievement was as Rana the frog in the Lakeridge musical production Rana's Pond, an environmental story about a frog in a polluted pond. Matthew didn't consult us about taking the role. He discussed it with his teacher, Pat Jamieson. He tried for the lead and got it. The whole thing was quite amazing to us. He had seen how much singing was involved, and Matthew was always resistant to singing in his natural register because he 'sounds like a girl'. He growls out the hymns because that's what boys should sound like. He performed the play twice. He has a lovely soprano voice.

Erik's account is missing.

1996

Sunday, July 14, 1996

Erik and Matthew are with Mama and Papa at Birch Hills. They headed away after Matthew's practise and game with the Saskatoon Summer Game's soccer team. They're planning to meet a family of Norwegian Bergs. Two of their children are near Matthew and Erik in age.

Erik is stretching up. He has long feet. He broke his big left toe at Northey's. He was kicking a ball. During the follow-through he jammed his bare foot into a wall. While examining the injury, Orin gave it a firm (painful) squeeze and asked, 'Is your toe always so crooked.'

Erik was in tears while Cheryl gave it a more tender assessment. He's lucky the injury came at the end of the soccer season. He would have been crushed to miss playing on the Cosmos, a team he loves.

We had a rather dramatic season-end barbecue at Crocus Park a couple of weeks ago. It was such a steaming-hot day, I feared no-one would show up. I pushed our wheeled barbecue across the street to the school ground. We pulled together a couple of tables. By then the parents and kids had begun arriving. Hardly had the last of them shown up when the sun disappeared behind heavy dark clouds. Someone wondered if this would be a short event. I rushed through the awards ceremony, handing out one for each of the players: Alex, Trevor, Corey, Tim, Erik, Geordie, Curtis, Scott, David, Justin, Brett, Avrim and Janet Trifa, Brian Boyes. The cooking and eating got underway. The clouds, deep blue by now, were roiling and firing off brilliant bolts of lightning. With some relief we observed their movement to the north east, into

Mennonite country. Someone made the cracks about it being better for Aberdeen than us. After eating, while the women visited, the men and boys played a game of soccer. Matthew joined. Erik was willing to risk getting his toe stomped. The men tired, the game turned into a rugby match, and one by one they rejoined the women. By then the clouds had turned purple and were moving southward. I predicted that in ten minutes it would start to rain. The words weren't out of my mouth when the wind came up. Jovial mood turned to panic. Everyone began grabbing their things and running. Erik picked up a lawn chair. Cheryl and Matthew got the food, tablecloths and chairs. I ran with the barbecue, the red cooler sitting on top, a turkey burger, three hotdogs and two hamburgers still cooking inside. A gust of wind tore the lid off the cooler. Erik's chair had turned into a sail. He was lifting off the ground. Trees were bending, garbage was blowing everywhere, sand stung our eyes. Kelly from the corner house ran to me and grabbed the cooler. Once inside, we watched through the front window. A car sped around the corner and pulled in front of Classens next door. As it stopped, our garbage bin crashed into its rear end. The tip of our young linden was whipping at the ground, shingles were tearing off the roofs across the street. Erik found this thrilling. Then the power went out. As quickly as the storm came, it ended. The sun broke through, the wind died. We went for a walk to survey the damage. St. Luke's skylight had been blown off and smashed on the school's lawn. Patches of roofs along Emmeline were stripped to the plywood. A contractor's truck paused near us. He asked if we wanted an estimate. Up and down the block families were out on the street to see what they had lost. Harley next door noticed that the school's flag was pointing south while the clouds were sailing north.

Behind them were more heavy clouds flashing with lightning. The storm was not over. We went back inside and watched the most dramatic lightning I can remember: strobe flashes, lightning bolts, walls of light. It continued for an hour. Peter arrived from work. He had heard on the radio that plough winds were 125 kph. Big trees and entire fences and roofs across the city had been blown apart. Curtis contacted Erik. His entire family had hidden in their basement. Curtis had never been so scared in his life. Mama and Papa drove around taking pictures of the damage. For the next two days people were telling their second- and first-hand accounts of destruction from Radisson out west and northeast beyond Osler: silos, granaries, roofs, barns, grain trucks wrecked, the debris flying hundreds of yards.

While in town Erik and Geordie are constantly together. If they're not in our back yard playing soccer, they're sitting under the Green Ash talking about what to do. They lounge on the front yard, for a change, and ride bikes in the park, play tennis with a worn-out ball, and play Clue, Monopoly or Cathedral in the family room. Michael Classen from next door and a girl from down the street have been at our door, asking Erik to play.

Summer bliss.

Matthew is playing a lot of soccer although he isn't spending much time on the recommended fitness schedule. He bought an electric bass guitar from Mother's music with a set of headphones. All we hear is the occasional buzz of a string. He wants to be ready for jazz band when school begins. He is reading James Herriot.

We were at Christopher Lake. Matthew, Erik and I went for a late evening stroll following the lake shore a couple of days ago.

We were waiting for the couple sitting on the dock to leave. Once they were gone we went onto the dock and watched the clouds. One in particular got our attention. It was a half-circle, the shape of a barrel ring. Matthew said he wished he had a girlfriend and they could sit on the dock in the evening with clouds blowing overhead just like they were. He pointed in the direction of the couple now gone from sight. A couple of loons were bobbing in the dark water. I made my own loon call. I asked Cheryl later, who had been in the trailer at the time, if she had heard me. She pretended she hadn't and that I was silly to think she could.

We shopped for a bike helmet for Matthew's Grade 8 grad. We picked a gold Bell Image for over a hundred dollars. Matthew wore it in the van on the way home and said what a sweet helmet it is. We bought Peter a fleece for his Grade 12 grad.

Peter is working full-time for the city at Harry Bailey pool as an instructor and a life-guard. He is taking a bit of time off from the quartet since returning from UVic where he spent the year studying with the Lafayette quartet, a quartet from Mexico city, and a cellist with the Cleveland quartet. Every day, he tries to make the most fun of everything. He plays Magic with Derek, who wears a fedora and talks in grumbling tones, he golfs with Alan at Wildwood (the plan to play 18 holes was halved because Alan had to go home for supper). He goes with Sarah Woods to hear a line-up of bands on 21st street. He told Cheryl that we should meet her sometime. He said she was different from the other girls because she had many interesting things to say. She was very busy working weeks at the Bible Society and weekends as a recreational coordinator at one of the paddling pools.

He has been shopping for a single-lens reflex camera. He reads whatever camera-literature he can get his hands on, visits camera stores to talk to salespeople, and updates us on what he has his eye on. He has perfected his mimicry of the Sikh taxi-driver in Victoria (which makes Papa nearly burst with laughter) and the Schwann's ice cream travelling salesman who came to our house some time ago. He has a role in play for Folkfest. His character is the understudy of a schoolmaster who is holier-than-thou and a bit of a sneak. He is planning to go camping with Michael Barth. The SYO kids are going to Christopher for a weekend at the end of July. He is submitting an availability form to the City for work this fall.

1998

November 24

It's Wednesday evening. The temperature is above zero. The sun is gone, the snow is gone. Early forecasts for a long, bitterly cold and snowy winter are premature. We hope so.

Peter studies in the basement. We've worked to make the whole space more liveable. Cheryl's dad and mine have spent Saturdays and evenings and a couple of weeks before school began, helping (more than helping since I haven't got a clue about most of it) with framing, insulating, installing drywall, hanging doors. I've hired a handy man to do the technical stuff, wiring, mudding and tapping, laying down the carpet. Cheryl and I did the painting. I put in the suspended ceiling in my own time. The boys have helped where they can. The end room is mostly finished, telephone and modem are hooked up, Peter has all the silence and space he could dream of. He is taking Biology, Chemistry, Drama, English and a second year Psychology class. He swims three noon hours a week, studies in the Geophysics library, has bowling evenings with drama kids on Thursday. He and a friend threw a party last Friday night, playing 'drama' games, dancing (Peter has rug burns on his hands), eating until 3 am. He slept over and walked home at noon Saturday. He is playing in four musical groups, two which will disband after their performances this Christmas, one which will perform in March, and the Harmony orchestra.

Note: It seems that life has got in the way. No more entries were made for this year.

1999

Monday, August 9

Today I saw his family off at the airport. They're going to Los Angeles for 3 weeks and then, if they raise enough money, to Nepal. I arrived alone at Dad's house 6:10 am. Dad was there. The Wongs were there. This is a family who let them live in their basement for the past two months. While Matthew attending to the pile of hockey bags, Mr. Wong introduced himself.

'My name is Chong Wong. What is your name? Tell me about your family. How many brothers and sisters do you have?'

After telling him a few things he smiled and said, 'Everyone has a different journey.'

I asked Matthew's Cheryl how the morning had gone thus far. Disastrous, she said. The bags Matthew had set by the van had been gone through. Money and one of their two computers were missing. Matthew took off. He found the computer in an alley, but no money. Just as he finished packing all sixteen bags into the van he dropped the keys into the pile, and it took removing most of them to find where they'd fallen. When I arrived at the airport, everyone was at the ticket counter. Mom was in a wheelchair, elbows on the armrests, hands folded in her lap, looking small, round and old. She had slipped in the parking-lot and hurt herself. They had just been told the bags were 60-odd pounds overweight. With the help of their minister at a church in Dundonald, belongings were removed, clothes got layered on top of the ones they were wearing and another bag was willed with the rest of it. Meanwhile the minister introduced himself to me. We were joined by another man, little, white-haired, a tidy suit, wire rimmed

glasses. He said his name is Gaines. He said something to us about 'a calm heart.'

The minister thought Gaines was talking about his heart and said, 'My heart is calm. I have no problem here. Maybe you mean Matthew.' Gaines repeated, 'A calm heart.' The minister was no clearer about whose heart Gaines was saying was calm. He pointed as a question to Matthew. Gaines allowed that Matthew's heart too might be calm, then swept his hand across the entire area of the airport, as if to say everyone's heart is calm, or should be, or might be if only....

Soon enough everyone was moving towards security. Several had moved apart from the rest, making a tight cluster, Matthew's family clasping hands, the Wongs, Gaines, the minister, laying hands on them, the minister beginning to pray. For several minutes he was calling for the safety of the family and the trip and the work of God and health of those who stayed behind. The other travellers stepped around them with every sort of look. The last I saw, Matthew was going through the metal detector for the fourth time. He was holding up his hands, the wand was passing over his body. He was looking in our direction. His eyes were wide, red-rimmed, seemingly hairless. He waved once, a choppy motion. Mom decided that they are gone and her work here is done. She stood, left Dad behind to put the wheelchair where he had found it, and walked briskly to the door.

Erik registered at Sci-fi Camp today, a gift from Mama. He attended soccer camp at Kinasao a couple of weeks ago. He wants blonder hair. He wants to grow taller. He doesn't want braces. He doesn't want his feet to be so much larger than he is (he bought a new pair of running shoes size 9 that we refer to as the SS Titanic).

We got him a new biking helmet to replace the grass-green little-boy helmet he never seemed to outgrow. If his feet are too big, his head, in his own words, is ‘tiny’. It’s time that thing started to catch up. One Saturday evening my brother came over with his girls. Erik groaned and slid downwards in the sofa. Even they are taller than he is.

He makes no secret that he likes girls but wishes he was 20 because that’s about the age of the girls he is interested in. Mostly he talks about Britney Spears. At 20, he’d be two years her senior.

He is taking jazz-piano lessons with Neil Currie, riding there on his bike. He took mine once because his was hanging on the garage ceiling. Back home he was smeared head to toe with grease. He had lost his chain, tried to fix it, failed, walked a ways, tried again to fix it, failed, walked some more, tried once more, succeeded, rode the rest of the way. [Some time that I can’t put my finger, he borrowed my bike and put a crimp in the back wheel rim. It rides — bump bump bump — as if the tire has a hump. It happened when Erik was hopping on or off a curb. He denied it was crimped, but if it was, I did it. Yes, he admits, he does pop sometimes onto curbs, but that has nothing to do with the damage that is or isn’t there. Probably he hadn’t even borrowed the bike.

He has been playing sax for the last week since we had ours repaired. He is our very own Lisa Simpson. Sad strains of Three To Get Ready come stumbling down the stairs. Listening to this feels like the bump bump bump of my bike’s back wheel. We are arranging to buy Erik a used Heintzman grand (5’ 7”) from Baldwin piano. Part of the conversation is about the rebuild. We took my parents once because they are personally invested: years

back they had forwarded a bit of their future legacy to buy a piano when we were ready for one.

Erik has become the ultimate putter-onner. Nothing is said straight. Whatever we say, he pretends he doesn't hear. Address him directly, and he looks a bit the other way. If he can't see us, then we're not there. If we then grasp his arm to force him to pay attention, he gives us a goofy surprised look and says, 'I'm sorry, was somebody saying something to me? And who are you?'

Another example of what it is like to talk with Erik, that gives deeper meaning to the word obtuse, as in deliberately difficult, comes from a day when the temperature was over 30 degrees. He was sitting next to me with his arms folded around his chest, as if he was cold. I asked, 'Are you cold?' He said, 'No, it's just the way I've arranged my hands.'

He spends time on the front lawn chipping balls because he's been golfing with friends. He's playing tennis, working on his top spin. Geordie still comes over, though we don't see much of his friends during the holidays. Erik tells stories Geordie has told him, stories designed to make Geordie's life larger than it would appear to his friends, more interesting, more hopeful. He is, according to himself, a very expert wakeboarder, snowboarder, skateboarder. Erik tells these stories with a big smile. 'See?' the smile seems to say. 'There is someone even more ridiculous than me.'

Matthew came in after a jazz practise last night. Peter, Erik, Cheryl and I were eating pizza. Matthew asked if we were eating pizza. Peter, Erik and I said no. Peter commented afterwards that our family has become a bunch of compulsive liars.

Erik hates going to bed, but he lives having baths. As soon as the water begins to run he starts singing. He soaks for so long we forget he's in the house. He gets up later in the morning. After a late night at the Fringe he slept until 11. He's in the act of becoming something new.

He is a steady pest. He takes shots at his brothers and when they bend and twist him in return he cries out for mercy. When they grant mercy he pests and pokes all over again. He goes wherever they go. With Peter downtown, with Matthew onto the sliding swings at the Berry Barn, with us downtown, with Cheryl for groceries. The rest of his time with us it's Peter rubbing his head or putting him into a headlock, or Matthew throwing him down and holding a victor's foot on his chest.

Erik is learning to do chores: clipping grass, feeding birds, staining the deck. But all those tasks, hardly begun, are quickly finished. He was asked to fill the bird feeder. He used a trowel. We listened to him sigh, and groan. And suddenly he was gone to golf with Brett Boechler. When I checked his work, I saw that the feeder was one quarter filled. The rest of the seed had been made into little piles, put in a row, like a buffet.

Earlier this summer I asked, 'Are you planning anything for the day?' He said, 'Dad, I'm only 12.'

Matthew's summer has slid by easily enough while waiting for word about job. It came the day we returned from Christopher Lake. A position in the kitchen of the Lawson Heights A&W. He was given his very own cap, shirt, pants, and apron. Without a job he can't buy the new bass he has his eye on, a five-string Ibanez from Mother's Music. Otherwise he spends his evenings with

Jason, Matt J, Hoover and other boys from Hardy, Brendan from Murray, Jody and other girls from everywhere. They see movies, attend the Fringe, go where there's Hip Hop stuff, go to Cranberry Flats, to paintball, to an SYO party. Or he's at the computer learning new computer languages. He practices bass, plays my Epiphone, reads, goes on the phone.

The last day at Christopher Lake, when Erik's last soccer game was over and the musical was being performed in the chapel, we chose a bench with room only for three. Matthew sat on the bench in front with three white-haired women. They began talking to him. They turned around and told Cheryl and Mama what a nice boy he was. Erik said, 'Matthew's finally got what he wants. A bench full of women.'

Matthew was assisting the soccer coach three times a day with mixed motives. One motive is, he loves soccer. A second motive is, the other assistant coach is a very good looking girl.

He said, 'Imagine a girl that good-looking living in P.A.'

We asked if he is looking for a girlfriend.

He said, 'Yes, but I never gets past the initial stages.'

We ask, 'Why?'

'Why else?' he says. 'I lack the motivation.'

While at the lake he and I did some biking in the woods. We followed a path made for snowmobilers. It is maintained for hiking and biking during the summer, but not so well that we didn't have to 'portage' over dead-fall or around or through

flooded areas nearly up to the waist. At the end there were branches and grass weaving through our spokes.

Matt is solid, 5' 10", and the house's biggest feet. After getting his hair cut he asked Cheryl to add blonde highlights. It ended up more reddish.

He sleeps until 11am. He's in the basement where it's cooler. He uses an air mattress. It's tidier than his bedroom, although he's doing something about that, strewing his clothes across the furniture, piling them on the floor.

He pushes his weight around. Out of the blue one day he bowled me over, had me pinned against the arm of the sofa, with my face was pushed into a cushion. After awhile of him wheezing his laughter in my ear, I said, 'All right, this is silly, let me go.'

Matt has an offbeat friendship with Jason who spends his days playing computer games, phoning friends, reading. Jason doesn't ride a bike. He doesn't have a learner's license. He lets Matt in on crushes on girls he has never asked out or even spoken to. There was that one time when one of them was sick at home and he went to visit. When the Johnson family went north for a week, they got Jason to watch over the house. One morning during that week while Peter was eating breakfast, Jason came into back yard — later, Peter mimicked how Jason bobs his head as he walks — and knocked on the patio door and waved his hand in a beckoning gesture to get Peter's attention. Peter asked him what's up. He said Helmer is lost and Jason needs help looking for him. Helmer is Johnson's very hairy cat that skulks around our back yard looking for birds. Peter tells him he can't now, he has to go to work. One

day the next week Jason dropped by to walk Matthew back to his house.

I asked Matthew, 'Did Jason walk all this way just to walk home again?'

Matthew said, 'No. He's just been to Johnson's house.'

I said, 'I thought he was done there.'

He said, 'He came to apologize to the daycare workers for scaring them. He had come with friends to watch a movie and used his key to get in. He also apologized for eating all the daycare cookies and bananas.'

Matthew agrees that Jason is exactly as he seems, and as Peter shows during hilarious supper time performances.

Peter works 6 days a week, 10 hours a day, as a delivery driver for Boryski's Butcher Block on Millar. He tells us about fellow workers, the 'Kabob girls' who roll their eyes when they talk, his boss Vern Boryski, who is highly disorganized and jerks his head wildly from left to right, as if between two distant, irreconcilable thoughts. He mimics Wayne's facial expressions. Les has an uncanny likeness to Ernie Kardash, right down to his moustache, his laugh, and his house in Rosthern, which Ernie used to own. There are Noah's 'wild' stories about being a hockey player, and the cheesy pickup lines he uses on good looking girls, lines chosen just so he can point out how cheesy they are, because, he tells Peter, that's the sort of observation quality people make. One line he used on Courteney — 'You must be an astronaut because your ass is out of this world' — not only failed to get the date he was after, it provoked a string of obscenities just ahead of her

squealing her tires in her hurry to get out of the parking lot, followed by days of silence.

Peter asked him, 'What are you going to do in the future?'

Noah bought a moment. 'Marine biology.'

'Do you have your sciences?'

'Mostly. I just need my Chemistry and Grade 10 Math.'

During the week Vern was away on holidays, Peter came home soaking wet. These are hot days and the crew has water fights with pressure hoses and buckets of water. There are alliances, alliances are broken, there are ambushes, injured parties vow revenge. Yesterday, two weeks after Vern was back, Peter came home wet and grinning. Noah had gotten belated revenge.

He said to Peter, 'Now we're even.'

Dennis said, 'I think this is just the beginning.'

The staff had a surprise birthday party for Vern at Vern's home. The surprise part was spoiled when Peter and Lynn arrived earlier than the others. They were hidden by the side of the house when Vern came by. He had a look of utter confusion. The pool was soon filled with clothed bodies. As Les was being thrown in he said, 'Ha ha, I have a second set of clothes in my car.' The second time he went in, he said, 'Ha ha, I have a good heater in my car.' A gag bag lady came. While she was doing her thing, Noah and Wayne were in the pool whacking each other with pool noodles. The next day Vern said how much fun it was.

Peter practises cello and hangs out with Mike Barth. In a couple of weeks, when work is done for both of them, they'll go to

Christopher Lake for a few days in the trailer. One of Peter's friends may be coming to Saskatoon after that, before classes start. Peter's classes are picked. He got what he wanted. His friends, who registered later, were not so lucky. They failed to get two or even three of what they wanted. He plans to work some Saturdays at Boryski's. He is looking into playing some symphonies concerts. He has performed at a couple of weddings. The money's good, considering time spent. He got his hair cut and dyed with blonde highlights. He wears a beaded necklace and \$2 pants from Value Village. Peter has made good friends with a girl named Erin from work. The problem is she's going to Australia to work and travel for a year. While the distance makes Peter's life easier, he's ready for a few complications. He went to Putt'n'Bounce with Janay and her boyfriend and three others. The boys putted together, the girls putted together, and they ribbed each other the whole time. He fights fatigue everyday and sometimes sleeps for brief periods after supper. He's in bed sometimes by 9. He starts reading, but in minutes the light is out. He has been very slow about moving the contents of his bedroom from the basement to the third floor bedroom. He has been there while we painted the house interior in mid-July. In the mean time, his mess in our territory is our problem.

It has been a challenging time recently, and Cheryl and I have fallen behind on things we ordinarily enjoy. Like reading. Cheryl called the library to reserve a few books to take to the lake. We spent a week there. One days was in Waskesiu. She is knitting again. We painted the house inside and stained the deck. We've been walking and biking. We went a couple of times to the Fringe to hear the Metro jazz band and a swing band. I haven't golfed once. I played tennis a couple of times with Erik. We have seen my

parents more than usual and Cheryl's parents less. When Mama isn't at Sears they go to the farm. Now we're getting ready for a visit from Michael and Cathy. Later we'll spend three days in Waskesiu and one day canoeing from Pike Lake to Saskatoon. Peter and I biked south of town along grid roads past wheat fields and farm houses. We were chased by dogs while hawks wheeled overhead.

Tuesday, December 28, 1999

Christmas holidays. The boys are in the basement playing ping pong. Matthew and Erik got new rackets with tacky surfaces for spin control. Everyone tries very hard not to lose. Losers will face days of gloating and questions that lay doubt on one's manhood. And we play as long as it takes for someone to be a loser. A fine socialist household.

We have made a special point this Christmas to build anticipation for Christmas Eve and Christmas Day. The Sunday before Christmas was the Sunday school performance. Monday, Cheryl and I took Mark and Nancy Rudoff to John's. Peter and Matthew babysat Helena and Jackson, who were in bed by 8:30. They spent the rest of the evening, Peter and Matthew, watching a Peter Pan animated movie. Tuesday afternoon and evening was spent with my family, first at the Sheraton Cavalier where Dad bought lunch for Diane's family, Uncle Hugh and Aunt Vi, and Joel and Michelle. They announced their engagement here. Across Spadina, city workers were flooding the Meewasin rink. They couldn't know that in a week the Pacific air will bring temperatures to 10+. Peter went home afterwards to study for his last exam and we went to Mom and Dad's. Uncle Ed, Aunt Audrey and Ernie's parents were there. The men talked about farming. Uncle Hugh held court on a wide range of topics, from farming to government to Quebec separatism. Aunt Vi looked was her jolly self in spite of the cancer concerns that have dogged her in recent years. Ernie was recently treated for colon and lung cancer. It didn't come up. He was uncharacteristically talkative and engaging. This is the culminating crisis in a chain events that have coloured family relations for 10 years. We stayed until 9 or so.

Wednesday just our family had supper by candlelight and choral music. I took it one step too far by suggesting we take turns reading classic Christmas stories. The boys balked.

Matthew asked, 'Does 17 mean something to you?'

I asked what he meant.

He said, 'Seventeen years of age is not when you should spend time with your family.'

Interesting point.

We skipped ahead to watch A Christmas Story. Cheryl had heard great reviews from people at school. The boys Ralphie and Randy are so much like much young Peter and Matthew, to felt like we watched our own home movie. When it ended the boys scrambled. Peter went with Stuart, Derek and Joe to play pool at the Sutherland Bar. Matthew went with Guru, Hoover and whoever else, and Erik went to Curtis' across the street. Cheryl and I were suddenly alone. With music in the background, we read.

Thursday evening was little Christmas Eve. We planned to invite Cheryl's parents to see Christmas lights before having appetizers somewhere. Cheryl's Dad beat us to the draw and invited us to Willow's for supper. They went ahead while I sat with an internet service technician who was installing software to speed up our internet. Back at home we watched White Christmas. Papa admired the beautiful actresses and chuckled at the patter between Danny Kaye and Bing Crosby. One sees him drifting back to a time when he was young, the film was new, life was simpler, and all those faces were fresh and alive.

On Friday, they came over just after 5 with food and gifts. We put steaming pots and serving dishes of sweet potatoes, white potatoes, carrots, peas, turkey, dressing, cranberry sauce, juice, buns, butter, salads, and the crowning glory, rømmegrøt, in places between candles, china, silverware, napkins. We went to the Candlelight service. Erik accolyted. Trying to reach the wick of the candle he came nearly to knocking it over while the congregation held its breath. The holy family is fortunate Erik hadn't been their obstetrician. History may have looked very different. On the way home we drove through the Forestry Farm Christmas display. We had Christmas pudding for dessert and opened the gifts. Erik was assigned to hand them out. Will he be relieved of the task when he's 6 feet and pushing 40? Not if his brothers have a say.

Next morning I was up in the dark. Papa joined me shortly after. He wondered why the boys weren't already there shaking their gifts. In time they arrived. The women came last. The gifts were opened, we ate oranges, King's College Choir and Dave Brubeck played in the background. The boys took apart the hard-drive to install a new CD burner. They played ping pong with their new rackets. We watched *It's a Wonderful Life*. We ate what was left from yesterday's meal. We sat in the living room and listened to old-time radio show cassettes that we gave Papa. Papa and Mama joined Cheryl at the TV to watch figure skating. They left at 9 pm.

On Sunday we remained home for most of the day. I walked around with my new tennis racket. Reading broke out all over: Peter with *Cleopatra*; Erik with the *Redwall* rat fantasy; Cheryl with *'Tis* and some book about healthy cells; me with *Napoleon*, *Robberbride*, and *Suchet's Last Master*. Cheryl and I went to

Costco for food for tomorrow evening. Back home, we found the boys fully dressed in snowboarding gear. The temperature outside was nearly 10+. Matthew has plans to go to Blackstrap mountain on Monday with Hoover and another boy who's father owns half the mountain. They're getting free lift passes and snowboard rentals.

Erik bought \$80 goggles, \$15 off.

They were 'cool', Matt said.

Erik said, 'I'll have them for the rest of my life.'

I said, 'I don't know about that. Wear them at my death bed. Beyond that, who cares.'

A few of us got food ready. Peter rolled meatballs, I clipped skin and ugly bits off chicken wings, and Cheryl did the rest, including arranging napkins on the table with each edge offset by half an inch to make a long paper-made Christmas-looking diamond. The knives were arranged like soldiers on parade, forks were stacked like coffins after a heavy battle, and so on. Peter and I watched Dog Day Afternoon. Matthew is mostly away with his friends in the evening. Hoover, Guru, Kevin and Jason are a travelling caravan that speaks mostly in single syllables.

The phone rings. Matthew gets it.

'Eh', he says.

'Eh', someone says back.

If Erik answers the phone and it's Guru on the line, the silliness really gets going. Erik asks if Guru's jacket is glued on. Whatever

Guru answers, Erik goes 'what, what, what, what'. It takes a flying body-part to stop him.

Papa came by and picked up Erik, Peter and me to go to Compu-smart for CDs for the burner and a computer for Papa. We returned by noon. Preparations began in earnest for the gathering that evening. People began arriving by 5:15: Diane and Ernie (who took a tour because in the 9 years we've lived here, they've never been), my parents, Cheryl's parents, Joel, Michelle and her sister Colette. We expected Carol and Les, but they had other plans. We ate in three rooms and the children played pieces: Peter and Matthew on cello, Matthew on his bass (such a big grin for such a little amp), Erik on the piano, the Kardash girls on piano. After each song we lightly applauded. Everyone was gone by 10.

Tuesday, the holiday began in earnest for Cheryl. I've been stealing moments for myself every day. The boys have a way of scattering like rats in a sudden light. Erik has been lying on the love seat reading his book with one leg hanging over the back. (He stressed the point that he has read more of this book in 5 days than he read in the Shannara book in two years.) He has a soccer tournament, with two games on Tuesday, one on Wednesday, one on Thursday. Peter and I went to see Fight Club, an anarchist fantasy with Brad Pitt. Peter and Matthew went to Zion Wednesday evening to be part of an ensemble group that will play for a church service Sunday evening at SaskPlace. Matthew took off early Thursday morning to go snowboarding with Guru. Both times he has taken the Honda. He was thinking of going to Table Mountain, but went to Blackstrap instead. Guru phoned at 7:30. Cheryl took the call, still in a dead sleep, and went to Matthew's dark room, calling him, searching for him in his blankets, and

expressing her shock when she discovered he was already up and dressed and showered and in fine spirits and nearly ready to go. Peter is rifling through a bunch of songs, singing and laughing as he listens, picking the tunes that Papa would most like to listen to. Cheryl is busy sewing. Moments earlier she was on her knees with the pain of banging her knee on the sewing machine cabinet. Besides the gash, was the knee cap broken?